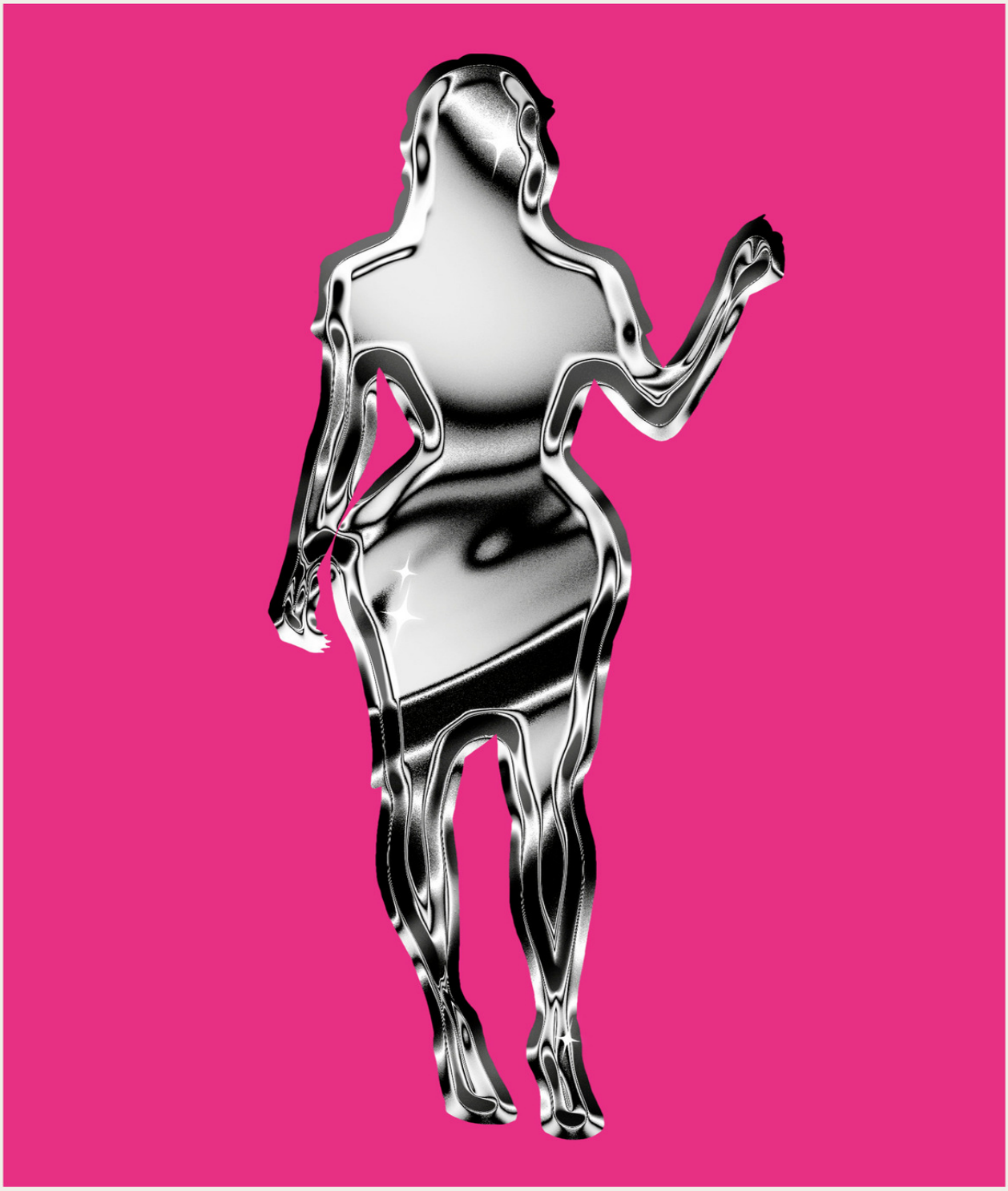
DEKONSTRUCTING THE KARDASHIANS



A New Media Manifesto

MJ COREY

DEKONSTRUCTING THE KARDASHIANS

【 A New Media Manifesto 】



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To Carly

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Out of the tomb, we bring
Badroulbadour,
Within our bellies, we her chariot.
Here is an eye. And here are, one by one,
The lashes of that eye and its white lid.
Here is the cheek on which that lid
declined,
And, finger after finger, here, the hand,
The genius of that cheek. Here are the
lips,
The bundle of the body and the feet.

. . .

Out of the tomb we bring Badroulbadour.

—WALLACE STEVENS,
"The Worms at Heaven's Gate"

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PREFACE

I HAD TO play a bit of catch-up when I finally started to keep up with the Kardashian family, though, like most people, I'd been ambushed by their faces and names in the media for a good decade. It was in 2018 that I first encountered their TV show, *Keeping Up with the Kardashians,* when a roommate put on the season 6 episode where the family goes to Bora Bora. Kim had been acting like a diva all throughout the resort. Then, at the pool, during a colorful exchange of insults, her brother, Rob, tells her, "Mom raised you better than that. Dad raised you better than that." She squirms in a way that feels incredibly "real" within a hyper-produced episode that seemed to have been edited to achieve a near-perfect narrative structure. When I mentioned to my sister, who was then a media studies major, the uncanny sensation this spectacle induced in me, she suggested that I read Jean Baudrillard, a French theorist who explores the way in which material reality as we know it is, more and more, becoming replaced by performance, advancing technologies, and commodity culture. I discovered that Baudrillard belonged to an expansive tradition of postmodern philosophers and media theorists who seek to deconstruct the way our fast-paced, pluralistic, and increasingly electronic world works. They are often maligned as purveyors of abstruse ivory-tower ideas meant for, well, media studies and comp lit majors, or as toxic ideological endorsers of a disconnected, performative way we *ought* to live. (The former *New York Times* literary critic Michiko Kakutani has even gone so far as to lay blame for our current post-truth world at their feet.) As the Canadian media theorist Marshall McLuhan described his work to *Playboy* in 1969, "The world we are living in is not one I would have created on my own drawing board, but it's the one in which I must live, and in

which the students I teach must live. If nothing else, I owe it to them to avoid the luxury of moral indignation…to get down into the junk yard of environmental change and steam-shovel my way through to a comprehension of its contents and its lines of force—in order to understand how and why it is metamorphosing man." The more I read, the more I realized that many of these theorists were interested in "mass culture" precisely because they cared intensely about the human experience, and I could not deny just how applicable their ideas were to social-media-saturated life in the new millennium. It felt worthwhile to try to share their ideas with the same masses most of these theorists were so concerned about, and with that my online presence Kardashian Kolloquium was born. Initially on Instagram, and, later, TikTok, I documented my self-study of postmodern and media theory through the accessible lens of the Kardashian family while working by day as a psychotherapist in private practice.

To be clear, I do not psychoanalyze the Kardashians; I do not know them, and they are not my patients. If anything, viewing, from the cold distance that is intrinsic to postmodern theory, the family as a media machine can hold a rather psychoanalytic mirror to the rest of us—the onlookers they titillate, outrage, and engage. After all, it is *our* attention that has been essential to their nearly two-decade-long construction of an American media empire.

As David Sinclair writes in the introduction to his 2004 book, *The Spice Girls Revisited,* "To announce that you were writing a book about the Spice Girls was to be forced…to defend both the group's honor, and, pretty quickly, your own. Why write a book about the Spice Girls? I was asked, time and again, although curiously, never once, anywhere in the world, did I have to explain to anyone who the Spice Girls actually were." I explore the Spice Girls as Kardashian predecessors later in this book, and I empathize with Sinclair's experience. Though I've never made it my business to defend the Kardashians' honor, I have been positioned time and again to defend why I'd want to explore the family's cultural impact, despite their omnipresence. Everyone knows who they are: a multibillion-dollar matriarchy who began their public lives as punch lines. We should probably try a little harder to

understand exactly how and why they've managed to pull this off—and question what it says about us.

To me, the Kardashians are no different from other enduring national institutions such as Las Vegas, Disney, and the WWE, which have become what they are by way of spectacle, narrative, and self-mythologizing, inspiring deconstructions by countless philosophers and critical theorists from Umberto Eco to Roland Barthes, who believed they could teach us something about our increasingly complicated world—not to mention, our own appetites for stories and images that amaze, our hunger for order in chaos, and our ceaseless drive to evolve our own technologies. One way or another, the Kardashian family has closely interacted with all these iconic enterprises, and we explore each of them in this book. In the introduction to his exceptional work about the history of Sin City's most famous resorts, *The Strip: Las Vegas and the Architecture of the American Dream,* the architect Stefan Al quotes the developer Steve Wynn: "Las Vegas…is a perfect reflection of America. It represents all the things people in every city like. Here, they can get it in one gulp."

As I argue in the "Blueprints" chapter, the Kardashians are an intentional amalgamation of all the things most people if not "like," then, at the very least, can recognize as culturally relevant, for us to then similarly consume in gulps—a composite of historical touchpoints, media tropes, and shifting identities. To further illustrate the family's "everything all at once" method, various emblematic people, places, and things they've associated themselves with throughout the years will serve as the focus of different chapters of the book, which is structured in two parts. Part 1 aims to offer a high-level pantheon of ideas about the power of ever-evolving media and technology to shape our perceptions—ranging from the network society to the attention economy. At the same time it traces the history of the last fifty or so years of media itself, with the intent of illuminating the conditions that shifted our modes of communication from analog forms like film and newspapers to today's hyper-digitalized realm of 0s and 1s—and how all this has made the rise of the pixel-perfect Kardashians possible. Part 2 attempts to show how these ideas can be applied, moving into the family's public debut in 2007 and

proceeding, mostly chronologically, through their ascent, while, whenever possible, further establishing the philosophical implications of their milestones. Here, the pace of the chapters generally accelerates in parallel with the rapid acceleration of media itself (and the family's barrage of content). Throughout part 2, I also weave in glimpses of my own online experience, reflecting the increasingly personalized nature of media consumption. As McLuhan would put it, "The medium is the message." The structure of the book is part of the point. Read on, and you'll find out exactly what he means—and why Kim would likely agree.

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PART I



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1. BLUEPRINTS

Postmodern iconicity and the network society

"WHAT'S MORE AMERICAN Than Marilyn Monroe?" So inquires the title of a *Kardashians* episode that follows Kim's preparation for the 2022 Met Gala. Fretting over dress measurements in her big beige closet and describing herself as a "shape-shifter," Kim prepares to don the nude sheath originally debuted by Marilyn in 1962 when she sang "Happy Birthday, Mr. President!" to John F. Kennedy. Of course, after the gala, public uproar across the press and social media inevitably coalesced into various hot-take factions:

1. *Kim* wishes *she were Marilyn:* "You can put lipstick on a pig but it's still a pig. Marilyn Monroe in this dress presented the vulnerability, sexuality, and unappreciated talent that were uniquely Marilyn. KK is a made-for-television plastic reproduction of Marilyn," a user commented on a *New York Times* article.
2. *Won't someone please think about the dress?:* "It was so disrespectful to wear it, if she really cared about Marilyn & her legacy she would've just worn the replica. It's not all on her though, whoever ok'd it gets blame too," @laura_gee13 opined on Twitter.
3. *Kim's crash diet to fit into the dress offers a dangerous precedent:* "Kim Kardashian's Met Gala Diet Stunt Is Both Outdated and Alarming," read a *Glamour* magazine headline by Michelle Konstantinovsky.
4. *Kim is an icon, after all:* "It makes perfect sense in 2022 why Kim K would be the one chosen to wear this dress. She IS a modern day Marilyn. Incredible," tweeted @MisterPreda, voicing the minority opinion.

I'm guessing that when you think of the term "American icon," Marilyn Monroe is one of the first names that comes to mind; it's just a question of which image your hippocampus pulls up. (For me, it's the white dress moment from *The Seven Year Itch.*) Charles Casillo, author of *Marilyn Monroe: The Private Life of a Public Icon* and *The Marilyn Diaries,* tells me that an "icon" is a "person who is so celebrated that they come to represent a particular thing or field—often the era that they come to prominence in—like a music icon, movie icon, a sports icon, fashion icon, a political icon. But also, someone who has outstanding and unforgettable characteristics that label them. Like 'a sex symbol' or 'genius,' or a 'hero.' " The other thing about icons is the enthusiastic emulation they inspire in others. "Let's face it," Casillo adds, "almost every female love goddess that has come after her has done a photo shoot or video dressed as Marilyn: Madonna, Drew Barrymore, Lindsay Lohan, Nicole Kidman, Naomi Watts, Scarlett Johansson, Miley Cyrus, Beyonce." What, exactly, does Marilyn's image offer them? S. Paige Baty suggests an answer in *American Monroe:* "By virtue of her familiarity, Marilyn serves as…an instantly recognizable expression of a mood, an era, a sexuality. She allows an audience to draw from a common ground."

This common ground seems to inspire biographers, documentarians, authors, and filmmakers to continually attempt to tackle Marilyn from some new angle. The most recent entry in this genre, as of this writing, is *Blonde,* the Netflix original adapted from Joyce Carol Oates's impressionistic novel of the same name, which drew an accurate, albeit bleak, allegory about what it can feel like to be a woman in this world. Perceived as a posthumous assault on Marilyn's dignity, the film was not well received, especially on the heels of Kim's boundary-pushing stunt. Baty adds, "Authorings of Marilyn claim to reveal the 'true' subject, yet each new book or image will be followed by even more 'final' rememberings…. The images are not frozen in the past, but rather are often reconstructed in relationship to contemporary products, events, and icons." Kim Kardashian can be deconstructed and reconstructed according to all kinds of products, events, and icons, from her self-identification as a "Balenciaga Barbie" in an Instagram caption during a time when she was wearing hot pink all over town in the 2020s, to the 1995 O. J. Simpson trial,

which many young people on Twitter claim to only know about thanks to her father's presence, to, well, Marilyn herself—an amalgamation of semiological systems that the French theorist Roland Barthes (inspired by the Swiss structural linguist Ferdinand de Saussure) considers the foundation for myth itself. Semiotics are made up of "signs that are seemingly straightforward but that subtly communicate ideological or connotative meaning and perpetuate the dominant values of society." This book aims to identify and compile some of the semiotics Kim Kardashian has attached herself to throughout the years to become a living myth. Because her multiracial, intergenerational, blended dynasty has colonized such vast cultural ground, odds are you're going to believe I omitted some crucial semiotics in my discussion—why isn't there, say, a "courtroom" chapter, wherein I unpack the underpinnings of Kim's besuited Elle Woods activist persona? Especially when, at the time of writing, the reality star and entrepreneur Kim, suddenly also an actress, has signed on to coproduce and star in a Ryan Murphy legal drama as a cutthroat divorce attorney? Or you might ask, what about Cleopatra, whose discourse-generating racial ambiguity and conversion of sexual prowess into political influence seem a worthwhile Kardashian comparison? I will say only that such omissions prove my larger point—that the Kar-Jenners, masters of contradictions, can be applied and deconstructed according to just about every aspect of American life.

Is earning an eternal legacy the unstated endgame of all pursuits of fame? The bad news for the stars on Casillo's list is that—aside from, probably, Beyoncé—their iconic status will never approach that of the late starlet Monroe. The rest of us might get all misty-eyed about her singularity—*there'll never be another Marilyn*—but the truth is that there'll never be another media environment quite like the one that made her: radio, film, newspapers, and some good old-fashioned razzle-dazzle (spoken with the transatlantic dialect that we hear in all media from those days, and which was in truth native to nowhere).

Our collective conception of the "icon" is ever evolving as new media forms continually reformat our understanding of the world. But let's first define what new media even is. *Cambridge Dictionary* says it's "information or

entertainment" delivered by way of "computers or the internet, and not by traditional methods such as television and newspapers."

We live the ramifications of new media daily: There's an overload of information online; information conveyed visually is easier to consume; we're able to consume faster than ever; and we are frequently inundated by everyone else's feelings and thoughts about all of it. Microsoft's market researchers have even suggested that the attention spans of goldfish now outshine our own, which have shrunk from twelve to eight seconds since 2000 ("about when the 'mobile revolution' began," as *Time* points out). This ever accelerating and expanding state of affairs affects how we think about icons because we can pull their images up on Google in seconds and skim their visual archives across websites, fan accounts, and social media conversations, and the process tends to elicit a spectrum of strong feelings: identification, nostalgia, yearning, fascination, disgust, and, sometimes, a belief that we have a better grasp of American history and culture. Baty explains it this way: "The mass media have helped to make the representative character a common means of relaying stories and constructing histories which are easily circulated and imaged across great distances of time and space."

The more representative characters put into conversation with one another, the better. As the Dress discourse swirled in the aftermath of Kim's viral Met Gala appearance, rumors began to tide online that Britney Spears was a distant relative of Marilyn Monroe's. Various Twitter threads and TikTok takes seemed to welcome this narrative in large part because it undermined Kim's sartorial statement. Britney's biography was certainly more akin to Marilyn's: The pop star, recently liberated from an exploitative conservatorship and clearly haunted by the harms done to her by a fame she'd always been ambivalent about, is—as Marilyn was—a tragic figure. (Meanwhile, Kim's legacy will never be defined by trauma because she *willingly* gives us all that we consume of her. Kim's consent is part of the problem: It means she has a *lust* for fame.) As everyone worked out how they felt about the matter—some conservators spoke out against Kim's violation of an archival piece, while Marilyn Monroe's estate released a statement of support—those red-carpet images of Kim wearing Monroe's dress further

propagated the social media posts, the message board threads, the news headlines. You saw the photos. Kim's head is held high, perhaps because she knew she'd hacked new media's defining economy—the attention economy—yet again.

Plus, the feeds, the threads, the headlines, all of which had delivered the Kim content, show us what it means to be *mediated*. Mediation is what happens when "media," a noun, becomes a verb. Whatever we consume from social media, message boards, and the news has been mediated to us. Kim does not have tragedy in common with Marilyn. But she will share with her the legacy of having been hyper-mediated.

✦✕✦

In keeping with the high-tech nature of new media, many pop culture consumers have applied a technical framework to understanding the function of icons: that of the blueprint.

In a viral April 2021 video titled "Unpopular Opinions: Kardashian/Jenner Edition," the TikTok user @mizfit said, "It's crazy how many people say the Kardashian/Jenners are the 'blueprint,' but not a single person can tell me what they're the blueprint of!" He continued with a not-infrequent critique of the Kardashians' success: "If they're the blueprint of anything, it is cultural appropriation on social media." In the video's comments section, responses resound in approval. "READ THEM BESTIE," says one user. "They are billionaires for nothing and that makes me mad," says another.

@mizfit and his commenters are half right. Cultural appropriation is a key component to Kim Kardashian's complex self-design, and while it's not the complete picture, her donning of Black women's hairstyles and numerous related transgressions may be why so many object to calling her the "blueprint" for anything.

But if icons represent eras, per Charles Casillo's definition, I can't think of a better blueprint for iconic fame in the internet age than Kim K, and reactions to her often mirror larger existential anxieties about the internet.

Her infamous ethnic ambiguity has worked to her advantage as her image proliferates across media forms more numerous than her alleged nose jobs: from centerfold to cosplayer to cameo to main character to muse to mannequin to influencer to emoji and more. To put it in TikTok terms? Kim's multiplicity "matches the energy" of the metaverse.

Kim Kardashian has cracked the code: Embody *every* icon. Live up the luxury life, invoking collective contempt à la Marie Antoinette (and wear a white wig and corset in a cable-TV energy drink ad). Play muse to grand designers while spinning memorable mythologies about the family dynasty, like Jackie O (and dress in similar suits for a magazine cover, to decorate every newsstand). Piss everyone off with Spice Girls–style Girl Power—or is it Girlboss?—messaging (and then "be" them with friends for a talent show). In fact, Kim confronts us with *dialectics*—a concept, derived from the thinking of the nineteenth-century German philosopher Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel, that seemingly oppositional phenomena can in fact be synthetized. The personal and the political. The mother and the whore. The leader and the Everywoman. Kim's ability to collapse binaries in every aspect of her brand is what renders her so confounding and therefore memorable. Within every semiotic in this book, you'll find dialectics at play. By doing this, Kim herself has become a medium: surrounding us at every turn, reviving the profundity of the past, and cultivating cultural comparisons of which she becomes the center.

@mizfit's complaint that "not a single person can tell me what they're the blueprint of!" stems from the "blueprint" discourse popularized on Twitter in 2020. According to the website Know Your Meme, "blueprint" is a term used to claim that a "stan's…idol was the first person to start a fashion or pop culture trend, making them the 'blueprint' others built off."

"Blueprint" establishes comforting mathematics out of an overwhelming economy of content. As the *Vox* internet reporter Rebecca Jennings explains of social media's influence on fashion, "No age group has ever had as much historical fashion knowledge and primary sources to draw from as young people do today, with the entirety of the last twenty years documented online." The kids today are motivated to create colorful taxonomies of the

throwback-inspired micro-trends they come up with, and then title them with the definitude of scholars: “bimbocore,” “coquette,” “indie sleaze,” “mod revival.” One popular tweet by a user named Dyke Angst posits that Miss Honey, the pretty teacher from the 1996 movie *Matilda,* was “the blueprint for cottagecore lesbian culture.” Other tweets claim that the screenshots of 1990s goth kids featured on shows like *Maury* and *Jerry Springer* are blueprints for a chaotic Gen Z fashion sensibility that Jennings has dubbed “TikTok Couture.” Instagram and TikTok feeds are so saturated with Looks and Concepts that it’s no wonder there’s such a fascination with the simpler times and icons—the blueprints—from whence they came.

Enter Kim Kardashian and her obvious incentive to borrow from big-name blueprints. As Barbara Walters told Kim and her sisters in an internet-acclaimed 2011 interview, “You don’t really act, you don’t sing, you don’t dance, you don’t have any—forgive me—any talent.”

Devoid of traditional talent, like many of us, Kim has made it her business to manifest mythology, performing the particular thrill of borrowed glamour. She has masqueraded, at some point, as all the icons below (and this is a vastly incomplete list):

1. Princess Leia, in 2008, for a Kanye West–produced puppet comedy show called *Alligator Boots*
2. Wonder Woman, for Halloween in 2008
3. Cleopatra, for a 2011 *Harper’s Bazaar* spread
4. Liz Taylor, for a 2013 Instagram post
5. Anna Wintour, for Halloween in 2014
6. Herself, for Halloween in 2015
7. Marie Antoinette, in a 2015 Hype ad
8. Marilyn Monroe, for a 2015 *Vogue Brasil* cover
9. Aaliyah, in a 2017 Halloween costume
10. Madonna-as-Marilyn, in a costume for the same Halloween weekend
11. Selena, again for Halloween 2017
12. Jackie O, in a 2017 *Interview* feature
13. Cher, in a 2017 *Harper’s Bazaar* cover and for Halloween

14. Kourtney Kardashian, in a 2018 episode of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians*
15. Princess Jasmine, in 2009 for a Halloween costume at a Los Angeles party, in 2016 for Instagram photos following her crisis event in Paris, in 2018 for a YouTube makeup tutorial, and in 2021 for an *SNL* sketch

In the beginning, Kim's costuming was campy—even a little cheap. The 2009 Princess Jasmine costume barely covered her mons and seemed to share the poor fabric quality I've seen on the racks at big-box stores. As Kim's Instagram follower count and media appearances increased, though, a perfect resemblance to the icon she'd elected to represent seemed to become a point of pride. This cultivated an uncanny tension, considering Instagram's growing Kardashian Clone Army (which we'll discuss in part 2, section "Kim 2.0"). Take the Selena costume Kim wore in 2017. She didn't just throw on red lips, a purple jumpsuit, and a wig with bangs, as she might have in 2009. Her KKW-brand makeup was contoured to simulate Selena's bone structure. She donned a perfect replica of *the* "Bidi Bidi Bom Bom" purple jumpsuit. She even clutched a prop mic.

Now Kim was going for essence, all seemingly for the purpose of a four-second video she posted to Twitter in which she imitates Selena's signature cumbia twirl. The video was met with a strong and mixed response. "For an 'Armenian' you sure do a lot of appropriation and never dress up as someone Armenian," said one. "Hell no! Don't compare yourself to Selena, she was talented unlike you!" said another.

But there were also a few like these: "Damn bitch u can look like anybody," and "I showed my mom and asked who do you think this is and she said that's Selena." Kim's message was clear: With enough money and vision, you can be whoever you want, and it could earn you a couple million views.

Kim has been called a witch by some comment-section detractors, who also tend to believe the legend that there's a Kardashian curse that dooms all men with proximity to the family (only proving the family's iconicity—being the subject of at least one conspiracy theory is part of being an American icon). The accusation likely arises from the public's unfamiliarity with seeing any woman use worldly means to accumulate so much power. It's true that

Kim's alignment with epic predecessors has transmuted their energy to enhance her fame in a way that might seem supernatural. But it's not magic. It's just what happens when publicity meets the internet.

✦✕✦

The art critic John Berger argues in his 1972 classic, *Ways of Seeing,* that "publicity is, in essence, nostalgic…. Publicity images…never speak of the present. Often they refer to the past and always they speak of the future." After all, if we're living, Zen-like, in the present, why would we need anything more? Ads convince us that buying stuff will bring change—change that could propel us to the superior futures shown in the ads. And nostalgia, which has become a topmost term of the 2020s (literally: Searches for the word spiked on Google Trends in the winter of 2021, and its hashtag has more than 100 billion views on TikTok), conveys a kind of credibility and novelty—or, as Berger put it, "cultural authority"—to any product or media content.

Pop culture commentary, from quippy comedy podcasts to archival '00s Instagram accounts, constantly features throwbacks to the "Bimbo Summit" (a 2006 *New York Post* cover story featuring a paparazzi shot of Paris Hilton, Britney Spears, and Lindsay Lohan in Paris's car after a night of clubbing) or Tyra telling Tiffany, "We were all rooting for you!" on *America's Next Top Model* or Bennifer's convertible canoodling. Holly Madison, reality TV star and ex-girlfriend of the *Playboy* mogul Hugh Hefner, once told me, of the '00s, "I can see how appealing that nostalgia is because everything looked so *fluffy* in that decade—but there was such a dark side to it."

Editorial features and ad campaigns also reach to the past. Kim Kardashian called on her former frenemy Paris Hilton to costar in a 2020 campaign for her shapewear company, SKIMS—they twinned in velour sweatsuits—and she featured a handful of former Victoria's Secret Angels (whom she renamed "the iconic girls" on her show) in the spring of 2022. It's not just Kim, either. Flip through any pandemic-era fashion mag or scroll any influencer's account and you'll find at least a touch of nostalgic fluff.

But it *is* true that Kim, specifically, has been utilizing this strategy since the beginning of her career, and she's gone way beyond references to the early '00s. I'm thinking of the blurry black-and-white selfie she posted in 2013, bath towel on her head, holding her massive engagement ring in front of her face, imitating a classic shot of Liz Taylor. This incited headlines like "Kim Kardashian Selfie Mirrors Famed Elizabeth Taylor Pose" and "Kim Kardashian Thinks She's Elizabeth Taylor." Her selfie statement was appropriate because of a well-known *Harper's Bazaar* photo shoot from two years before in which Kim dressed as Cleopatra, a re-creation of Taylor's decadent starring role in the eponymous 1963 film that nearly bankrupted Twentieth Century Fox. The references to past iconic moments, which are often themselves references to an even deeper past, perpetuate a tradition of re-creation that lends an illusion of importance to the images of every woman involved. Then we see imitations of these photo compositions crop up across Instagram as the rest of us seek to present ourselves with an essence of the iconic.

Berger claims in *Ways of Seeing* that what we have learned "at school of history, mythology, poetry can be used in the manufacturing of glamour." It doesn't even matter how well we remember those classes, which left us with at least vague mental images of Egypt's grand sphinxes and serious portraits of kings. Allusions to history seen in ads and celebrity content "should merely be reminiscent of cultural lessons half-learnt. Publicity makes all history mythical, but to do so effectively it needs a visual language with historical dimensions."

In other words, does the image have old-timey vibes? Then it has more credibility. And that's something we'll encounter again and again in this book: Our culture increasingly relies on a currency of iconic imagery and "cultural lessons half-learnt."

According to Berger, imagery derived from oil painting, especially, can be identified in contemporary advertising. He demonstrates this by placing classic art next to contemporary ads. "Romantic uses of nature" and "women's legs" and "the equation of drinking and success" show up as common patterns. With this exercise of "putting almost identical images or

details of images side by side," Berger predicted an Instagram craze to come, decades later, as seen in accounts like Art But Make It Sports or Tabloid Art History, which reveal the through lines of high and low culture by juxtaposing relevant images ("Because for every pic of Lindsay Lohan falling, there's a Bernini sculpture begging to be referenced," reads Tabloid Art History's bio). In fact, you'll see all of this in Kardashian content: their posed family tableaux for annual Christmas cards, Kim's release of a perfume bottle shaped like a Roman bust, all the social media stories showing Kendall raising glasses of her 818 tequila with her circle of socialites, or even Kylie's penchant for posting Instagram photos of herself standing beside orange trees or in sublime desert landscapes.

But old-world aesthetics are only part of Berger's point. He wants us to grasp that the *process* by which a "visual language" of the past—with all its aforementioned "dignity" and "cultural authority"—is reimposed onto the present is also generative of glamour, and, therefore, of sales. Liz Taylor's performance as Cleopatra—which entailed stereotypical Egyptian makeup, luxe costumes, and generally being surrounded by various trappings of the ancient and exotic—was not the sole cause of her glamour.

This is another idea that will come up again and again in this book: Structure—sometimes called form—is at *least* as important as the content within it. The TV set is as influential to our cognition as the programming it offers. The Instagram and TikTok news feeds shape our minds as much as the actual images we scroll past. The Canadian media theorist Marshall McLuhan put it this way in *Understanding Media:* "The 'content' of a medium is like the juicy piece of meat carried by the burglar to distract the watchdog of the mind." In his famous phrase, that is, "The medium is the message."

In the case of Kim as Liz and Liz as the queen of Ptolemaic Egypt (also known as "father-loving goddess" or "famous for her father," according to the Greek translation of Cleopatra's name), our minds' watchdogs should focus less on winged-tip eyeliner and more on Liz's body's function as a medium. The effect of glamour was fundamentally induced by Taylor's state of *change*. She looked one way before, and then another way after. The same goes for Kim's *becoming* of Liz's *becoming* of Cleopatra. Their vast transformations

indicate their *freedom* to become and their access to the money, time, and help necessary to facilitate a process of becoming.

All of this culminates in an effect of greatness, one that, as Berger put it, "speak[s] of the future" by indicating movement—from the eye-catching "before" photo in some tabloid makeover to its aspirational "after." Which suggests another precondition of glamour: *being* something other people strive to emulate. If you're glamorous and beautiful and cool in some enclosed room but no one can see you to want to be you, are you even glamorous? Some might say yes, sure, glamour is a state of mind. But according to Berger, advertising promises us that "people who have apparently been transformed…are…enviable. The state of being envied is what constitutes glamour." This might explain the saying that "everyone loves a comeback."

Is this conceptualization of glamour—that it is a process of becoming, a catalyst for envy—the underlying formula for any given Kardashian Halloween costume or SKIMS campaign? If Berger believes that emulations of oil paintings lend today's ads "cultural authority," then maybe Kim means to establish similar prestige by referencing history's hot girls. Manifesting Madonna-as-Marilyn, for example, Kim reminds us that Madonna (who happened to be the Kardashians' Beverly Hills neighbor in their early days), herself called a "postmodern myth" in 2002 by the French cultural critic Georges-Claude Guilbert, matters because she inspires mimicry—and then Kim manufactures glamour by showing off her own ability to transform, just as Madonna did in 1991, when she dressed as Marilyn to perform "Sooner or Later" at the Academy Awards, and throughout a career known for evolution and reference. And maybe, just maybe, given her inspiration, we'll start to wonder whether the physical compression enabled by SKIMS or the facial contours offered by KKW Beauty can help us shape-shift too.

✦✕✦

We can probably trace this keen tactic to Kanye, who played Pygmalion—or, some might say, Svengali—in his mythic coupling with Kim.

In a 2013 interview with the popular New York City–based radio show *The Breakfast Club,* Kanye compared his then-wife to Marilyn Monroe while critiquing the myopic elitism of legacy media and flattering the attention economy's democratization of fame. "The paparazzi…empower us. *Vanity Fair* wants to say Kate Upton is Marilyn Monroe. Kate Upton ain't Marilyn Monroe. We all know *Kim* is Marilyn Monroe. *Kim* is controversial."

The comparison conjures a mental matchup of Kim's and Marilyn's images, which in turn evokes the formulaic aesthetics of emerging web-based interfaces of the time. In 2013, *BuzzFeed* was becoming more and more culturally entrenched for its "aggregation" approach to content, reflecting—and perpetuating—a consciousness shift in how people lived online. "We're organizing ourselves to be a company for the way people consume media today," its cofounder Jonah Peretti told *The New York Times* in 2014. This meant creating a user-friendly, hyper-visual, list-oriented platform that empowered content consumers to become "distributors" of the media that resonated with them. "Nobody wants to be a shill for your brand," *BuzzFeed*'s chief creative officer, Jeff Greenspan, told *New York* magazine in a 2013 profile about Peretti. "But they are happy to share information and content that helps them promote their own identity."

In 1996—long before the dawn of Instagram, Twitter, and his own transformation into media mogul—Peretti published a paper called "Capitalism and Schizophrenia: Contemporary Visual Culture and the Acceleration of Identity Formation/Dissolution" in *Negations* magazine. The piece was about how "late capitalism not only accelerates the flow of capital, but also accelerates the rate at which subjects assume identities." For example, Kim can't dress up as just *one* icon per Halloween. That would be forgettable. In compliance with the algorithm-informed attention spans of her audience, she typically delivers at *least* three to five costumes as content. Plus (as the data scientists at the Kardashian Data Koalition discovered in 2023), with her shapewear company, SKIMS, Kim parts from the traditional retail model of "seasonal" drops and instead floods our feeds with new collections and campaigns seemingly at random, often featuring of-the-moment public figures in an assortment of visual styles—like high-contrast shots of two

beloved starlets from the second season of the hit HBO series *The White Lotus,* following its explosive finale, or Polaroid-style flicks of Team USA as the 2021 Olympics neared.

Recontextualizing Jacques Lacan, the French psychoanalyst who asserted what Peretti describes as "the importance that images play in the process of ego and identity formation," and Roland Barthes, yet another early twentieth-century French thinker known for deconstructing the cultural coding of media images, Peretti explains the way visual culture promotes identity formation: "Paging through a fashion magazine such as *Vogue* or *Elle,* we encounter a variety of radically different images: some models are child-like, some are butch, some are waifs, some are tattooed, some wear elegant party dresses, some lounge in torn jeans…. [T]aking the TV remote in hand, we encounter a…similar visual cacophony. The viewer is encouraged to identify with cops, thieves, surfers, businessmen, princes, paupers, housewives, and athletes, to name but a few…. Not only does each of these mediums contain a surprisingly varied image-repertoire, but a late capitalist subject may encounter all of these mediums in a single day."

This might be why so many scorn Kim for daring to align herself with the Greats: It seems as though she were suggesting an inflated sense of self. If anything, though, the images of Kim's controversial cosplay encourage our *own* identity formation. Opining about whether she's entitled to play whichever new role helps us determine our personal boundaries, values, and identifications. In other words, she offers catharsis, an Aristotelian concept meaning "purgation" or "purification" in Greek, what happens when, according to *Britannica,* "the emotions (especially pity and fear)" are purged "primarily through art." The fact that Kim engages so often with dialectics—virgin *and* whore, family woman *and* entrepreneur, entrepreneur *and* activist—only heightens catharsis as we behold the concurrence of constructs we'd always been taught were at odds with each other. Aristotle believed that catharsis, inspired most of all by dramatic tragedies, could aid in the cultivation of virtue because living vicariously through well-told stories can get bad, sad, or mad vibes "out of our systems." Numerous scholars, from Walter Benjamin to Richard Janko, would also argue that comedy, as much as

tragedy, facilitates the same sort of purging. I would argue (and I'm sure others have) that catharsis can purge emotions beyond pity and fear—like rage, lust, and envy. My point here is the divine comedy and tragedy that is Kim Kardashian's spectacle of appropriation and approximation poses a subtextual prompt: Who would *we* "be" if we could be anyone at all? And how would we feel—what would we *do*—if we had such power?

Peretti's notion of a visual cacophony might also explain why Kim's multiplicity—Madonna, Selena, Aaliyah, mannequin, video vixen, video game avatar, CEO, activist, wife, mom, the list goes on—has been so effective in holding the public's attention. We've become accustomed to such pace and pluralism that we might even crave it. As the French theorist Jean Baudrillard writes, "They say that stars give you something to dream about, but there is a difference between dreaming and fascination by images. The screen idols are immanent in the unfolding of life as a series of images. They are a system of luxury prefabrication, brilliant syntheses of the stereotypes of life and love. They embody one single passion only: the passion for images and the immanence of desire in the image."

Peretti cautions that the cacophony of images is unleashing at greater and greater volume thanks to media's advancing algorithms, and utterly without "continuity" (think about how many tabs you have open at any given time, or the fact that Google Images search results seldom appear in chronological order). A sea of images without any meaningful containment by space or time causes us to swim—or, more likely, drown—in the fluff. This is where *BuzzFeed*'s hyper-organized interface comes in—and Kim's unmistakable body, the single consistent structure beneath a ceaseless cycle of costumes. The medium is the message.

Peretti aimed to consolidate information found across the web in a fun and fast way, famously often in the form of lists, while also eliminating "web page views" as a metric for "reach." With *BuzzFeed*'s readers acting as willing "distributors" of the site's content, its bright red logo could syndicate itself across Facebook, Tumblr, and Snapchat feeds, seaming together an increasingly collage-like internet landscape and proving yet again that the best

strategy for building a media legacy from scratch today is being everywhere at once.

Anyway, who doesn't love personality quizzes and listicles? Listicles aggregate data from other sources so that we needn't click around. And they break that information down in quick and digestible ways—ideal for brains shaped by the immediacy and simplicity of, say, hashtag culture on X (né Twitter, a platform that had popped off around 2007 after a successful SXSW event, jumping from twenty thousand user tweets a day to sixty thousand, and continuing to grow in the decade that followed). Plus, personality quizzes nurture our narcissism and aid us in the conceptualization of our own personas—useful for self-concepts increasingly formed by Facebook status updates and Instagram feeds. For example, discovering which Spice Girl you are from a *BuzzFeed* personality quiz—and then tweeting the results—is irresistible shorthand for "This is me!"

Two formative mediums arose around the same time: *BuzzFeed* and Kim Kardashian's body. Jonah Peretti clocked our growing culture of connectivity and the consequential commodification of the self. His media company's explosive early success proved that the public had a hankering for an orderly presentation of content that could help us assert our identities. And by comparing Kim Kardashian to Marilyn Monroe, Kanye declared his wife's potential to fulfill that same unconscious need to see identity organized in a visual way. After all, she possessed the perfect hourglass shape, ethnically ambiguous face, and willingness to wear whatever: a quintessential mannequin on which myths—in the form of fashion statements—could be made.

Eventually, the establishment—starting with Condé Nast—caught on. In 2015, *Vogue Brasil* styled Kim as Marilyn for its June cover. Twitter responses were predictable. "Blasphemy!" read one tweet. "I can only hope she OD's on Heroin and dies young," said another. But the critics proved Kanye's point: Just like Marilyn, Kim was controversial. In fact, the self-appointed keyboard defenders of Monroe's honor seemed to forget that the audience at Madison Square Garden had gasped when she removed her fur coat to sing "Happy Birthday" to John F. Kennedy in 1962, or that Tony

Curtis once commented that kissing her was like "kissing Hitler," or that Laurence Olivier labeled Monroe "the stupidest, most self-indulgent tart I have ever come across."

It was after *Vogue Brasil* that Kim's use of references started to rise—and randomize, spanning reputations and generations. The following year, she was robbed in her Paris hotel room, surviving an almost tragedy that would have made pop culture history had it ended differently. The following year, Kim, along with her four-year-old daughter, North West, shot a now-notorious "Kennedy-themed" cover for *Interview,* featuring Kim suited in classic Jackie O looks (and sporting a very dark tan, reminding us that one of the first Kardashian enterprises, back in 2010, was a self-tanning gel). Twenty seventeen was also the Halloween of Selena, Aaliyah, and Madonna-as-Marilyn. Kim was a living listicle of legendary ladies—specifically mononymous ones iconized by tragic deaths, one year after she almost met one herself.

As Kim's relevance grew, the comparisons between her persona and her chosen blueprints began to take on a sense of poignancy, prophecy, or impertinence, depending on the context. A year following her *Interview* cover, in a conversation with the art dealer and designer Axel Vervoordt for *The Hollywood Reporter,* Ye said of his wife, "I see her as a representation; a Marie Antoinette of our time." Fast-forward to 2022. In the face of a not-yet-post-pandemic landscape, Kim told *Variety,* "I have advice for women in business: get off your ass and work. It seems like no one wants to work anymore." Social media erupted with comparisons of Kim's comment to the felled French queen's misattributed tagline "Let them eat cake." Maybe you see what I'm getting at: Kim's image is now syndicated with History's Hot Girls.

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Surely there are so many viral TikTok videos and hotly debated think pieces comparing Kim to (or contrasting her with) the women she's pretended to be —*she's nothing like Marilyn, but* Britney *is! Kim is Jayne Mansfield because of*

all the publicity stunts, or maybe Liz Taylor with all the marriages, or what about the time Kanye called her Marina Abramović?—because of the proven codependent relationship between the brain chemical dopamine and the mental function of pattern perception. The statistician, author, and social theorist Nassim Taleb has written at length about this. "Pattern perception increases along with the concentration in the brain of the chemical dopamine," Taleb explains in *The Black Swan: The Impact of the Highly Improbable*. Dopamine controls aspects of our internal reward systems. Some patients treated with medication for their Parkinson's disease suffer depletion of dopamine and, Taleb writes, have ended up suing their doctors for their subsequent gambling addictions. Gambling, after all, seduces the brain with the pleasure of sensing patterns, thereby re-inducing the floods of dopamine lost due to medication. Taleb suggests that because it feels so good to find connections, we might even sometimes be at risk of "overinterpreting." I wonder whether, on some level, Kim understands that most people have these "meaning making" reflexes and whether that's partly why she aligns herself with countless cultural myths. That irresistible exercise—whether "seeing" the connections or feverishly explaining why they don't apply—further engages us with her content, positioning us as authors of her public myth, or maybe just automatons for her publicity machine.

"Both the artistic and scientific enterprises are the product of our need to reduce dimensions and inflict some order on things," Taleb explains, and then compares the brain to a computer. "Information is costly to manipulate and retrieve." He describes our urge to mythologize with a computational term: "compression."

"A novel, a story, a myth, or a tale, all have the same function: they spare us from the complexity of the world and shield us from its randomness. Myths impart order to the disorder of human perception." Once compression has occurred and order has been established, then, "as we can remember it with less effort, we can sell it to others, market it as a packaged idea." Sounds more than a little Kardashian-esque.

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If publicity is all about encouraging a cycle of emulation, and nostalgia is at least partly about narrative compression, how does this shape the way we present ourselves online?

"In this electric age we see ourselves being translated more and more into the form of information," Marshall McLuhan wrote in *Understanding Media*. He was making a metaphor about the blurred boundaries between human beings and the various electronic devices we use to connect to the world (radios, phones, TVs). McLuhan's whole notion was that technology was becoming an "extension" of man, predicting the self-deprecating jokes we'd one day make about smartphones being attached to our hands. I wonder what he'd think of the grid, the feed, the For You page. Anytime we post ourselves, after all, we translate ourselves into information.

In 2016, the U.K.-based data sociologist Christopher Till used a software program called NodeXL to scour Twitter's results for the #Durkheim hashtag. Émile Durkheim was a French theorist whose deconstructions of the social function of religion could totally be applied to fan culture, but Till just used his name for the novelty of it. Afterward, he created a visualization of the web of connections that he encountered to make a larger point about the interconnectedness of information enabled by social media networks.

"I wasn't looking for Kim Kardashian," he told the Kardashian Data Koalition in a video discussion we hosted with him several years later. But, in 2016, a French radio station had referenced Durkheim's theories about crime (that it functions in part to help a society figure out where its moral lines begin and end) in relation to the world's mixed response to Kim's robbery in Paris, so her name surfaced in connection to the iconic French sociologist. "I wonder if I'd put almost anything in," Till said, laughing, "maybe it would have all come back to Kim."

It's appropriate that the software Till used was called Node. As Till defines the word, a node "could be anything that has connection with other things." Information flows through the digital landscape as an infinite network of connections, and one way or another meaning will be made of it. Manuel Castells, a Spanish sociologist and the author of *The Internet Galaxy,* put it this way: "There is a multilayering of global networks in the key strategic

activities that structure and de-structure the planet. When these multilayered networks overlap in some node, when there is a node that belongs to different networks, two major consequences follow. First, economies of synergy between these different networks take place in that node: between financial markets and media businesses; or between academic research and technology development and innovation; between politics and media."

Say we are pop culture fans. Some of you may be if you're reading this book.

Consider the sheer volume of pop culture info that exists: every "iconic" celebrity that has ever existed and the vastness of the histories and social context surrounding them. The memory of Marilyn Monroe lives in the image of her in the pink dress surrounded by male admirers as she sings "Diamonds Are a Girl's Best Friend," and that image is found on Google Images, and Instagram, and maybe most important Wikipedia—the space where knowledge itself becomes a decentralized and participatory project—where you learn that Gail Levin said that Monroe was one of the most photographed women of the twentieth century, or that her name has been licensed for hundreds of products, or that she was Andy Warhol's muse for a moment. Marilyn was a person, but thanks to media she equates, also, to information. How are we to make sense of that cacophony of content?

Kim shows us. She *performs* the information when she dresses up as it for social media, and, in doing so, attaches Marilyn's historic social capital to her own, generating Castells's aforementioned "economies of synergy." And when Kim *becomes* Madonna-as-Marilyn, she reminds us that in the vast realm of 0s and 1s, we can click open any archive and waft through a web of interconnected information. In costume as someone else, Kim embodies the persona but also the act of a click, the opening of the web page, and the impulse to interpret whatever we find.

Even this notion that Kim is traveling through time when she reanimates the past tracks with Castells, who also said that digital life has created something called timeless time, time that is "de-sequenced, including past, present, and future occurring in random sequence." His point: What do constructs of clocks even *mean* when internet life is so immaterial? Think

about that usually stomach-turning sensation of coming out of a Twitter or TikTok spiral, only to realize that two hours have passed.

Now imagine the web of connections between public figures as nodes and all the modern mediums on which they live. Marilyn to Madonna to Kim. Movies and magazines to TV and radio to Instagram and everything still to come. Every time Kim appropriates another icon or pops up performing a new role in a surprising location of the digital realm (as an emoji, as a video game avatar, as an activist standing behind the White House press lectern, as a performance art costar with her ex-husband, getting fake remarried in Balenciaga at the center of a stadium, to be reproduced as shareable content all over Twitter), what Till calls her "betweenness centrality" intensifies. According to this setup, Kim would show up in a NodeXL visualization as a larger node than all the rest, with many lines going to and from other nodes. "Centrality essentially means how important you are as a bridge to other nodes," Till explained. Kim is relevant to text messages, to CNN, to a hit album, to fashion shows, to Halloween.

Does it follow, then, that the larger the node, the more it becomes immortal or iconic or relevant, or whatever the word du jour is to explain the power of a certain kind of cultural figure? "What we've increasingly realized," Till says, "is people like Kim become whales, and everyone is just kind of living around the edges. I think that kind of virality and centralization around particular nodes creating particular hubs is related to [social media platforms'] economic models. They've gone for this advertising-funded system which needs to attract eyeballs. The people who've been successful as influencers—people like Kim Kardashian—have very cleverly been able to manipulate that system."

Among the 2.35 billion active users on Instagram, many of us—consciously or unconsciously—emulate Kim's sensibilities. Even if, say, we're not fully embodying the *Legally Blonde* protagonist, Elle Woods, to iconize, through Instagram, our law school journeys, hordes of us *do* dress up to go out and then post the photos in a performance of our own self-concepts. The app favors variety and performativity (all within the parameters of a visually pleasing grid, of course). If your Instagram account comes off as its own

"visual cacophony" of information, you'll enjoy more "likes" (which is to say, of course, more dopamine).

Pre-pandemic, I observed a spectrum of this aesthetically driven self-presentation all over Brooklyn. We wanted to go to the colorful restaurants, like Brooklyn's Wes Anderson–esque Turk's Inn, wearing a vintage look to suit the setting, to take a picture at the table, tag one another, and geotag the venue (because specificity just hits different). Plus, online performativity seems to exist on a spectrum, and there are many examples of more extreme approaches. Consider the wide swath of influencers who completely costume themselves for their activities, whether they're wearing a full cowgirl look to take a horse-riding lesson or dressing in dreamy pastel-hued sundresses for park picnics that look like ads for—anything.

To some extent, this visual language is merely the modus operandi of fashion. We might recall that Carrie Bradshaw brought a touch of theme wherever she went in *Sex and the City* (recall the berets worn during season 6's stint in Paris). But Kim Kardashian's deep embrace of publicity and "iconic" posturing, mediated by Instagram, has established an inescapable standard. Surely most of us have at least subconsciously noticed that the IG posts that look the most like an album cover, an ad, a tableau—or, most of all, *like something Kim Kardashian would post*—are the ones that get "likes."

Of course, the COVID-19 lockdown destabilized Instagram's dominant "who what where when" conventions. In 2020, the short-form content platform TikTok was downloaded 850 million times, and, in the years that followed, exceeded 1 billion. The app was known for its "anti-Kardashian" influencer culture, which entailed stuck-inside young people performing trending dance moves while wearing "TikTok Couture" or offering Storytimes and hot takes while putting makeup on. Neither linearity nor context was of any concern to the algorithm's mysterious, powerful, and addictive For You page, which might deliver users a video made three months earlier if their recent engagement interests indicated they'd like it. The speed of these video deliveries was faster than anyone had asked for. Advertising, too, had become so direct that it was downright invasive. Nostalgic content was no longer the sole force to attract eyeballs. According to Shoshana

Zuboff, author of *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism,* technology has advanced to an ability to "align the forces of supply and demand." Of course, this has been going on for some time (since 2001, says Zuboff): Cookies track our clicks—which is to say, our interests—and now platforms can deliver us tailor-made content to "tune, herd, and condition our behavior with subtle and subliminal cues, rewards, and punishments that shunt us toward their most profitable outcomes." But, as legislative deregulation of surveillance persists and social media algorithms advance, the phenomenon is more complex and powerful than ever—think of all the jokes we make these days about feeling as if our phones listen to us—and targeted ads align with TikTok's modus operandi of catered content to a T. If a young person's online behavior shows an interest in, say, "bimbocore" aesthetics—to be worn alone in their room while making videos—they might begin noticing targeted ads for cheap fashion companies that can manufacture the style fast enough to keep up with evolving trends. (I use this example because Gen Z are among the world's biggest consumers of fast fashion, but really the power of targeted content shapes culture in numerous and expansive ways, from the more obvious shopping trends to political and religious ideology.) If the medium is the message, then TikTok's message—and that of this era of ads in general—was that material reality is incidental, structure is arbitrary, and no limit exists to the acceleration of production and consumption.

Upon the world's reopening, of course, plenty of social media users have resumed their routines of flexing looks and friend groups while visiting enviable locales. But 2020 had brought new meaning to the term "living online," exposing us to the far reaches of a digital bedlam I suspect Kim has been using as #inspo all along. We can assume that she now has access to the kind of data necessary to inform her costume choices for optimal impact—when, for example, in February 2023, the British royal family was in the news for some Meghan and Harry drama and Kim publicly bought one of Princess Diana's necklaces at auction for nearly $200,000, inserting her name in that week's media cycle—and it's impossible to ignore the fact that Big Tech's domination of the information economy has challenged the media industry at large.

In May 2023, following several quarterly reports showing dwindling revenues, Jonah Peretti announced that the company's most vital division, the award-winning *BuzzFeed News,* was shuttering and the company would be laying off 15 percent of its workforce. The solution? Investment in AI to generate quizzes and games and nurturing more commercial partnerships with individual social media influencers. "Audiences will begin to expect all content to be personalized, interactive and dynamic," he wrote in a letter to the company, predicting growing consumer preferences for fun and fast content, plus more parasocial connections to creators. To ensure profitability, the company needed an affordable and efficient way to provide these kicks to the site's readers. "Adaptation is in our DNA," he added.

The internet is a place wherein archival images, mental projections, targeted ads, and networked connections all come together, with a shrinking sense of time and space. It's only natural that we find ourselves seeking blueprints in the icons who came before. Blueprints suggest a semblance of order: the same sort of clarity once promised to us by *BuzzFeed,* as it reflected and curated the mayhem of the World Wide Web beyond it; the compression of information into myth that'll save our busy brains some room; the guidance in glamour construction that might earn us some semblance of social power (or at least "likes").

In 2022, talking to Tucker Carlson, Kanye West amended his 2016 pronouncement of Kim's significance. "Kim is a hybrid. She's not just Marilyn Monroe. She's also a fashion person. She's a mom. She's an activist. She's a lawyer. She's a multibillionaire."

Kim was never coming for Marilyn's blueprint. Her blueprint is the network society itself. She said as much on her TV show while shimmying into a dress apparently destined to twice send shock waves across media's web of connections: "Honey—I'm the Jackie *and* the Marilyn."

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2. MARILYN MONROE

The Old Hollywood studio system, aura, and space/time

Season 2 of *The Kardashians*—the family's 2022 streaming relaunch with Hulu after the conclusion of E!'s *Keeping Up with the Kardashians,* the series that made them famous—was dedicated to Marilyn's Dress. We follow Kim from her appeals to Ripley's Believe It or Not! for permission to borrow it (according to Kim, the franchise, which bought the dress at auction in 2016, only relented once "Kris Jenner called") to her Rocky Balboa–esque mission to fit into it (SKIMS shapewear assisted the final zip). Hours before her debut on the Met Gala red carpet, Kim confessed to feeling anxious. "I'm a little nervous that people will hate, and just be like, 'How dare she think she can step into Marilyn's dress?' "

As we know, people did. Bob Mackie, the sketch artist behind the Jean Louis design, told *Entertainment Weekly,* "It was designed for [Marilyn]. No one else should be seen in that dress." The International Committee for Museums and Collections of Costume, Fashion, and Textiles released a statement: "Heritage must be understood as belonging to humanity, regardless of which institution has custody of the property. As museum professionals, we strongly recommend all museums to avoid lending historic garments to be worn, as they are artifacts of the material culture of its time."

A famous essay by the twentieth-century Jewish-German art critic Walter Benjamin both affirms Kim's detractors and rationalizes her decision to colonize an original: "What withers in the age of the technological reproducibility of the work of art is the…aura." Aura, Benjamin wrote, withers due to "the desire of the present-day masses to 'get closer' to things, and their equally passionate concern for overcoming each thing's uniqueness by assimilating it as a reproduction."

Which is to say that if the commodity queen Kim Kardashian had donned a mere replica of Marilyn's controversial 1962 look, it simply would not have landed the same.

Benjamin fled propaganda-ridden Nazi-era Germany for Paris, where, in 1936, he published "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," about the perils and possibilities he observed in industrial mass production and its effect on culture. Sure, emergent and ever-evolving machines could totally manufacture photos and clothing and cars—among countless other products for which there was growing demand—but no factory could assemble and distribute the *essence* of great artworks. So, Benjamin asks, if an original piece can be printed a thousand and more times, does its "authority" decay, or is it democratized? A common exercise posed by professors is to consider the frenzies we find at certain museums. Why are the original *Mona Lisa* and *Venus de Milo* such Louvre hot stops when we can google their images whenever we want, or even decorate our millennial-pink bedrooms with mini-*Venus*es? (I use mine as a bookend.) The sheer power of their authenticity is why. Benjamin writes, "In even the most perfect reproduction, one thing is lacking: the here and now of the work of art—its unique existence in a particular place. It is this unique existence…that bears the mark of the history to which the work has been subject…. The here and now of the original underlies the concept of its authenticity."

On *The Kardashians,* Kim googled grainy clips of the moment at Madison Square Garden when Marilyn serenaded Mr. President while swaying in the Dress's soufflé silk (a textile that is no longer made). By the end of the episode, Kim has repeatedly described her own experience of climbing the Met steps for the ninth time while wearing the historic piece as a "moment" of its own: "I set my mind to something, and I was able to pull it off. That was the best moment ever."

It's true that Kim inhabited space and time in a powerful way for those ten minutes, manufacturing memorable spectacle and maximizing the red carpet as a self-contained medium (as a condition of the Dress's lease, she changed into a replica after reaching the top of the stairs). Plus, throughout the evening, camera-conscious Kim appeared to avoid standing too close to her

youngest sister, Kylie Jenner, whose own rise to fame in 2014 had come, in large part, from undergoing an injectables-assisted pubescence that had resulted in a startling "Kim K 2.0" effect. It's become a matter of public curiosity about whether Kylie's uncanny resemblance to Kim is intentional, but regardless it sends a message to consumers that the Kardashian aesthetic is attainable to anyone willing to pay for pokes to the right places in the face.

On this evening, however, Kylie's function as a living example of the reproducibility of Kim's image might not have been so conducive to her sister's intended fashion statement. Whether on purpose or not, Kim stood mostly alone.

Here's the thing: The Monroe myth entails a "brick and mortar" come-up. To "make it," Marilyn pounded the fresh pavement of a booming industry, gathering cinematic milestones at Hollywood landmarks that would one day become the stuff of L.A. bus tours, while Kim's fashion-focused climb was digitalized, her greatest wins involving virality on new mediums. This distinction in space and time is not only what makes the SoCal-bred icons seem so different from each other, but also why the masses love to love modern Marilyn and love to hate postmodern Kim.

"Industrial modernity, as it began to sweep across the European landscapes of the nineteenth century and introduced technologies such as the steam train, the telegraph, the telephone, the cinema, and the automobile, inaugurated an age of unprecedented time-space compression." This is how Lutz Koepnick, author of *On Slowness,* summarizes the era Benjamin reflected on in his essay. Notice that these changes rolled in by way of communication and transportation. "Modernity brought the thrill of speed and motion to the sluggishness of preindustrial life. It provided unknown physical sensations, perceptual pleasures, and psychic agitations and, in this way, it not only reworked the entire human sensorium, but promised a future joyfully different from the past."

Modernity meant the California gold rush of 1848–55, which was, as the historian James N. Gregory called it, an "extraordinary drama of luck and adventure that forever fixed the state's reputation as a land of dreams." The rush catalyzed construction of roads, DIY cities known as boomtowns, and all

kinds of industry, displacing and killing tens of thousands of Native Americans in the process. As for popular culture? Theaters were erected in more developed areas like Sacramento; vaudeville occasionally toured through smaller mining communities. Big names—like the ex-courtesan Lola Montez, an Irish-Anglo dancer notorious for her Spanish self-presentation—attracted automatic crowds because miners had so few entertainment options.

Modernity meant the advancement of film as a form. In 1877, the landscape photographer Eadweard Muybridge was hired by Leland Stanford to help the former governor of California scratch a brain itch of the sort we all experience from time to time—namely, Stanford wondered, Is there any millisecond when all four of a galloping horse's hooves are suspended in the air at once?

What resulted was *The Horse in Motion,* a series of what were essentially stop-motion photographs, made possible by manipulated shutter speeds, starring an unnamed Black jockey riding Stanford's favorite horse, Occident. (The horror auteur Jordan Peele referenced the game-changing "chronophotographs" in an early scene of his 2022 media-theory meditation, *Nope.*) The purpose of projects like *The Horse in Motion* was to help us better grasp the way that bodies (and objects) moved through space and time. Think about it: Without cameras to capture it, how would we really *see* the abstract notion of motion? And even if our eyes could catch useful details—such as Stanford's initial, sudden, and short-lived glimpses of a levitating Occident—without cameras we couldn't document them for further study. Long before Kim Kardashian was the self-appointed leader of the self-documentation movement, humans became rightly enamored with their newfound ability to transform literal, fleeting steps into lasting images.

Cameras began to evolve. About a decade later, in Paris, the Lumière brothers built upon the (already patented) *cinématographe* to solidify their own, more sophisticated version in 1895. They'd be most remembered, though, for their 1896 Paris premiere of *L'arrivée d'un train en gare de La Ciotat,* which showed, in moving film, exactly what its title declared: a train arriving at a station. Legend has it that audience members panicked at the

sight of a train coming toward them and, according to one writer, "jumped up from their chairs in shock."

Finally, in 1905 New York City, the Hungarian immigrant Adolph Zukor, a self-made furrier and recent investor in penny arcades, took notice of Hale's Tours exhibits, which simulated the experience of riding a train by rocking the stage-car the audience sat in and projecting images of European scenery out of their "windows."

"The making of these low-priced projection machines," Zukor later said, "made it possible for a number of store shows to come into existence." Including his own, because he invested in the exhibition spaces, which could be considered the OG movie theaters.

As technologies advance, early adopters often reap rewards, and the most successful among them figure out how to fill the forms in new ways. Kris Jenner attested to this in 2020 when she told Andy Cohen, "When we started doing our show, there was barely Twitter. There was no Instagram, no Snapchat, no TikTok. We came along when it was a perfect storm." Kim and her sisters would soon fill those wide-open digital landscapes with selfies and subtweets and #ads, demonstrating an intuitive understanding of the power of narrative.

"During 1907," the historian Douglas Gomery wrote, "Zukor came to believe the industry would prosper only if he raised the stature of the films he showed." Zukor pondered vaudeville's successful storylines, and he also traveled to Europe to observe the elaborate production of *The Life and Passion of Jesus Christ* by the prospering Pathé studios in Paris, ultimately developing a vision for longer-running, narrative-driven films. "I was sure that personalities plus a good story were all that we needed in pictures," he later told Harvard Business School.

World War I would soon sabotage the rapid growth of the European studios, enabling Zukor's new Famous Players Film Company to play catch-up. But New York City was a rather confining space to try to go big, in part because the East Coast was Thomas Edison's turf: The owner of numerous motion-picture-related patents, the famously prolific Wizard of Menlo Park was also infamously litigious.

Southern California, where the courts moved more slowly and were conveniently disconnected from East Coast legal networks, became the prime place for Zukor and a handful of like-minded entrepreneurs to seek distance from the threat of Edison's lawsuits and set up shop because, as the film scholar Thom Andersen points out in his video essay *Los Angeles Plays Itself,* "its varied terrain and eclectic architecture allowed Los Angeles and its environs to play almost any place. Lake Arrowhead, seventy-eight miles from downtown Los Angeles, could play Switzerland. Calabasas in the San Fernando Valley could play the valley of Ling in China after MGM excavated some rice paddies. More often than not, Los Angeles played some other city." Technological and industrial progress—modernity—was proving that time could be captured and space, manipulated.

In fact, in 1914, the director and screenwriter D. W. Griffith shot L.A.'s Griffith Ranch (among several other SoCal sites) as a stand-in for a Civil War battlefield in Virginia. He was making *The Birth of a Nation,* which depicted the assassination of President Lincoln and then followed the conflicts between two families: one, pro-Union, and the other, pro-Confederate. The film, teeming with white actors in blackface, portrayed the Ku Klux Klan in a positive light, featured a lynching, and framed as calamitous a sequence of a Black governor passing legislation to legalize interracial marriage. *The Birth of a Nation* was one of the first to actualize Zukor's vision of longer-running, narrative-driven films (though Zukor was not involved with its making), and it was a historic success, raking in an estimated $50–$100 million. President Woodrow Wilson even screened the film at the White House ("It is all so terribly true," he is said to have remarked when it was over), proving that the genesis of American media is littered with racism.

The streets of the developing city of Los Angeles, on the other hand, though not entirely without their own hazards, contained a dynamic multiculturalism among the working class, suggesting that material reality and media production are often, on some level, at odds. At the time of Adolph Zukor's 1916 merger of his Famous Players and Lasky Corporation, which would one day become Paramount Pictures as we know it—creating Hollywood's biggest film company—L.A.'s primary transportation system

was the Pacific Electric Railway, which offered affordable and expansive streetcars and, according to Jovanni Perez, an environment for interaction across cultures to take place. Italian, Irish, Mexican, Jewish, and African Americans were shuttled, shoulder to shoulder, from point A to point B, very often to factory jobs. The mobility that the cars provided to citizens also "permitted Los Angeles to spread out," as Angelenos bought land in "remote, but now connected" areas, helping L.A. to actualize its now-defining horizontal spread.

Let's talk about dimensions—both literal and metaphorical. Compared with horizontal L.A., Zukor's city-defining business model was entirely "vertical," which Tim Wu, author of *The Master Switch,* describes as "the stacking, as it were, of the parts of an industry that perform different functions (here, production, distribution, and exhibition) to create a consolidated single entity…. In steel, [vertical integration] meant owning the mines, the trains, and the mills. In film, it required owning the talent—stars, directors, and writers—as well as the studios, the distribution networks, and, ultimately, the theaters."

This would be the foundation for the golden age "factories" we think of today when we mythologize the process of bright-eyed young women like Norma Jeane Mortenson being plucked from obscurity, bleached blond, renamed, and spat out of a well-oiled publicity machine like the products they were. The vertical model could also be compared to Kris Jenner's (self-trademarked) "momager" role and her epic success at commodifying her kids, which the Kar-Jenners have all seemed to credit, at different points, to a collectively agreed-upon "keep it in the family" ethos. Manufacturing, once an industrial process associated with machines, was moving on to immaterial products: movies, movie stars, and myths.

But if Kim followed Marilyn's blueprint by moving through a star construction system to become the most famous woman in the world, then Marilyn, knowingly or not, followed Mary Pickford's. "The best-known woman who has ever lived, the woman who was known to more people and loved by more people than any other woman that has been in all history," as one reporter of the time put it, was born Gladys Smith in Toronto in 1892, a

struggling theater actress discovered by D. W. Griffith in 1909 to star in Biograph pictures like *To Save Her Soul* and *Sweet and Twenty*.

Like L.A. itself, Pickford's ability to shape-shift appealed to moviemakers. "I played scrubwomen and secretaries and women of all nations," she once told a reporter. "I noticed rather early that Mr. Griffith seemed to favor me in the roles of Mexican and Indian women."

But even though millions of Americans were going to the cinema to see Pickford and her contemporaries, audiences didn't know who she was. As the scholars Susan J. Douglas and Andrea McDonnell explain of early silent films, "Studios were leery of promoting individual players for fear that they would become intractable or demand higher pay. And so names and identities were kept from the public and audiences were compelled to make up nicknames when discussing their favorites." Pickford was known in the press and movie posters as "the girl with the curls," "Blondilocks," and "the Biograph girl."

But didn't Benjamin mention earlier that the masses had a perpetual desire to "get closer to things"? According to Douglas and McDonnell, "The cinematic apparatus—sitting in a darkened theater while watching illuminated bodies and faces larger than your own performing for you and engaging with you—enabled an entirely new and deeply compelling production of celebrity, especially as theaters and screens got larger. Various theorists have argued that this particular viewing experience replicated foundational psychological moments from infancy, when we both identify with and idealize the larger faces and bodies that tend to us and nurture us."

People began to crave more closeness with the performers they enjoyed on-screen and demonstrated through ticket sales and press reviews their collective wish to see the ambiguous archetypes come into clearer focus. (Another thing we'll notice often in the history of media: The masses, with all their spending power, can influence the direction in which media moves.) Thus, "the girl with the curls" became "Mary Pickford, America's Sweetheart," finally billed by name at the theaters and in *Photoplay* profiles. It wouldn't be long before Zukor poached Pickford for Famous Players (soon to be known as Paramount).

The prolific actress eventually became half of a beloved power couple with her fellow star Douglas Fairbanks (in a Kimye-like move, they named their Beverly Hills estate Pickfair), and would be, along with her husband, the first star to lay hands in the wet cement in front of Grauman's Chinese Theatre. All in all, Mary Pickford laid a reliable blueprint for star formation to which studios would continue to return.

In 1934, the *Los Angeles Times* ran the headline "Mary Pickford Sees Talkies as Lipstick on [Venus de] Milo," quoting her complaint that "there is too much talking in the films today," and this is partly why Pickford is often considered one of those tragic casualties of the industry's transition into sound. In truth, audiences liked her first talking picture, *Coquette,* which grossed $1.4 million, and though she eventually phased out of film, acting was never her sole bag anyway. In fact, Mary Pickford did exactly what we've watched girlbosses like Kim Kardashian and Rihanna do today: She moved beyond her role as a performer-commodity to make a name for herself on the male-dominated business side of things. Along with Charlie Chaplin, D. W. Griffith, and Douglas Fairbanks, Pickford founded United Artists (which parted from the powerful but ultimately ill-fated vertical systems of the time by focusing only on distribution). She'd also eventually buy back the rights to many of her own films and become one of the founders of the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences.

Adolph Zukor would agree that Pickford ought to be better known for her business acumen. He once told a reporter that when he proposed her move to Paramount, she said, "You know, for years I've dreamed of making $20,000 a year before I was 20, and I'll be 20 very soon." Zukor recalled, "She got the $20,000. And before long I was paying her $100,000 a year." Among her more charitable ventures was one from 1916, when, along with Constance Adams DeMille, Pickford founded the Hollywood Studio Club, a "chaperoned…sorority" where women could safely bunk while chasing their Hollywood dreams—and where Marilyn Monroe would one day stay.

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Marilyn's myth as we all seem to know it cavorts across an expanding horizontal city and a booming vertical industry, a montage of moments and milestones. The word "montage" means "to assemble" in French and connotes an editing technique devised by early Soviet filmmakers to shrink space and time while still communicating a mood or a point. (Sergei Eisenstein wrote in 1929 that montage was the "nerve" of cinema.)

"I used to sit in the window and cry because I'd see RKO and I knew my mother had worked there…. When I went there to work…I wanted to look back to see the orphanage, but you can't, there's too many sound stages in the way, and office buildings, and homes." That's Monroe in 1960, telling a reporter about her view of the RKO studio's water tower from her childhood orphanage. Her poetic attempt to reclaim the view probably occurred in 1950 or 1951 when her home studio, Fox, lent her out to RKO to make the noir Clash by Night.

Monroe is born in 1926, at the precipice of the movie industry's radical transition from silents into sound. Silent films were often shot outdoors, making the most of L.A.'s varied topography to tell all kinds of "international" stories, but the advent of talking pictures has brought production inside. Movie attendance has doubled to 110 million viewers a week, and studios must meet demand, building bigger infrastructure to accommodate soundstages and additional departments.

The film scholar Jeanine Basinger explains it this way: "Since the system needed movie stars every day (and lots of them), it did the sensible thing: it manufactured its own. The studios dedicated themselves to creating stars, and they made all kinds of them."

The "Big Five" studios of the golden age—MGM, Fox, Warner Bros., Paramount, and RKO—have become bona fide factories, achieving the apex of Zukor's vertical design, helping Hollywood to weather the Great Depression when few other industries will. It isn't only the stars who are contracted, either. Writers, directors, set and wardrobe designers, and publicists are all in-house, governed from the top down, and contained by hundred-acre-sized lots. "It was a complete city," Janet Leigh once said of the studios. "You could live there."

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The studios may feel like cities, but beyond the VIP-filled lots, more people than ever live in Los Angeles. Depression-era New Deal funding paves the way for more roads as well as, Jovanni Perez writes, "committees and investigations…to locate the best possible routes of major highways." Most of these routes, intended to accelerate the pace and potential of L.A., trample eastern neighborhoods like Boyle Heights, displacing the Black and brown communities that had once made the most of the Red Car transit system. The City of Angels, a mecca for celluloid dreams, will become racially stratified and remain that way. Modernity may connote a thrilling sense of progress, but it also moves Angelenos inside machines—their cars—and away from one another.

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Now World War II has arrived. Even more freeways are being built "due to defense industries which enhanced the need for the automobile." Defense industries include the Burbank factory where, according to The New York Times, *an eighteen-year-old brunette, Norma Jeane, "inspected and sprayed parachutes" with fire retardant. In 1944, David Conover, a photographer for the U.S. Army's First Motion Picture Unit, is assigned by Captain Ronald Reagan "to snap some fresh Rosie the Riveter–type pictures of women in war production." "I snapped her picture and walked on," Conover would write in his 1981 memoir,* Finding Marilyn. *"Then I stopped, stunned. She was beautiful. Half child, half woman, her eyes held something that touched and intrigued me." Soon Norma Jeane will be renamed Marilyn Monroe and make her way from Radioplane toward a different kind of manufacturing center: Fox Studios.*

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First, newly blond Marilyn works as a model around town, and L.A., with its emerging grid of new and in-progress freeways, further develops into an

"autopia." It tracks that a media center like L.A. is becoming more and more defined by two intersecting forces: transportation and communication. Marshall McLuhan considers transportation a starting point—and metaphor—for media technologies. The "basic function of media," he'll write in Understanding Media, *is to "store and expedite information." Which is why his tome comprises chapters titled "Roads and Paper Routes," "Motorcar," "Telegraph," "The Telephone," and, of course, "Movies." All are mediums, by McLuhan's estimation, and all "extended" the functions of the human body. "It was not until the advent of the telegraph that messages could travel faster than a messenger," he points out, emphasizing a perhaps obvious but often overlooked evolutionary sequence from feet to horse hooves to wheels to electricity and telecommunications networks.*

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So, when, around 1946, Marilyn, a spry Fox studio "apprentice," begins motoring around the L.A. freeways to get from home to work to dates to whatever else—perhaps in a convertible, the kind of car in which she was most often photographed—McLuhan might say that Monroe is herself *information, being transported from point A to point B.*

By this logic, "information" in the form of marginalized Angelenos had been largely scrapped during the city's updates, along with its main system of movement, the streetcars, which offered far more tactile, real-time connection to the land than cars could, and regular person-to-person encounters, which promoted richer, realer cultural exchange than movies did. As McLuhan writes, "The railroad next took over the development of the suburbs, with housing kept within walking distance of the railroad stop…. The automobile, followed by the airplane, dissolved this grouping and ended the pedestrian, or human, scale of the suburb." Basically, these transportation advancements distanced us from our material sense of place and personhood, even though cinema, a new method of movement, brought the country together in theaters; in its depiction of human dramas; in its delectable production of beyond-human—yet man-made—stars.

McLuhan was a bit of an underdog in his time (a 1967 documentary profiling him includes a sequence of more conventional cultural critics commenting that his work was unlikely to have "lasting influence"), but his takes on media are why we now speak of the internet using metaphors, whether we're calling it a "global village" (McLuhan's term) or the "information superhighway" (clearly influenced by McLuhan, even though many claim it was Al Gore). It's a whole new brain itch to consider: Did we make the simultaneously antisocial and hyper-connective internet in the image of freeways, or do we speak of freeways to make sense of what we made? As the communications scholar Father John Culkin, SJ, once wrote (in a quotation widely attributed to his close friend McLuhan), "We shape our tools, and thereafter, our tools shape us," and McLuhan wrote that the Latin root of the word "metaphor" is "to transfer," or "to carry across."

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In 1948, Marilyn Monroe moves into the Hollywood Studio Club at 1215 Lodi Place, in the heart of Hollywood. She falls behind on rent and so she poses nude in a red velvet bed for Tom Kelley, photos that, several years later, will wind up in the first issue of Playboy *without her consent. A year or so following this photo shoot, she moves into the Hollywood Roosevelt Hotel, another L.A. landmark that exists thanks to Mary Pickford's investment. (One day, hotel tour guides will claim that Monroe haunts the Roosevelt's mirrors.)*

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In 1950, Marilyn makes two brief movie appearances: in The Asphalt Jungle, *a noir, and* All About Eve, *a drama. Studios selected certain up-and-comers for future stardom in part by the volume of fan mail they received—they had whole departments dedicated to the popularity metrics provided by fan mail, a precursor to the data analytics that now determine viral success—and perhaps positive audience reception contributed to the call to elevate her. Of course, Basinger writes, studio gossip suggested that Marilyn had "negotiated the executive office" using alternative methods. However it happened, "Fox,*

experienced at grooming successful sexy blond stars, chose to pull Monroe out of the ranks and give her everything they had in the buildup."

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Nineteen fifty-three: Grauman's Chinese Theatre and its semi-virgin pavement. Marilyn Monroe and Jane Russell, stars of the hit comedy Gentlemen Prefer Blondes, *plunge their hands into the wet cement of the Hollywood Walk of Fame, certifying themselves, officially, as stars. Monroe makes a crack that her breasts and butt belong in the cement too, or at least that's how legend has it.*

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In 1962, Marilyn flies across the country to asphalt jungle New York City to sing "Happy Birthday" to President John F. Kennedy at a DNC fundraising event being framed as his party. She's introduced to the Madison Square Garden stage by the English actor and Rat Pack member Peter Lawford as the "late Marilyn Monroe," because she'd developed a reputation out in Hollywood for being late wherever she went.

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A few months later, Marilyn dies in bed at her home on 12305 Fifth Helena Drive of a mysterious overdose, clutching her telephone, a communication medium that, McLuhan points out, "is a participant form that demands a partner." Could there be anything lonelier?

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With the viral mobile app game *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood,* nobody needs to be on the other side of the phone, because an avatar of Kim Kardashian is there on its small screen and ready to be your "bestie."

On June 24, 2014, the intricately designed, playable rendering of Kim's already-notorious life was released to the App Store by the gaming developer

Glu Mobile, and would be downloaded 45 million times and reap $160 million in revenue that year alone.

The premise is simple, according to the game's summary on Google Play: "Get famous in Hollywood and create your fashion story!" With Kim as your guide, you must move from "Z-List to A-List" in what the *Verge* cultural critic Kwame Opam calls a "cartoonified" media industry. Here, McLuhan's metaphors run rampant. A *Kardashians* sign replaces the real-life Hollywood one, looming in the background of many scenes. Your primary "power supply" is "energy," which you can regain by resting but also by getting into VIP events. When it comes to meeting VIP characters, your interaction options are typically to "flirt" or "network." This simulated quest for status echoed a computer game released by Sierra Entertainment in 1990: *Jones in the Fast Lane*. At the start of the game, players defined their aspirational levels of "money, happiness, status, and education," and competed against their nemesis, Jones (named after the expression "keeping up with the Joneses"), as they moved their way through a board-game-inspired interface, which housed buildings in each of its little squares (a bank, an employment office, an apartment building, a fast-food restaurant, a factory).

Most of the *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood* challenges are fashion focused; after all, they follow Kim's real-life rise. You can work at a clothing store, just as, in early seasons of *KUWTK,* Kim worked at Dash, her family's Calabasas clothing boutique. Or you can lend a hand at photo shoots, a common setting in the Kardashi-sphere, especially tied to the brand after the widely memed 2007 *Playboy* shoot when Kris Jenner snapped a digital camera pic of a nude Kim while telling her, "You're doing amazing, sweetie." With more "star-power," "experience," "cash" (the game's currency system), or real cash, you can also buy cooler clothes for your avatar, suggesting Kim's famous 2012 makeover, when her new boyfriend, Kanye West, emptied her closet of its gaudy early '00s contents to fill it with his preferred luxury pieces and neutrals from Yeezy, his own nascent label. "Kanye's definitely inspired me to be a little more of an individual," Kim remarked in the resulting *KUWTK* episode, which is ironic, because this wardrobe overhaul marked the beginning of the power couple's sweeping impact on mass-produced fashion.

In the years that followed, Kanye distributed Yeezy uniforms—most often fitted bodysuits in basic color schemes—to the willing, walking mannequins that were the Kar-Jenners. Yeezy's streamlined aesthetic suited the perfect symmetry of Kim and her sisters' contoured faces and hourglass figures (which had already proven ideal for the Instagram grids, which, studies also proved, favored visual homogeny). Plus, Yeezy's "blank canvas" aesthetic made Kim's high-fashion statements really stand out anytime she stepped into other designers like Balmain or Mugler. *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood* tracked it all, updating players' shopping offerings with more desirable looks first seen in Kim's IRL outings and with virtual fashion show invites from bigger names. Balmain's creative director, Olivier Rousteing, was even sucked into the game as a "VIP" character, and within the first month of his cartoon debut more than twenty thousand users owned his digital bags and dresses.

Of course, this craze for Kardashian aesthetics spanned virtual *and* material reality. By 2018, fast fashion was a multibillion-dollar industry, and the Kardashians' combo-display of standardized and luxury looks largely drove its economy. Within weeks of whatever latest Kim K or Kylie Jenner fashion statement—a Yeezy biking short seen on Kylie's Instagram; Kim's latest Met Gala dress—some sweatshop cranked out thousands of copies so that pop culture fans and fashion fiends could mimic the accelerating rotation of looks on their own feeds.

This Kardashian-social-media-post-to-fast-fashion pipeline counts as another advancement in the relentless rushing of media. After all, McLuhan believed that clothes, too, are media, an "extension of the skin" and a "means of defining oneself socially." If cameras and cars define L.A. as a media center, then content and clothes define Kim Kardashian as a social media center, confining information movement as close to the self as possible—phone attached to hand, self-concept proclaimed by dress on body. Every new fashion era Kim enters seems to unlock a new level in the ongoing game of her real life, which is then offered as an experience to players of her video game.

"She's turned a video game into a kind of personal blog," Opam wrote for *The Verge*. "Something no one else thought to do, much less pull off." In this

sense, the game collapsed space, bringing fans ever closer to Kim, with whom they were already quite close, considering her sex tape, reality show, and social media feeds. The game collapsed time, too. Glu's CEO, Niccolo de Masi, told Opam that he viewed the game as "the first transmedia entertainment property where you can effectively follow Kim on your own schedule. You don't have to wait until a TV show on Sunday…. The game allows you to interact with her world whenever you want for as long as you want."

Kim Kardashian: Hollywood collapsed space and time so completely because it was a "postindustrial" product, which means that it was not an industrial age commodity like a car, born of the heavy machinery Walter Benjamin described in the 1930s. Nor was it the kind of big-screen entertainment manufactured by film studios in the Mary and Marilyn eras, which borrowed from factory blueprints using the machinery of cameras, soundstages, and craft. No: *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood,* the immersive phone app, was constructed by coders out of 0s and 1s to be downloaded en masse, and designed to drive home the notion that digital identities are today's most salient media, all the while ignoring the fact that the Yeezy looks sported by the family in real life were mass-produced by machinery at an Adidas factory somewhere in China, as were the phones through which we consumed the family's imagery. In the game, manufacturing was purely conceptual and supposedly in the hands of the user.

There is a reason why I chose to depict Marilyn's myth as a montage. I had plenty to say about L.A., modernity, and Marilyn, but I also had to arrive at where we are today, tapping our phone screens to access a virtual world that allows *us* to "manufacture" our *own* "fame" in the fashion-forward image of Kim Kardashian. So, I utilized this modernist tool to zip from point A to point Z while maintaining a tone reflective of the magic that so many perceive in Marilyn's myth. And if you'd like to experience that dreamy montage IRL, it can still be set into motion by taking a Hollywood bus tour or paying a personal pilgrimage to all those momentous sites from Marilyn's life; maybe you'll even encounter her "aura" along the way. As one tourist wrote in a Tripadvisor review of the Hollywood Roosevelt's Marilyn Monroe suite, "I

would love to come back again and stay in this room. There were times I thought I smelled her and felt her energy drifting in and out of the room. Magic*!"

But the *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood* game is far from magic. It brings all relevant Kardashian spaces and places and costumes *to* us in animated form, eliminating the need for tours or pilgrimages in pursuit of aura: The *game* is the bus tour; a *look* is the bus tour. The pleasure of aura is replaced by the gratification of reaching the next level with a digital Balmain bag (or maybe a real-life knockoff bought from a website you deep down know is contributing to the agony of a stranger somewhere far away).

The game is an algorithmic compression of Kim's already episodic life into fifty-one levels. It is addictive, because phones are addictive, and because it's been designed to feature all the "tapping," "collecting," and assorted "psychological aesthetics" that the game designer James Liu says most mobile games entail, but that, apparently, *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood* does especially well. "*Hollywood,*" he wrote in a 2014 review of the game for *Forbes,* "has good retention because it doesn't break emergence." The game is about clout chasing, which is a real-life game, too, and therefore every level of the mobile game—from networking with characters by using a Twitter function that connects to your actual Twitter account, to receiving news that you got the "job" in the form of actual, dopamine-inducing phone notifications—collapses the boundaries between virtual and material reality until you suddenly realize you've been spending real money on it. And this is (part of) the *real* reason people are so mad at Kim Kardashian: She's the train arriving at the station, but she's also *actually* busting through the screen.

"Not only did she rip Marilyn Monroe's dress, but she added her legendary rarity item to the game…I'm shocked." That's a comment on the *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood* Instagram account beneath a photo of Kim's avatar wearing the Dress. Yes, for a limited time only, and for enough "stars" or cash, the historic Marilyn Met Gala dress was available for "purchase." (A year or so later, SKIMS would partner with Swarovski to unofficially re-create the Marilyn dress, which sold out in days.)

Had Kim succeeded at manufacturing something as existential as a "moment," a word used no fewer than ten times by Kim and her family in the *Kardashians* episode about the Dress, to be distributed as a postindustrial commodity on her game? Well, to some extent, she was just continuing a long-held tradition in the fashion world.

"The runway is where any moment makes its first public appearance," Julia Szabo wrote in a 1995 *Washington Post* feature called "The Anatomy of a Moment," which examined the "weeks, even months, of intensive labor" that go into the industry's construction of trends. "When designers set out to create a collection," Szabo wrote, "they are picking up on signals transmitted by the consumer. The collection simply gives tangible shape to the public's unarticulated desires." Of course, no longer is the runway the primary public medium for fashion "moments." Every year, Kim Kardashian is unsubtle in her use of the Met Gala red carpet as a visual narrative space, and this is another reason why everyone is mad at her. By wearing the *original* Marilyn dress, Kim broke the norms of a super-fast-fashion culture of which she'd become the face. We at home crave encounters with something Real in an increasingly hyperreal media landscape, to experience what it's like for time to stand still, and are instead left to read the news of what she's done from the harsh backlight of our computer and phone screens, on feeds that will refresh faster than we can comprehend, with yet another inundation of news.

The social media fetishism of "moments" reached a peak during the 2020 COVID-19 pandemic, when the term "main character moment" went viral among Gen Z TikTok users. A video by Ashley Ward, viewed more than three million times, tells viewers, "You have to start romanticizing your life. You have to start thinking of yourself as the main character. 'Cause if you don't, life will continue to pass you by." The monologue, soundtracked by a harp's twinkling melody, was turned into a usable "sound," which inspired even more users across the algorithm to post their own "main character moments," whether showing off outfits or picturesque vacation highlights. "Main character moments" could be constructed, according to Kyle Chayka in a 2021 *New Yorker* piece, from "any situation in which a person is making herself the center of attention, the crux of a particular narrative, as if cameras

were trained on her and her alone." Again, by this logic, cameras are essential to the actualization of a Moment, and social media had democratized the everyday person's ability to make them.

"A fashion moment is when it goes beyond the clothes and goes into a feeling," Khary Simon, a creative director at Hearst, tells me. "It's exhilaration. It's continuous. That's a Grace Jones concert. Circumstance and shape and volume and spectacle and light and color." For this reason, Simon is dubious about whether authentic "moments" can be manufactured. "Can moments only be told by the future? Let's say something else happened. Let's say Kris gets into a helicopter accident and her head is literally in Times Square. There's no more 'moment' of that dress."

Kim claims she had a "moment" on the red carpet as she co-opted aura from a piece of history, and though, through narration and photos and virtual gaming, she's brought us as close to the experience as possible, we'll never know exactly what it felt like.

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3. PRINCESS JASMINE

Animation, exaggeration, and exoticism

Here's something you might not know: At the dawn of the twentieth century, long before Kim Kardashian began continually costuming herself as Disney's first princess of color, Jasmine, the young British member of Parliament Winston Churchill (along with William Knox D'Arcy and Charles Greenway), began to realize that battleships could be fueled by oil instead of coal, which required less human labor to extract and was easier to truck around than the cumbersome rock. The shift to a resource that could more efficiently fuel the world—and, in essence, accelerate the medium that is war—kicked off what numerous historians agree to be a new era of Western presence in the oil-rich East, enabling the World War I allies, as one British cabinet member put it, to "float to victory on a wave of oil."

Like clockwork, as Western interests in the resources of the East came to light, and more of its citizens sought refuge in our purported melting pot due to economic instability, sectarian conflict, and even genocide in parts of the Ottoman Empire, cultural fascination converged on the region I'll refer to by the non-colonial term SWANA (Southwest Asia–North Africa, which includes, according to the SWANA Alliance, "Kurds, Nubians, Sudanese, Armenians, Circassians, Arabs, Iranians, Druze, Assyrians, Chaldeans, Turks, Yazidis, Azeris, Turkmen, Afghans, Copts, Imazighen," among others). Old Hollywood produced stars like Rudolph Valentino, the Italian "Latin Lover" also known for his role in *The Sheik,* and Theda Bara, star of *Cleopatra,* a headdress-wearing girl from Cincinnati whose stage name was an intentional anagram for "Arab Death."

The industry was making its transition from silents into sound at around the same time—1928—as the United States signed the Red Line Agreement, along with Britain and France, to gain greater access to Middle Eastern oil.

The relationship between distorted media depictions of SWANA people and American presence in their nations is, as the Palestinian American literary theorist and activist Edward Said has written, no coincidence: "To say simply that Orientalism was a rationalization of colonial rule is to ignore the extent to which colonial rule was justified in advance by Orientalism, rather than after the fact." In other words, by seeing the faraway SWANA regions as sites of religious fanaticism, veiled eroticism, and outright barbarism in silver screen silents, with their scenes of sheikhs courting white women via camel rides and the same women disguising themselves as veiled dancers to sneak into desert casinos, the West was not only groomed to accept its own persistent presence there but paving a path forward for more.

Meanwhile, one of the most influential and enduring media machines in American history was being born: the Disney brand, which established blueprints for American myth—and, in many cases, enduring cultural caricatures. Born on December 5, 1901, the fourth of Elias and Flora Disney's five children, Walt coped with an austere family life on a Missouri farm by honing his art and drawing abilities. When his father's health began to decline, the family moved, and Walt's dedication to his Kansas City newspaper delivery route, shared with his older brother Roy, has since been burnished by his numerous biographers into a prime example of his now-mythic grit and media savvy.

In 1923, Walt joined Roy in Los Angeles, where the duo developed the Disney Brothers Studio, Roy handling all things money related and Walt developing and animating a "Lucky Rabbit" character for Universal Pictures. The character, Oswald, proved unlucky for the brothers: Realizing its commercial potential, Universal's producer Charles Mintz made a secret deal with their animators to keep the rabbit—whose IP was owned by Universal—as well as their creative team, while pushing the Disneys out. Walt learned, writes his biographer Neal Gabler, that "you had to be careful whom you trusted…that you had to control what you had or it would be taken from you," and "how duplicitous the business world could be."

Still, this would not be the only time in the grand arc of Walt's life that he got burned by trusted partners. A few years after, Disney's sound distributor

Pat Powers began withholding accounting statements from the brothers, even poaching one of their lead animators. Much later, in 1941, came the animators' strike, which inspired reactionary anticommunist politics in Walt (who'd remained convinced that the Disney company, which was by then hugely successful, was still more of a "family" than a labor-driven enterprise). Mintz's betrayal, though, was one of the most crucial turning points in Walt's career.

Nearly broke and desperate to create a new character, Walt and his longtime collaborator, Ub Iwerks, began to contemplate other creatures, from cats to dogs to cows. Over time, the Mouse began to come to life—rebranded, once Walt's wife, Lillian, nixed the stuffy name Mortimer, with what Gabler aptly describes as an "Irish name, an outsider's name." Mickey was drawn simplistically, with three circles, for, as Gabler quotes of one animation historian, "maximum ease of animation."

These circles alone would become fodder for endless discourse ("We just make a Mickey, and then the profs come along and tell us what we got," Disney once told Aldous Huxley). "Some psychological approaches regarded Mickey as striking deep psychic lodes," Gabler writes. "These analysts found Mickey's visual iconography to be reassuring ('[C]ircles never cause anybody any trouble,' observed longtime Disney associate John Hench, comparing Mickey's shape to breasts, babies, and bottoms, while people have 'bad experiences with sharp points')," while the "children's author Maurice Sendak located Mickey's appeal in his plasticity. Sendak found in the early Mickey cartoons, which featured 'kicking the ass, pulling the ears, tweaking noses, twisting necks,' a 'passionate investigation of the body.'…Mickey finally gave the viewer the 'license to touch.' "

Along with an iconic design, Mickey was blessed to appear alongside a historic moment for the film industry—the advent of sound in moving pictures. Like everything else on-screen in those days, Oswald the Lucky Rabbit and all of Disney's previous projects had been silent. Inspired by the booming success of Hollywood's first sound film, *The Jazz Singer,* and with the help of the staff artist Wilfred Jackson, Disney figured out how to use a metronome to time his animation frames with the beats of musical

accompaniment. This precision would set Disney animation apart from other animated shorts of the time, which also attempted sound, but without synchronizing it to the action. Despite surging to the forefront of a new era of technology (not to mention its resilience as a family business), however, Disney still struggled to secure distribution. "One distributor," Gabler writes, "picked up a package of Life Saver candies. 'The public knows Life Savers,' he told Walt. 'They don't know you. They don't know your mouse.'" Walt decided that if the audience liked his movies, they'd damn well know the producer's name. "He…decided to stage a full-scale assault on the animation industry and establish 'Walt Disney' as its undisputed leader—the Life Savers of animation." American audiences, enraptured by their big silver screen stars, were being overcome with a slow and steady need to move closer to the objects of their consumption; now, even an animated character was nothing to them without his all-too-human creator.

Walt took his first leap toward achieving Life Savers status in 1928, with the debut of *Steamboat Willie* (a reference to the recent successful Buster Keaton silent, *Steamboat Bill, Jr.*), released by Pat Powers of Celebrity Productions (who would soon betray him) and audaciously promoted as a "Walt Disney Comic." This initial iteration of the ever-evolving Mickey was playful—even provocative. He appeared more mouselike than he would in the future, and befitting the groundbreaking relevance of the sound film, the story followed his jubilant discovery of music, as he drummed on pots and pans, trash cans, and even other (less humanoid) animals. With what Gabler terms "casual sadism," he also pursues a fleeing Minnie, yanking her by the skirt and exposing her drawers. His persona—not necessarily fixed, but "borrowed…from notable figures of the time," including Charles Lindbergh, Rudolph Valentino, and other romantic leading men of the screen, as M. Thomas Inge writes—would with time fade into an even more scalable neutrality.

Suiting this Everyman quality, Mickey was "racially coded as both black and white," according to the animation historian Nicholas Sammond. Much animation scholarship has argued that Mickey must be viewed within the context of the era in which he'd been made. After all, Jim Crow laws—which

were instituted in the late nineteenth century, as post–Civil War federal oversight of southern states faded, and stretched until the 1960s, sustaining Black segregation and suppressing Black votes—were named not after a real person but after a minstrel show called *Jump Jim Crow*.

"Like Felix, Bimbo, Oswald, and most of the animated film characters who preceded him," notes Inge, "Mickey had a black body and head, large white eyeballs, and a white area around the mouth—all characteristics of African Americans as portrayed stereotypically in cartoons, illustrations, and advertising of the time and based on the image of minstrel show performers in black face," devoid of "any of the language or cultural nuances of black life."

Meanwhile, the boundaries of Black and white would be troubled by the first "wave" of SWANA immigrants then settling in the United States, mostly "Arab Christians from the Ottoman province of Syria (today's Lebanon, Israel/Palestine, and Syria) fleeing wars and declining economic prospects. In 1920, the United States was home to at least 50,000 immigrants from this region." Armenia, outside the technical bounds of the "Middle East," and confusing to contextualize because of its small size, landlocked geography between West Asia and Europe, and long-term occupation under the Ottoman Empire, was seeing its people slaughtered en masse, leading to a worldwide diaspora (mostly in Lebanon, Iran, and Syria), including an influx of thousands of Armenians into the United States.

While SWANA people were clearly seen as Other—nonwhite—they were not registered as Black, and therefore occupied an uneasy middle ground, from which naturalization nonetheless remained no easier to grasp. As the historian Earlene Craver has written, "aliens" could not own property or even lease farmable land, in some states, could not practice law or medicine, or even access some other professions. "As debate on a restrictive immigration bill began to peak, Congress passed a law in 1922 stating that 'any woman citizen who marries an alien ineligible to citizenship shall cease to be a citizen of the United States.'" The country, with its legacy of white domination, Black exploitation, and brown erasure, was set up in such a way that identification with whiteness seemed integral to survival.

The American court system, itself a production site of spectacle, narrative, and myth, turned racial classification of all these new foreigners into a battle, even after immigration slowed due to the passing of the Johnson-Reed Act in 1924, which set quotas on immigration from "nonwhite" countries, shifting favor to northern and western Europeans. As Sarah Gualtieri writes in her book *Between Arab and White: Race and Ethnicity in the Early Syrian American Diaspora,* however, "decisive proof of whiteness" was difficult to nail down. "Lawyers and applicants marshaled evidence that ranged from skin color to national origin, culture, scientific studies, and popular opinion—or some combination of these factors—to claim whiteness. It was up to the courts to decide which elements should be the basis for determining race and, by extension, eligibility to participate in the privileges of citizenship." Every court was different (though completed cases often set precedents for the ones to come).

One landmark case occurred in 1925 Oregon, where V. W. Tomlinson, a naturalization examiner, declared that the hopeful Armenian petitioner Tatos Cartozian was "every whit as dark complexioned" as Bhagat Singh Thind, an Indian Sikh recently deemed nonwhite and denied citizenship by the Supreme Court, and that Tomlinson believed the Supreme Court's decision equally applied to Cartozian. While Tomlinson swore, "I cannot see where an Armenian, Syrian, Turk, Kurd, Arab or Bedouin, are any of them admissible to citizenship as white persons," Cartozian's side argued that there had been enough "intermarrying" between Armenians and Russians to prove that Armenians got along with white people, and besides, Armenians were reassuringly Christian. It worked, and the court decreed Cartozian to be white. Craver suggests, also, that Cartozian's status as a successful Oriental rug business owner helped his case, in contrast to another petition the court saw that day for a Syrian family, hailing from a nation not at all far from Armenia, who had come into the room bearing small American flags, only to be rejected on the basis of "illiteracy," and, Craven suspects, class.

Gualtieri writes of another Syrian petitioner, Costa Najour, who was, "after four hours of testimony," asked by "the exasperated lawyer, desperate to prove that Najour was not white…to take off his shirt and show his body to

the court. Najour began to comply but was stopped in the early stages of undress by Judge Newman, who wanted no such theatrics in his courtroom." Najour was decreed to be white—in fact, Caucasian: "Using the literature on ethnology, he [Judge Newman] reached the conclusion that Syrians were 'part of the Caucasian or white race.' The use of 'or' was significant, for it indicated that being Caucasian and being white were held to be one and the same thing." The conflation of Caucasian and white, rooted in nineteenth-century eugenicist movements, is as debatable as the still-prevailing question of where, among the "four monolithic racial categories," as Gualtieri put it to me, SWANA people belong. These courtroom classifications were case-by-case crapshoots that offered little meaningful clarity about "what" SWANA people "were," but they do illustrate the American legal system's obsession with classification and simultaneous gatekeeping *and* consolidation of whiteness (is whiteness an identity to protect, or is it expansive and enveloping?) and over time paved the way for the next few "waves" of the SWANA diaspora in the 1960s and 1980s.

This liminality has led to problems in on-the-ground SWANA communities. Gualtieri points out the perils of SWANA identity being subsumed by whiteness in the formal accounting of the U.S. census, leading to a lack of translators and other culturally appropriate resources in immigrant communities, and the example of a lynching of the Syrian grocer Nola Romey, whose legal status as white didn't matter much to the KKK (nor would it make a difference in 2016 when a Lebanese caterer named Khalid Jabara was murdered by his openly racist neighbor). But in the case of potential cultural icons, like Kim, whose ethnic ambiguity has been its own viral point of debate throughout her career, and Mickey Mouse, liminality can be an asset, especially accompanied by the ability to subtly shape-shift according to consumer desire.

In an interview with Richard Heffner, host of the public television show *The Open Mind,* Neal Gabler described Mickey as "a mouse without a core… without a core being" who "reflected many of the things that were going on in the studio generally." The more viral Mickey went, the more the studio expanded, and the less sadistic became his storylines and the "cuter" the

animation of his three circles. “Throughout 1932 and 1933 Mickey gradually became rounder, shorter, thicker, less sinewy—his mouselike features shrinking and softening as his human features—his hands, his head, and his feet—grew, and his mouselike characteristics yielding to gentler, more human ones,” writes Gabler. He also made sales history: By 1932, one million people belonged to the Mickey Mouse clubs that had opened all over the country, and the Mickey Mouse wristwatch, released in 1933, sold a million units in eight months. He became a common cultural reference in popular songs and movies (the semiotician Josh Glenn points out that in the 1934 Cole Porter song “You’re the Top,” which “included the line ‘You’re Mickey Mouse,’ he was referring to Mickey’s popularity—his status as an icon—along with the Coliseum, the Louvre, a Shakespearean sonnet, the Mona Lisa, a Strauss symphony”). In 1936, Mickey was labeled a “symbol of international goodwill” in an award bestowed upon Walt by the League of Nations, and that same year *The New York Times* called Mickey “the best known and most popular international figure of his day.”

Also in 1936, by then working with RKO studios and in keeping with his embrace of technological evolution, Walt applied the recent development of Technicolor to what would become his biggest hit yet, *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs.* It was with this film that he introduced princesses to the brand’s storytelling, a move for which, after being given a tour of his studios, the Nazi propaganda filmmaker Leni Riefenstahl expressed her admiration: “He has the German feeling—he goes so often to the German fables and fairytales for inspiration.” The animation scholar Esther Leslie drew a comparison between Riefenstahl’s historic two-part film, *Olympia*—which documented the 1936 Summer Olympics in Nazi-era Berlin and introduced groundbreaking editing techniques we still see today, including slow-motion shots, extreme close-ups, and underwater views—and Walt’s *Snow White:* “These two films are about animation and stasis, and they both dramatize that interest in key scenes. And they both also seem to let on that the cult of the perfect body is a cult of death—the stone athletes, the dead princess.”

Walt also continued his pattern of massive success by selling accompanying merch—hats, glasses, and dolls—alongside the film, which

generated $8 million at the box office (today's equivalent of $100 million). Later, in the 1950s, when television began to take off, most movie industry people recoiled, but Walt leaned in, introducing a *Disneyland* show, using his ABC deal to fund the construction of his theme parks, which were meant to expand his vision beyond the screen and into the real world. These milestones began to accumulate into a full-blown media conglomerate. "Disney's rise in the 1950s," the Hollywood studio system scholar Douglas Gomery writes, "signaled the end of the classic studio system era as much as any single change in the history of the Hollywood studio system." Even as the Disney brand spread horizontally, colonizing culture, Walt attributed much of his brand's success to his beloved mouse. "There'd be no beautiful studio like this without him," he once said, during a tour of his Burbank studio. "I owe it all to Mickey and I'm plenty grateful."

When Walt passed away in 1966, Douglas Gomery writes, "Roy, by his own admission, missed his brother's passion and sales ability…. Alone, he shrank from responsibility and sought consensus, creating layers of committees. The company operated like the Roman Catholic Church, but without a pope." It's tempting to wonder whether a similar approach will suit the collectivistic Kardashians once their leading matriarch, Kris Jenner, retires; thus far, their family unity has proved perhaps their greatest strength. The Disney brand carried on like this for some time until Michael Eisner, former president of Paramount Pictures, took over in 1984. Though he'd become infamous for a 1982 memo written during his Paramount days and leaked in a 2000 Disney brand exposé by Kim Masters—"We have no obligation to make history. We have no obligation to make art. We have no obligation to make a statement. To make money is our only objective"—Eisner was, Gomery writes, "at his best replicating Disney's past successes." This meant, in Gomery's view, an expansion of the theme parks, reissuing Walt's classic films (the 1993 reissue of 1937's *Snow White* generated $300 million in "home-video" revenue), and, I might argue, a return to princesses. (Walt released two more princess movies after *Snow White*—*Cinderella* in 1950 and *Sleeping Beauty* in 1959—but there was a thirty-year princess gap until Eisner's takeover brought them back, starting with *The Little Mermaid* in

1989.) *Aladdin* was 1992's most successful film and is still the third-highest-grossing animated feature worldwide. It launched some classic Disney musical earworms, an iconic Robin Williams voice-over, and the first nonwhite Disney princess.

Based on the beautiful princess Badroulbadour in what most people assume is a passage from the Islamic golden age classic *One Thousand and One Nights,* also known as *The Arabian Nights* (though the passage in question was later identified as a Chinese story that had made it to the Arab world and then circulated through oral tradition), the animated princess Jasmine is shaped like an hourglass, is dressed like a belly dancer, and, despite being a total daddy's girl—she's among the 75 percent of Disney protagonists without mothers, per a 2007 study of the brand—is a feisty adventurer eager to experience the world beyond her Taj Mahal–inspired palace in the fictional Agrabah. You probably already know how her story goes: Aladdin, a poor "street rat," rubs the right bottle at the right time and meets a genie, who grants him his wish to become a prince so that he can win his regal beloved.

In the form of the Gulf War, which stretched from August 2, 1990, to February 28, 1991, the Middle East was having its own star turn in the media at the time of *Aladdin*'s release. As the cultural critic Chuck Klosterman wrote of the public reception of the short-lived war, which had been kicked off by Iraq's money-motivated invasion of Kuwait, "Had the U.S. done nothing, it would have likely become another interchangeable episode in the long series of Middle Eastern events that Americans accept as problematic without understanding what they are or where they're happening." But the United States, at the time commandeered by the elder George Bush, gathered and led a coalition of almost forty nations into war, which, of course, contributed to how fast the whole thing started and soon ended—with a free Kuwait, albeit one in flames and sopping in oil spills; minimal American casualties; more than ten thousand Iraqis dead; Saddam still in power; and a further destabilized region.

What made coverage of this war unique, according to Klosterman, was its "video-game aesthetic," due to news media's enthusiasm for ever-crazier,

cutting-edge camera technologies and editing strategies like "cameras mounted on the noses of missiles, providing the viewer with the sensation of riding weapons directly into their targets." Not only did this bring a first-person sensation to depictions of the conflict, but there was also a sanitization to its framing, which emphasized violence toward empty territory rather than people. "The destruction of Iraq was unusually watchable, particularly since that destruction seemed to involve no humans whatsoever…. It was as if the war were only fought by machines, devoid of human suffering or existential meaning." Pointing out that "while only half the country had supported military intervention before the opening attack, the war's approval rating soared to almost 80 percent a week after it began," Klosterman draws in the French postmodernist Jean Baudrillard, who wrote a controversial serialized analysis for Jean-Paul Sartre and Serge July's daily paper, *Libération,* called "The Gulf War Did Not Take Place." Baudrillard's argument was not that the war did not happen, Klosterman writes, but that "the presentation of the war made it feel like a simulation," and "because there was no obvious emotional component to the war, which meant that there was no narrative," this became "a war with no story," therefore a war destined to be forgotten.

If media presentation of the Gulf War had made the SWANA region seem like a blank canvas awaiting American arrival, then *Aladdin* filled in the region's gaps with cartoonish depictions of its culture and people, a prime example of what Said termed "Orientalism"—that is, "the ineradicable distinction between Western superiority and Oriental inferiority." Building upon Said's scholarship, Abderrahmene Bourenane writes, "Jasmine is represented according to a Western imagination of the oriental female figure: she is over-sexualized through the belly dancer outfit that she wears all over the film and she is confined in the palace until her decision to escape. Jasmine is presented with a tiger pet in an attempt to push the limits of oriental exoticism and danger." This stretching of reality is, in fact, what animation exists to do, by design.

The animation scholar Paul Wells has written that "animation in the United States has been characterized by a desire to express difference and otherness," a point contextualized by Disney's own animators Frank Thomas

and Ollie Johnston, who wrote, in *The Illusion of Life,* that "when Walt asked for realism, he wanted a caricature of realism." This led to the "12 Principles of Animation," like the "squash and stretch" technique, which was defined by pliable facial design, so that when a character is sad, their eyes might droop past what is normal, and their mouth widens to a melodramatic degree. Another approach is "exaggeration"—perhaps that character's tears rain out enough to fill a bucket. If not rendered with such excess, Disney animators theorized, the character's emotion would not translate as well on-screen. After all, as Thomas and Johnston write, our primary "tools of communication are the symbols that all men understand because they go back before man developed speech."

On some level, turning anything into a representation, however rooted in reality it may be, is going to require exaggeration and caricature, but should bias or ideology be layered into the imagery or narrative, this process can be dehumanizing to its subject. Consider *Aladdin*'s super-angular villain, Jafar: Bourenane comments that he "symbolizes pure evil. His dark outfit, skin and hair implies a dark personality, he represents the malevolent side of the Arabs." Such was the dominant cultural view of Arabs (and SWANA people generally) after the 2001 attacks on the World Trade Center by pan-Islamist militants—that they were terrorists—and an early-career Kim, in fact, with her natural tan, still-strong nose, and not-yet-lasered hairline, was likened to Jafar in several Twitter memes. Who could blame her for wanting to be a princess instead?

She first dressed up as Jasmine for a Hollywood Halloween party in 2009, at a time when images of the SWANA region were populating news channels once again, across all media: The new president, Barack Obama, had begun making good on his promise to withdraw American troops from Iraq after their six years of waging George W. Bush's "war on terror." This first known instance of Kim-as-Jasmine also occurred during an era wherein she often asserted her identity.

In 2007, as a close collaborator of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* producers, she allowed a scene of a tipsy white man telling Kourtney and Khloé, "Armenia is the cool thing now, you guys made it cool again." In

2009, she tweeted, “I am so proud to be Armenian! Where are all my Armos at???” In 2010, she and Kourtney went on *Lopez Tonight* to discuss the results of a DNA test she’d taken. “You’re 94 percent Armenian,” George Lopez announced (before joking he was shocked to see that nowhere on the test were positive results for Black). “That explains all the hair!” she replied—consciously or not, referring to that inexorable “cult of the body,” the inspective approach to nonwhite bodies that inspired prosecutors to ask Costa Najour to strip in the courtroom. Kim also invoked Disney: Upon learning that she was “also 6 percent Native American,” she replied, “Oh, a little Pocahontas, I like it!”

One of the most common subjects you’ll find in SWANA feminist scholarship—from thinkers like Nadine Nabir, Helen Samhan, Joanna Kadi, and Nada Elia—is that of the invisibility/hyper-visibility paradigm: the idea that SWANA women are more readily “seen” by Westerners when their identities are being caricatured. Because media “images are so pervasive,” Amira Jarmakani writes, “Arab American feminist thought is often overlooked or not heard unless it engages the dominant myths and categories through which Arab womanhood has been filtered in the United States.”

The “white” Arab appears browner when she is wearing a veil, which the scholar Minoo Moallem has called a stigmatized semiotic for exoticism and oppression, while the racialized Arab is viewed as Other for *being* veiled. (You could say something similar of large noses, “excess hair,” and all the other stereotyped SWANA features that led to Kim’s Jafar comparisons.) In Kim’s binary choice of being seen or erased, Jasmine, a caricature, had some utility. After all, in their studies of princesses and girlhood, the historians Miriam Forman-Brunell and Rebecca C. Hains write, “princesses are everywhere there are girls,” and in the world Disney made, every girl wants to be crowned as a princess. If you’re white and blond, you have many options, but Kim, dark-haired and olive-skinned, hailing from a geopolitically complex nation that even SWANA scholars have struggled to orient, had just one. By self-costuming as an exaggeration, one recognized by people who know little else about the SWANA region—a 2017 study revealed that more than 80 percent of Americans cannot identify the Arab world on a map, and

one in five respondents believed that Jasmine's fictional home city was a real place—Kim used the visual "tool of communication" to assert that she belonged in the Princess Jasmine race category, one that might not appear on the U.S. census but is undeniably distinct according to Disney logic. In this costume, she eludes the state of "in-betweenness" that Gualtieri accords to SWANA identity (in the current system). If Kim, in real life, is "in-between," then "what are the poles of the betweenness?" asks Gualtieri. "Is it between Black and white? Is it between Asian and white? Is it Armenian and Black?"

Over time, Kim had gone the Mickey Mouse route—shrinking her nose, fine-tuning her hairline, and erasing the body hair (she told *Allure,* "I am Armenian, so of course I am obsessed with laser hair removal! Arms, bikini, legs, underarms…my entire body is hairless"), effectively "sanding away certain telltale signs" of her SWANA identity. As the cultural critic Lauren Michele Jackson puts it, "Her hips grew wider, ass larger, waist banished to near nonexistence—her style acquired the flavor but none of the fun of a baddie: bodysuits, biker shorts, and two-piece couture." Her hourglass figure is just as inviting as Mickey's circles: representing fertility, as she poses for wholesome photo shoots with her kids encircling her; sexual availability, as she exposes her curves to racy magazines and SKIMS lingerie ads; and racial mutability, as her presumedly Brazilian butt-lifted ass, its own instantly recognizable brand semiotic, inspires endless discourse about how not-quite-white-but-definitely-not-Black Kim has profited from surgery-facilitated mimesis of silhouettes associated with Black women.

This is to say that Kim began to pinball between the poles perhaps most visible, visceral, and iconic to America: whiteness and Blackness. The still recent virality of the Kardashians during this time marked a major cultural turn from the post-9/11, George W. Bush era, when being all-American—that is, skinny, rich, and white, like Kim's iconic former frenemy, Paris Hilton—ensured dominion over media. As the war in Iraq endured, initial reactionary surges in hate crimes against SWANA people waned, eating disorder hospitalizations spiked, and a Black First Family entered the White House, Kim's well-fed curves and abiding Otherness seemed to satiate an emerging public appetite, however laden with mistrust, for something

different. Images of Kim and her extensive clan could even be compared to what Said has written about media depictions of Arabs: “In newsreels or news-photos, the Arab is always shown in large numbers. No individuality, no personal characteristics, or experiences,” inspiring “a fear that the Muslims (or Arabs) will take over the world.” Anxiety seemed to abound that Kim and her homogeneous gaggle of giggling sisters, too, might undeservedly dominate pop culture, which, of course, only fed their virality. In 2014, *Rolling Stone* published a Rob Sheffield–penned feature, “The Kardashians: The Egos That Ate America,” which asked, “Will our long national Kardashian nightmare ever come to an end?” In 2017, Kris admitted, during a *WWD* panel, “We are kind of everywhere, so there is a possibility that there is an oversaturation,” leading to a *People* magazine headline: “Even Kris Jenner Agrees: The Kardashians ‘Are Kind of Everywhere.’” As Lauren Michele Jackson writes in a *Slate* excerpt from her book *White Negroes,* “If Kim were truly white, we probably wouldn’t know her name. If Kim were unwaveringly white, her consolation prize for the gross violation of privacy that was her leaked sex tape—besides a multimillion-dollar settlement—would have merely been that December issue of *Playboy* and a kitten-eared page in a long line of Hollywood mishaps. An Armenian American with an Armenian name and brown features, Kim’s distance from whiteness, however relative, made her a person of interest and revulsion—that is, a desirable person.”

A KDK survey of nearly three hundred Kardashian Kolloquium readers found that “cultural appropriation” is one of the family’s most notable offenses. Especially since Kim’s *PAPER* magazine “Break the Internet” cover came out in 2014, depicting her in an ass-enhancing pose previously made famous by Grace Jones, and, not long after, her half sister Kylie Jenner—who had by then emerged in the public eye as Kim’s protégée—posted to Instagram a cornrow-wearing selfie with the caption “I woke up like disss,” public conversations in the form of think pieces, video essays, and Instagram infographics about the family’s cultural appropriation have become some of the most viral and therefore valuable currency in the Kardashian content economy online. Most of these posts situate the family, collectively, as white

women, and the comment sections under these posts often devolve into "is she or isn't she?" debates about whether being half Armenian means Kim counts as brown. Some commenters seem to really need Kim to be brown, and others really, really need her to be white.

It's tempting to wonder whether the politicization of Kim Kardashian's identity has proven more captivating for the masses than understanding the actual geopolitics and diaspora of a region that has been essential—and, therefore, both invisible and hyper-visible—to the United States for more than a century. If you search the terms "Armenia Caucasus Mountains" on X, numerous Kardashian-related results surface, and you'll be scrolling for a long while. You'll find spats, dating back years, about the *meaning* of Armenia's location on the world map; gotchas about the fact that, for a time, the U.S.S.R. occupied Armenia, which sounds whiter; gotchas about the fact that Kim's family originated in modern-day Turkey, which sounds browner; and mic-drop one-liners about the etymology of the word "Caucasian." To date, versions of these lengthy debates will be found under almost *anything* posted online about Kim Kardashian and her relationship to race. The discourses often entail arcs of cringe-inducing, Wikipedia-sourced thought traps and, just as often, pockets of poignant and thought-provoking reflections on race. Always, they reanimate the American legal system's insistent racial classification of its citizens, proving that, on some level, we can't resist the influence of our country's basic tenets. They also prove that when it comes to Kim Kardashian, we are forever trying to find the "line," to illuminate the boundaries—or lack thereof—that seem to animate her, to figure out how, exactly, the conundrum of her "identity" can be utilized to clarify our understanding of the larger world, all of this only further engaging viewers in the evaluation and consumption of images of her ever-changing body.

The thing about Kim's body, though, is not only that its evolution helped her to appropriate an array of racial constructs—many other pop stars of the early '00s were committing this offense, from Miley Cyrus and her infamous twerking routine at the 2013 VMAs, to Ariana Grande and her deep fake tan, to Iggy Azalea and her rapping career—but that its extreme proportions have ensured that we paid attention at all. As Meredith Jones, pop culture scholar

and founder of Kimposium!, the Kardashian symposium, has written, "Tweets and Instagram photos, reality TV, red carpet events, paparazzi shots, interviews, etc., all push the narrative that this family is in constant flux through shared details of their marriages, divorces, sibling rivalries, pregnancies, births, deaths, friendships, depressions, illnesses, recoveries, etc. In other words, this is a 'real' family writ large—ourselves but bigger—a reality television producer's dream come true." Jones might have meant this in a more general sense—that the multi-genre, multimedia, multimember, multiracial Kardashians have all the tools necessary to mediatize their lives in a high-scale way—but it applies specifically to Kim's curves, which were amplified and optimized to a cartoonish degree, enabling even louder and clearer visual communication of, well, her presence.

"The image of the desirable female body has changed little in Disney films through the decades," argues Gail Dines in the 2002 documentary *Mickey Mouse Monopoly: Disney, Childhood, & Corporate Power.* "You still have the same highly sexualized female body with the big breasts, the tiny waists, the fluttering eyelashes, the coy expressions, and the seductress." Like the princesses' exaggerated bodies, the famous Kardashian silhouette is, of course, artificial (allegedly), as well as all the other fine, fluttering details that define their collective beauty.

In a season 5 episode of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians,* when Kim "tries Botox for the first time," Kourtney tells her that she looks like "a cartoon version" of herself. In another episode, when Khloé visits a plastic surgeon to consider a body-contouring treatment called VelaShape, she is told that the device provides a function "almost like you are a sculptor and whittling away or contouring away." In 2018, Kim joined the makeup artist Kandee Johnson to use super-contoured stage makeup to "transform" into full-cartoon Princess Jasmine—a labored process throughout which Kim doesn't so much as flinch. Nor are their relationships with machines limited to their pursuits of perfect figures and faces. In 2020, an episode of *KUWTK* shows Kim's late father, Robert Kardashian Sr., reanimated as a hologram, dancing to the doo-wop songs he played for his daughters when they were kids; in 2023, an episode gag on *The Kardashians* shows Kris pranking Khloé

by appearing in holograms all over her home. These are just the technological ventures the family has been willing to share with us, yet we know, somehow, that there are even more cutting-edge interactions with beauty, brand, and performance-enhancing machinery going on behind the screens. The Kardashians are living exemplars of the collapse between humans and technology, and Walter Benjamin, who nurtured a fascination with Mickey Mouse, would say the same of Disney's iconic character: "The existence of Mickey Mouse is such a dream for contemporary man. His life is full of miracles—miracles that not only surpass the wonders of technology, but make fun of them…. Nature and technology, primitiveness and comfort, have completely merged." Perhaps the best example of nature and technology merging in the Kardashian brand can be cited in the origin story of Kim's fame: the sex tape, wherein a video camera captured one of the most natural acts two human beings can perform—a cyborg scenario that reached its conclusion in 2020 when Kanye retrieved all the computers and hard drives containing the footage and delivered them to Kim in a suitcase. As Kim wept over the miracle, a *Kardashians* camera rested its gaze on all the mangled hardware sitting in the open case. But it's also Kim's ability to capture collective attention—the collective imagination—and to serve as a figure of mass catharsis that exemplifies her singular potential and conjures Disney's legacy.

In Mickey Mouse's ability to make audiences laugh en masse, Benjamin detected an astounding power: "The ancient truth expressed by Heraclitus, that those who are awake have a world in common while each sleeper has a world of his own, has been invalidated by film—and less by depicting the dream world itself than by creating figures of collective dream, such as the globe-encircling Mickey Mouse." (Isn't "globe-encircling" so much more fun than "viral"?) He even went so far as to say that "collective laughter" could provide the necessary catharsis to stave off violence or dangerous social unrest, providing a "preemptive and healing outbreak of mass psychoses…. American slapstick comedies and Disney films trigger a therapeutic release of unconscious energies." Nicholas Sammond might agree with him; he argues that the body-obsessed, sadomasochistic conventions of cartoon comedy—

known as gags—must have offered some sort of catharsis amid rampant cultural tensions: "Sigmund Freud's description of humor as the invocation of affect and its diversion speaks well to the existential horror we call the gag. Especially in the short subjects that defined American animation until 1937 and still thereafter provided its bread and butter…. Bodies twist, stretch, explode, melt; they are crushed by anvils, pianos, giant mallets, whole buildings; they are sliced and diced by razors and knives—and through it all we laugh. Why is it that, faced with such horrific violence and fierce torment, we are amused, tickled, jollified?"

Kim once told *i-D* magazine, "I think people might not get that we're absolutely in on the joke," and it's true that gags make up most of the Kardashian TV show's resulting memes: the sisters lifting their leading matriarch, Kris Jenner, upside down to drink from a keg in Vegas, foam sputtering everywhere from her mouth; Khloé wrestling Kourtney on slippery hardwood floors, and then dragging her off camera by the foot; Kim, in a bikini, being flung by her tall athlete boyfriend into the ocean, losing a diamond earring in the process. It seems almost inevitable that such body-centered gags would inspire darker riffs; in 2008, Kim played a cameo in the parody comedy *Disaster Movie,* where she is, mid-sentence, annihilated by a falling meteor. (She would later say she found this particular role "mortifying.") In 2015, a portrait shot of Kim was stolen, reappropriated, and photoshopped by a male artist who claimed to wish to raise awareness about domestic violence, covering her face in cuts and bruises and captioning the image "Life can be a fairy tale, if you break the silence." Finally, in the early weeks of October 2016, during Paris Fashion Week, Kim, nude beneath a bathrobe, was bound and gagged and thrown into her hotel suite's bathtub by a group of men who had been tracking her whereabouts on social media and robbed her of $10 million worth of jewelry. This act of violence punctuated two consecutive years of explosive success for Kim: from her clickbaity nuptials to Kanye West to her record-breaking first *Vogue* cover to ventures in makeup retail, the video game app, and an emoji line that had ensured her status as a household name (and this is a limited list; 2014 and 2015 were some of the most significant years for Kim's self-enterprise). For the public,

this violent incident was a welcome disruption to Kim's merciless captivation of audiences. Tweets shot out that the robbers should have "finished her off," *The Sun* published digital maps of the hotel room setup, complete with a gagged and bound Kim character in the tub, and, because Halloween was only a few weeks later, a $69.99 "Parisian Heist Robbery Victim" costume kit appeared for sale online, complete with a long black wig, fake ring, and rope. Read the description for the kit: "This Halloween it's all about the #Hallomeme and who better than America's goddess of all things glamorous 'Parisian Heist Robbery Victim Costume'? She has devoted her life to promoting American decadence, youth, and hedonism but all that flashy living caught up with her one night in Paris when armed men bound her, stole her jewelry and her peace of mind. This Halloween have some fun with pop culture and dress just like the Queen of Social media with our sensational 'Parisian Heist Robbery Victim' Costume."

In 2022, the robbery ringleader, Yunice Abbas, explained his reasoning for choosing Kim to *Vice News:* "I saw one of her shows where she threw her diamond in the pool, in that episode of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians*. I thought, She's got a lot of money. This lady doesn't care at all." He explained that, for him, Kim represented all the celebrities who flaunt their assets amid an ever-widening wealth gap: "They [celebrities] should be a little less showy toward people who can't afford it." In a Disneyfied world, you know you've made it when you become more symbol than human being to the masses. Kim had wanted to be a princess, and just like one, she had become a symbol of something else.

Walter Benjamin argued about Disney with his longtime friend the philosopher Theodor Adorno, who viewed Disney's creations not as impressive cultural unifiers but as dangerous cultural streamliners. In his essay "The Culture Industry," written with Max Horkheimer, Adorno argues that the industrialization of culture will lead to totalitarianism; after all, mass culture is totalizing by its very definition. If we are what we "consume," then, on some level, we're all gorged on the same fodder, unified by a shared expectation of our regular feedings. Adorno worried that seeing wacky cartoon violence on-screen would not help the masses blow off steam, but

instead nurture their sadomasochistic impulses. “To the extent that cartoons do more than accustom the senses to the new tempo, they hammer into every brain the old lesson that continuous attrition, the breaking of all individual resistance, is the condition of life in this society,” he and Horkheimer wrote. “Donald Duck in the cartoons and the unfortunate victim in real life receive their beatings so that the spectators can accustom themselves to theirs.”

The idea is that the debasement of someone who represents capitalist excess may be gratifying, but gratification can lead to complacency, and even normalization of violence when done to us. Exhibit A: all the young women, themselves statistically at risk of experiencing violence, self-binding, and self-gagging in the Parisian Heist Robbery Victim costume.

Halloween followed Kim’s assault by only a few weeks. Having suffered the beating so many seemed to hunger for, she decided to lie low as she rarely had since before 2007. Her brother, Rob, posted photos of her wearing her Princess Jasmine costume at home with her kids, North and Saint. “Now you know Kim loves Halloween,” he wrote on the family’s now-defunct website. “She couldn’t disappoint North once she found a Princess Jasmine costume from back in the day. North is crazy into Princess Jasmine right now. So being the good mommy she is, she wore her old princess Jasmine costume to match North!” There’s no need to read too much into Kim’s decision to embody her favorite Disney character after such a traumatic event—besides, maybe, the fact that in Disney’s world princesses survive their perils.

Not long after, Kim released a *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* episode about the whole thing—a collage of true-crime-style tabloid snippets, interviews with Kim’s sisters recounting their “play by play” memories of the evening, and, after Kanye was famously called offstage mid-performance to Paris for the emergency, the soft-filtered cinematography he’d been using to document his Saint Pablo Tour. Over an uneasy breakfast in the hotel suite, Kanye tells Kim that the robbers knew better than to hurt her because “if anything had really happened to you, I wouldn’t have stopped until they was dead.” The episode ends with Kim wiping away tears as she confesses to Khloé and Kourtney that she’d begged for mercy, reminding the men that she was a mother. But Kim’s rendering of herself as a damsel in distress was

careful, perhaps even painstaking, and ultimately short-lived. On their private jet back to Calabasas, Kris Jenner tells Kim she may need therapy for PTSD; Kim blankly stares back, shrugging her shoulders. Throughout the episode, Kim comments that it was a good thing something so terrible had happened to her, and not her sisters, because while she could handle it, her sisters could not. This might have even surprised some cynics—that the oversharing Kim we all knew and side-eyed had opted against hyper-capitalizing on her assault, which was only referenced in a handful more episodes that season and mentioned in an interview or two years later. But look at it this way: None of Disney's princesses are the singular face of the Disney brand. At a crucial turning point in her own brand's mythology, it seems Kim knew better than to limit herself to damsel-dom.

Next she'd hone her image as an activist, working with the then-president, Donald Trump, to free Alice Marie Johnson from her lifetime incarceration for a nonviolent drug offense (and, some years later, featuring Johnson in a SKIMS campaign), and meeting with the president of Armenia in 2019 to discuss the importance of more nations acknowledging the Armenian genocide. But let's be real: Armenia is small and feels far away from the United States, while criminal justice reform is a domestic issue, inextricable from the traumatic Black and white history that defines this country.

From the foundations of her own roots, Kim was moving on to the concerns of other communities, being photographed with mostly Black journalists, inmates, and lawyers, and integrating her intentions to become a licensed attorney into her *KUWTK* storylines, in 2020 even releasing *The Justice Project,* a documentary on the Oxygen channel, about her efforts. Kim, hardly a stranger to shape-shifting, was a pop culture princess no more; instead, she was becoming a quintessential American superhero, the supplement to a broken system, rescuing one individual at a time, placing special emphasis on the principles of "personal evolution" underlying criminal defense advocacy: that all people are capable of change and deserving of redemption. This would only become clearer when, in a 2019 episode of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians,* Kanye compared his family to the popular Disney franchise *The Incredibles,* which had debuted in 2004 and become an

instant classic. “The wife’s got a big butt,” he explained, “and I just see our life becoming more and more like *The Incredibles* until we can finally fly.” Mrs. Incredible, as arrestingly hourglass-shaped as Princess Jasmine, also goes by Elastigirl: She can stretch herself into all sorts of forms. It wasn’t until Kim and Kanye announced their separation in 2021, though, that Kim began using fashion to officially—which is to say, visually—assert herself as a superheroine. With Kim dressing in Balenciaga-designed, monochromatic getups that looked right out of the animated film, and Kanye, also donning Balenciaga, staging publicity stunts all over the world to promote his experimental album, *Donda,* together they kicked off one of their most viral media cycles yet: the Kimye divorce.

And, amid all this, Kim would embody Jasmine once more—in the aftermath of her signing a nine-figure deal for the next iteration of her family’s reality show, now with Hulu, a Disney-owned streaming service—when she hosted *Saturday Night Live* in 2021. In one of the most memorable sketches, cartoons become live-action comedy: Kim dresses as Jasmine, with her costar (and soon-to-be rebound boyfriend) Pete Davidson as “1992 Aladdin—when Aladdin was still white.” They’re taking a magic carpet ride filled with innuendos as Aladdin shares his trepidations about finally sleeping with Jasmine, because she is, after all, “a lot of woman” and might “break him.” In light of all the wealthy, powerful, and, it’s implied, Black men she’s dated in the past, he’s worried that he won’t satisfy her, and he might have reason to worry: When he admits to being “excited” the last time they were intimate, she says she thought she felt “a pack of Life Savers” in his pocket. Eventually, Cecily Strong as “Jourtney,” Jasmine’s sister, and Kenan Thompson as Jourtney’s boyfriend, the NFL running back Ezekiel Elliott, fly up on another magic carpet, only making matters worse when “Elliott” relentlessly diminishes Aladdin: “Hey, little dude! Jasmine taking you on a little carpet ride for your little birthday?” On one side of Kim-as-Jasmine sits the Americanized Aladdin, a minute metric of comparison set against her larger-than-life shapeliness and exoticism. On the other side is the exceptional Black athlete, not at all intimidated by her Otherness. Between these men, the function of Kim’s body is clear: an exaggeration of proportions, a cathartic

punch line unifying the five and a half million people watching, a mediation between the binaries of Black and white, and a symbol of, well, every single discourse that Kim Kardashian has provoked through the years.

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4. THE KENNEDYS

Television, the nuclear family, and parasocial relationships

In a 2011 *KUWTK* episode called "The Former Mrs. Jenner," the world's most notorious momager takes Kim and Kendall on a walk through a nondescript neighborhood in some Los Angeles suburb to announce that she's considering changing her name to Kris Kardashian because "professionally it might be a really good idea." When her daughters scoff, Kris, who divorced her first husband, Robert Kardashian, in 1991 and took her second husband Bruce Jenner's name one month later, throws up her hands and exclaims, "It's like a brand, it's like the Kennedys. Everybody knows the Kennedys!" A few years later, TMZ reporters stopped Kerry Kennedy on the street to ask whether she thought her family had anything in common with the Kardashians, and she answered with a guffaw, but it's a fact that the Kennedys were pioneers of the same medium that had secured Kris Jenner's family's fame: the small screen.

About a year after "The Former Mrs. Jenner" aired, Kris and Kim attended the White House Correspondents' Dinner, a controversial annual (televised) event that brings together high-level government officials, journalists across partisan lines, and, increasingly, celebrities, to let bygones be bygones for a night and toast to the press. On the red carpet, when asked if she really planned to run for mayor in the city of Glendale (making the rounds that week was a clip of Kim floating the idea to her sister on the family's spin-off show *Khloé & Lamar*), Kim was coy: "Stay tuned!…I always set my goals really high."

Later, at the dinner, in a pretaped "hot mic" gag, Obama's voice was broadcast to the room: "I'm the President of the United States, and I'm opening for Jimmy Kimmel? Why am I telling knock-knock jokes to Kim Kardashian? What is she famous for, anyway?" (When Kimmel came to the

stage, he was also powerless to resist making the most of Kim's utility as a cultural motif for a few punch lines about the erosion of media's integrity.) In the days that followed, Kim's presence at the event set the press off into a flurry of think pieces. *U.S. News & World Report*'s Susan Milligan wrote, "Kim Kardashian? Really? When did the correspondents' dinner turn into a pathetic display of accomplished, smart professional journalists competing not for a story, but for who got the most famous Hollywood celebrity to sit at their tables?"

In truth, the line between politics and celebrity has been under slow but certain collapse for decades, and the public figures most likely to emerge from its rubble are the ones who've figured out how to commercialize their personal lives. Those with accessible yet aspirational families behind them have a special advantage, perhaps because, as the social theorist Michael Trask suggests in a paper called "The Kennedy Family Romance," of "early associations of the family business with power." Or maybe because after World War II the country entered a family-first, hyper-consumerist cultural era we now think of in terms of what one scholar describes as formulaic, episodic sitcoms like *Leave It to Beaver* and *I Love Lucy* (the latter of which offers prime early examples of product placement, a marketing strategy at which the Kardashians would one day excel).

It's practically an adage among historians: Modern American wars generate prosperity. In 1947, when veterans were returning to the States ready to get married and make babies and maximize their GI Bill benefits (which funded education, housing, and business loans), a real estate company called Levitt and Sons addressed a looming housing shortage by mass manufacturing homes much as cars and other commodities had been (the family patriarch and company president, William Levitt, even called his company the "General Motors of the housing industry"). The family business operated vertically, like the old Hollywood studio system, meaning that the Levitts owned everything from their homogeneous architectural plans to the acres of New Jersey potato fields that would house the planned "towns" to the nails that their nonunion assembly lines pounded to produce 17,500 homes within four years. This was the symbolic birth of the suburbs: Levittowns

were a hit with hopeful homeowners, and began to colonize the East Coast (and, later, Puerto Rico and France), serving as the blueprint for nation-sweeping suburban sprawl.

And how to fill these homes, which were as grid-like and vacant as a social media feed in need of content? Well, as the historian Lizabeth Cohen writes, the top-down message was that "mass consumption was not a personal indulgence. Rather, it was a civic responsibility designed to improve the living standards of all Americans, a critical part of a prosperity-producing cycle." In other words, shopping became a patriotic act, not only to stimulate the economy, but also, as the historian Elaine Tyler May has written, as an act of resistance to our international nemesis, the communist Soviets, who apparently disdained consumer culture and family values. The idea was, May tells me, if *they're* collectivistic, then *we'll* revel in our individualism, reminding me, in a way, of how Kanye rapped in 2007, "Everything I'm not made me everything I am," or how Kardashian critics often assert moral superiority by flagging their opposition to the family, buying themselves T-shirts and coffee mugs that say, "In a world of Kardashians, be a [Jackie O/Lucille Ball/Audrey Hepburn]." Thus, throughout the late 1940s, in part to express their patriotism, "Americans purchased 21.4 million cars, 20 million refrigerators, 5.5 million stoves, and 11.6 million televisions and moved into over 1 million new housing units each year. The same patterns extended into the 1950s, a decade in which prosperity continued to spread."

Consumerism is, of course, the outgrowth of capitalism, the spirit of which is competition. *Keeping Up with the Kardashians,* the title, is a nostalgic nod to the term "keeping up with the Joneses." Some say the concept stems from the director D. W. Griffith's silent-era comedic film series about a quirky family (sample titles: *Mrs. Jones' Lover, Mr. Jones Has a Card Party, The Joneses Have Amateur Theatricals*), which was followed by an unrelated 1913 comic strip by Arthur R. "Pop" Momand called *Keeping Up with the Joneses,* about a social-climbing family all too aware of the social and economic capital possessed by their neighbors. In 1950, the lawyer turned sociologist David Riesman used the phrase to explain a major cultural shift in his bestseller, *The Lonely Crowd,* writing,

> The inner-directed person, though he often sought and sometimes achieved a relative independence of public opinion and of what the neighbors thought of him, was in most cases very much concerned with his good repute and, at least in America, with "keeping up with the Joneses."…In contrast with this pattern, the other-directed person, though he has his eye very much on the Joneses, aims to keep up with them not so much in external details as in the quality of his inner experience. That is, his great sensitivity keeps him in touch with others on many more levels than the externals of appearance and propriety. Nor does any ideal of independence or of reliance on God alone modify his desire to look to the others—and the "good guys," as well as the best people—for guidance in what experiences to seek and in how to interpret them.

Riesman blew nuclear age readers' minds by calling out the cognitive and cultural impact of suburban conformity and observing that as time went on, people seemed to be shifting from being "tradition-directed" or "inner-directed" to "other-directed," which is to say, super concerned about what others thought of them on a material but also existential level.

Such keen awareness of what the Other was up to also manifested itself in cases of mass paranoia in both the media industries and the neighborhoods that they broadcast to. The same year *The Lonely Crowd* was published, a pamphlet called *Red Channels* circulated among the Hollywood film studios, naming 151 "red fascists" and "sympathizers," leading to the blacklisting of hordes of suspected communists from entertainment. Hollywood's historic "red scare" would destabilize the film industry just in time for television to make its cultural debut.

Add to that, Levittowns and the numerous American suburbs modeled after them were often sites of racism and antisemitism—it was literally written into Levittown leases that nonwhite people couldn't buy homes in the neighborhood—and when, in 1957, the Myers family, the first Black family to move into Levittown, Pennsylvania, arrived with their three children, they faced harassment and violence. Both mass media and city infrastructure were

evolving into more efficient, orderly, and socially connective shapes, but that progress did not eliminate power hoarding or the policing of others.

It was into this culture of family making, mass manufacturing, and paranoia that TV and JFK came up, almost in tandem with each other (much in the same way that the Kardashians entered the public eye just as social media applications like Instagram and Twitter began hitting the scene).

By the mid-1950s, over half of Americans owned a TV, so it was fitting that in 1956 the term "parasocial," which we today, on the internet, understand as the feeling that you personally *know* your favorite famous person, was coined in a paper by Donald Horton and R. Richard Wohl. The authors called the parasocial dynamic between audiences and TV stars a "simulacrum of conversational give and take": "In television…the image which is presented makes available nuances of appearance and gesture to which ordinary social perception is attentive and to which interaction is cued."

Kennedy, at the time a young Massachusetts senator, maximized the medium to make his mark. He cushioned his TV appearances with his siblings and wife to convey, presumably, American family values, the importance of which had arguably intensified over the course of the decade with the national increase of duck-and-cover drills and the rise of fallout shelters as a status symbol in the suburbs. Given this kind of nuclear anxiety, it made sense that America needed a daddy. In 1957, the Soviet Union beat the United States to space with the launch of the Sputnik satellite, which the historian Lynn Spigel called a "grave blow to national self-esteem," not to mention the economic recession that followed not long after, creating "general doubts about the consumer economy." Spigel has written of the unease that was spreading across "uniform, tidy" suburban culture; America needed not just any daddy but one who could maintain optimism by making the country's people feel seen.

In 1958, Kennedy appeared on a special program called *At Home with the Kennedys,* sitting in his Boston living room with his wife, Jackie, his mother, Rose, and his sisters, to answer questions and comments called in from viewers. The questions are a mix of personal and political, some asking about

unemployment benefits, and others how many kids he hopes to have with Jackie. Throughout, he employs a strategy he'd one day become known for—looking straight at the camera, as though looking right through the screen at the viewer (a convention we see now in reality TV "confessionals"). "The spectacular fact about such personae," Horton and Wohl wrote, of telegenic Kennedy types, "is that they can claim and achieve an intimacy with what are literally crowds of strangers, and this intimacy, even if it is an imitation and a shadow of what is ordinarily meant by that word, is extremely influential and satisfying for the great numbers who willingly receive it."

This wouldn't be Kennedy's last interview from his family-filled living room; such dispatches reflected the impact of television as a form, which was bringing audiences physically closer to the figures of their consumption than cinema could. A "sense of personal connection is reinforced by the domestic setting of television viewing," wrote Susan J. Douglas and Andrea McDonnell in *Celebrity: A History of Fame*. "Whereas film requires audiences to leave the comfort of the home, to make a plan, television is always there, ready when you are, and requires no advance planning. Cinema-going was an outing; television viewing is a part of everyday life." That the suburbs—and the nuclear family unit—had boomed (more than four million babies were born in 1958 alone) made the in-home entertainment offered by TV a welcome convenience: Parents no longer needed to hire a sitter and leave the house to connect with the larger world. Plus, as Douglas and McDonnell point out, "early TV was limited in its channels and programming, which meant that it had to appeal to the whole family."

The family-first programming of the time combined with the culture's increasing "other-directedness" can help us see why the world was eager to have a cool young family in the White House—and on their TV screens. To paraphrase a notorious Kim Kardashian catchphrase (uttered during one of her conflicts with her older sister, Kourtney), they'd be "exciting to look at."

It isn't that Kennedy was posturing, per se, when he presented himself on the TV screen alongside his family members. Kennedy's relationship with family and media had been authentically mixed from birth. In his book *Shooting Kennedy,* the art historian David M. Lubin suggests that JFK was

"created" by his millionaire father, Joe Kennedy, a connoisseur of industries whose brief Hollywood foray in the late 1920s had involved establishing RKO studios, carrying on extramarital affairs with movie stars like *Sunset Boulevard*'s Gloria Swanson, and, most important, learning that one can "manufacture" a star. After his eldest, Joseph Jr., was killed in World War II, Kennedy set his sights on John, the succeeding son of his and Rose Fitzgerald's nine children, sending the dashing and ambitious young man to Hollywood to "have a look around," paying for features in major press outlets like *The New Yorker* to hype John's wartime triumphs, and sharing political contacts from his own Roosevelt-era tenure as the U.S. ambassador to Britain. A 1958 *Life* magazine feature on the Kennedys read, "Joe hopes to see one of his sons U.S. president, another, a governor, and has assigned an aide, James Landis, political advisor to FDR, to help them." His children did not disappoint; most of them would engage in some form of politics or public service as opportunities arose.

But first, John Fitzgerald. Subsequent *Life* coverage of the Wisconsin leg of his 1960 presidential primary campaign focused on his "family plan," which entailed "spreading Kennedys all over." John's brother Ted shook hands with fans at press conferences, and three of their sisters held "coffee parties" at the homes of potential voters to garner support. This effective harnessing of the family's charisma—and size—even prompted Kennedy's competitor the Minnesota senator Hubert Humphrey to comment, "I don't think this should be a contest over who's got the best voice or personality." Decades later, the Kar-Jenner kids, too, would make the most of their multiplicity, deploying to different industries and events based on their archetypes and availability (Kendall, the model, struts NYFW, while Kourtney, the nonconformist, sucks her rock star husband's tongue at the VMAs, and so on).

Joe Kennedy was even alert to the kind of data-driven virality that would one day characterize the Kardashians, who exemplified the "famous for being famous" trope we now know so well not only because they began as reality stars but also because they were always breaking records (a popular moment in early *KUWTK* shows Kim bragging to her sisters, "Did you know I'm the

most searched on Google this week?" to which Khloé replies, "That's because she googles herself"). In a 1960 interview, Kennedy boasted of his relatable son, a self-proclaimed lover of football and James Bond flicks: "Jack is the greatest attraction today…. Why is it when his picture is on the cover of *Life* or *Redbook,* they sell a record number of copies? You advertise that he will be at a dinner, and you will break all records for attendance. Why is that? He has universal appeal." He certainly looked the part. It was Jack's picture-perfect 1960 presidential debate—the first one ever televised—against a sweating and bumbling Richard Nixon that inspired the media theorist Daniel J. Boorstin to write *The Image: A Guide to Pseudo-Events in America,* his indictment of modern media. "Far more interest was shown in the performance than in what was said," wrote Boorstin. "Of course, a man's ability, while standing under klieg lights, without notes, to answer in two and a half minutes a question kept secret until that moment, had only the most dubious relevance" to his presidential abilities, but Kennedy's ability to resemble a president on-screen had enabled him to become one.

"Dad-ager" doesn't have as much of a ring to it as Kris Jenner's trademarked "momager"—perhaps because the passing down of patriarchal power comes as no surprise to any of us—but one thing is for sure: The Kennedys understood the public appeal of family and personality even before Jacqueline Lee Bouvier arrived to perfect the picture.

✦✕✦

"Jackie functioned as a movie star in American culture. She originated as a political figure, a President's wife, but even during the Kennedy administration, she was treated, in the popular press, like a film star," writes Wayne Koestenbaum in *Jackie Under My Skin.* Kim Kardashian's controversial 2017 *Interview* magazine cover, for which she dressed up as Jackie O and posed alongside her four-year-old daughter, North West, displays the icon's unmistakable semiotics: gloves, a prim pastel suit, pearls, a capped bouffant (and a small child, despite the truth that Jackie preferred privacy when it came to the kids). A lover of French fashion, art, and film,

Jackie was advised by John to ditch the Chanel and start wearing American designers (and to allow the kids out for occasional publicity shots). According to multiple historians, not long after JFK was inaugurated, department stores began fashioning their mannequins to look like Jackie.

Michael Trask describes the Francophile Jackie's relationship with her Everyman husband and his parasocial public this way: "She…recognized that bourgeois sold well in a social order whose regnant ideology maintains the universality of middle-class identity. What [the historian W. J.] Rorabaugh calls 'the desire many women had to be like Jackie' issued in part from the First Lady's astute application to her own life of the signature middle-class 'dynamic of emulation.'"

When I asked my grandma what she thinks of when she thinks of the Kennedys, her answer was, "Jackie's pink pillbox hat." (And then, "Camelot," which we'll explore later.) My mom once told me, I recalled, that her mother had indeed owned one of those hats—participating in that dynamic of emulation.

By 1960, 90 percent of American households owned TVs, and in a 1963 *Show* magazine piece titled "Too Many Kennedys?," Alistair Cooke minces no words in summarizing the impact of Jackie and Jack's presence in the White House: "Since the 35th president and his wife are the most physically attractive couple to live in the White House, the urge of the publicists, magazines, networks and photographers to fuse two American dreams and reveal the White House as the ultimate movie set is irresistible."

Does it come as any surprise, then, that Jackie's 1962 Valentine's Day White House tour aired on both NBC and CBS (and ABC a week later), capturing eighty million viewers during the first broadcast, and later won an Emmy? With the help of the Fine Arts Committee (formed for this very purpose), she'd refurnished the White House, filling it with historic antiques and improving logistics for destination tourism by printing brochures and setting up visitation hours. "It just seemed to me such a shame when we came here to find hardly anything of the past in the house," Jackie told the journalist Charles Collingwood as she led him through each room, sharing the backstories of various tables and clocks and paintings. Though Jackie had

written in her school yearbook that she did *not* want to become a homemaker, Trask points out that through her iconic White House project Jackie had in fact become a glorified version of the homemaker described in Lizabeth Cohen's influential study, *A Consumers' Republic,* "whose home economics consisted precisely in choosing and acquiring things for the house."

There was, of course, one impossible-to-ignore difference between Jackie the homemaker and her peers in Levittowns and other middle-class suburbs. Nineteen fifties consumer culture, made possible by mass manufacturing and characterized by homogeny, had streamlined the American lifestyle and democratized leisure. In her book, Lizabeth Cohen cites a *Harper's Magazine* article: "The rich man smokes the same sort of cigarettes as the poor man, shaves with the same sort of razor, uses the same sort of telephone, vacuum cleaner, radio and TV set, and drives a car with only minor variations." The Kennedy White House, on the other hand, was filled with rare originals, like a super old portrait of George Washington in the East Room, or the Red Room's chairs hand sewn by a widowed Mrs. Lincoln, described by Jackie as "destitute." Middle-class couples, inspired by Lucy and Desi, could buy all the Philip Morris cigarettes they wanted, but they couldn't aspire to acquire these historic White House treasures. They had two options instead: to *be like* the Kennedy family, in fashion and partisanship, or to pay for their own pilgrimage to the White House.

The $2 million restoration, which transformed a drab domicile into a veritable archive (or, as Jackie called it, a "living museum") of American politics, was revolutionary because, if you can believe it, before the Kennedys arrived, the White House wasn't much of a D.C. destination. "American history is sometimes a dull subject," John noted when he joined his wife in the Monroe Room at the end of the tour. "There's so much emphasis on dates." But if students "come here and see, alive, this building and, in a sense, touch the people who've been here, then they'll go home more interested, and…become better Americans. And some of them may want to someday live here themselves…even the girls." With this, Kennedy acknowledged that Jackie's remaking of their home into a better political monument (or the reverse) increased its potential to inspire a new kind of patriotism in

Americans, one that was reflective of the forward-thinking, energized "New Frontier," as he'd named his administration. Today, content creators understand that attention is a scarce commodity and often fret about how to "engage" audiences. A common hack offered by "engagement coaches" (a real job) is to "share something personal or vulnerable about yourself." During the New Frontier, the Kennedys engaged Americans by making politics more personal.

JFK instituted many more initiatives with similar impact, like offering weekly televised press conferences from the White House, which drew up to sixty-five million viewers (according to Pierre Salinger, Kennedy's press secretary, "There were only three or four newspapers in the entire United States that carried a full transcript of a presidential press conference. Therefore, what people read was a distillation…. We thought that they should have the opportunity to see it in full"). Again, I present to you one crucial function of media's ceaseless iteration: its ability to give Americans more information, faster and more directly.

Still, every Camelot-era academic I've spoken with wanted to make sure I understood that the Kennedys did not broadcast their personal dramas in the same crass way that the Kardashians do today. As Lizabeth Cohen told me in an email, "It strikes me that the Kennedy clan hid all the familial dysfunction (the mentally disabled daughter, the philandering father, Jack's infidelities, etc.), while the Kardashians seem to display all of theirs with great drama and pride." But our culture of curated oversharing had to start somewhere, and Jackie's tour (as well as John's starring roles in fly-on-the-wall documentaries like *Primary* and *Crisis*) institutionalized the notion that cameras can take fans beyond boundaries that once existed between the people and the powerful. It's true, of course, with the advent of reality TV and social media, that some aspects of the parasocial dynamic have evolved—becoming more claustrophobic and manipulative and gripping than ever for both consumer and creator, leading to cyberbullying and stalking and mistruths and abuses of power—but the simple template of celebrity home tours still seems to sate parasocial appetites.

In 2000, *MTV Cribs* was the go-to TV show for glimpses of the homes of stars like Missy Elliott, 50 Cent, and Hugh Hefner. Known for its catchphrase, "Hey, MTV, welcome to my crib," which was uttered by every star upon opening their doors, the hit show ran for nearly a decade before its syndication, eventually losing steam amid its periodic repackaging for other networks.

Architectural Digest's "Open Door" tours on YouTube are now the most famous of the genre, earning millions of views on its monthly videos, featuring A-listers like John Legend and Chrissy Teigen, RuPaul, and Demi Lovato as they lead a camera through their sunny mansions, making quips about the little items their interior designers picked out for them. (Interestingly, in 2023, it was the Gen Z social media star Emma Chamberlain's tour that earned an overwhelming ten million views, second only to the Kardashian husband Travis Barker's fifteen million.) In 2020, Kimye sat down in their living room for *Architectural Digest* to ask each other "design questions" about their home. Kanye shares that the home was built to be kid-friendly; Kim reveals that the home theater is the best room in the house for taking selfies; and, in one of the most replayed (and later-memed) moments, Kanye mimics Kim in a humorous way after she exclaims, "Can you believe we don't have a jacuzzi?" This conversation about the family home provided less meaningful insight on its construction than it served as an extension of their family's reality show, shown through the whimsical frame of a non-E! media outlet. When Kim asked Kanye about his "most prized possession in the house," he answered, "You."

The Kar-Jenners also often open their doors to *Vogue,* with which they've been affiliated since Kimye's controversial 2014 cover debut. One video from 2019, part of the publication's "73 Questions" series, has been viewed more than sixty million times. Leading cameras through her mansion's barren, beige corridors, Kim says that she views it as a "minimal monastery," citing both her husband and the famed interior designer Axel Vervoordt as its "inspirations." (At the very least, its aesthetic neutrality functions well as a set for the TV show so that focus can center on the family's products: their clothes, bodies, and makeup.) One of the most replayed scenes in this tour

comes at the end, when, in a staged bit, Kris Jenner FaceTimes Kim and asks why she wasn't invited.

I asked my Kardashian Kolloquium audience why they enjoy watching these tours, and someone answered, "They are extremely creepy. The excess is genuinely disturbing." More than twelve hundred people voted in agreement. Both Jackie's and Kim's tours shared, with the world, lifestyles that might have been relatable in the sense that they were family-centric, but that remain aspirational, because no common family could ever live the same way. While Jackie's tour is remembered by history with awe, the public response to Kim's tends to match a tone that pervades culture today: some combination of amusement and disgust.

Another person, though, answered my "why watch" question by saying that they enjoyed "how sentimental [the Kardashian family] can be." A few years after "73 Questions," newly single Kim gave *Vogue* another tour, where she shared specific items endowed with what Walter Benjamin would call "aura": sophisticated paintings of mountain landscapes and animals made by the young and apparently well-tutored North West; a Minnie Mouse dress Kim wore as a child; and a stack of scrapbooks dedicated to each child, filled with printouts of Instagram photos. This tour, focused on what *Vogue* called Kim's "wonderful objects," was much more like Jackie's in 1962. "I don't love how minimal and empty the house feels but when you see the drawings and little mementos it's so heartwarming," wrote the YouTube commenter @ikariiprince1958.

What do we get, though, out of seeing a painting made by a kid we don't actually know? Alistair Cooke warned of the precedents of parasocial consumption being set by Kennedy's publicity strategies, predicting a tabloid culture to come:

> The President's determination to mold his public face has set some forces in motion that are now clearly beyond his contrivance or his control. The new publicity has extended the area of permissible public curiosity and therefore invaded the area in which the pulps and scandal sheets usually score their scoops. Respectable magazines seem to be

> taking over what used to be squatter's territory. Consequently, the scandal sheets, the pulps, the comics and the parodists have expanded their own twilight zone—under the impression that in the Kennedy regime anything goes. Hence, the coloring books, the phonograph record skits, the lurid "unauthorized" biographies and…the final degrading horror of the "intimate" revelations of the fan magazines about Mrs. Kennedy's aims, dreams, anxieties and griefs. It is doubtful whether the new publicity helps anyone really to know more about the President or offers us more telling evidence on which to judge him either as a man or a chief executive. But it is, by now, what the publicity experts and the mass media have taught people to want.

The question of whether John F. Kennedy was a great president or, as Lubin writes, merely a media-primed image of one has been subject to studies throughout the decades. Was he slow to action on civil rights despite his numerous campaign promises, or did he have a legitimate impact on the well-being of Black communities? Was his mission to bring America to the moon the right call, or did it distract from more pressing issues on our home planet? It's easy to idealize a leader in the warm light of his professed potential when he never had a chance to finish his term, especially after his widow, Jackie, wisely compressed the political nuances of his administration into a singular, idyllic semiotic called Camelot.

Following Kennedy's assassination and its resulting media frenzy, the paparazzo Ron Galella began stalking Jackie to fulfill the continued public interest in her life. A 2020 *Town & Country* profile on Galella details his boundary-pushing vigilance to get the shot: "Galella had taken to showing up at her house every day, often donning disguises—fake moustaches, hippy garb and afro wigs. He'd followed her into Broadway theaters, her son's school Christmas pageant, and a Chinese restaurant, where he shot her from behind a coatrack. He dated her young housekeeper and pumped her for intelligence." "In September 1969, Galella leapt out of the bushes in Central Park to capture Jackie and eight-year-old JFK Jr. biking—according to Jackie, John nearly rode into Fifth Avenue traffic out of fright—and Jackie, according to Galella, shouted 'smash his camera!' Secret Service agents

handcuffed him and drove him to the nearest police precinct. He sued on first amendment grounds." This was just one of a series of lawsuits exchanged between the photographer and his unwilling subject, who would testify in another trial that "his constant presence lurking outside her Fifth Avenue apartment and following her as far as Greece meant she had 'no peace, no peace of mind, was always under surveillance, imprisonment in my house.'"

In 1975, nude paparazzi shots of Jackie on a private beach in Greece were published in *Hustler,* titled "The Agony, Ecstasy, and Nudity of Jacqueline Kennedy Onassis." The spread (which had not been photographed by Galella) turned *Hustler* into an instant hit, rescuing the strip club owner Larry Flynt's fledgling sex publication from what seemed like assured failure (there's a dramatic scene depicting the revelation of the issue's success in the 1996 film *The People vs. Larry Flynt*). In 2014, it would be suggested by a tell-all that Jackie's then-husband, Aristotle Onassis, had tipped off the paparazzi to punish her for her complaints about the tabloid coverage their relationship attracted due to his infidelities with the opera singer Maria Callas.

In his critique of the Kennedys for *Show,* Alistair Cooke predicted that public appetites for media spectacle would only heighten. No longer are we "keeping up" with the Joneses. We are eager to wholly consume them. Sellout issues of exploitative pornography are a good example of such voracious consumption. Women, heavily marketed to in the 1950s as prime consumers due to their positions as homemakers, were being situated as commodities at new scales. Jackie, the White House curator, became Jackie the centerfold, all because the public was hungry for more of her. Kim, purveyor of media spectacle and retail commodities, is also the most prized possession in her own home.

Today, we revel in this collapse between the private and the public spheres, and our growing entitlement to seeing into others' homes—an outgrowth of ever-enlarging cultural "other-directedness," perhaps—has led to a normalization of surveillance or a politicization of transparency, depending on how you look at it. A short-form video trend prevails on social media in which everyday city dwellers—some of them established influencers, some of them "real" people bidding for their fifteen seconds of

fame—open their apartments to inquiring "on the street" interviewers and offer tours of the casual but stylish ways in which they occupy their studio apartments, disclosing how much rent they pay (with more opulent occupants often claiming they'd snagged a rent-controlled spot). In January 2023, the onetime Kanye West muse and TikTok superstar Julia Fox made headlines when she declared that "transparency is important" and gave her own apartment tour, delighting millions of viewers with the relatable way in which she lived—her bed located in the cluttered living room, her young son's playroom, the size of a walk-in closet, the two of them living with a self-admitted mice problem. ("Julia Fox Gave a Tour of Her 'Underwhelming Apartment,' and It's Screaming Most Relatable Celebrity of the Year," read one *BuzzFeed* headline.) "I don't like excessive displays of wealth," she explained at the conclusion of the tour. "They make me feel icky." A few months later, news broke that she had purchased a $2.9 million brownstone in Harlem. Conversations on social media message boards promptly critiqued the purchase, labeling her a gentrifier and a sellout. Fox will likely never invite us inside her new home, and we should probably wonder why we want to look.

If Kim really is considering a political run, she is taking a pragmatic approach: using social media to draw the public closer and closer while gradually theming her life to activism, law, and politics, from dressing up for Halloween as pop culture's favorite fictional Harvard law student, the pink-clad sorority princess Elle Woods (played by Reese Witherspoon in 2001's *Legally Blonde*), to posting updates on social media about her privately tutored law studies by posing in bikinis as she reads beside a stack of textbooks, to taking audiences into her criminal justice activism work with *The Justice Project,* a limited-run TV show that aired on Oxygen in 2020. This goes beyond the standard, "relatable" parasocial courtship of viewers; it adds a performative, aspirational angle. In the 2020s, several surveys revealed that considerable percentages of Americans would like to elect the actor Morgan Freeman as POTUS, who has played commander in chief in multiple film and TV roles. This is because, the media scholar Jason Turcotte writes in *Comedy, Cameos, and Campaign Communication,* as the public increasingly

embraces “outsider candidates”—and, I’d argue, as our discernment between real life and mass-media-produced narratives further degenerates—it’s easy to envision electing someone who has conveyed presidential qualities in on-screen performances. Consider this phenomenon a tweaked take on Walt Disney’s famous mantra “If you can dream it, you can do it,” to “If you can look like it, you can do it.”

Nearly fifteen years after suggesting at the White House Correspondents’ Dinner red carpet that she might run for mayor, a decade after the presidential inauguration of America’s most well-known reality star—Donald Trump—with whom she later worked on several criminal justice reform lobbies, posing for photos with him in the Oval Office wearing a suit (and a politically neutral facial expression), and ten years also after being violently robbed in her hotel room in Paris, Kim testified at the trial of her attackers. I was present in the Palais de Justice courtroom. As her mother, Kris Jenner, looked on, a couture-skirt-suited Kim took to the lectern at the center of the space with impeccable posture and presidentially declared, “I do want to become a lawyer, and this is my closure,” before testifying for about four hours.

That same morning, the trailer dropped for *All’s Fair,* the Ryan Murphy–created legal drama in which she starred as a powerful divorce attorney. “Almost exactly one week after testifying,” as I reported for *The New Yorker,* “and two days before the trial’s conclusion, Kardashian posted on Instagram announcing that, after six years, she has completed her law program.” A makeshift graduation ceremony was held in Kardashian’s backyard, where she wore a graduation cap and her kids were dressed up “as lawyers in tiny suits holding big suitcases.” One can guess that Kim today could understand where her mother was coming from when, in 2011, she sought to frame the Kardashian family name as akin to that of the Kennedys. Maybe Kim won’t run for office, but following years of accommodating the public’s appetite for private affairs, and of making reality out of make-believe, her family is now a proper dynasty, and we’ve become accustomed to the sight of her in a suit.

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5. O.J.

News, race, and spectacle

"You know the football player O.J. Simpson?" inquire the Kardashian sisters in their 2010 memoir, *Kardashian Konfidential.* "He was one of the best running backs in the NFL. And he was charming and good-looking, and after football he did some commercials and movies."

Simpson was a superstar on the field throughout the 1960s and 1970s, around the same time that the ABC producer Roone Arledge was adding a new dimension of entertainment value to sports telecasts by integrating instant replays and slow-motion effects. In an essay for the Simpson-focused anthology *Birth of a Nation'hood,* Leola Johnson and David Roediger argue that this approach to sports editing, an innovation upon techniques made famous by the Nazi filmmaker Leni Riefenstahl in her documentary about the 1936 Berlin Olympics, "provided the medium that could best showcase highly improvised and visually exciting running styles increasingly seen as hallmarks of African American players, especially Simpson."

His athletic career was a winning case study in how to exploit new mediums—and the body—to brand oneself. But for the Kardashian women, he was "our dad's best friend…. We called him Uncle O.J. One of our mom's best friends was his wife, Nicole, and we grew up with their kids…. Then Nicole was killed, and O.J. was accused of her murder."

The gory story lacerated an already deteriorating image of the once picture-perfect, modern-American Simpson family, and it was underpinned by two forces that seem to seize human attention without fail. In another essay for *Birth of a Nation'hood,* the Black feminist scholar Ann duCille invokes a *People* cover that came out amid feverish media coverage of the case, featuring a nude family portrait of O.J. and Nicole and their infant daughter, Sydney: "Using large, blood-red type, *People* titled its cover 'LOVE

AND DEATH.'" DuCille says we're drawn to such content because the "mass media—tabloids, TV talk shows, and even the more respectable press—play to the same coliseum mentality that thrilled at the sight of human slaughter. We have become a nation of voyeurs," she goes on, "who despite (or maybe because of) our advancement as a civilization, retain what the black psychiatrist Frantz Fanon described as 'an irrational longing for unusual eras of sexual license, of orgiastic scenes, of unpunished rapes, of unrepressed incest.'" George Lipsitz (called by Cornel West the "Eminem of African American studies") adds that these vicarious violent delights further swell whenever they can incite "alarm about the family in jeopardy."

"Love and Death" (or, sex and violence), as the cathartic cheat code to media virality, can be found in most of the Kardashian family's actions. (Think of the time Kim and Khloé donned their standard skintight bodysuits and full makeup masks to tour luxury underground bunkers, debating in elusive but unmistakable terms about whether they'd prefer to die with the rest of the world whenever the Big One comes.) The O.J. case became a landmark courtroom trial, which, of course, meant that there were two sides—prosecution and defense—which, of course, meant that only one could win. It is in the courtroom that we found our contemporary coliseum, one modernized by its reliance on storytelling over swords (as the literary critic Peter Brooks wrote, "If one were to ban narrative from the courtroom, there could be no more verdicts. Crime and punishment demand stories"), and the Kardashian patriarch, Robert Sr., jumped right into this one. "One of our dad's best traits was fierce loyalty," Kourtney, Kim, and Khloé wrote in *Kardashian Konfidential,* "so he renewed his attorney's license and helped defend O.J."

With Dad on O.J.'s side and Mom "100 percent convinced that O.J. had killed Nicole," the Kardashians' home lives became a microcosm of the divisive public discourse about the case, which was viral before people were using the word. The murder had occurred after the Cable News Network (CNN) began twenty-four-hour coverage in 1980, Court TV joined cable networks in 1991, and the 1994 advent of satellite broadcasting (DirecTV)

added hundreds of channel options, so the case supplied a newfound demand for content from an increasingly roomy media landscape.

It didn't hurt, either, that new technologies were even at play within the courtroom, enhancing its function as a TV-primed narrative space. The media theorist Douglas Kellner points out in his book *Media Spectacle* that "the court had installed a $200,000 computer system, and both prosecutors and defense attorneys used it to present evidence to the jurors on an overhead screen. Judge Ito, the attorneys, and witnesses had fifteen-inch monitors on which to observe the evidence, and laptop computers were visible and in use by defense, prosecution, and the judge…. Never before in such a public forum had so many hi-tech exhibits and displays presented the evidence and revealed to the public the ways in which new technologies were transforming the legal profession." New media forms (flashy courtroom technologies) were layered into larger new media forms (expansion of cable TV channels), and if you want to imagine some version of what the media saturation of the case *felt* like, consider TikTok's role in inflaming public interest around Johnny Depp's 2022 defamation lawsuit against his ex-wife Amber Heard, which was dubbed the "TikTok trial" by some media experts. TikTok had exploded in popularity only a few years before, and multiple news channels live streamed the trial on the platform, racking up views in the hundreds of thousands at any given time. (As soon as trial coverage finished for the day and news networks switched to address Russia's recent invasion of Ukraine, viewer numbers would visibly hemorrhage from the live stream.) As the trial stretched into several weeks, lurid information was continuously revealed about the elite couple's troubled marriage, inspiring aspiring influencers to make hot-take reaction videos in the hopes that the platform's curatorial algorithm might include them. Anytime I opened TikTok during this time, some new video covering the case would appear on my For You page. With Amber Heard memes also filling the Instagram feeds, and testimony clips making television news, the trial began to feel inescapable—incredible for a social media landscape that had, by the 2020s, famously fractured into echo chambers based on user engagement patterns, narrowing opportunities for collective experiences. The stream of content led to more than 16,049,016

tweets in a two-month span, and three billion views of TikTok videos with the hashtag #justiceforjohnnydepp.

In 1994 and 1995, the same head-spinning phenomenon—epically expanded information circulation due to new channels of communications—was playing out with news media on television. Ninety-five million Americans tuned in to what the Kardashian sisters summarized as a "famous car chase where O.J. was speeding down the freeway for hours in a white Bronco with the police pursuing him." CNN and Court TV dedicated their entire networks to broadcasting the trial and created talk shows and roundtables to fill the off-hours. (This jump-started the TV careers of multiple talking-head pundits, just as hot-take virality on TikTok turbocharged many influencers' followings.) In his own essay for *Birth of a Nation'hood,* Lipsitz notes that CNN "presented 631 hours of direct televised coverage of the Simpson trial, attracting an average of 2.2 million viewers at any given time. This content increased the channel's ratings and revenues by close to fifty percent." The benefit of ratings and revenues, of course, encouraged networks to harvest as much dramatic content from the case as they could, rather than, as Kellner adds, cover the "over thirty civil wars" that were going on throughout the world at the time. (Citing the *Tyndall Report,* which provides a "weekly analysis of evening network news programming," he writes that coverage by major news networks "exceeded the combined attention to the war in Bosnia and the Oklahoma bombings, which…were the second and third most covered stories of the period.")

"It was very difficult," Kris Jenner told Ellen DeGeneres in 2016, "because my ex-husband was on one side and I was kind of on the other, the kids were in the middle." Being in the middle was perhaps the only feasible position for children, because most American adults, inundated with the trial's sensational headlines, would have developed their own take. Not only was this a tragedy of "love and death," but it was also a case study of gender and race in America. O.J. was a Black man and Nicole a white woman, and the murder occurred just a couple of years after the Rodney King riots, which had resurfaced Los Angeles's long history of racial unease. The prosecution uncovered O.J.'s history of beating Nicole, who once confided in a friend that

she believed he would one day kill her. The defense argued that O.J. had been a victim of corrupt policing and exposed the leading criminal investigator as a racist under cross-examination. The storylines that unfolded both in the courtroom and in the media—probably two of the most powerful vehicles of cultural narrative in our country—meant something different based on the sympathies of the viewer. The legal expert Patricia J. Williams sums up the resulting tensions by identifying the two "sides." "White women, Black men—each contesting their figurative disfigurement, the matter of their symbolic debasement. And as Black men continue to be Willie Horton–ized to death," she writes, referencing William Horton, whose crimes committed while furloughed from prison became a flash point during the 1988 presidential election, "no less do white women continue to be Nicole Brown Simpson–ized into the beautiful shape of the sheet-covered dead."

> Yes, Willie Horton was a real rapist and Nicole Brown Simpson was a real victim of domestic violence, but as the public discussion turns him into all Black men and her into all white women, real Black men spend their lives trying to overcome an impossible burden of other people's run-amok fear, while real white women find themselves rendered archetypally fragile and pornographically prone to slasher plots, dismembered in the media with such relentless reiteration that it only goes to prove their endless miraculous powers of figurative resurrection.

For this reason, as the humanities professor Michael Eric Dyson told PBS a few years after the trial, some of the Black community championed O.J.'s cause. "Often for black people, we don't get a chance to choose those who end up symbolizing us. We had tried to get a 747 to represent us—Martin Luther King Jr., Malcolm X, Ossie Davis, Harry Belafonte—but lo and behold, a broke-down, rickety old secondhand car named the O.J. Simpson case became the carrier of our dreams. And so many black people invested in that broken-down car because that was going to get the message across." After all, the "broken-down" car that represented O.J.'s once stellar public

image carried the remnants of a record-making sports sensation and media-savvy Everyman whose broad smile, whether in movies like *The Naked Gun* or Hertz rental car commercials, reflected true star power. Media scholars like to reference the historic Astor Place Riots when explaining the ways that media inspires audience identification with representational figures, often sparking conflict. In *Celebrity,* Douglas and McDonnell write that theater was one of the earliest forms of entertainment in major cities like New York, bringing together people from diverse backgrounds and then stratifying them in the physical space based on identity: "The expensive boxes above and to the side of the stage were reserved for the wealthy. Below the boxes (what we would today call the orchestra) was 'the pit,' where the emerging middle class —manual laborers, sailors, mechanics, tradesmen, and, in New York, the Bowery b'hoys—sat. Known for their boisterous (often drunken) behavior, bright clothes, and love of the theater, the b'hoys were single, working-class men, mostly firemen and mechanics. Above and behind the pit were the cheap gallery seats (today's mezzanine) occupied by newsboys, apprentices, and other lower wage workers; segregated from everyone in the upper third tier were African Americans (assigned the very worst seats), and prostitutes and their clients. Those in the gallery were known to pelt actors who displeased them (as well as those in the boxes) with rotten fruit, eggs, peanuts (hence the peanut gallery), and pennies. Those in each sector of the theater resented the others." Eventually, "this segregation within theaters began to give way to segregation between theaters. The new, luxurious Astor Place Opera House opened late in 1847 and was meant for the rich." In the spring of 1849, a highbrow British actor, William Macready, was due to perform *Macbeth* there, and his American rival, Edwin Forrest, beloved by working-class audiences, was slated for *Spartacus* a few blocks away. The penny press—that is, the tabloids—of the times egged on their antipathy toward each other, situating Macready as a British elitist and Forrest as a man of the people (even though both were Shakespearean-trained actors). On May 8, the tensions bubbled when hundreds of Forrest's followers bought tickets to attend *Macbeth* and disrupt Macready's performance, hollering and throwing food at him onstage. They reached a boiling point a few days later, when

more than ten thousand people gathered outside the Astor Place Opera House and, after police attempted to contain them, began rioting, leading to more than twenty-two deaths. Talk about fan loyalty. Macready's and Forrest's audiences were the ultimate ride or dies who viewed their faves as representations of their own stations in life. "Conflicts about celebrities are never only about them. Ever," write Douglas and McDonnell.

The irony is that the lives of O.J. and Nicole, not to mention Amber and Johnny, bear no resemblance to the life of the average Joe, yet both couples nevertheless came to stand for widespread and profound cultural traumas and anxieties. Yes, it's undeniable that women will be slaughtered, and Black people will be unjustly profiled, regardless of their wealth and fame. But it's also true that everyone involved in these cases was an American approximation to royalty, and few of the everyday people so captivated by their worst moments would have comparable experiences with the justice system if they ever found themselves in a high-stakes courtroom. Kellner suggests that "the decline of community in an era of suburbs, media culture, and consumerism led people to need greater units or groupings than their immediate social relations, to be part of something bigger," which Stuart Hall, the Jamaican-British sociologist and founder of the *New Left Review,* explains as a natural need for media figures to function as metaphors for ourselves in an increasingly globalized world, inviting us into previously unimaginable worlds and scenarios. "[Politicians and public figures] are our representatives, and where we can't be, they can be," he told the crowd at an Open University lecture in 1997. "So the notion of something which images and depicts, and that which *stands in for* something else, both of those ideas are kind of brought together in the notion of representation."

For example, when, in 2009, Kanye West stormed the MTV Video Music Awards stage to intercept Taylor Swift's Best Video by a Female Artist award and declare that he'd let her finish, "but Beyoncé had one of the best videos of all time," he was able to speak for anyone among the nine million watching at home that night who might have felt the same way. But his moment of truth-telling was also a media spectacle onto which outlets and audiences alike could project loaded tropes. "If only West and Swift wouldn't have

played so perfectly into their roles: the innocent white girl and the supposedly menacing Black man," Yolanda Sangweni wrote for *Essence* the following year, after Taylor was suspected to have IRL-subtweeted Kanye while performing her new song "Innocent" at the 2010 VMAs, which featured lyrics like "who you are is not where you've been," and expressed forgiveness of an unnamed thirty-two-year-old's bad actions. Sangweni interpreted Swift's act as one of performative martyrdom, especially in contrast to West's rendition that same night of his latest song, "Runaway," in which he publicly declared himself a "douchebag" and an "asshole." "Like it or not," Sangweni wrote, "pop culture is a reflection of our reality and cannot be dismissed as having no meaning or value. Case in point: As soon as Swift's performance ended, commenters on sites like EW.com couldn't help but take it there. 'Kanye West is a d-bag n***,' wrote one commenter. 'I hope he meets up with his mom in hell real soon.' One wonders if we'd still be talking about this a year later if West had interrupted Gabourey Sidibe, for example. Somehow, I doubt it."

Does pop culture reflect our reality, or does our reality reflect pop culture —or some confusing combination of the two? Stuart Hall gifted us a tool for interrogating the sometimes-fraught relationship between media representations and consumers when he invented the "encoding/decoding model of communication" to map out the different ways media phenomena can be received based on the vantage point of the consumer. He argued that producers of media "encode" content with their chosen ideology or belief system, and it will come as no surprise that most encoding promotes whichever ideology is driving the dominant culture. This is what made the O.J. case so confounding: Racism and sexism, two dominant American ideologies, were being situated at odds with each other in the courtroom. (Hall himself is no stranger to the experience of being torn: He once told *The Guardian* of his experience as a Jamaican-British academic, "The life I have lived is one of partial displacement.")

People magazine featured that eye-catching Simpson family portrait, framing it with a smaller corner image of Nicole's sheet-covered body being carried out on a stretcher, encoding the cover with a message that reinforced

the one being constructed day after day by the prosecution: *O.J. did it.* When, in the aftermath of Kanye's VMAs spectacle, CNBC's John Harwood asked Obama if his daughters were as upset as *his* kids had been about what happened to Taylor, what could the nation's hyper-scrutinized first Black president do but echo the popular consensus? "He's a jackass." And there it was: *Obama didn't like what Kanye did either.*

(Proving true, to some extent, claims Kanye would later make that he—and, later, Kimye—was one of Obama's most useful references, against which the president could morally contrast himself and come off as pop culturally attuned.)

And what of Kim Kardashian? Though some consider the O.J. trial the Kardashian book of Genesis, others mark Kim's true beginnings with the 2007 leak of her sex tape with the pop star Brandy Norwood's younger brother, Ray J (a 2023 survey by the Kardashian Data Koalition discovered that 62.9 percent of respondents believe it remains Kim's most impactful scandal). Vivid Entertainment claimed to have purchased the tape for $1 million from an "unnamed entity," and Kim sued the company for invasion of privacy before its release, demanding ownership and profits from the tape. They reached a settlement of $5 million, and Ray J later revealed that together they'd negotiated and split a million-dollar advance and continue to earn quarterly royalties.

Pop culture's sex tape lineage follows, of course, the *Baywatch* star Pamela Anderson and the rock drummer Tommy Lee's *Stolen Honeymoon* in 1995, to the socialite Paris Hilton and the poker player Rick Salomon's *1 Night in Paris* in 2004, each with their own creative direction and backstories and both proving that sex scandals can augment a woman's fame, albeit balanced by a good deal of public shaming and little to no padding to the pocketbook.

So, what made Kim and Ray J's production special enough to earn $1.4 million in its first six weeks and $100 million over ten years and debut Kim's name on Google's top-searched list when her status as Paris Hilton's lowly sidekick had plateaued? Yes, the family's now-infamous business acumen was essential to *Superstar*'s success, but so were the tape's costars, whose

identities, if the O.J. trial taught us anything, were packed with meaning: a Black man and a "white" woman (whose true racial identity leaves room for almost as much decoding as the scenario itself), offering a sexy script in place of a story about death.

Encoded messaging travels through media as discourse, as its recipients are tasked with "decoding" whatever they've taken in. Hall writes that there are three ways that audiences do this: They can take the message at face value, from a "dominant-hegemonic position," which is the reading the producers want the audience to have, and in this case would be the straightforward "O.J. did it," and, on a deeper level, as Williams suggests, the idea that all Black men are violent and/or all white women are destined to mutilation. When Obama disavows Kanye, we are meant to be assured that he is aligned with how the rest of the country feels; we can release a sigh of relief that he won't take, as Sangweni wrote, the "menacing Black man's" side. In Kim Kardashian's case, well, Pornhub comments for the video follow a pattern: sexist remarks about Kim's appearance and racist evaluations of Ray J's penis size.

Alternatively, the viewer can "negotiate" messaging by acknowledging its intended coding but deciding how it fits into her own perspective based on her positioning in the larger social context, leading, in the O.J. case, to some groups viewing the Simpson case as a story about sexist violence, others, about racist state violence, and others, celebrity privilege.

It was inevitable that *Superstar* would be prime for negotiated decoding. Heavy-handed narrative framing about the Tape on the family's reality show, in which the first-ever episode of *KUWTK* showed Kim fretting about how to talk about it on an upcoming *Tyra Show* guest spot, and occasional tabloid stars teasing new tidbits about its production have led to public confusion about what was true and public debates about the conflicting meaning it holds for its two stars.

Kevin Dickson, a former *In Touch* editor, shared in a 2017 *Page Six* oral history of the Tape that Kim's angst about its leak had been sincere. "Paris calls me and she's like, 'Dude—what the f——k!' And Kim was crying in the background. She'd seen the story by then, and Kim's saying, 'It's not me, it's

not me.' Kim was saying that [the hip-hop 'video vixen'] Superhead was actually the person in the video."

Superhead was the alter ego of Karrine Steffans, the former dancer, model, and best-selling author of *Confessions of a Video Vixen,* who was not, of course, the woman in the video and had her own view of the distribution deal that Kim and Ray J cut with Vivid Entertainment following Kim's lawsuit for invasion of privacy. "Ray was…trying to figure out whether to sign the deal. I told him I didn't think it was a good idea. 'You're a black man, so it's not going to do for you what it's going to do for her,' is what I told him, and I said, 'If she were a black female, I'll tell her not to do it. But she's not.' "

The psychoanalyst Manuel Harpin argues in an essay in *Kardashians: A Critical Anthology* that due to the family's historic and famous proximity to the O. J. Simpson trial, Kim's sexual dynamics with Black men will always be loaded with "the memory of the trial and a memory of interracial violence. Consciously or not, it is only with this memory in mind that Kim's sex tape with Ray J resonated with the American public." Others, like the *Mirror*'s Saira Khan, decode Kim's refusal to be shamed for the event as a key takeaway: "If that had been me, I'd never have been able to show my face again in public. Not Kim. She turned the event into a business opportunity."

When I surveyed my Instagram audience about their opinions of Kim's sex tape, thousands voted, and I found that 71 percent of respondents felt that the tape would not be as popular if Kim had performed with a white man. Fifty-four percent felt that its creation was exploitative of Black men. Thirty-seven percent felt that Kim's monetization of the tape was empowering for women. Seventy-eight percent felt that the Kardashians probably facilitated its release. "Decoding within the negotiated version," Hall writes, "contains a mixture of adaptive and oppositional elements: it acknowledges the legitimacy of the hegemonic definitions to make the grand significations"—in other words, we all know that a sex tape is scandalous, especially one starring an interracial couple in the context of a racist and sexist society—"while, at a more restricted, situational level, it makes its own ground rules—it operates with exceptions to the rule." There are numerous ways into understanding the anxieties generated by the content.

Finally, viewers can altogether shoot down whatever's being fed to them (Hall's "oppositional" perspective), which is what the trial's jury did, for better or worse, when they rejected the claims made by the prosecution and acquitted O.J. of both murders, and what Kim tried to persuade people to do when she told George Lopez in 2010, "I could literally be, like, full on making out with a white guy in the middle of the street and no one would even care. And I could stand next to, you know, someone else and they would automatically take a picture." We can't forget that she relied on a racist dominant hegemony when she initially (allegedly) tried to pass off a Black woman as Ray J's sex tape costar, nor the countless ways her family has situated itself at the center of racist spectacle, as explored by numerous Black feminist cultural critics, from Lauren Michele Jackson to Natalie Franklin, but her point that media frames the content more likely to turn us on, piss us off, and position us against one another is a good one to keep in mind.

Hall wants us to grasp that media messaging may not land exactly as planned, because the "masses" are far more complex and diverse than dominant culture would like to imagine. I appreciate his notion that the masses are not a monolith, in part because it might persuade you not to cancel me for failing to deconstruct the Kardashians in the *exact same way* that you would. But maybe that makes it sound as though Hall's were a simple point about the subjectivity of opinion. His essential argument is that the more *actively*—rather than passively—audiences consume media, the more empowered we'll be to negotiate its messaging, if not entirely resist it. And maybe, just maybe, one day delete our social media accounts and turn off our TVs and make sense of reality based upon our day-to-day material experiences rather than the ways that representations are organized in relation to—or against—one another.

In an interview with the Media Education Foundation, bell hooks offered her own incisive decoding of the O.J. trial. Invited to speak on *Good Morning America,* she says,

> I was asked to just give my response, but they really wanted me to say, who was innocent and who was guilty. And what I said was that the

> only thing I really knew about the O. J. Simpson case was that it began and ended with male violence and that no one to my knowledge ever speculated that there were a bunch of women waiting outside that house to hack anybody to death…that's not the quote that anybody wanted to hear. They wanted the black woman to be choosing against the white woman or to be protecting the black man, they wanted this whole racialized scenario…. The masterful nature, conservative aspect of this spectacle was that it successfully got people to move back into very one-dimensional positions of identity, politics, of racial or sexual essentialism, because there was no frame within the spectacle itself to allow for a complex accounting of what was taking place…. The O. J. Simpson case was not compelling to me personally as something to watch and to observe and to talk about because I felt the deepest terms in relation to Guy Debord's work on the Notion of Spectacle…. And I felt morally and ethically that as a feminist who has opposed domestic violence, who has wanted there to be a recognition of the meaning of domestic violence as one of the ways in which patriarchy affirms and perpetuates itself…that I was actually…not only affirming the patriarchal culture of violence that surrounded this case, but also actually working to do the very thing I critique about patriarchy in my work around domestic violence which is that we're made to think that…the more interesting story is the story of the life of the perpetrator.

In labeling the Simpson trial a "spectacle," hooks summoned Guy Debord, a French Marxist philosopher and founding member of the Situationists, an organization of avant-garde intellectuals who, among varied acts of resistance, critiqued commodity culture by subverting popular marketing and cultural images with their preferred ideological messaging. One often aesthetic method was called *détournement,* which translates from French to "rerouting" or "hacking." A common citation of *détournement* art in internet discourse today is a sourceless thought-bubble application of the French author Georges Duhamel's line (popularized by Walter Benjamin) "My thoughts have been replaced by moving images" to the comic-book-ish image of Roy

Lichtenstein's *Crying Girl*. (One might argue that the Situationists laid groundwork for meme culture today.) Debord is best known for his difficult-to-explicate manifesto, *The Society of the Spectacle,* in which he argues that postwar capitalism had replaced a reality of human interaction with one of image interaction. "All that once was directly lived has become mere representation," he wrote—predicting, nearly half a century early, the dynamics that underlie Instagram—because Western social life had declined from "being into having and having into merely appearing." Why? Postindustrial society had fulfilled most basic human needs, creating new and increasingly symbolic demands. Advertising dangles the promise of consumer gratification to keep us working to buy the stuff that can *say something* about who we are. This may not come as any great revelation; most of us understand that ads manipulate us into believing that our lives will be better if we have more stuff culturally deemed "cool." What's pressing about Debord's point is that the *images* of these products and lifestyles are meant to *stand in for* our personalities, interests, and values, mattering much more than the functional use of the items themselves. The thrill, during Instagram's peak, was not so much *wearing* or even *owning* the Yeezy sneaker as being able to post an *image proving that you had it*. Same went for Brazilian butt lifts and lip fillers. And even if you never bought into such aspects of Instagram culture, the fact is that whenever you leave a comment on a friend's post, the message is coming from a small round photo of yourself—your profile picture—not You. When your friend clicks on your username, they'll arrive at a grid full of images or videos of you—or whatever other images you decided were relevant—organized in a way that represents not your literal, physical personhood, but a self-concept. According to Debord, "When the real world changes into simple images, simple images become real beings and effective motivations of a hypnotic behavior." Hypnotized, we continue to scroll, tap, post.

This image-based system is called the Spectacle, and it has accustomed us to navigating life in terms of representations. As public figures whose personhoods are indistinguishable from their brands, Kim and Kanye offer high-scale examples of what happens when representational images interact

with one another. When Kimye announced their love in 2014, the couple was both a romantic enmeshment and a merging of the semiotics that had come to represent them: the prolific and unpredictable genius whose face is always covered with sunglasses or masks or balaclavas with the insatiable, performative woman with a big booty.

This is also why, Lipsitz writes, the O.J. trial was so primed for TV. "The key pieces of material evidence in the trial were almost all commodities: the white Bronco and the Rolls Royce, the mysterious knife and the expensive Italian shoes, the unusual pair of designer leather gloves, some missing luggage, a golf bag, and even O.J.'s socks…. The prominence of these items allowed journalists to report the news and talk about shopping at the same time."

Decades spent investing in the symbolic value of commodities have shaped the way we now relate to imagery, even when we're not positioned to pay for a product. The story of Kanye and Taylor at the 2009 VMAs is nothing without the Hennessy bottle, the mic, the trophy, his sunglasses, and the camera cut to Beyoncé's astonished expression. In 2020, Kim Kardashian recycled the decade-old sex tape scandal for the series premiere of her *Kardashians* TV show for Hulu. After her young son, Saint, stumbled upon an internet meme suggesting that Ray J was planning to release "another tape," she swore that there was no additional footage to leak, and speed-dialed her lawyers. "What if I was asleep and he put a dildo up my ass?" she joked, then changed up the tone to add that she had "all the money, and all the resources to burn them all to the fucking ground." (By this later stage in Kim's career, she was litigious about her moneymaking image, much in the way Disney over time became of its own precious brand semiotic, Mickey Mouse, especially after 1972, when the illustrator Dan O'Neill rendered an image of Mickey performing oral sex on Minnie for his comic book and was promptly sued by the conglomerate.) The following week's episode celebrated Kanye, who retrieved the footage from Ray J, arriving at Kim's hotel room before her *Saturday Night Live* hosting gig with a mysterious suitcase in tow. When she opened it, it was full of computers and external hard drives. After these episodes aired, incensed by the rapey way he'd been depicted on the show,

Ray J went live on Instagram and began presenting Vivid contracts on a wall-sized projector to suggest that the Kardashians had indeed been the ones to leak the sex tape back in 2007. A few years later, Kris Jenner took a lie detector test on *The Late Late Show with James Corden* (eliciting an echo of O.J.'s famous failed lie detector test, taken two days after Simpson and Goldman's murders) and testified, to a passing verdict, that she had *not* had a hand in the leak of the tape. This was a story of memes, Kim's Crying Face, threats of lawsuits, dildos, suitcase, computer parts, wall-sized presentations, official-looking contracts, and hands hooked up to wires in the pursuit of truth. But what did the meme actually say? What did the computer parts really contain? What did the paperwork ultimately prove? How do lie detector tests work, anyway? The meaningful information is hazy, eclipsed in memorability by the super-visual objects that represent it, and, when presented as a sequence of events, indicate Drama. Kellner says audiences engage with Spectacle when they are "transfixed by the packaging, display, and consumption of commodities and the play of media events," and he credits the Simpson trial with the rise of "heavily media oriented" identity politics, wherein "contending groups articulat[e] and circulat[e] their views through the media…. The very structure of the media encourages such an adversarial culture and politics of confrontation" and risks that the groups "fragment into smaller social atoms, as, for example, when feminists split into ever smaller divisions according to race, class, political affiliations, sexual preferences, and the like." We can observe this on TikTok today, where "discourse" sometimes devolves into clout-grabby callouts or community infighting, with users "stitching" one another's videos—clipping five seconds from one video to add to one's own recorded response—as a means of participating in viral outrage.

Still, Kellner also recognizes the role that spectacles like the Simpson trial can play as educational tools, offering "instruction concerning how the legal system works (or fails to) and how society is split around the axes of gender, race, and class. Watching the trial unfold, one could learn about the intricate machinations of lawyers, judges, and others involved in the criminal justice system…. An attentive audience could learn about male abuse of women."

Maybe he'd say the same of internet debates. His concern is just that this amounts to "pseudo-participation, while decreasing involvement in actual sociopolitical struggles." Richard Dyer, author of *Stars,* might be inclined to add that "for groups—the working class, women, blacks, gays—who have been excluded from the culture's system of representations in all but marginal or demeaning forms, the call for an end to identification figures is, if nothing else, premature." Clearly, the progress and perils of a society predicated increasingly upon our "identification figures" and the politics they inspire are considerations for a whole other book, but they are worth touching on here, as we explore the function of late-capitalist new media pop icons, because politicians, corporations, and pop stars are more and more easily able to mobilize and transform identity groups into useful voting constituents, market demographics, and fandoms.

The spectacle doesn't always mean high drama, though. It's just the world you enter once you accept the inescapable premise that images operate as a cover for real life, the more novel, the better. The same impact of the Spectacle that Kellner perceives in identity politics shows up in our consumption of pop culture, as we gaze upon pop figures and fantasize in TikTok takes and silly tweets about what our fandom "tells us" about our personalities, principles, or the state of the world. Sometimes I consider Debord's idea of the Spectacle more in terms of "the simulation," as we joke about it in memes today. When Kim, Kanye, Elon Musk, Grimes, Travis Scott, Quavo, and Saweetie posed for a photo together at the Kardashians' 2019 Christmas Eve party, the Instagram artist Gabi Abrão, known as SighSwoon, used the image for a meme that declared "the simulation is breaking." The joke was that this was a novel interaction between unexpected representations within the much vaster web of public figures.

Whether representation is engaging because it is surprising, like a Kardashian in a group of unexpected faces, or brutal, like a race-baity crime story at the helm of new mediums, we increasingly understand the world in terms of encodement and visual narrative. So, when the Spectacle remixes images and narratives in a way that reshapes our existing paradigms, it leaves a mark in public memory.

"One source of public dissatisfaction with the trial," Lipsitz writes, "with its participants and its outcome, seems to stem from the failure of the trial to fit the frame that television established for it, to come to a 'happy ending' in the form of an unambiguous verdict of guilty." As with Kim's sex tape, which was supposed to end in her shame, media had trained us to anticipate one kind of script, and instead we got another, one open to multiple interpretations but with the definitive ending of Kim's triumph. What a jolt!

Media careers were launched by the O.J. case, deploying its key figures to continue to build upon the Spectacle reality Americans had accepted by way of engaging. The trial's judge, Lance Ito, was said to have been offered $1 million to star in *The People's Court.* Gerry Spence, a popular commentator on the case, was given his own show on CNBC. The William Morris Agency clamored to represent the prosecutor Marcia Clark for future publicity appearances. A member of the jury was featured in an issue of *Playboy,* and, Kellner adds, an O.J.-themed cruise ship set sail from California to Mexico so that self-proclaimed "OJ addicts," willing to shell out between $500 and $800, could deep dive the media content of the trial without the distractions of day-to-day life. Lipsitz continues: "Industry experts confided to *The Advertising Age* that 'Simpson-related marketing could produce as much as one billion dollars in media and merchandising sales.'" Good thing Simpson, already a proven businessman with his high-profile Hertz partnership, sports commentating, and countless movie and TV cameos, had thought to trademark his name and nicknames while the trial was under way, and filed "more than fifty lawsuits against merchandisers marketing items" that used it. "In addition, Simpson negotiated deals for a video, a book, pay-per-view interviews, and other projects that might eventually net as much as $18 million."

It's not a stretch to guess that the Kar-Jenner proximity to the case informed their future proficiency in cultivating image-driven virality; after all, Kris Jenner and her daughters are famous for trademarking everything related to their family's brand, from the term "momager" to their own names to the names of all their children. *The People vs. O.J. Simpson,* a ten-episode miniseries produced by the notoriously sensationalistic Ryan Murphy,

premiered in 2016, creating a more overt visual dialogue between the Simpson case and the Kardashians than had ever been depicted by media in the 1990s. Yes, Kardashian had been at his best friend's side during the trial, and pregnant (with Kendall) Kris Jenner once spoke to news cameras in the media-savvy fashion ("not only have we lost Nicole, and we've lost O.J. too") we'd come to know so well, but Robert Sr. was not the lead attorney of the case, and, if any of Nicole's pals were famous then, it was Faye Resnick, who published a lurid bestseller about Nicole's sex and drug habits not long after the trial concluded (and would, much later, make appearances on *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* as one of Kris's friends). *The People vs. O.J.,* though, decoded the situation largely from Robert Kardashian's bewildered view. *Did his friend really do it?* There's even a scene that shows the Kardashian kids chanting their own last name at the TV screen as they watch their dad read O.J.'s suicide note on live TV. If this tabloid-esque TV show, which garnered 7.7 million viewers, will provide posterity to the case for younger generations, then history has been revised in a way that further places the family at the center of an iconic American event. (When O.J. died in 2024, countless tweets were posted to the effect of this one by @Fritschner: "Interns and younger staff discussing OJ Simpson say they barely know who he was but they know one of his lawyers was a Kardashian.") In 2019, the Kardashians devoted an episode called "Rumor Has It" to the trial, depicting Kris's recollection of the loss of her friend and confrontation of rumors that she and O.J. had an affair. (The psychoanalyst Manuel Harpin has written a deconstruction of the hyper-sexualized framing of Black masculinity in that episode.) In 2020, Kim hosted *Saturday Night Live* and cracked a joke deemed to be "in bad taste" by Denise Brown, Nicole's sister.

"It's because of [my father] that I met my first Black person. Want to take a stab in the dark at who it was? I know it's sort of weird to remember the first Black person you met, but O.J. does leave a mark, or several, or none at all. I still don't know." She's quipping to the many people who feel that she's made a spectacle of her alignment with Black communities, interests, and traumas for clout. She's also declaring her position on the O.J. matter to be in "the middle," as it was when she was a kid, torn between her parents.

Ironically, Kim's refusal to publicly interpret the trial, "pick a side," or "decode" the messaging encoded in its enduring myth itself *caused* a spectacle. The image of Kim in her pink superheroine-esque Balenciaga jumpsuit, cracking inscrutable jokes about race and death, was one of the most memorable moments from her *SNL* appearance, which earned 5.3 million viewers.

Sometimes, the Kardashians encode their media with such maddening self-restraint and intentional ambiguity that the rest of us are provoked into negotiating it, further involving us in their spectacle even as we deconstruct it. I'm indicting myself here; after all, you're reading these words in a book I've authored called *Dekonstructing the Kardashians*. Other times, their encodement is self-evident—for example, anytime Kim makes a public statement about urgent news, always via Instagram, whether on Kanye's latest meltdown during their marriage, reminding audiences of his "mental health struggles," or the 2024 eruption of conflict in Gaza, expressing allegiance to Israel—which makes the negotiation or opposition process at least a little easier to manage.

In September 2022, fed up with being characterized as a villain in the recycled sex tape storyline, Ray J told Charlamagne tha God that there would be "some legal stuff happening." While, to this date, that promise has not yet been fulfilled, 50 percent of KDK survey respondents say they would like to see Ray J take Kim Kardashian to trial. It's not hard to imagine that, on some level, Kim, who herself has stated an ambition to become a licensed attorney —which would allow her to apply her authorial mastery, developed on digital mediums, to the iconic American medium that is the courtroom—might not mind so much either.

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6. THE SPICE GIRLS

Girls in groups, archetypes, and metrics of virality

As THE SPICE GIRLS were becoming one of Britain's biggest cultural exports in the mid-1990s, Victoria Beckham, known then as Posh Spice, sometimes said that she wanted to get "as famous as Persil Automatic," the U.K.'s household-name laundry detergent. Through the years—packaged with Baby, Scary, Sporty, and Ginger—Victoria would achieve this, and, well over a decade later, when Kim Kardashian posted a photo of her own colorful five-piece girl group (herself with her sisters) to Instagram and captioned it "The Spice Girls," Victoria reposted the photo to her page (as did the equally approving "Ginger" Geri and "Baby" Emma) and asked which one was Posh. She'd have her answer a few years later, when, in 2021, Kim shared a grainy throwback photo of her teenage self with friends costumed as the Spice Girls for a high school talent show (kinda funny, considering the Spice Girls and the Kardashians alike have been derided as "talentless"). Young Kim was wearing the iconic black "Posh" dress and throwing up the group's signature peace sign. "The Perfect Posh," Victoria answered on Instagram, and a few years later she would invite Kim to sit in the front row of her eponymous fashion label's Paris Fashion Week showcase (next to Anna Wintour). These early interactions made headlines in *Vogue,* the *Mirror,* and *Marie Claire* (among others), perhaps because, despite the banality of their content, their structure had produced a pleasing spectacle: the two biggest girl-group sensations of the past two decades expressing positivity toward each other across the algorithm, in essence connecting and expanding their collective media power—or should I say "Girl Power"?

Groups of girls often arouse public ire—which is, itself, a form of power. In 1997, when the Spice Girls were established as the world's best-selling girl group in music history (which they remain at the time of writing), with two

hit albums, countless brand partnerships, and a Super Bowl weekend movie box office smash, *Spice World,* under their belts, the famed music producer, songwriter, and future murderer Phil Spector said, "There is a big difference between the Spice Girls and a porno movie. A porno movie has better music. Am I the only one who believes…are the Spice Girls the anti-Christ? That's what it feels like to me." Not long after, in conversation with *Rolling Stone,* Radiohead's front man, Thom Yorke, echoed Spector's "anti-Christ" comment, adding, "If I had kids…I'd move to an island where you can't get hold of any Spice Girls stuff." A 1998 episode of MTV's gory satirical series *Celebrity Deathmatch* showed the girls as Claymation characters in a boxing ring, fighting the popular American pop trio Hanson for the title of "Most Annoying Band in the World," resulting in Baby Spice's body being torn in half by the boy band. Is it *so* tough to imagine today that a playful lineup of ladies in platform shoes who promoted positivity and Girl Power would be so detested by so many? After all, Daniel Craig, otherwise known as the new millennium's James Bond, told *British GQ* in 2011, "Look at [the Kardashians]. You see that and you think, 'what, you mean all I have to do is behave like a fucking idiot on television and then you'll pay me millions?' " In 2012 the actor Jon Hamm shared a similar sentiment with *Elle UK*. "Whether it's Paris Hilton or Kim Kardashian or whoever…being a f**king idiot is a valuable commodity in this culture."

The issue was, according to their critics, that the Spice Girls were "fake" or "talentless" (sound familiar?), no more than sex dolls manufactured by industry hacks to commodify the sacred art of song and maximize profit. It's true that the Spice Girls, most of them from modest backgrounds outside London, had answered a call to audition put out by the father-son duo Bob and Chris Herbert of Heart Management, who were specifically seeking five members, because "four will invariably split up into two separate camps, increasing the likelihood of feuds." And why a girl group? "There are a lot of boy groups around at the moment," said Chris in video footage from 1994. "We thought it was time to…get together a white girl singing, dancing group because there is just a need for it." (Racism shows up often in Spice Girls productions—why was the group's sole Black member, Mel B, dubbed the

"scary" one, always costumed in animal print? Yet somehow, at the time, this was seldom, if ever, the catalyst for the widespread scorn directed at the group.)

As we know well, the Kardashians are viewed as canned media commodities—though, one might argue, they're a bit more "organic," since they were produced and put together by Kris Jenner's womb, rather than some management company—who leave a greater impact on screens than in real life (which is why Kim's success as a *Saturday Night Live* host in 2020 was such a coup; she'd survived live TV and a studio audience). As for the Spice Girls, it was no secret that they were selected for being "extremely marketable. You had the sporty girl, the pretty girl, the sophisticated girl, the black girl," said Erwin Keiles, a producer who was present during the auditions, describing crass early typecasting that would, over time, develop into iconic archetypes. "It's almost as if they went out and did a survey to decide how they were going to design a new model of car. It was a great concept. But none of them could sing any better than the girl who lives down the street." (Besides the two Mels.) Girl groups were historically Black, emerging in 1957, according to Jacqueline Warwick, the music scholar and author of *Girl Groups, Girl Culture,* and dominating the pop charts from 1960 to 1963, when the cultural dominance of male baby-boomer-era music stars had waned (Elvis joined the army, Chuck Berry was in jail, Little Richard became a minister, and Buddy Holly perished with his friends in a plane crash). Many of these girl groups had been put together by more established male groups, or music industry boyfriends, or labels like Detroit's iconic Motown Records, which, in its earliest years, churned out hits by groups like the Temptations, the Four Tops, and the Supremes. Did this manufactured status mean that girl groups lacked a Walter Benjamin–certified "aura"? Not necessarily. After all, "during the most active years of the Southern Civil Rights movement, young female singers such as Diana Ross of the Supremes were among the most visible African Americans in the United States, and they represented notions of black identity as well as girl identity." Warwick points out that certain musical conventions of these girl groups rang true to the best aspects of female collectivism:

> The established girl group ensemble singing style of the early 1960s typically follows a rhetoric of call and response, wherein a lead singer makes statements that are answered by backup singers. The response can entail encouraging remarks such as "Go ahead girl!" (in Martha and the Vandellas' "Heat Wave") or "Come on baby" (in Little Eva's "Locomotion"). Girls listening and singing along to records are free to choose between the roles of caller and responder and to imagine themselves alternately as the individual in the spotlight or as one of a group of sympathetic friends. The interactions rehearsed through call-and-response singing provide a model for relationships among girls, who can learn how to talk and listen to one another…. Girl talk at its most virtuosic involves coaxing, comforting, dissenting, and confirming remarks from friends supporting a girl's articulation of her concerns.

Girl groups seem to work best when the participating girls care for one another ("We decided early on that we'd always put the band first," Mel B told the camera in "behind the scenes" footage from 1994) and understand that they can harness power by leveraging individual strengths in the service of a bigger and better whole. As Kim Kardashian told Andy Cohen in 2021, "The one thing I always was certain of was, I'm ten times more boring in real life. I knew…I was nothing without my sisters and my family." When the experimental punk author Kathy Acker interviewed the Spice Girls for *The Guardian,* Geri—who was often described as both a branding visionary and something of a mother hen to the other girls—told her, "Collectively, we've got something going. Individually, I don't think we'd be that great." Reading through accounts of the early years of the Spice Girls and the Kardashians, I discovered a resonant theme: Collaborators remember both groups for their contagious energy ("I fell in love with them on the spot, like everybody did," said the songwriter Biff Stannard of the Spice Girls), impressive chemistry ("You cannot manufacture what those girls had. I know there was a plot behind it…. But they chose the right people," said Ric Blaxill, producer for *Top of the Pops*), and exhaustive work ethic ("Those girls worked harder than

anybody else I've ever seen in my life," said the attorney Gerrard Tyrrell, while Kim's *American Horror Story* costar the actress Emma Roberts commented in 2024 that Kim Kardashian is "one of the most prepared actresses" she's ever worked with), always subverting initially low expectations.

"It's the meeting that changed the world," recalled Eliot Goldberg, VP of production and development at Ryan Seacrest Productions, of his first and fateful encounter with the Kar-Jenners in 2007. "My expectations were fairly in check, because I just didn't have any idea that they were going to be marketable, or what this was. So, the meeting is the five of them in our conference room and they proceed to basically play out the show in the meeting, what the show would become. Normally, you would think, 'They're putting this on, this is an act,' but you could see they were just being themselves, talking like they do to each other."

"Together it was easy," Mel B later recalled. "When one of us couldn't be arsed to answer a question, another person could. Where one person just wanted to go home, there would be another one who was well up for staying. The energy vroomed around the group and you'd always catch it from someone else if you were feeling tired or bored."

"I like these girls," Kathy Acker concluded, in her *Guardian* profile; she could "hardly make out who's saying what" due to "all the girl excitement."

Plus, as even critics of the Kardashians will concede (it's become almost a mantra in the #discourse), they are great businesswomen, just like the Spice Girls. Heart Management did not formally "sign" the girls to a contract, even after moving them into the financier Chic Murphy's Maidenhead house for pop star training. Reflecting on the reasoning behind this miscalculation, Chris Herbert said, "I suppose it's that old school management thing where he [Murphy] wanted insecurity to play a part in it, so that they were always on their toes, always hungry for it, and had something to prove. Because if one of them had played up, he'd have one shipped out and shipped the next one in."

Belonging to a girl group traditionally came with such a peril. Writing of the aesthetic homogeneity so typical of the early groups—the Ronettes and

their stilettos and beehive bouffants, the Supremes and their sleek bobs and silk gloves, all the ladies always matching in dresses or gowns—Warwick argues that "the matching dresses worn by members of girl groups are like uniforms, erasing elements of individuality and humanity as they explicitly proclaim the wearer's membership in a group and discourage seeing her as unique." This dehumanizing "interchangeability" also encouraged the audience's parasocial attachment to the group. Warwick quotes the musicologist Cynthia Cyrus when she adds, "If there is little to distinguish one group member from another, then one has only to don the attributes of the group to belong to it."

Maybe this is why some studies have proven that social media consumers report a greater sense of well-being when they look at "groupies" (group photos) and far less of a sense when looking at solo selfies. Maybe we like to imagine ourselves belonging there, in the picture, surrounded by others, evading the loneliness that pervades new-media-saturated late capitalism. In a sense, we can observe a comparable grid-friendly uniformity from the Kardashians; with their matching facial symmetry and athleisure sweatsuits, they suggest that if you fill your face with hyaluronic acid and shape your silhouette with SKIMS, you, too, can feel like a Calabasas aristocrat whose ensemble of clone-like companions ensures you're never alone.

But the crucial difference between girl groups of yore and the Kardashians today is that the racially privileged, Instagram-age Kardashians were able to own the means of their image production, posting selfies and groupies to the feeds at their whims, existing as the sole financial beneficiaries of the resulting engagement. Kim even admitted to David Letterman in 2020 that she can make more money from a social media post than a whole season of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians*.

The Spice Girls, too, determined that they deserved greater ownership of their own labor. Two events incited this revelation: first, a successful 1994 studio showcase, where they discovered just how much buzz they were generating across the industry, and, second, the completion of their single "Wannabe" with Biff Stannard and Matt Rowe. With its jubilant "call and response" chorus, they realized they had a hit on their hands, one that could

make young women feel represented. In fact, the Spice Girls' competence when it came to both the creative process and the business of songwriting revealed how much they stood to gain by putting the band first. David Sinclair notes that they were active in most songwriting processes (to a degree that impressed the professionals they worked with: "I can attribute great moments on all those records to each one of them," recalled Matt Rowe. "I remember Mel B coming up with the 'Mama' concept. I remember Geri coming up with the lyrics for 'Viva Forever' "), yet they were not competitive about who got credit for which line, a wise mindset in an era when, partly due to the advent of illegal streaming, copyright royalties were becoming more and more important for artists than actual record sales. The perk of being a "manufactured" group was that there was an assumption of streamlined credit, without any one member being compensated more (a model previously associated with rock bands), and no Spice Girl allowed ego to disrupt such an empowered and egalitarian—and profitable—setup.

And so the girls executed a cinematic coup. "Geri and the two Mels went to the management offices," Sinclair writes, "and, by means that remain unclear to this day, managed to retrieve the master recordings of their songs. Victoria and Emma, meanwhile, went to Trinity Studios to collect various odds and ends belonging to the group. They met up at a roundabout outside of Maidenhead and took off." Sinclair suggests that this was an exemplary act of the girlboss-y ruthlessness that would make (and, later, break) them: After a year of being groomed, housed, and fed by Heart Management, the girls signed instead with Simon Fuller, the future creator of *Pop Idol* and *American Idol,* and became the chart-topping, Prince Charles's bum-pinching girl gang we know today. In 2020, Mel C told *Love* magazine about how they moved from the original plan to dress in uniform, as the old-school groups did, to their now-famous archetypes, which, it turns out, the media coined:

> When we used to rock up to rehearsals, you know, Geri would have some crazy outfit from the second-hand store and I'd be in a tracky and Emma would be in a baby doll dress and we were just like, one day…why don't we just wear what we wear as individuals? And we

> never thought too much more of it, and then, you know, the record came out, and it was *Top of the Pops* magazine that gave us our nicknames. It was just a silly little throwaway article one week, and they just stuck. What was really interesting about that was…whether it was on our appearance or the way we presented ourselves, you know, they were quite fitting, and we just embraced them…. We became caricatures of that thing and…maybe in a way it was like a protection mechanism because it was like putting on this armor of being this… character, rather than it actually being you, you know?

Of course, because so many girl groups were put together by men in the industry, they often endured abuses of power. When Ronnie Spector, the lead singer of the Ronettes, published her memoir, *Be My Baby,* the world learned of the horrific violence she suffered at the hands of Phil Spector, her husband and producer, who would later be convicted of killing the actress Lana Clarkson. *Spice World,* the absurdist 1997 fan-service film starring the girls (written by Simon Fuller's older brother, Kim), shows them in a ceaseless power struggle with their fictitious manager, who overworks them out of worry that they might lose their dominion over media. ("It was a sort of comic cynicism rather than clairvoyance," swore Fuller.) Not to mention the numerous implications of having been "made." "Girl group songs are clearly and unapologetically products of the recording studio," Warwick writes. "Many of the effects that characterize this music could not be created in the context of a concert; the crucial prominence of handclaps in a recording such as the Supremes' 1964 breakthrough 'Baby Love' could never carry in a live performance venue." This and other "examples of percussive sounds used in the rhythm tracks of girl group songs are among many instances of effects that are utterly dependent on a studio environment. In important ways, the production techniques of girl group records mirrors girls' experience in a culture that tries to confine them to safe, domestic spaces and hands them ready-made and obviously prefabricated experiences to make their own." In fact, most scenes in Kardashian reality TV episodes occur in the home, as Kim, the pretty one, Khloé, the funny one, Kourtney, the natural one, Kendall, the tomboy, and Kylie, the glamour girl, laze on luxury couches in

luxury wear, bemoaning their various miscommunications. It's sometimes easy to forget that even when they *do* venture to an exotic resort or some fashion or media event—or, of course, the medical office of someone tasked with enhancing their appearances—we are only watching them travel and transform on our screens. In a similar vein was the Spice Girls' installment in Chic Murphy's home for their rigorous year of preparation and subsequent public appearances for TV and photo ops before performing any live shows. Ensconced in controlled industry environments, they carried on a girl-group legacy of confinement to the studio and curated public mediation; even after they "made it," it would be several years before they put on their first concert, in Istanbul, Turkey.

Within these fabricated, studio-derived experiences, girls can play with archetypes, a term that the communications scholar Adriana Braga has traced through its Greek and Latin roots to Plato: "The word archetype derives from the Latin noun *archetypum,* which is an adaptation of the Greek word *archétypon,* which in the adjective form is *archétypos*. The word is formed from the verb *archein* (beginning, origin) and the noun *typos* (model, form). In ordinary language, the term means 'the original form.' In Philosophy, the term archetype was originally deployed in Plato's works with the meaning of 'the perfect example or ideal form.'" You might also think of the Swiss psychoanalyst Carl Jung when you hear the word; in 1953, he described archetypes as "unconscious images of the instincts themselves…patterns of instinctual behavior," and coined the now notorious term "collective unconscious," which he called a "deeper layer" of consciousness that is "more or less the same everywhere and in all individuals." By Jung's logic, Baby, Posh, Scary, Ginger, and Sporty resonate so much with us because their archetypes reflect deeper truths about human nature: Is there a Baby, Posh, Scary, Ginger, and Sporty within us all?

And why do we continue to fetishize these "forms," designating them, more and more, in our modern world, as valid identity categories? The French theorist Michel Foucault wrote, in *The Order of Things,* about how the "classical era" of history (from 1660 to the end of the nineteenth century) marked a shift in the way humans related to knowledge itself. History, he

explained, is made up of an ongoing iteration of "epistemes," or eras definable by the different ways humans relate to knowledge as history is made by the passage of time. Using natural history—our study of plants and animals—as an example, he wrote that our relationship to language, representation, and structure evolved with the advent of new observation technologies like microscopes, allowing us to "see things…systematically… by four variables: the form of the elements, the quality of those elements, the manner in which they are distributed in space in relation to each other, and the relative magnitude of each element." If time and progress have cultivated in us a reflex to think in terms of categories and "systems," then it kind of makes sense that in the 1960s Marshall McLuhan linked the archetype to the cliché and considered it—you guessed it—a "medium." By Platonic and Jungian logic, there's something intuitive about forms and archetypes, which only became more easily nameable, according to Foucault, once advances in how we organize information led us to view the world in a more orderly, designative way. And, eventually, some of those categories—the femme fatale, the good girl—would become so embedded in culture that we might start taking them for granted, as, according to McLuhan, either archetypes or clichés.

One view all these thinkers seem to share is that categorization makes the apparent chaos of the human condition more coherent—which is why the Spice Girls and the Kardashians are so savvy: They consolidated power as collectives while also fleshing out each member into a relatable category, reflecting the endless acceleration of media, which encourages even closer identification with the images and concepts we consume and provides an illusion of "choice" within a packaged offering. The pleasure, after all, of determining "which Spice Girl," "which Greek goddess," "which *Sex and the City* character," or "which Kardashian" you "are" was how *BuzzFeed* managed to tickle our egos and blow up so fast in 2013, starting with the virality of a quiz called "Which 'Grease' Pink Lady Are You?" and, within months, producing more personality-driven quizzes that earned up to twenty million monthly "hits." This is consistent with the findings of an early 1990s Mark and Pearson survey of fifty brands with either "tightly defined" or "confused"

archetypal identities. The brands "strongly aligned with a single archetype"—like a Brazilian beer brand that attached itself to the "jester" archetype—showed 97 percent market value added, and grew at a rate 66 percent greater than the "confused" ones over the course of six years. Analysts at Life Science Marketing concluded that "careful selection and maintenance of your brand-story's archetype promotes differentiation," which is, of course, the name of the game in any oversaturated marketplace—or public-facing ensemble, from girl groups to large reality TV families.

Like a *BuzzFeed* quiz or a niche Instagram persona, archetypes can be fun, colorful, and well ordered. In *Spice World,* the girls' archetypes are materially manifested as themed sections within their cartoonish tour bus, which we're introduced to right away by watching them bound on board and settle into their respective squares. It's tempting to compare the interior of the bus to a social media grid, where each member of the group inhabits a profile representative of her persona. Posh has a runway in her section, Sporty an exercise bike, Baby a swing set, and so on (and all these little worlds are unified by the vehicle's patriotic exterior, emblazoned with the Union Jack). Quickly, the girls jump into a debate about astrology, reducing one another's personalities to celestial clichés. Later, Mel B turns her gaze to her personal aquarium, pointing out which fish would be which Spice Girl (something Kris Jenner also does in a season 12 episode of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians,* when she and her partner Corey Gamble dine in an underwater restaurant, and she names the fish after her daughters based on how they swim). It goes without saying that the self is complicated and jumbled, and it can be comforting to find a premade label to stamp upon oneself. To meet this demand, the Kardashians and the Spice Girls are happy to supply.

The fun of *Spice World*—called by *Vice* in 2018 a "deranged postmodern masterpiece"—is that it's a composite of campy scenes depicting performances of identity. What would the Spice Girls be like as *moms*? Ginger would wear garish makeup and chain-smoke while complaining about being underappreciated by her kids; Sporty would toil on an exercise bike in a sweatsuit; and Scary would, apparently, be mixing food while wearing a traditional African sheath. What would they be like as *spies*? Baby would be

skilled at hand-to-hand combat while sucking on a lollipop, and Posh would wear tight silver minidresses and pose in front of luxury cars as the *Charlie's Angels* theme song plays. Such semiotics shape and exaggerate personae, reinforcing everything audiences are meant to understand about the girls, both compressing the pesky nuances of their personhoods and accelerating our understanding of all that we, the masses, really need to know about them—plus, provoking private inquiries about what "type" of girl the viewer is, or ought to be. (The Kardashian sisters have embraced the notion that "girls" are best viewed in terms of "types." In their 2010 memoir, *Kardashian Konfidential,* Khloé wrote, "Each of us has a particular personality from the show that people identify us with. For example, I'm the outrageous, feisty one." In 2016, Kim announced that she wasn't a "feminist or a 'free the nipple' type of girl." A few years later, in an interview with *Good Morning America,* she described herself as a "relationship kind of girl," and, in 2023, agreed with a *Kardashians* producer that she is a "lights-off kind of girl.")

In fact, the Spice Girls archetypes are so vivid and immutable that the girls were even able to embody cultural icons in a way that aligned with their existing shticks. Another *Spice World* scene shows the girls in a studio rebelling against a corny male photographer who is trying to control their looks and poses. They raid a nearby costume closet, and suddenly Geri is Marilyn Monroe in *The Seven Year Itch,* Posh is Jackie O with the pillbox hat, Scary Spice is Diana Ross, and Baby, Sporty, and Posh are Charlie's Angels, all characters that the Kardashians would one day also perform. The girls don't stop there. In the next scene, they've dressed up as one another, parodying each one's signature moves, with Sporty in a black minidress, mimicking Posh's strut, and Scary as Ginger, holding up the peace sign and saying, "Blah blah blah, girl power, feminist, know what I mean?" The Kardashians would do the same in 2019, when Kris had the "idea for…a team-building activity" in the form of a dinner party where Khloé, as Kris, donned a Versace-esque two-piece and sipped a martini, Kourtney dressed in all black and stuffed the ass of her sweatpants to embody Kim, and Kendall, playing Kylie, showed up in a pink wig, clutching lip kits to shill over their meal, and so on. In both cases, the women and their trusty archetypes

functioned as mediums, or living templates on which an archive of iconic images could be displayed—including their own.

Marshall McLuhan, collaborating with the Canadian poet Wilfred Watson, called archetypes and clichés "retrieval systems," because "the dominant technologies of one age become the games and pastimes of a later age." Basically? The passage of time can determine the relevance or utility of an archetype, and bringing a particular archetype to public awareness is an automatic reference to what Foucault might consider a former "episteme." "In the age of electronic retrieval," McLuhan wrote, "the entire phenomenal universe is at once junkyard and museum…. Every culture now rides on the back of every other culture." A 1970 *New York Times* review of McLuhan's book *From Cliché to Archetype* decodes McLuhan's theory this way: "Decades after the Victorian Novel became 'a hopeless cliché,' John Fowles made the best-seller lists by crafting a Victorian novel. The reason we pay for 'The French Lieutenant's Woman' instead of fetching a Victorian novel down from the attic is that John Fowles knows things about the Victorian Novel that Victorian novelists didn't know. His conscious attention—hence his book's show of psychological insight—is precisely on what his forerunners did unconsciously." So, when the Spice Girls and the Kar-Jenners dress up as one another, they're asserting their own cultural significance, and a consciousness of how their archetypes might be recalled in the future. McLuhan argues that clichés are so repetitive in culture that we've become "anesthetized" to them —even though they usually feed into our big-picture grasp of cultural archetypes. When we see Ginger as Marilyn (connected by their shared clichés of sleepy-eyed sexuality) or Khloé as Kris (connected by shared clichés of martini-sloshing campiness), we're confronted with, as McLuhan calls it, the "shock of recognition" that these images in their original forms had become cultural givens.

Once recognizable, these archetypes readily engage cultural consumers through questions not just of identification ("which one *are* you") but of preference ("which do you find most exciting to look at?"). The Spice Girls, joshing around in their colorful Spice Bus—a veritable simulacrum on wheels —exist as a pleasing compilation of *information* in what the media theorist P.

David Marshall has called a "presentational media culture." "Indeed," he writes, "one of the most prominent and powerful forms of click-bait on the Internet is to include one's information in a top five, ten, or twenty ranking. These forms of popular online communication are now called listicles." My point isn't even that there are *so many* listicles ranking the Kardashians or Spice Girls in terms of "value" (though there are). It's more that, in a culture where, as Marshall writes, the annual Fortune 500 list generates public conversation and attitudes, and where "similar efforts have been employed by *Rolling Stone* magazine to rank popular music albums, adding aesthetics to the efforts of *Billboard* magazine's sales-derived Top 100 format, or perhaps for a more contemporary feel, iTunes song downloads," we appreciate seeing information assembled and presented in a way that at least suggests the *option* to rank. Maybe this is the new media iteration of Foucault's classification-obsessed classical era.

Besides, the Spice Girls as a collective were tiered on the very *Billboard* chart that P. David Marshall referenced to make his point, because, whether haters liked it or not, the Spice Girls dominated the marketplace, exemplifying constructs of virality long before the term was common, generating the kinds of numbers that defined them as "global sensations," and paving the way for the day when the Kardashians could go viral *for being* viral.

In writing *Hit Makers: How to Succeed in an Age of Distraction,* Derek Thompson found that while *Billboard* has played a role in using data to legitimize music stars "every week…since 1958," its rankings didn't reflect objective reality. "The *Billboard* list has been built on lies, half-lies, and made-up statistics," he writes. For more than thirty years, accurately tracking radio stations' top-played songs and weekly record store album sales was a challenge. *Billboard* relied on the integrity of radio stations and store owners, but this system was often compromised, because music labels influenced DJs to promote specific records and labels aimed to quickly cycle songs and albums in and out of the charts to sell new hits. "You might say the twentieth-century music industry excelled in planned obsolescence," Thompson notes.

In 1991, *Billboard* abandoned this system, opting for point-of-sale data from cash registers.

Upon this systemic change (which also took in Nielsen ratings, with time), Thompson writes, two things happened: First, hip-hop emerged as a dominant musical genre on the charts. The real numbers revealed a public appetite for Black cultural products—evidence of the cultural capital that many critics believe the Kardashians have co-opted. Second, the winning songs also hung out in the "top 10" for several weeks at a time. The "real numbers" revealed that people tend to stick to their favorite songs for longer than the previous illusion of rapid turnover had indicated.

So, when, in the winter of 1997, the Spice Girls colonized the charts —"Wannabe" spent seven consecutive weeks on the U.K. singles chart, and four in the United States—data showed that the masses were not only listening but continuing to listen, again and again. "Rankings were like steroids for hits," Thompson writes. "People who could see them were more likely to download songs that were already popular. The mere existence of rankings—the simple signal of popularity—made the biggest hits even bigger…. Rankings created superstars, even when they lied."

Going viral for being viral or becoming famous for being famous is an aspiring star's best-case scenario in today's algorithmic attention economy. The Kardashians are known for relying on this model, like Kylie's announcement of her daughter's name on social media during the 2018 Super Bowl weekend, which broke Instagram's "most liked" records and generated headlines of its own, or via periodic, triumphant updates of SKIMS' ever-climbing billion-dollar-plus valuations, made for rebroadcast.

Nonetheless, the "self-made" star system of spectacle spinning, self-commodification, and self-promotion can evoke disgust in audiences (whose engagement, whether positive or negative, is essential to the sensationalizing of any public figure). Some people hated the Spice Girls because it began to feel as though they were "everywhere." David Sinclair wrote, "There was apparently no product of consumer interest, however mundane or embarrassing, that it was beyond their ingenuity to adapt to the girl power credo." By 1997, "their faces were on T-shirts, coffee cups, crash-hats, skates,

BT phonecards, watches, bomber jackets, posters, schoolbags, calendars, key-chains and pencil cases."

The Kardashians, whose image and narrative productions are often traceable to some either blatant or subliminal partnership, are similarly mocked or viewed with suspicion. In 2010, Kim provoked ridicule by partnering with Charmin toilet paper and posing with two giant Charmin bears in Times Square to launch the company's new public toilets; ten years later, eyebrows raised when the luxury fashion house Balenciaga seemed to be outfitting her hyper-mediatized divorce from Kanye West. In a 2016 episode of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians,* Kim and Kris Jenner reminisce on their notorious willingness to work with every opportunity that came their way. "All the things we would do," Kim said with a smile. "It's so wild."

"Well," Kris answered. "It's not like you could sing or dance. We made the best of it, and it got us to here." Let's be real: Kim was famous for *not* being able to sing and dance. Like the Spice Girls', her true talent was her ambition, and her ambition was to establish herself as the Hot One, the Hardworking One, the Everywoman. Belonging to a female collective, individually differentiated by archetype, primes girl groups to *sell* products—because, in a sense, they earned their place in the public eye by *existing as* products. Just as Jackie O, America's valorized housewife, was at once the curator of prized objects in the White House *and,* herself, one of its prized objects, the Spice Girls and the Kardashians—so easily manufacturable into doll form—are at once commodities *and* purveyors of commodities. Maybe this is why people hated both girl groups: They skipped straight to the point, shedding light on the crass truth that most of this supposedly sacred art making is *just business, baby*.

"By June 1997, it was reported that the Spice Girls had applied for more than 100 trademarks," Sinclair notes, and quotes a contemporary article from the *Daily Express:* "They are proving ruthlessly determined to exploit the merchandising possibilities of their fame. If you thought their confessed admiration for Thatcherism was just a bit of showbiz PR, think again."

The reference to Thatcherism stemmed from a 1996 "gotcha" interview in *The Spectator,* titled "Spice Girls Back Sceptics on Europe." The interviewer,

Simon Sebag Montefiore, plied them with highbrow political questions, intending to "caricature" the girls as "a bunch of celebrity airheads sounding off on subjects far beyond their areas of competence." The issue was *The Spectator*'s best selling in its two-hundred-year history. Geri offered a punch line—and gold mine—to the piece when she confessed to admiring Margaret Thatcher, the former prime minister of England, calling Thatcher "the first Spice Girl, the pioneer of our ideology." This was met with some public outcry in the U.K. Sinclair reminds us that while there's an "almost universal tendency for pop stars to lean politically to the left," they "operate in one of the most viciously competitive arenas the capitalist system has ever devised. While espousing egalitarian ideals, even the most politically committed entertainers are part of a rigorously selected elite." In this sense, Sinclair argues, unlike most other pop stars, by aligning with the capitalistic Tory Party, the Spice Girls "owned" what they "were," paving the way for Kim Kardashian to admit to Bari Weiss in 2021 that politically she's a "mix of both [parties]," saying, "I believe in the rights that the Democrats want, but I believe in the taxes that the Republicans want."

That increasingly visible women in power pledge allegiance to the Establishment has become a new-millennium feminist cliché, taking shape in the cultural meme known as the girlboss. In her 2020 essay, "The End of the Girlboss Is Here," Leigh Stein traces the origin of the archetype to 2013, when Facebook's COO, Sheryl Sandberg, published *Lean In,* her best-selling manifesto exhorting young female professionals to office leadership. It presented "gender disparities in the workplace as a war to be fought on a personal level," Stein explains. "Sandberg allowed women to feel like they were activists whenever they advocated for themselves." Next came Sophia Amoruso's memoir, *#Girlboss,* which detailed the "rags-to-riches story" of her e-commerce brand, Nasty Gal, and public-image construction into one of *Business Insider*'s "sexiest CEOs alive." Social media, Stein points out, was supporting the girlboss in new ways: "Millennials weren't buying $18 lipsticks at department store beauty counters? Sell them $18 lipsticks on Instagram. The ascendancy of the girlboss entrepreneur coincided with the growth of direct-to-consumer brands, which spent a gazillion dollars on targeted social

advertising to meet their customers where they're at—scrolling." (A business model that, once again, relies on women being idle, inside the home.) After that, Stein writes, came Hillary Clinton's 2016 presidential run, and the opening in several major cities of the Wing, a members-only, women-only co-working space founded by Audrey Gelman, notorious for its designer bathroom products and luxe, girlie decor. Finally came the 2017 rise of the #metoo movement, when women in Hollywood began exposing the systemic sexual exploitation they'd been subjected to for generations, a historic social-media-driven revolution that nevertheless shed most of its light on upwardly mobile women in the public eye. Quoting Jessa Crispin, Stein argues that "when you make feminism so accessible and palatable it can be universally adopted, you put the 'focus on labels and identity, rather than on the philosophical and political content of the movement, [and] what becomes most important are the things on the surface.' Things like Chanel products, velvet chairs, and pretty websites." It tracks, then, that some of the greatest girlbosses of our time, including Kim Kardashian, Beyoncé, and *Barbie*-era Margot Robbie, have all cited the Spice Girls' influence on their feminist consciousness—which we may understand as their brand development. When we're feeling a little less cynical, we might say that the Spice Girls' Girl Power took the worthy concept of "female self-love and solidarity," aestheticized it, and extrapolated it to a global scale, perhaps doing some good, but also sacrificing its political spirit in the process.

A 2016 article for *Vice* by Jenny Stevens explores "how the Spice Girls ripped 'girl power' from its radical roots." The Riot Grrrl movement, which lasted from around 1991 to 1996, originated in the Pacific Northwest and the Northeast and was "developed in part as a reaction against increasingly anti-women facets in the DC punk scene—in part as a way to drag to light the hidden horrors of sexual abuse, but also simply the frustration of being shut out, degraded, mocked, and laughed at for being a girl trying to make music." The bands were classified by their growling punk sound, colorful emphasis on DIY media production (like zines), and frequent subversion of stereotypically "girlie" fashion aesthetics: miniskirts, pigtails, and T-shirts emblazoned with cartoons. There were no real performances of archetypes, but rather a punk

version of the 1950s and 1960s girl groups' uniformity. Some music scholars credit the future Spice Girls interviewer Kathy Acker with igniting the movement; she had advised the aspiring artist-activist and future Bikini Kill front woman Kathleen Hanna to join a band because "nobody goes to spoken word, but people go to see bands."

Here's the thing. The Riot Grrrl movement put special emphasis on real-life *space*. As Nyala Ali writes, "In the late 1980s, all-female subcultures were still very much restricted to the private spaces of the home, reflecting the notion of 'bedroom culture.'" But Riot Grrrl shows allowed female music fans to relate to space in new ways. Bikini Kill's Kathleen Hanna was known for stopping shows to yell "girls to the front," commanding the guys in the crowd to yield to their fellow fans. While planning the second issue of their fanzine, Hanna and her drummer, Tobi Vail, began to brainstorm the word that felt wrongest next to "girl." "We came up with 'power.'" This would be the title of the issue.

But when Stevens interviewed Ginger Spice for *Vice,* Geri claimed ignorance of the American Riot Grrrl movement or Bikini Kill. Her notion of Girl Power had come from another girl band, Shampoo, an English duo who, much like the Riot Grrrls, "dressed like a pastiche of candy-pink girlhood," were known to trash their hotel rooms like notorious male rock bands, and had released an album called *Girl Power* in 1996.

I don't intend to level these two girl groups against each other, which would be replicating the very media legacy of false binaries and constructed rivalries we explored in the last chapter, nor to overly idealize the Riot Grrrls. What interests me more is the seemingly parallel systems at play of global scale and on-the-ground community. The thing to keep in mind about the Riot Grrrls was that ideals like "girls to the front" had real-life, measurable impact, compared with the symbolic, mass-mediated function of Girl Power. In other words, it encouraged a material and immediate political action: *If there are girls in the room at this moment, let's prioritize their well-being.* A rallying cry like that—focused on the indisputable physical hazards faced by women—has the potential to transform, if not the world, then at least a scene or neighborhood or local community. It might not be possible to escalate such

urgent messaging to a global level, across mass media, as the Spice Girls did with their cry of "Girl Power." (And would you be allowed to profit if you did?) The politics of their message had more to do with resisting broad, conceptual social scripts—what Leigh Stein meant when she said the white millennial #girlboss "saw gender inequity everywhere she looked," which "gave her something to wage war against." And when we consider the Kardashians' connections to the Riot Grrrls, well, the closest link I could find was again by way of spectacle and commerce: In 2016, after Nasty Gal released an eighteen-piece collaboration with the controversial 1990s grunge goddess Courtney Love, Kim tweeted that she was "kinda obsessed" with the collection, to which Sophia and Courtney tweet-replied with adulations. In 2019, Love told *Interview* that she was "ensorcelled" by the "Venusian fertility cult in the valley" that was the Kardashians.

Does it matter whether the Kardashians' and the Spice Girls' Girl Power makes a feminist difference or is just a cynical, demographic-pandering cash grab? Did the Spice Girls deserve to deteriorate, as they finally did by the new millennium? I'm often asked, in my own studies of the Kardashians, what it would take for their cult to collapse. After all, most girlbosses crash and burn after flying too close to the sun. Trump beat Hillary in 2016; Nasty Gal went bankrupt in 2017 and was sold to Boohoo.com (where Kourtney Kardashian would later sign on as "sustainability ambassador"); the Wing shuttered during the COVID-19 pandemic amid accusations of racism and sexism. Good riddance, right? These women had failed to help the rest of their kind. Stein explains it this way: "The rise and fall of the girlboss says more about how comfortable we've become mixing capitalism with social justice, as we look to corporations to implement social changes because we've lost faith in our public institutions to do so." It's true. A 2024 study by Deloitte revealed that 72 percent of Gen Z "believe that companies should be more actively involved in creating social change." Sounds good in theory, but does this perception of what companies exist to do just reinforce the notion that they ought to represent us at all? In this sense, the Spice Girls and the Kardashians have let women down not only because, as Stein points out, "women are held to account for how ethical and virtuous they are as leaders in a way that men

are not," but also because massive capitalist projects are now somehow supposed to reflect our ideological and political allegiances, a catch-22 perhaps best exemplified by the success of 2023's *Barbie* movie, which was a glorified commercial for the Mattel brand filled with self-referential winks about how Barbie is both "everything wrong with our culture…a fascist" and a useful object onto which girls and women can project their aspirational fantasies. The discourse *Barbie* generated in advance of its release—*is Barbie feminist or anti-feminist?*—only contributed to its virality, and the blockbuster grossed $162 million on its opening weekend. No matter the amount of criticism leveled at the doll, Barbie can't be "canceled," and we're left with few options but to be glad that a female director finally broke some records for making clever points about the unresolvable condition of women in this world, all the while enriching Mattel and ensuring Barbie's posterity as a representation of white-feminist empowerment.

It was two events that incited the end of the Spice Girls, which might help us conceive of what it would take to topple the Kardashians: their abrupt termination of Simon Fuller's management contract, and Ginger Spice's departure from the band.

Despite the countless celebrity cameos seen in the *Spice Girls* movie, from Elton John to Roger Moore, which amplified the girls' social capital in relation to other stars in a controlled setting, Simon Fuller preferred to keep them siloed from fellow celebs in real life. (Kind of, one might muse, like collector's-item Barbies not allowed to leave their packaging or the dismay some people express when Kim Kardashian dares to transcend her domain as a homebound reality TV star and makes appearances at the White House as an activist or as an actress in shows like *American Horror Story*.) On arrival at the MTV Europe Music Awards in 1997, they discovered that he'd booked them in a "different hotel from all the other stars on the show." Coupled with Fuller's recent refusal to grant Geri some time off, they were ready to reclaim their power. That night, the girls decided to sack Fuller, who was recovering from back surgery in Italy. The next morning, his lawyers heard from theirs.

The Scotland *Herald* reported the news this way: "The pop guru, who catapulted the group to fame…was fired in a move masterminded by Ginger

Spice Geri Halliwell…. Fuller, 36, has reportedly netted the girls $4m from merchandising deals and is credited with promoting their five number one hits." This coverage, emphasizing Fuller's role in making them what they were, is exemplary of the barrage of backlash that followed. Bad press was one thing the Spice Girls had not bargained for in letting go of Fuller, who had always leveraged his collaborator, the attorney Gerrard Tyrrell, to manage their media coverage by using "a mixture of charm, persuasion, threats, and coercion." Tyrrell moderated the kind of mutually beneficial relationship with the press that many suspect Kris Jenner of facilitating with today's tabloid media, for instance, arranging a $1.5 million exclusive with *People* for Kim Kardashian's 2011 wedding to Kris Humphries and ensuring a steady flow of soft-scandal headlines in most major media outlets. Now, "without Tyrrell breathing down their necks," Sinclair wrote, gossip rags "were free at last to make up for lost time." Victoria openly wondered whether they were being punished for letting go one of the few significant men in their world. "The thing about the media is that it's a very male-dominated industry," she said at the time. "A lot of men…liked the fact that they thought a man was behind the Spice Girls. And they don't like that now it's the five girls taking control."

Here's where the Kardashians have an advantage over the Spice Girls. The most significant man in their self-styled mythology is the girls' late father, Robert Kardashian, who is absent, but whose memory they are still able to invoke whenever necessary by visiting his grave, or inviting a psychic medium on to their reality show, or through high-tech holograms of his image. Audiences have been primed from the start to view Kris Jenner as her daughters' Simon Fuller, sharing memes about how "the devil works hard but Kris Jenner works harder" and social media comedy sketches by the impersonator Benito Skinner, known as Benny Drama, who covers himself in red body paint to depict her as Satan incarnate. These jokes don't harm the Kardashians, who instead reappropriate them for their own publicity: Kris has cameoed in Benny's sketches, and in 2020 he even appeared on an episode of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians*. Kanye West was essential to the family's myth, it's true, and they seem to have anticipated the damage that his divorce

from Kim might do to the brand by dedicating ample screen time throughout 2021 to Kim's admissions that she'd "be nowhere without Kanye" and her expressions of trepidation about how she'd dress without his style guidance. Over the course of their breakup, however, Kanye's outbursts established him as more media liability than asset: here, publicly harassing a Black *Vogue* editor on social media after Paris Fashion Week; there, declaring on Alex Jones's podcast that he loved Hitler. Though the Kardashians thrive on bad press, attachment to Kanye's media cycles likely would have wound up doing more harm than good, only further proving the point that the Kardashian matriarchy is at its best when women run the show.

As for the Spice Girls, the absence of Tyrrell and Fuller led to some PR woes, but the real nail in the coffin was Geri's dramatic departure, which, to this day, remains mostly a matter of speculation. One can assume it had to do with preexisting group dynamics compounded by the rise in external pressure. Many of Sinclair's interviewees in the industry agreed that Geri, the group's self-appointed leader, often took the most heat when the girls were under stress. Robert Sandall, former director of press for Virgin Records, said a *Big* magazine picture was worth a thousand words: "There was some big bust-up between Geri and the rest of them…. The Girls are sitting on a staircase at the top of a tower block, and there are four of them sitting together, all very lovey-dovey, and Geri at the end sitting on her own, looking glum. You can just tell that there was this big friction. It's a very graphic image of the way things were going." In May 1998, Geri announced to the girls, via their longtime lawyer, her plan to leave the band. According to Victoria's memoir, they didn't believe it right away—but, sure enough, Geri pulled out of the European tour they'd been on for months, forcing their record label, Virgin, to announce that she was suffering from "nervous exhaustion."

Meanwhile, the Kardashians have even turned their closest approximation to such a threat—an inner circle defection—into yet more content. In 2020, Kim and Kourtney threw real punches at each other in a disagreement about work ethic (Kourtney wanted to "focus on being a mom," and Kim wanted to see more participation from her older sister in the family business). Their tension would resurface again and again over the course of the show's

following seasons, culminating in a season 4 storyline that featured a tug-of-war between the two of them over a Dolce & Gabbana partnership. "My sister used my wedding as a business opportunity," Kourtney fumed, after Kim signed a deal with the luxury fashion house that had "hosted" Kourtney's nuptials to the drummer Travis Barker in Italy only a few months before. Kourtney's sound bite was featured in the season trailer. A *Daily Mail* headline a few months later read, "Kourtney Kardashian's Family 'Fears She Will QUIT Their Reality Show After She Welcomes Her Fourth Child as She Plans to Scale Back Her Work amid Tensions with Her Sister Kim.'" Somehow, though, Kourtney never actually leaves the show. It's as though the Kardashians shield themselves from the typical girlboss perils by selling their potential weaknesses along with everything else.

After Geri left, the Spice Girls did their best to carry on as a foursome—with each releasing singles, bidding at their own solo star potential—but it didn't quite work. Sure, each of them saw some songs make it to the *Billboard* charts, but they seldom lingered for long, and sometimes their releases competed with one another. In 2000, the remaining four released an album called *Forever,* and it lost a battle for the top U.K. *Billboard* spot to Westlife's *Coast to Coast.* The album wasn't ultimately a flop—it spent ten weeks on the U.K. Albums Chart—but the end was near. Victoria had married the soccer star David Beckham, and Mel B gave birth to her first child. Fan engagement was fading. The music executive Ray Cooper put it this way: "I think it may well have hurt their younger fan base when Geri left, because I don't think they could quite understand why individuals leave groups."

The end of the Spice Girls did not herald the end of girls in groups as a media concept, however. A show called *Sex and the City* had hit HBO, a channel with a subscription-based business model that prioritized narrative over metrics. The show, slated between *The Sopranos* and *Six Feet Under,* was a "bright pop of hot pink in the middle of HBO's gritty, dark, predominantly male lineup," as the TV historian Jennifer Keishin Armstrong puts it, and followed the sexual misadventures and Socratic brunch-time dialogues of Charlotte, the Romantic One, Miranda, the Serious One, Samantha, the Sexy

One, and their more integrated figurehead, Carrie, played by the *Vogue* cover darling Sarah Jessica Parker. Again, female viewers were prompted to identify which one they "were" from the ensemble, and could observe what kinds of men and bags went best with their chosen persona, and witness interactions between differentiated archetypes as the Sexy One and the Serious One debated whether it was self-exploitation to accept money from men after sex. As with the girl groups of yesteryear, and the Spice Girls in the early noughties, the *Sex and the City* ladies were better together. In the first week of their premier season, the show was watched by 3.8 million people, and more than 10 million tuned in to its final episode six years later. "Maybe we can be each other's soulmates, and then we could just let men be these great, nice guys to have fun with," Charlotte, played by Kristin Davis, said in season 4. Rumors had it, though, that the show ended in part due to a longtime feud between Parker and her costar Kim Cattrall, who played the beloved, campy Samantha and, at one point, called Parker a "hypocrite" only interested in sustaining her "nice girl persona." When the show returned to HBO in 2021—this time, sans Cattrall—audiences made such fervent demands to see her return that in season 2 of the revival Samantha was written into a ten-second scene, offering such obvious fan service that the fourth wall might as well have shattered. For a fleeting moment, the girl group was complete, all its archetypes restored to their proper equilibrium. A few months later, Cattrall was featured, solo, in a SKIMS ad.

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7. PARIS HILTON

Social capital, underdogs, and tabloid culture

Kim K Confesses: "Paris Literally Gave Me a Career!"

We all know it—if only from the photoshopped memes of Kim Kardashian rubbing her feet: Paris Hilton, the "famous for being famous" hotel heiress whose bone-thin, bleached-blond, mean-girl image defined pop culture in the early '00s, led the charge for Kim's eventual decade-plus reign over American culture. Kim admitted it herself during a forty-five-second appearance in the 2020 documentary *This Is Paris:* "Paris really started that movement of having paparazzi follow your every move. I wouldn't be here today if it hadn't been for, number one, her starting off in the reality world, and her introducing me to the world. The best advice that she ever could've given me was just watching her." The American sociologist Thorstein Veblen explained the power of association another way in his seminal 1899 work, *The Theory of the Leisure Class:* "Those who stand near the higher…grades of the wealthy leisure class, in point of birth, or in point of wealth, or both, outrank the remoter-born and the pecuniarily weaker. These lower grades, especially the impecunious, or marginal, gentlemen of leisure, affiliate themselves by a system of dependence or fealty to the great ones; by so doing they gain an increment of repute, or of the means with which to lead a life of leisure, from their patron."

We can guess, then, that Kim was watching when, in 2006, for the millionth time, paparazzi photographers surrounded Paris Hilton, Britney Spears, and Lindsay Lohan as they rushed into a car after an event at the Beverly Hills Hotel. "Paris, did you really hit Lindsay?" asks one of the paps, referring to a dramatic claim made by Lohan earlier in the day. This was the era of the movie blockbuster *Mean Girls,* itself based on *Queen Bees and Wannabes,* a 2002 book written by Rosalind Wiseman about the

psychological costs of aggression between teen girls. The book described the cliques that they were liable to fall into—school cafeterias were, apparently, simulacra teeming with toxic archetypes: Queen Bees, Wannabes, Targets, Bystanders—and it wasn't hard to see that pop culture was playing out and broadcasting similar roles. Paris was a Queen Bee, Lindsay a Wannabe (and sometimes a Target), and Britney an obvious Bystander in a media landscape that had proven, if the spectacle of the O.J. trial and the success of the Spice Girls were any indication, that audiences were addicted to scandal, tended to project their identities onto the public figures they watched, and especially enjoyed keeping up with archetypal girls in groups. Kim wasn't present this evening, though, because, at this stage, she was largely a nonfactor. Of course, in retrospectives of this era, Paris and Kim would often be remembered as dialectical, inseparable best friends—the "ebony and ivory of socialites," as *Harper's Bazaar* wrote in 2011—but while Kim was sometimes around as a supporting character in Paris's public appearances and reality show, *The Simple Life,* she was mostly a second-rung wannabe who smiled too hard whenever she made it into Paris's frame and got pushed out of the way if a fan wanted a shot with the real star.

At the time, the luminous resulting photograph of the Britney-Lindsay-Paris girl group—packed together in the front seat of Paris's car—was dubbed in a *New York Post* headline the "Bimbo Summit." Today, in allegiance to the pervasive and (debatably) subversive impulse to venerate pop culture's more inane moments, fans have titled it the "Holy Trinity"—a name validated by Hilton in 2023 upon posting the shot to Instagram with the caption, "17 years ago…History was made. The 'Holy Trinity' #ThatsHot," topped off by a Bratz doll re-creation as a final slide, reminding us that it was a tableau worthy of being reproduced and reinterpreted (which it has been, in Halloween costumes, drag shows, and TikTok reenactments).

In *Celebrity: A History of Fame,* the communications scholars Susan J. Douglas and Andrea McDonnell determined that "in the first half of 2005 alone, *Us Weekly*'s paid circulation increased 24 percent to 1.7 million, and the *Star*'s increased 21 percent to 1.4 million, while *People* led the pack at 3.7 million…. Entertainment or celebrity news consumed more space in

magazines than any other topic." With such an increase in demand, Neal Gabler writes, "The media supplied. But as the demand for celebrities kept growing beyond the capacity of the finite number of movie stars, singers, athletes and other conventional entertainers to satisfy it, the media had to find or create new figures." This would be where the public nature of Paris's nightclub-oriented lifestyle proved useful, providing photos and dramas—content—for an expanding new medium in hyperproduction mode. When we think of celebrity today, it's thanks in large part to this time that we think of flashing camera lights and aggrieved starlets, even though these days media's most notorious names are not necessarily being pursued by hordes of paparazzi but being captured by sneaky phone videos—or opting to skip the pleas for privacy altogether and post themselves directly to the feed.

Tabloids: Old News Made Modern!

O. J. Simpson's 1995 murder trial had already uncovered the intensifying love affair between news media and spectacle, though it would not be accurate to claim that the decade between the mid-1990s and the mid-'00s marked the genesis of the tabloid. Before that, during the Old Hollywood era, magazines like *Photoplay* and *Modern Screen* profiled the studio-made stars of the 1930s and 1940s so that fans could feel closer to their glamorous idols. Plus, throughout the nineteenth century into the twentieth, coinciding with the arrival of more than eleven million immigrants in American cities, we had the "penny press," newspapers that cost—you guessed it—only a penny and targeted working-class readers with booming headlines about sex scandals, violent crime, and dramatic legal trials (reminding us, yet again, that Freud was indeed on to something: Humans are drawn to sex and death, and such narratives can prove cathartic). When the publisher William Randolph Hearst—and his archrival, Joseph Pulitzer—hit the scene in the 1890s, newspapers' pages were also increasingly filled with eye-catching photos, and were renamed the yellow press after a cartoon character called the Yellow Kid, who was featured in both competing publications. This transformed the print medium, Neal Gabler writes, into a form of "visual entertainment." Previously, popular culture was not so much by and for the people as a

sampling of what the elites had deemed acceptable for the masses and was usually dosed with messaging about morality. Gabler cites the American studies pioneer Henry Nash Smith on the function of novels in the nineteenth century: to "present images of beauty and nobility in order to inspire emulation" and to "offer readers opportunities to identify themselves with virtuous and attractive characters." As cultural production methods evolved—and dime novel publishers, movie studios, and newspaper presses proliferated—access to entertainment democratized, inducing "reactions by exciting the nervous system much in the same way drugs did." These sensationalist papers, then, beaming with violent delights, felt like a middle finger to the stuffy elites.

Paris Hilton, a distant, decadent descendant of the "famous for being famous" Old Hollywood–era socialite Zsa Zsa Gabor, was perfect for such a visual medium, which, Gabler adds, used "pictures…as symbols, a kind of self-contained shorthand that frequently didn't even require accompanying text, other than a caption." Hilton, a hybrid of socialite and celebrity, is what the 1930s gossip columnist Walter Winchell would have called a "celebutante," and she popularized an alternative celebrity archetype to the movie and TV stars whose mainstays remained the big and small screens. Don't get me wrong: In Paris's heyday, tabloids still loved traditional stars—Douglas and McDonnell have argued that the presence of mega movie stars like Brad Pitt, Jennifer Aniston, and Angelina Jolie on tabloid covers provided fans an invaluable sense of access to celebrity lives as appetites for closeness increased with the acceleration of media—but, as a celebutante, Paris had the freedom to bring something fresh to the form. Her sort-of grand-aunt, Zsa Zsa Gabor, once wrote about her youthful revelation that life could be lived like a "play within a play, in which I was always the heroine, waiting for the prince to awaken me with a kiss." In this sense, the celebutante is at once relatable and aspirational. Her self-concept was influenced by the media, like all of ours, yet she was also endowed with the unrelatable means to actualize as an agent in its machinations. With this unique positionality comes a unique relationship with cameras. During outings, certain to be photographed, Hilton often wore what Fox News called

“tabloid shirts”: Her chest bore messages like “Team Jolie,” “Don’t Be Jealous,” “Rich,” and “Stop Being Desperate.”

Behind the Bentley: The Secrets of Paris Hilton’s Elite Lifestyle!

Yes, Hilton is rich, a fact—and personal brand—invoked today anytime people align themselves with the elite by tweeting sniffy comments to the effect of “Remember when Kim Kardashian was Paris Hilton’s *maid*?” A 2004 study found that “status” is the “main motivational force that drives interest in reality television,” and people “who are motivated by status have an above-average need to feel self-important.” Another common motivator of reality TV consumption was “vengeance,” associated with the “enjoyment of competition.” It’s a little like the twentieth-century turn Gabler wrote about—when middle-class readers “demonstrate[d] their superiority” to the “presumably moronic” readers of the yellow presses by subscribing to the far more respectable *New York Times.* Even then, readers seemed to understand that media was on some level a spectacle in which engagement equaled allegiance.

And so it is with fandom. Set in contrast to Kim, Paris came off as “old money,” entitled to her decadence (you’ll see it again and again on the “Pop Culture Chat” Reddit channel, where users muse about how Paris “didnt NEED it [fame], she just did it for funnsies. also, old money like that doesnt like the kind of press that this kind of celebrity brings”). Meanwhile, Kim, darker in her features, curvaceous, and more desperate to be noticed, suggested the stench of “new money,” straining against the command of one of Paris’s most iconic tabloid shirts. Sometimes I wonder whether it’s a secondhand superiority boost that these tweeters are chasing when they voice allegiances to figureheads of a class system that cares about them least of all.

In truth, though, both women were “new” to generational wealth. According to anthropologists like W. Lloyd Warner, “old money” is applicable only to family money that dates back centuries—like that of the Astors, or the Rothschilds, or Jackie O’s family, the Bouviers—and there are even more specific distinctions between “old” and “new” related to which

industries had furnished a family with wealth (and whether it originated before the American Revolution).

Plus, in 1979, Paris's great-grandfather Conrad left most of his hotel fortune to charity, writing in his will that "there is a natural law, a Divine law, that obliges you and me to relieve the suffering, the distressed and the destitute," and requesting that "as the funds…have come from many places in the world…there be no territorial, religious, or color restrictions on your benefactions." Unfortunately for Paris, the Bush era was a time when it was cool to be real-deal rich, especially in contrast to pals like Lindsay and Britney, whose obvious struggles to adjust to their own even more recent wealth made for tabloid punch lines. Fortunately for her, the French sociologist Pierre Bourdieu has written that additional forms of capital exist beyond the "economic capital" that comes to mind when we think of rich people and the big numbers in their bank accounts, and she was able to make the most of them:

1. **Social Capital:** In *This Is Paris,* Paris showed off her childhood family photos with the Reagans (who notoriously waltzed the line between politics and entertainment). Integral to her public image was the number of icons in her known network, from the old-school celebs her parents and grandparents hung out with, to her party buddies, other "nepo babies," and the top pop stars of the time. But it's not only about what it *looks* like to be friends with big names. It's the fact that big names beget big things, from enough contacts in the entertainment business to begin developing, say, a reality TV show, as Paris Hilton did in 2003, to having easy access to the most coveted defense attorneys in the game whenever you run into trouble with the law, as she did in 2006 and 2010.
2. **Economic Capital:** Let's be real. Conrad Hilton might have abdicated much of his fortune to charity, but rich people are seldom left without a cushion. Paris's father, Richard, leveraged his own modes of capital to establish a real estate investment firm in the 1980s, and developed a suspected net worth in the hundreds of millions. Paris had enough cash to buy stuff that set her apart from average Americans—from sparkly lap

dog adornments to designer purses and expensive cars. This also enabled what Thorstein Veblen coined "conspicuous consumption," best defined by the *Stars* author, Richard Dyer, as "the way by which the wealthy display the fact that they are wealthy."

3. **Cultural Capital:** Bentley, the luxury car brand, became Paris's recurring device for displays of conspicuous consumption, and it could also be seen as a signifier of cultural capital, which Bourdieu called familiarity with "legitimate culture" within a society. Cultural capital meant access to elite schools and clubs, leading to an understanding of *how* rich people talk to each other and carry themselves, and insight into the kinds of things they like to talk about, think about, and buy. Rich people *do* seem to prefer six-figure cars with century-old heritage, so, in 2005, Paris was featured in a Carl's Jr. Super Bowl commercial washing a Bentley while wearing a bikini and dripping in diamonds. Yes, Paris was technically "new money," but as far as the hierarchy of old to new goes, the rest of Hollywood, a postindustrial business, was even fresher. Hasn't a hotel heiress more right to dance up on a Bentley than the latest actress discovered in some mall? Soon enough, Paris would buy herself a bright pink Bentley and pose with it for several magazine spreads. (Which, according to *Forbes,* incited in the company some amount of hand-wringing: "While Hilton is appropriately young, rich and well-connected, she's not exactly a cover girl for class." Bentley tried to pivot by investing in campaigns with "cool folks like Carine Roitfeld, former editor of *Vogue Paris;* the polo player–model Nacho Figueras; and Peter Brant, an art connoisseur. Not a Hilton type among them.")
4. **Symbolic Capital:** Which words do audiences associate with Paris? "Hilton," for one. "Heiress," for another. As she wrote in her 2004 book, *Confessions of an Heiress,* the best way to be like Paris Hilton is to be "born into the right family." The cultural capital this birthright afforded her—access to private schools and etiquette training, exposure to the highbrow norms of upper Manhattan circles—also funneled into the broader concept of symbolic capital, what Bourdieu called "acquisition of a reputation for competence and an image of respectability and

honourability that are easily converted into political positions as a local or national notable." Basically? This form of capital is where we, the audience, factor in. We know she's an heiress (which most of us are not), and we have ideas—most of them media fed—about what it means to be one.

All this capital adds up in Hilton's 2003 reality show. She was already a pro at documenting her own life; after all, she later claimed to have invented the selfie. *The Simple Life* was inspired by a 1960s sitcom called *Green Acres,* which followed a posh New York City couple (the wife was played by Zsa Zsa's sister Eva Gabor) who move to the country and struggle to adjust. *The Simple Life* follows Paris as she and her best friend, Nicole, Lionel Richie's daughter, move to Altus, Arkansas, a predominantly white, low-income city with fewer than a thousand residents, to work at burger shops and farms, all the while expressing alternating puzzlement over and ridicule for the conditions of working-class life. New money shines extra bright when contrasted with real poverty, and though the scene recalled most often today is the one in which Paris asks her host family what Walmart is, another exemplary moment is when she tells Nicole that Laundromats are places where "people who can't afford washing machines go to clean their clothes." Such absurdity can sometimes convert into a kind of camp aesthetic that collapses the "highbrow" and the "everyday," which the Kardashians would one day treat as a prescriptive formula, like in season 15 of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* when the self-appointed culture aficionado Kris Jenner "art shames" her daughter Khloé for not knowing who the contemporary artist Jeff Koons is (for which Scott Disick later humbles *her* by orchestrating a *Seinfeld*-inspired art world prank that would expose her own ignorance). Just think of *The Simple Life*'s promotional imagery: Paris and Nicole with their perfect blond coifs, unsmilingly wielding a digging fork and a Chihuahua in an emulation of Grant Wood's *American Gothic.*

You could argue that *The Simple Life* was about the worsening Bush-era wealth gap, which is what Cassidy George gets at in a 2018 *i-D* article: "The show maintains this unique ability to fascinate its viewers from both ends of the spectrum—rural and/or conservative folk gawk at rich nihilism, while

affluent and/or urban folk gawk at pastoral traditionalism." But if TV representations existed for the masses to identify with, then who was it that audiences related to more: the rich girls or the Walmart shoppers? Though correlation has been proven to exist between poverty and higher rates of TV watching, media historians tend to agree that most TV programming is geared toward the middle class, which, according to the social science think tank RAND, constitutes about 50 percent of the country and fits into the empty space between the two extremes depicted on *The Simple Life.* One thing is for sure: The show was edited from the vantage point of the decadent ones, and its 2003 premiere was watched by 13 million people, most of whom surely occupied a different tax bracket from the show's stars. These ratings pointed to how engaging pop culture could be, especially when it reflected cultural anxieties. They also proved that pop culture could often trump politics in holding the attention of the masses. In 2003, *The New York Times* reported on the Nielsen ratings of a *Simple Life* episode showing Paris "baking pies and working the town fair's kissing booth in a miniskirt," which earned 800,000 more viewers than the 11 million brought in by Diane Sawyer's *Primetime* interview with George Bush, whose military had recently captured Saddam Hussein.

War Overseas and Hollywood Disease! Will America Ever Know Peace?

Indeed, the Bimbo Summit had happened during wartime. The United States invaded Iraq in 2003, seeking "weapons of mass destruction," and to find and kill Saddam Hussein and replace his dictatorship with democracy. When it turned out that there were no weapons to find (only oil), the war became more and more divisive, with Republicans and Democrats battling it out on TV and in IRL. I remember watching as white kids parroted their parents' talking points in our middle school cafeteria, already fracturing into factions of "for" or "against" regarding a conflict they were too young and removed from to understand.

The postcolonial theorist Edward Said, then in the throes of a battle with leukemia, wrote often about the conflict by applying his classic theory of "Orientalism," a lens that might also help us understand how Eurocentric

beauty standards and mean-girl antics became so normalized at the time. "This is the most reckless war in modern times," Said wrote for the *London Review of Books* in 2003. "It is all about imperial arrogance unschooled in worldliness, unfettered either by competence or experience, undeterred by history or human complexity, unrepentant in its violence and the cruelty of its technology." We were in a post-9/11 time: Hyper-patriotism and fear of the Other permeated culture, and because women's bodies are never just bodies but also symbols, it makes sense that the whitest, thinnest—most all-American—women had an almost divine right to the social landscape.

We all know what happened next: Women in the spotlight and everyday life alike went to war with their bodies. In a 2008 TV interview with the Kardashian sisters, Tyra Banks, who, as a Black woman, faced some of the worst tabloid scorn of the time, reflected, "It's called Hollywood disease…. It's so sad that in our society right now, super super stick skinny, a size 0, is supposed to be the most beautiful thing in the world." A health study from 2011 shows that "hospitalizations with a principal diagnosis of an eating disorder increased 28 percent from 1999–2000 to their peak in 2007–2008," meaning that alongside the rise of tabloids came the rise of anorexia, bulimia, and other toxic relationships with food. Today, media's trickle-down impact on the body image of everyday women is explained by viral throwback video compilations of clips showing male late-night TV hosts interrogating their female guests about their dress sizes and magazine covers mocking stars for weight gain.

Paris was a paragon of these ideals, and not only did her wealth, whiteness, thinness, and cruelty crown her the Queen Bee of her girl groups, but they made her the literal money shot, transforming symbolic capital into economic capital. Photos of Paris made for valuable currency in the tabloid economy, which the Hollywood.TV founder, Sheeraz Hasan, explained this way: "I had over a hundred guys [paparazzi photographers] in Los Angeles, all of them making a living off Paris Hilton. For a photograph, at that time, it could range between 50,000 up to a million dollars. If you know that you can make a million dollars in one day, what does it look like? It's war."

These wars were fought on the shopping sidewalks of L.A. and valet areas in front of nightclubs as Paris and her friends strutted from hot spot to hot spot and paparazzi tussled to earn their shot. Whenever you see photos of the crowds of photographers that followed these young women, it's not surprising at all that the paparazzi phenomenon was reality TV's antecedent. The paps were like a TV crew whose presence the often-ambivalent stars had not consented to and for whose results, unlike the photographers and tabloid publishers, they were not paid (besides with the capital of fame). Today, in our post-Kardashian media landscape, any camera-captured occurrence might be a brand sponsorship or planned narrative. "I knew exactly where they were, if you wanted to be seen," Kim admitted to Andy Cohen in 2021, of staging photo ops for paparazzi in her early days (already indicating that she was figuring out how to engineer and reenact Paris's more effortless outings). "I would stop off at the Ivy and would pick up something to go—even if it was just some bread to go. Anything! An empty bag!"

The Bimbo Summit, though, had no need for empty bags. They were prosperous with the kind of drama best contextualized by the era's popular anthems, like the one that went, "Don't cha wish your girlfriend was hot like me?" by the Pussycat Dolls, who, unlike the Spice Girls, Jennifer Keishin Armstrong has written, didn't exactly represent notions of "real, noncompetitive female friendship."

Paris FULLY EXPOSED in Shocking New Blog!

The wars were often fought over men as a form of territory (whether men's centrality to these women's lives was "fake news," generated by tabloid headlines, is a question for another book), and after particularly brutal clashes this new class of tabloid stars couldn't help but turn to the ever-present cameras as communication tools for their messages to one another. Their conflicts seemed painfully real. For instance, in contrast to Kim's sex tape and its highly suspect leak, the infamous *1 Night in Paris* was understood to be a devastating humiliation for Hilton ("It was like being electronically raped," she later said). There was the time Lindsay ran up to some cameras to swear that Paris had hit her "for no reason" the night before. After all, Instagram

and Twitter did not yet exist to provide a forum for celebrities to curate their public images and post (deletable) subtweets. When TMZ, one of the latest tabloid websites, posted a video of the oil heir Brandon Davis's car-window assessment—with Paris laughing beside him from the driver's seat—that Lindsay Lohan was a "firecrotch" who was "worth about seven million, which is really poor, it's disgusting," it was clear that any at-home viewer was really a bystander to some very real shit between these rich strangers. Blogs like *Perez Hilton,* too, began popping up, following the same celebrity news covered by tabloids, allowing everyday people to voice their takes on all the content they'd consumed.

"Launched in 2004, [Perez Hilton's] blog included mocking comments or 'doodles' scrawled over celebrities' photos, superimposing crude sketches and nasty catchphrases in white, hand-drawn text, literally defacing the celebrity image and inviting readers to post comments," write Douglas and McDonnell. "He prodded and enacted an invitation to judge and make moral appraisals, and to do so publicly. So his readers—and those of other blogs—could bond with or against each other as they articulated or rejected the sanctity of social norms flaunted by celebrities." Just as celebutantes represented a new hybrid between the aspirational and the relatable, so did blogs, which democratized media commentary while also, Douglas and McDonnell point out, making mini stars of their authors, who echoed the cruel tone of the moment. The fact that Perez Hilton's blog made him a millionaire—bringing in sixty million page views in one month in 2007—is proof enough that the most magnetic media encouraged people to think in terms of "self-importance" and "vengeance." The Bimbo Summit and their like battled one another while the tabloids battled them, and the tabloid readers mimicked both stars and media, some of them transforming into bloggers and playing both roles. On some level, everyone was trying to work out who "deserved" to have power.

Paris was at war with not only her friends but, apparently, anyone who didn't fit the Queen Bee mold. In 2007, items stolen from a storage locker and posted to a website called ParisExposed.com included home footage showing her using anti-Black and antigay slurs ("She was forever using the N-word," Brandon Davis later said. "She is a racist, plus an idiot"). In 2020, amid her

This Is Paris press tour, throughout which she claimed her Paris Hilton persona had all been a big act, Jezebel received a video of her singing an altered version of "We Are Family" by Sister Sledge, rife with antisemitic and anti-Black slurs. Later, *BuzzFeed* compiled all these violations and more into a listicle—including a restraining order made in 2006 by a party promoter who testified that she'd ambushed him with aggressive phone calls and called him a "lazy Mexican," and another account by her former friend Neil Strauss claiming that she'd told him, "I can't stand Black guys. I would never touch one. It's gross."

It follows that being food starved, in a constant state of war with your friends, and bigoted is unsustainable. *The Simple Life* was eventually canceled, in part due to a falling-out between Paris and Nicole. The same year that the Paris Exposed Tumblr came out, the *Kim Kardashian, Superstar* sex tape dropped, costarring a Black man; in the following years, Bush left the White House, replaced by Barack Obama, the country's first Black president; and blogs and reality stars became as prominent to media as tabloids, movie stars, and celebutantes, presaging the rise of social media. Plus, in 2007, the first touch-screen iPhone was released, replacing the ubiquitous BlackBerry attached to the hands of all the era's tabloid queens. Douglas and McDonnell noted that if you fast-forward to "2016, with so many more readers going to apps or online for their celebrity news, the circulation of the celebazines overall had fallen significantly: *US Weekly* was down to just over 300,000 circulation, *Life & Style* down to just under 200,000, and *People* down to just over 650,000." When Lindsay Lohan, slated for a reality show with E!, was slapped with a DUI, leaving the network with an open time slot, *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* found its place, debuting in 2007 and enjoying explosive success—perhaps due to its timely focus on family and multiracial relationships at a moment when multiracial family rates were peaking in the United States, and its centering of browner, rounder bodies as Obama's rhetoric brought renewed attention to the Middle East. Paris still tried to point out the ways Kim did not fit into the hegemonic order she'd once ruled. In 2008, on the *Chet Buchanan and the Morning Zoo* radio show, when asked if she would "rather have Jessica Simpson's rack or Kim Kardashian's ass," she

said, “I would not want that [Kim’s ass]. It reminds me of cottage cheese inside of a big trash bag.” Walter Winchell once wrote, “The way to become famous fast is to throw a brick at someone who is famous.” Paris was inadvertently revealing the identity of the new star.

Kim K STUNS in Media Underdog Story for the Ages!

Rather than throwing a brick back, Kim distanced herself from Paris, building a storyline instead. Season 2, episode 7 of *KUWTK,* “Kardashian Civil War,” shows Kim all hyped up to buy her first Bentley, the same car that had once represented Paris’s various forms of capital. “I’ve worked very hard for this car,” she tells the cameras in a confessional. “Since I’ve been twelve years old, it’s been my dream to get a Bentley.” She describes the car’s design: “Black on black on black…. This is gonna be the new sleek look. Get rid of the pink.” In playing up her eagerness rather than entitlement, Kim embraced one of the most powerful archetypes American media has ever known, far more effective than any Queen Bee, key to the lovability of icons from Mickey Mouse to the Spice Girls: the underdog. Only fitting for the girl whose most memorable appearances in *The Simple Life* included being called a “ho” behind her back by a snickering Paris and Nicole, and helping Paris pack for a trip to India as an orientalist drumbeat played and Paris asked whether she was “allowed to be blond” in the East. This positionality would transcend Kim’s relationship with Paris and follow her through life. The gatekeeping she faced at every stage of her fame ascent is now implicit to her larger myth. For example, in 2012, comment sections were gleeful when it leaked that Anna Wintour “hated Kim” and would never invite her to the Met Gala. Famously, Kim appeared on its red carpet a year later, accompanying Kanye, over time becoming one of the fashion event’s most anticipated annual guests. Even in 2020, when the world should have been accustomed to the cycle—we doubt Kim, she proves us wrong—she “shocked” the internet by hosting *SNL* on live TV without a hitch, and, a few weeks later, passing the notoriously difficult “baby bar” in her law studies. I’ve learned, over the years of running Kardashian Kolloquium, just how rare it is to encounter a self-professed Kardashian “fan.” But haters are also fans, because they’re still

Keeping Up, and sometimes I wonder whether we root for her failure just so that we can watch her win again.

In *This Is Your Brain on Sports,* L. Jon Wertheim and Sam Sommers cite more than four studies to prove the power of the underdog in sports media (it's often said among pop culture fans that reality TV is "sports for girls"), including one that suggested that positioning a politician as the clear underdog in a race made people read him as warmer and more competent than when he was labeled the front-runner, and others "more economic in nature, such as the notion of greater potential return on the emotional investment in an underdog. When the favorite you're rooting for wins, the payoff can be tepid." Again and again, underdogs prevail. Wertheim and Sommers found a particularly on-the-nose study from the University of Richmond in which researchers showed people animations of a circle rolling up a hill with varying degrees of adversity—stopping, rolling back, trying again—and another one that had no trouble getting up and over. "Results indicated more rooting for a struggler than a non-struggler," Wertheim and Sommers wrote. "That's right, feelings of personal identification with an animated circle." In the Bentley episode of *KUWTK,* Kim's sisters Kourtney and Khloé build upon Kim's underdog construct by teasing her. "Kim said Bentley about twenty-five times," says Kourtney, rolling her eyes. But when Kim's peanut gallery gets into a tiff with the manager of the dealership for making them wait too long, Kim refuses to take their "side," and all hell breaks loose. "No loyalty!" they scream at Kim, after she frets to get them back into the car they'd arrived in, and she (famously) screams back, "You are so jealous! You are just so jealous that you cannot get a Bentley! And you're trying to ruin my moment for me!" By being accused of class envy, Kim's sisters became the successive underdogs. A therapist once told me that we are *every* character who appears in our dreams—that if you're being chased in a dream, you're both yourself, being chased, and your pursuer, because it's your psyche that's producing the whole scenario. In their self-produced reality show, the sisters were empowered to generate drama that entailed all the archetypes and themes of the tabloid era—Queen Bees, Wannabes, Targets, Bystanders, desperation, aspiration, jealousy, and rage—but, unlike with the Bimbo Summit, it would

not end in someone drunkenly weeping under a nightclub table or shaving their head, because the Kardashians were a family, bound to one another forever by blood and united by the shared goal of protecting their fledgling brand.

At this point, it's worth considering *whom* underdog messaging especially resonates with. A 2010 study shared with the *Harvard Business Review* showed that 71 percent of people chose chocolate brands that had been framed to them as "underdogs" against big-name competitors like Lindt and Godiva. No surprise there. Researchers also found that the "stronger a subject's own 'underdog disposition'—a sense of struggling in tough circumstances—was, the greater his or her preference for the underdog brand…[especially among] traditionally disadvantaged segments, such as women, blue collar workers, and ethnic minorities." When you assess the case studies of most iconic underdogs, this seems to track; Mickey Mouse, for example, was, as Walt Disney himself put it, "a little fellow trying to do the best he could" whose determination to bounce back up after being knocked down appealed to Depression-era audiences. Though Kim would, over time, face continued accusations that she appropriates working-class and Black and brown culture, the consistently explosive engagement numbers that defined her pop culture debut implied that a wide demographic range of America was nevertheless interested in watching an ethnically ambiguous wannabe, with a more diverse social circle than that of the previous era's starlets, start from the "bottom" of the Beverly Hills pecking order and work her way up—as Meredith Jones put it in a 2023 podcast, taking her family name from "blue collar to white collar to diamond collar." In 2016, *The New York Times* found that the show was "most popular in areas with large Hispanic populations, particularly in the Southwest," and among viewers whose favorite shows also included *Empire* and *Love and Hip Hop*.

Would it be too simple to point out that laughter can be a great unifier? Some of the most iconic *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* moments occurred in its early seasons, when the family produced scenes that were, if not always relatable, at least absurd in a way that encouraged viewers to experience its members as the punch line. Following their squabble at the Bentley

dealership, Kim overheard her sisters talking shit about her at Kourtney's apartment, and she burst into the room to bash Khloé with her purse, saying, "Don't be fucking rude," nearly knocking over one of their fast-food bowls.

Still, Kim retains some traces of the tabloid-era tone throughout the first few seasons of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians*. She speaks in a baby voice reminiscent of Paris's, and after getting mad at the whole family for not seeing her side of the Bentley battle, she throws her mom's cell phone off a ledge at a ski lodge and tells the camera, eyes glinting, "It's what she deserves."

Soon enough, though, they'd divest from brattiness, taking their brand in a "hustle culture" direction, talking about being businesswomen (in their memoir *Kardashian Konfidential,* they said their show was the "perfect commercial for our products. We're trying to make the most of our current success and we don't apologize for it…. That's what smart businesswomen do") and boasting about never being late to appointments (despite the *KUWTK* opening sequence, which shows Kim rushing in to join the family's photo shoot, shoving her sisters out of the way to remain centered in the shot. "That…bothered me, because I was always on time," she later told the *Los Angeles Times*). They also, of course, showed themselves experimenting with cosmetic enhancement technologies on their show, actioning what Elizabeth Wissinger has coined "glamour labor," or the work of "investing time and effort into editing the body and self to appear as fascinating and polished in person as in one's highly scripted, filtered and manipulated online life…while simultaneously crafting one's online image." This is now the given in public Kardashian discourse—that hardworking Kim has shaped her own narrative around the myth of the American dream. This may also explain another discovery in the chocolate-brand "underdog effect" study: that affinity for the underdog was more prominent among American respondents than their Singaporean counterparts "because, we suspect, the triumph of the underdog is so deeply embedded in the American Myth."

This investment in an all-American underdog narrative might also explain why, no matter how many public swipes Paris Hilton took at her, Kim avoided engaging. She quietly appropriated the selfie, even publishing a book,

Selfish, compiling her most significant contributions—marking a major cultural turn from paparazzi as a celebrity semiotic to the phone as an appendage that anyone could use to emulate their idols. Her conflicts were reserved for her sisters, which happened to provide the TV show with content—until 2016, when she threw a brick at a different blonde: the Americana pop star Taylor Swift, who, by then, had blown up the Billboard 100 with multiple hit singles from her fifth studio album, *1989,* becoming the first woman to replace herself with a new song in the No. 1 spot. After Kanye referred to Taylor (with whom he'd be forever tied after interrupting her acceptance speech at the 2009 VMAs) as a "bitch" in his song "Famous," and she expressed displeasure, Kim inserted herself into the dynamic by complaining to *GQ* that Taylor "totally knew that [the song] was coming out. She wanted to all of a sudden act like she didn't." Later, Kim posted a video she'd made of a phone call between Kanye and Taylor to Snapchat, prompting a social media firestorm that inspired Team Kimye members to flood Taylor's social media comments with snake emojis. As the playground cliché goes, fighting with someone "beneath" you brings you down to their "level," and in the Kardashian universe the inverse is as true. Becoming enemies with Swift approximated Kim to Taylor's level of global pop stardom, taking her further away from the annals of reality TV and tabloids (where she would have remained had she accepted Paris's various challenges).

This doesn't mean that Kim had no use for Paris anymore. In 2018, Kanye hired Paris to dress up as Kim for a postmodern Yeezy campaign that depicted various social media figures as Kim clones being followed by paparazzi, which had, by then, become a semi-nostalgic notion. In 2020, Kim invited Paris into a SKIMS campaign in which they wore the velour jumpsuits so "iconic" during and emblematic of their peak tabloid years, and the following year Kim made sure to be photographed at Hilton's wedding, cheerfully fixing her veil. Kim has often been quoted, on her television show and in various interviews, expressing her gratitude to Paris for making the blueprint of reality-based fame. Kim *should* be grateful; the mean-girl era gave her a high-contrast, lower-status starting place from which to rise. Next to Paris, Kim's long-expired underdog myth can persevere, while Paris is left

to do her best to Keep Up with new, Kardashified formats of fame. In her documentary, Paris wears the kind of sleek, waist-length hair extensions we've come to associate with the Kardashian family, and her face boasts the kind of hyaluronic-acid-enacted symmetry and contoured makeup aesthetic that has been termed by some cultural critics "Kardashian face." Telling her sister, Nicky, that she doesn't know when she'll have time to have a baby, Paris echoes Kim's signature pontification about the essential role that "hard work" has played in the construction of her multibillion-dollar brand by declaring, "I will not stop until I make a billion dollars."

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PART II



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ARRIVAL (2007–2013)

Kim hits the tabloid scene and makes her way to the TV screen thanks to a classic method: "Sex sells."

The Brady Bunch

"We're the modern day Brady Bunch—with a kick!" That's how Kim describes her family in the premier episode of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians,* "I'm Watching You," which made its E! Network debut on October 14, 2007. The episode follows the matriarch, Kris, and her then-spouse, Caitlyn (known at the time as Bruce) Jenner, as they plan their sixteenth wedding anniversary dinner. As in the countless family-focused sitcoms that have defined mainstream television since the nuclear era, when promotion of "family first" values was a matter of patriotism, wacky antics ensue as Kris and Kourtney get too tipsy while tasting wine for the party. Kim has a stripper pole installed in the family's home office as a gift for the occasion and then receives a scandalous lesson in how to use it from a member of the Pussycat Dolls; nine-year-old Kylie tries a few twirls before Dad comes in to spoil the fun. Later, at the party, Kris makes the "I'm watching you" hand signal to Kourtney's philandering younger boyfriend, Scott, and the little ones, Kendall and Kylie, scamper behind the bar to mix margaritas for the guests. Amanda Scheiner McClain, who deserves credit for publishing one of the first book-length deconstructions of the Kardashian family in 2013, writes that "the lack of parent/children boundaries is part of the show's appeal, as audience members may watch to see which taboos will be broken," and adds that *KUWTK* "blur[s] boundaries that are distinct in typical households," resulting "in a complex web of right and wrong…. The only ideal clearly elucidated is a reliable and clichéd sitcom moral, the importance of family." The family's dismissal of boundaries—especially in the hot-button areas of gender and sex—defies what the TV scholar Jeremy

G. Butler has written of early network television, which "produced comedies that were largely informed by heterosexual, patriarchal, and cisnormative discourses…. [W]omen's roles in these comedies were presumed to be in pursuit of heterosexual romance, subservient to men, and free of transgender blurring of the lines between femininity and masculinity." In *KUWTK,* the women were the main characters. They flaunted their sexuality in the face of Caitlyn's patriarchal disapproval and made their own business decisions, all the while performing the kind of male-gaze-approved femininity that might initially fool you into thinking that they subscribed to classic sitcom formulas.

The public—freed by the boundaryless show to draw its *own* lines—reacted with fascination and revulsion. A *Washington Post* review of the first season called the show a "monstrosity" and joked that Kim's sisters were probably "slipping lard into her food." When Reese Witherspoon won a VMA a few years later, she announced in her speech, "Girls…it is possible to make it in Hollywood without a reality show. When I came up in this business, if you made a sex tape, you were embarrassed and you hid it under your bed."

The country was also in the throes of what would come to be known as the Great Recession, following the revelation of the U.S. mortgage system's corruption and subsequent collapse of several major banks. Property ownership was in peril, and unemployment was rising; the grievance that gave rise to Occupy Wall Street was a few years in the future (a historic cultural moment at which Kim's future husband, Kanye, made a headline-generating appearance). And yet here the Kar-Jenners were, framing the American dream as something that began in the middle class. Not only that—they seemed to suggest that upward mobility was something that *must* and *could* be achieved simply by turning profit from the public's collective hate boner.

As one columnist griped in 2011, "This family that's famous for being famous are all multi-millionaires by sinking their money-grubbing hooks into innumerable products…and getting in the 'news' in any way, shape, or form possible." The incessant flaunting of sexuality, especially in the show's first season, seemed to offer up an opportunity to not only "watch to see which taboos will be broken" but engage with taboo, react to it, and opt to either

accept or reject it; part of the matriarchy's offensiveness seemed to be that they were making money off viewers' attraction and revulsion. Butler points out that "grotesque sexuality—along with excrement—are key elements of psychoanalyst Sigmund Freud's theories of the subconscious…. contend[ing] that comedy provides a way to release social tensions that build up around sexuality."

The fact that, as early as their first episode, the Kar-Jenners were declaring their much spicier likeness to the squeaky-clean *Brady Bunch*—which came out in 1969, exemplified all the classic gag-driven sitcom conventions, and ran for nearly five years—also proves that the clan has always understood just how useful cultural references can be in contextualizing—and constructing—an image for the masses. The *Brady Bunch* comparison works because, even if we modern viewers haven't seen the vintage series, many of us are still familiar with its catchy theme song and, therefore, basic premise.

Like the Brady Bunch, the Kar-Jenner clan is big and blended. Kris Kardashian, née Houghton, former teen mistress to a professional athlete turned flight attendant turned Beverly Hills housewife turned divorcée, mother of Kourtney, Kim, Khloé, and Robert Jr., met and married the former Olympian Bruce Jenner in 1991, with whom she had Kendall and Kylie. This background was a big reason why the family was selected to fill the E! reality show slot left open after Lindsay Lohan's latest DUI. "Frankly, as an executive, you look for the archetypes," an executive responsible for signing the family told the *Los Angeles Times* in an oral history of *KUWTK*. "'Girls Next Door' was a little 'Three's Company,' and I thought this family…were that modern take on 'The Brady Bunch.'" This approach can at least partially explain the success of most popular phenomena in contemporary culture. In his book *Hit Makers,* Derek Thompson describes how Airbnb was originally pitched in Silicon Valley as "eBay for homes," and later Uber was likened to "Airbnb for cars." The idea is, Thompson writes, "to frame your ideas as tweaks of old ideas, to mix a little fluency with a little disfluency—to make your audience see the familiarity behind the surprise."

In 1973, as *The Brady Bunch* was nearing its end, *An American Family* came out on PBS. Destined to one day be remembered as America's "first reality show," it was a twelve-part documentary following the Loud family of Santa Barbara as the married couple Bill and Pat struggled to overcome their spousal quarrels (which, the French philosopher Jean Baudrillard suggests, were worsened by the relentless awareness of being watched) and their five kids journeyed to find themselves (including the groundbreaking subplot of one son discovering his homosexuality in New York City). According to her 2021 *New York Times* obituary, the outspoken and business-savvy Pat Loud was perceived in her time to be "materialistic and self-absorbed. An 'affluent zombie,' one [critic] said." Decades later, though, "public perception of her had shifted. Where once she had been seen as an unmitigated self-promoter, now she was a wise, refined matriarch of a genre gone astray."

Though ten million people tuned in to *An American Family* weekly, it would be decades before reality TV made its most irrevocable mark on culture in the 1990s with shows like *The Real World*—and longer still before early '00s shows like *The Osbournes, Run's House,* and *Newlyweds* returned their gaze to the home—but it makes sense that, given sitcoms' traditional celebration of families, the first product of a new genre would follow suit. As James Gandolfini, playing the producer Craig Gilbert, says in *Cinema Verite,* a 2011 fictionalized retelling of *An American Family*'s production, "We've gone to the moon and beyond, but we have yet to get past the American front door. And when we get past that door, what do you think we're going to find? The cute little jokes with the laugh tracks? No. No one has ever done this before."

In keeping with the family's modus operandi of "blurring boundaries," *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* also collapsed genre categories between the sitcom and the reality show, constructing every episode with such a snappy pace and precise A-plot/B-plot formula that you'd expect to hear a laugh track resounding after naughty jokes about Kim having "junk in the trunk" or how "horny" she had been when she made the Tape. No matter how scandalizing the reality-based content of any given episode, they followed

proper sitcom form, always closing with some Kar-Jenner in a confessional shot, uttering a version of the same adage: “What matters most is family.”

I Love Lucy

The truth is that *I Love Lucy* might be an even more precise blueprint for *KUWTK* than *The Brady Bunch,* and Kim herself referenced the 1950s classic in a 2014 interview with the tech journalist Kara Swisher: “We’re filming our tenth season right now and we’ve had nine seasons of spin-offs, so…we have more episodes than *I Love Lucy*.” (Outrage over the comparison generated its own headlines.) There’s the fact that Lucille Ball and Desi Arnaz made a number of historic, showbiz-savvy decisions that the Kardashians would totally emulate if faced with similar challenges: When CBS was reluctant to sign the married B-list celebs on for a TV show, in part due to Desi Arnaz’s Cuban American background, the duo rebranded themselves as a vaudeville act called Desilu and toured the country in person to prove their crowd-pleasing potential to the network. While negotiating their consequential contract, they accepted lower pay to retain rights on all their productions, which would make moguls of them once Desi realized they could syndicate their show. This profit windfall enabled Desi to purchase RKO studios, rename it Desilu, and put out shows like *Mission: Impossible* and *Star Trek* (which would, in 1968, depict the first kiss between a Black woman and a white man on TV). Then there was their use of product placement, an advertising strategy that would come to define almost every moment in *KUWTK:* In 1953, Philip Morris paid the couple $8 million to have its cigarettes integrated into the show, which, by that point, *Time* reported, had earned a “higher Nielsen rating…than the TV coverage of President Eisenhower’s inauguration.” Not only that: Like that of *KUWTK,* which was, in essence, a reality show *about* reality stars, *I Love Lucy*’s essential premise was “meta.” As Susan J. Douglas and Andrea McDonnell write, the show “confronted the question of fame in all its ironies. Lucy and Ricky played aspiring celebrities…but the couple was, of course, already famous in real life. Lucy plays with audiences’ awareness of this fact, poking fun at the bizarreness of fame and people’s hunger for it throughout the series.”

Finally, *I Love Lucy* was a tad provocative when it came to race and sex—at least as much as was possible for the time—in featuring a marriage between a white woman and a Cuban American man at a time when less than 5 percent of Americans approved of interracial marriage, and sixteen years before the landmark Supreme Court case *Loving v. Virginia* would strike down state bans on interracial marriages. After this ruling, support for interracial marriages increased to 20 percent and would grow bit by bit by the decade, with a jump from 75 percent as late as 2005 to 94 percent in 2021. It should be noted that often-whitewashed Cuban identity tends to generate its own questions about racial "in-betweenness." Desi belonged to an elite family back in Cuba, and Reddit debates abound on whether he counted as "white." This discourse usually begets the question of whether Arnaz whitewashed himself for white American audiences, or exoticized himself for them, or faced real racism in the industry, or appropriated the culture of less privileged Latinos for the screen, or some combination of all of the above. But the fact is, CBS was initially eager to cast Lucille alongside her (white) former *My Favorite Husband* radio costar, Richard Denning, and balked when Lucy suggested Desi instead. It can't be denied that, as the communications researcher Jenna Shaffer writes, Ricky's angry eruptions into bursts of Spanish, in the show's early seasons, separated him "from the ideal levelheaded husband who was later personified in the character of Ward Cleaver on the television show *Leave It to Beaver* (1957–1963) and were often a result of frustration with his wife and his emasculation." A 1956 skit on *The Bob Hope Show,* with Bob Hope as Ricky and Desi Arnaz (who normally played Ricky) as his landlord Fred, illustrated Ricky's lack of power. "Hope as Ricky dominated Ricky as Fred throughout the show by using his ethnicity against him," writes Shaffer, describing how Hope says to Arnaz, " 'What happened? Did you just come back from a "wetback" luau?' " This word was a slur, "coined to describe Mexicans who had either swam or waded across the Rio Grande river into Texas illegally."

I Love Lucy spun comedy gold at least in part out of classic American anxiety about race and the idea of the white woman's domestic domain. For better or worse, so has *KUWTK*. Chris Rock summarized his view of the

Kar-Jenner clan's approach to race relations in a 2023 stand-up special: "If you're black and you wanna be accepted by your white in-laws, then you need to marry a Kardashian…. Kris Jenner is like the Statue of Liberty…. Kris Jenner lets everybody in." (A far more palatable framing than in the meme Khloé reposted to Instagram in 2014, with an image of the sisters tagged "the only KKK to let Black men in.") At the time of the debut of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians,* Kim and Khloé had publicly been in serious relationships with high-profile Black athletes, which led to racist critiques from some white viewers as well as concern among some members of the Black community. At times, a particular talking point converged. In 2010, Yolanda Young described, for *The Huffington Post,* a recent George Lopez interview with Kim Kardashian and Khloé where he asked, "What's up with y'all and black guys?" Young wrote, "I've heard black women snipe that Kim and Khloé date black men because white men don't want them," a contention I've also come across in comment section takedowns on the family from white viewers. Only a few months before Young's piece came out, the *Los Angeles Times* had published a feature called "The Kardashian Phenomenon," also questioning the role that Black men have played in the family's brand, and both pieces were reported on at Jezebel by Dodai Stewart, who called the "funny, friendly, and admittedly not perfect" Kardashians a "refreshing alternative to the standard super-skinny Hollywood blonde," acknowledging that "the Kardashians seem to be getting away with things not many celebs can." Objectionable as some viewers might have found this dynamic, it might be said that the Kardashians were modeling a path for new power dynamics to emerge in the home within the same decade that, according to the Pew Research Center, "the number of white and black biracial Americans more than doubled."

The Kar-Jenners themselves, as McClain points out, *say* little about the politics of interracial relationships in early seasons of the show—even as Kim semi-regularly sighs about her hopes to one day marry her football star boyfriend, Reggie Bush—but they *do* fashion visual spectacles out of the notion of racial unity. In one episode, a rap group comes by to "kick it" with Kris, who tells them, "Welcome to the *hood*!" Once everyone's inside, she

playacts as the stereotypical sitcom housewife, bringing out milk and cookies, but somehow ends up draped in diamond chains, encircled by the men as they all dance to one of their tracks.

KUWTK was watched by 1.3 million people in the United States just as the country was anticipating the next First Family to replace the stuffy, dopey double-term Bushes in the White House. On February 10, 2007, in Springfield, Illinois, the young Illinois senator Barack Obama announced his plan to run for president, to the delight and dismay of a country whose divided partisan lines had become almost cartoonishly defined after its post-9/11 invasion of the Middle East. The content of Obama's speech emphasized his plans to tackle poverty, to reform health care, and, most of all, to end the so-called war on terror, while the oratorial delivery of his speech intentionally echoed John F. Kennedy's. In reporting on the event, the *Chicago Tribune* noted that Obama also utilized Kennedy's masterful camerawork strategies: "You wouldn't know it from looking at most of the photographs and video of the event, but in making his address, Obama wasn't speaking to the crowd but was facing a multitiered riser on which dozens of television cameras were situated." The report featured a quotation by an enlivened future voter swearing that "he'll be our next Kennedy." The charismatic Democratic senator's racial identity was one of the most talked-about topics among voters who were eager to see the first Black family in the White House, and critics who seemed to dread that possibility. (A 2009 survey revealed that 54 percent of respondents "thought that race was at least a minor reason why 'people oppose Barack Obama's policies.' ")

In a study of media coverage of Black issues during the first year of Obama's first term, Pew Research discovered that "storylines that generated the most press attention on African Americans were driven primarily by black figures who made news," rather than the ways the economic crisis was affecting Black communities, for example, or what Obama's health-care reform plan could mean for them. When, in 2009, at the beginning of Obama's first term, the Black Harvard professor Henry Louis Gates Jr. was locked out of his own home, accused by the police of burglarizing it, and arrested for disorderly conduct, the media focused on the incident for months,

mostly making way for pundits to debate whether the situation had been racist or not. “Harvard professor Henry Louis Gates and President Barack Obama accounted for more than a third (37%) of the African American newshole” in the time between 2009 and 2010, a continuation of media’s preference for amplifying a singular figure into representing more complex and widespread issues. The focus was on the optics of Black men entering spaces where they were perceived to not belong—whether the White House, Gates’s own home, or the Kar-Jenners’ living room.

GIRLS GONE WILD

The year *KUWTK* debuted, 2007, was also the year that Perez Hilton declared “the year of Girls Gone Wild.” The blogger was describing the tabloid shenanigans of It Girls like Paris Hilton, Lindsay Lohan, and Britney Spears with this reference to the household-name porn franchise launched in 1997 by Joe Francis, who, Scaachi Koul of *The Huffington Post* writes, “came up with the idea while working as a production assistant for ‘Real TV,’ a syndicated show of cutting room floor clips considered too grisly to air. It gave him an idea: What about a show like this, but for boobs?” The idea bloomed into what the feminist writer Ariel Levy has dubbed “a fantasy world dreamed up by teenage boys. A world of sun and sand where frozen daiquiris flow from faucets and any hot girl you see will peel off her bikini top, lift up her skirt… all you have to do is ask. It’s no surprise that there’s a male audience for this, but what’s strange is that the women who populate this alternate reality are not strippers or paid performers, they are middle-class college kids on vacation—they are mainstream.” Before reality TV had truly taken hold of culture, Francis created a reality-inflected iteration of the porn industry, produced, as the communications scholar Vicki Mayer writes, “with the highest-grade amateur…video cameras available,” which enhanced a certain sense of realism. Girls Gone Wild was then packaged for pay-per-view, VHS, and DVD, and marketed via ubiquitous nighttime infomercials. The operation brought in $20 million in its first two years, and by 2001 had sold 4.5 million videos and DVDs. In 2003, though, Francis was arrested in Panama City,

Florida, for a "slew of charges: racketeering, possession and intent to distribute drugs, soliciting minors, child abuse, and filming minors in a sexual act, just to name a few." Through all of this, he was a pal to the Kar-Jenners, whose show he later claimed he had helped to write. Like the all-female jury that threw out an emotional distress lawsuit leveled at him by four women who claimed that their involvement in GGW had ruined their lives, the Kar-Jenners were able to look past the plentiful accusations of exploitation leveled at Francis's enterprise. He even makes an appearance in a season 1 episode of *KUWTK,* by phone, when he calls the girls from jail ("We love you, Charlie," they trill, referencing the 1970s girl-group sitcom *Charlie's Angels*) to ask them to model for the franchise's latest swimwear line at his seaside Mexico estate—where Kim and Kanye would, much later, celebrate their honeymoon, and which countless celebrities, from Hailey Bieber to Vanessa Hudgens, continue to visit. "Sometimes people have a negative connotation with Girls Gone Wild," Kris tells the confessional. "But this bikini line is so fabulous—a high-end, couture bikini line." When Caitlyn, the family's patriarchal figure, surprises the girls in Mexico to scold them for lying and running off to "do a Girls Gone Wild video," Kourtney reassures her, "You know we would never do anything that would make us look not classy."

This was 2007. Not only had Girls Gone Wild further dissolved boundaries between the sex industry and the "everyday," but discourses about sex work were entering the mainstream in other ways. One year earlier, five sex workers in Ipswich, England, had been found murdered, creating, Michael D. E. Goodyear writes, "a media controversy over whether labelling them as prostitutes was dehumanising, as well as raising questions about our duty to protect such women." A year before that, the future *Juno* screenwriter Diablo Cody published her memoir, *Candy Girl: A Year in the Life of an Unlikely Stripper.* Also in 2005, *Cathouse,* the HBO docuseries about Nevada's legal brothel, the Moonlite BunnyRanch, began its two-season run, offering viewers a look inside the brothel's business operations and sexual dynamics. The scholar Elizabeth Bernstein was also writing about the increasingly complex relationship between sex workers and the middle class,

noting, in *Temporarily Yours,* an exemplary class-encoded contrast between two photography projects:

> The relationship between class-based ethical ideals and the meaning of sex work was inadvertently well illustrated by two different series of "before" and "after" photographs featuring San Francisco sex workers, both published in 1998, with each series telling a very different morality tale. The first series, published in *Life* magazine, featured streetwalkers who had left prostitution and committed their lives to helping other women leave the trade. The *Life* series of photos was intended to illustrate the women's successful completion of a longed-for transition from "disreputable" street life into the respectable middle classes…. The second series of photographs derives from sex-worker activist and performance artist Annie Sprinkle's "Transformation Salon," the stated aim of which is to "bring out the inner slut/whore/porn star/pinup in any woman and capture it on film for her and her loved ones to marvel at for years to come." In contrast to the *Life* magazine pictures, Sprinkle's photos illustrate a new petite-bourgeois rejection of the pursuit of respectability in favor of a celebration of the "fun ethic."

The Kar-Jenners have, at times, made the most of the "fun ethic" while also devoting screen time to their furrowed-brow deliberations about the "classiness" of their sexual self-commodification. In one episode, Kourtney scrimmages with Kim about how she'll broach the issue of the Tape during her upcoming *Tyra Show* appearance. "Why did you make a sex tape?" Kourtney asks. "Because I was horny and I felt like it," Kim says. Bernstein elaborates on her photo project anecdote by sharing that many of the middle-class sex workers she interviewed expressed a desire to distance themselves from working-class "streetwalkers" and the stigmas associated with their vulnerability, which the Kardashians also echo. We see Kris accidentally hire a porn star known as Bree Olson to babysit Kendall and Kylie; the episode ends with Khloé calling the woman "trashy," during a confessional, and the

family asking Olson to leave the house and slamming the door behind her. We see nine-year-old Kylie spinning on a stripper pole; we see the Girls Gone Wild "swimwear" episode (which also includes a scene of nine-year-old Kylie pretending to lift her own shirt up as one of Brody Jenner's adult male friends films her with a camcorder), and we hear a whole lot about *Playboy*. When I asked an adult entertainer with a minor role in yet another pornography-fixated *KUWTK* episode whether she felt that Kim was a sex worker, she replied with an unequivocal yes. Yet in another episode that season, when Rob makes a comment about wanting a girlfriend and Scott Disick jokes that they should visit a "gentlemen's club" to meet girls, Kim says, "My brother is not dating a stripper—that's sick. I'm going to find him a nice, normal girl." Later, when Kim's makeup artist tells her about his eligible best friend, recently named *Playboy*'s Playmate of the Year, she can't set Rob up fast enough.

PLAYBOY

Like Girls Gone Wild, the primary object of *Playboy*'s flirtation was the American middle class. The art historian David Lubin describes Hugh Hefner as a "young army veteran in Chicago" stuck in an unhappy marriage, with a professional background in mass-market magazines, whose initial plan was to put together a publication called *Stag Party* (the old-school term for "bachelor party"). Hefner strode toward actualizing this dream in 1953 by borrowing some cash from his mom and $600 from the bank to "negotiate with a calendar manufacturer for the right to a 1948 color pinup photo of a fetching blonde model who posed with her lips invitingly open and her eyelids sensuously lowered." Yes, this was a pre-fame Marilyn Monroe, who was paid only fifty bucks for the Tom Kelley photo shoot and whose image made an instant success of the rechristened *Playboy.* It almost goes without saying by now that exploitation is essential to the success of the mass-mediated selling of sex: Nude paparazzi photos of Jackie O would put *Hustler* on the map; some Girls Gone Wild participants, paid in T-shirts, drinks, or small sums of cash, turned out to be underage or too drunk to consent; leaked celebrity sex

tapes brought hordes of clicks to pornography websites. Sexual accessibility is, apparently, most alluring when there's a sense that no woman is profiting from it, which is probably at least one reason why the Kardashians (and the Spice Girls) became more reviled the richer they got, and also why people would one day rag on the sex-industry social media website OnlyFans, which came out in 2016 in the thick of Kardashian-driven influencer culture and offered a space for many sex workers to own the means of their production. (Ray J would, in 2024, tell the ex–NFL star and podcaster Shannon Sharpe on his podcast that he believed their sex tape kicked off the cultural shift that led to the success of the site.)

Playboy's intended essence was all about boys' club classiness, "creat[ing] a nationwide stag party." It launched in the 1950s, when, Lubin writes, men were looking to JFK, whose own James Bond–loving, cool-guy Everyman image dominated *Life* and *Look* magazine covers. "Hefner received his training in the magazine business working for *Esquire,* a publication that during the 30s and 40s symbolized male glamour and rakishness," writes Lubin. "Its name denoted an English country gentleman, a landowner who ranked higher than a commoner but lower than a knight or a lord. Hefner's *Playboy* exploited its readers' aristocratic desires and pretensions but democratized them, for the underlying theme of the magazine was that any man…could achieve playboy status for the nugatory price of a newsstand copy." One day, Kim Kardashian would achieve something similar with the expansion of her TV show, and her fragrance, makeup, and shapewear lines—democratizing her glamorous Calabasas luxury lifestyle for the cost of a corset or a streaming subscription to Hulu. But in 2007, still a mere sitcom-reality star with a sex tape, she deferred to the institution that was *Playboy,* which called Kris to offer Kim the honor of being a "celebrity pictorial" in its coveted December issue. The fourth episode of *KUWTK*'s first season follows Kim's dilemma about whether to accept the offer, and then, once she does, whether to fully undress. "They'll *say* it's going to be classy and fabulous," Khloé jokes, when Kim comes to her sisters for advice. "It is really classy," Kim insists. "It's the December cover—that's a huge deal." "Do it with class, but undress that ass," Kourtney chimes in. "That'll be your slogan." As the

episode goes on, Caitlyn invokes the family's main patriarchal figure, questioning how Kim's late father would feel, while Kris reveals that it was *her* "lifelong dream" to pose for *Playboy*. Finally, once on set, Kim clutches her metaphorical pearls when she is, indeed, asked by the photographer to undress.

CATCHPHRASES

After Hefner himself invites Kim and Kris to the Playboy mansion, where he explains that Marilyn "happened to be" Playmate of the Month for the magazine's first-ever December issue, Kim is more trusting of his promises that the spread will be "classy, discreet." She marches back to set, strips, and is draped in pearls that hang from a choker necklace.

You can hear the words already—"you're doing amazing, sweetie." As Kim posed, Kris, the perfect parodist of extreme stage-mom-dom, voiced her pride and, from behind the professional photographer, snapped her own digital pics of her nude daughter.

Kourtney's instincts were right on when she ascribed a slogan to Kim's ass. Think of all the slogans and catchphrases we associate with icons: *Honey, I'm home! Yes, we can. If it doesn't fit, you must acquit. Girl Power! That's hot. You're fired. Let them eat cake.* Catchphrases are essential to icons, and part of the Kar-Jenners' power is that they have so many. *Stop taking pictures of yourself—your sister's going to jail. There's people that are dying. Get your fucking ass up and work.*

In a study of one thousand movie scripts, researchers at Cornell determined the structure of memorable catchphrases: They often have "unusual word sequences built on common syntactic scaffolding"—which is to say, surprising words stated with a familiar cadence—and "tend to invoke general themes that aren't tied to the specific setting they came from," which means "fewer third person pronouns" (he/she/they), "more indefinite articles" (a, an), and "more present tense," because all of these elements made for vaguer sentences, which make for contextual "portability." "You're doing amazing, sweetie" can totally be deconstructed according to these principles:

There's not a third-person pronoun to be found—the amazing "sweetie" could be anyone, anywhere—and while the compliment itself may have a ring to it, the combination of words is helplessly funny: Why "amazing," rather than "great"? Why tack on a term of endearment (or—why not)? The researchers of this study tried to focus on sentence structure outside context, but they admit that certain lines, when contextualized by funny or otherwise memorable media moments, may increase in memorability because "there are complex connections between humor and memory."

The "you're doing amazing, sweetie" scene, which eventually earned its own slang entry on Dictionary.com, proved memorable enough that Kim would reference it more than fifteen years later with her 2023 Met Gala look, working with Schiaparelli's Daniel Roseberry to deck herself in fifty thousand pearls over a corset top. She debuted the look by showcasing a mother-daughter moment of her own: walking out of the Ritz-Carlton hotel holding hands with ten-year-old North West, who wore a pearl choker beneath a chaste tweed sweater. In a sense, this linkage-by-gemstones is the Kardashian-West take on "you're doing amazing, sweetie." From kings in antiquity, to the Kennedys, to sitcoms like *The Brady Bunch,* most media depictions of powerful or upwardly mobile families focus on the father who "knows best" and passes his leadership role on to his heir apparent—the first son. Here, the Kar-Jenner matriarchy subverts this patriarchal routine, demonstrating that power can indeed be garnered and consolidated through sex and then inherited by the female next of kin. All this has inspired our *own* if not catchphrases, then mantras about the family, which come up again and again whenever we try to make sense of their power; we say that they are masters at "controlling the narrative" (though it would require a whole book to deconstruct exactly how). We admit that they may be flawed, or stupid, or even deplorable—but "they *are* really good businesswomen."

Playboy responded to Kim's Met Gala look on Instagram by reposting all of her best spreads, confirming what everyone could see—that the look was a reference to one of the early-career memes that contributed to Kim's ever-iterating notoriety. Back when Kim was mulling over whether she should pose for *Playboy,* Caitlyn, playing the *Father Knows Best* role she had been

prescribed at the time, encouraged Kim to reconsider: "*Playboy* needs you more than you need *Playboy*." Audiences might have scoffed at such classic Kar-Jenner self-aggrandizement at the time, but only a few years later, in 2009, the *New York Post* announced "Playboy in Market for a Sugar Daddy with $300M." The magazine industry had been taking beatings as the American financial recession stretched on, and as the influence of the internet continued to rise, *Playboy* was especially hemorrhaging funds. "In the most recent quarter, the company said it lost $13.7 million, compared with a loss of $4.2 million a year ago. Revenue eroded to $61.6 million in the quarter from $78.5 million a year ago." The magazine industry scholar Samir Husni told ABC, "In the last three decades…Playboy has lost its relevancy and has had to compete with an increasing tide of porn that has made its magazine 'look like Sesame Street for kids.' It lost on the intellectual side for people who actually bought Playboy to read it. And it lost on the other side for people who just bought Playboy to look at the pictures because there were plenty of pictures now everywhere." Joe Francis told ABC that he'd tried to purchase the brand in the past, but now no longer considered the business "salvageable." "Their overhead is astronomical," he explained. "They have no core business that's attractive." Digital media was dominating, and anyone who wanted to consume female sexuality no longer needed a pseudo-aristocratic way to do so.

CONFESSION

Early seasons of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* might have played like a sitcom, but it was an American reality show, which meant that it came with its own narrative conventions—among them, the confessional. One of the most persevering Kardashian memes comes from a confessional moment in the show's first season: Kris Jenner, sitting before a red backdrop, tells the camera, "When I first heard about Kim's tape, I wanted to kill her. But as her *manager*…"

In a 2015 piece for *The A.V. Club,* Noel Murray describes the narrative device as "a direct-to-camera or looking-just-past-the-camera interview with

the participants, filmed later but usually edited and phrased to come across like an immediate commentary on whatever just happened." It is its own form of movie magic: Audiences never know *when* a confessional was filmed—even as it shows a reality star explaining, in the present tense, their view of a situation. When, in 2008, Kim is about to walk onto a Las Vegas stage to perform a solo for the Pussycat Dolls cabaret, Khloé, initially shown cheering from the crowd, appears in a confessional to say, "Kim is actually going to be the finale tonight, and, oh my God, I'm shaking." Somehow, Khloé, arriving from another time and place, is reliving the moment to make it more vivid for viewers. As the scholar Danielle Lindemann tells Louis Staples in his 2023 investigation of reality TV confessionals for *The Cut,* confessionals intensify "parasocial" impact on audiences. It's true—the direct-to-camera gaze mimics what American presidents have been doling out at least since Kennedy's administration to build extra connection with audiences. Other scholars suggest that postmortems after sports games, game shows, and courtroom shows like *Judge Judy* laid the blueprint for confessionals. Staples writes, "Reality-TV writer Brian Moylan, author of *The Housewives: The Real Story of the Real Housewives,* cites *The Real World*'s use of confessional interviews as the moment reality TV really began as a cohesive medium. 'Reality TV isn't just about observing what's going on,' he explains. 'It's about asking the people how they *feel* about what's happening to them…which is far more interesting than viewing the raw footage alone.' "

In short, confessionals offer a way for reality TV producers to play God—and invite us to play the (Catholic) priest: We viewers are brought closer to the subjectivities of the show's stars and the raw material of confession. Michel Foucault argues that Christian values—like purity, the cultural obsession with which, he says, only draws *more* attention to sex—and Christian rituals—like penance seeking, which offers a space or "technology" for one to further self-actualize—have shaped the way we think about and construct Western society as we know it today. In his fourth and final lecture on human sexuality, *Confessions of the Flesh,* which was published posthumously, he explores Christian notions of subjectivity and power. The church confession was, he writes, an avowal, "a verbal act through which the

subject affirms who he is, binds himself to this truth, places himself in a relationship of dependence with regard to another, and modifies at the same time his relationship to himself." Reality TV teems with avowals, because at least part of the point of the genre is to offer media consumers material they can feel closer to. Avowal, Foucault wrote, also applied to "judicial and penal institutions." The hand-on-Bible rite before someone testifies in court, in fact, turned into a constant catchphrase within the Kardashian family. (Bobbing in a hotel pool, Scott accuses Kourtney of peeing because the water feels warm. "Bible, I'm not peeing," she swears.)

CHURCHES

The Kardashians, intent on becoming all-American icons, mostly an overtly Christian bunch (John F. Kennedy, Walt Disney, Barack Obama) or at least followers of an Abrahamic religion (Bob Dylan, Princess Jasmine, Muhammad Ali), were bound to replicate the entrenchment of Christianity in American identity in their own media content, ultimately depicting Kim as a messianic, endlessly resurrecting figure. Invoking the scholars Scott Schieman and Jong Hyun Jung's concept of "Prosperity Christianity," a "'transdenominational doctrine that emphasizes that God grants material prosperity…to those who have enough faith,'" Meredith Jones writes about how, in a 2023 episode of *The Kardashians,* Kim takes Kris and Khloé in her private jet, Air Kim, to help Khloé's ex-boyfriend Tristan after his mom passes away. Khloé, Jones points out, tells Kim, "You were and are a little angel." Jones surmises that the countless scenes of Kim's strength and self-sacrifice—taken with the whole family's insistent proclamations of faith—suggest that some of their success can be explained as God's reward. Not only are Kim's regular acts of goodness Christian in nature, but so is her famous project of physical self-transformation. Jones points out that "many people describe their cosmetic surgeries as transformative beyond the physical. Some describe going into the darkness of general anesthetic and waking into the light transformed—dare I say 'born again'—as akin to revelation." Jesus died and came back, and though Kim has not yet been transparent about which

surgical procedures she's undergone, we know she's been reborn more than a few times as well.

A 2013 *Christian Post* article takes inventory of the family's numerous early incidences of professing their faith, which only multiplied the more famous they became. In a 2011 interview with Josh Skinner, Kris Jenner said, "Even a family as crazy as ours can have a great relationship with God." Kim seemed to emphasize her Christianity as a redemptive or compensatory factor for her commodified and widely reviled sexuality, telling Oprah in 2012, "I hardly drink—I go to church on Sundays. I'm so far removed from my image."

Kim was able to spend so much time at church because her family owned one. After the Westlake, California, pastor Brad Johnson was disgraced by an adultery scandal in 2007, Kris Jenner tracked him down at the Starbucks where he was working to cofound a new church—to be eventually rebranded as California Community Church—where congregants are expected to pay $1,000 a month or 10 percent of their income to attend services that were initially held at an Agoura Hills Sheraton Inn (and, eventually, in a leased space across the street). Churches of this sort, writes the Catholic priest and liturgical design consultant Richard S. Vosko, are "best described as the big box variety that can be constructed quickly and inexpensively. Typically there are no bells, stained glass windows, crosses, images, or altars. What is more important to people—the religious building itself or the worship experience inside?" This mass-production approach to places of worship contrasts with the historical construction of churches, which, Vosko writes, typically involves "sacred elements" like pathways, which "move people from the outside world to the inner precincts where one may hope to find a sense of the sacred," and thresholds, which "mark the journey of the worshiper from the tedium of the everyday world into a more liminal state."

The ease with which Kim's family had assembled their own "big box" church, though, enabled her to, in 2011, boast to Piers Morgan about how she gives back, telling him, when pressed about her net worth, "Whatever it is, I give 10 percent away to the church and that's what I was taught. Every year. Absolutely." If churches are where faith is made tangible, the Kardashians

had built a Christian wing of their enterprise, simply by picking a multipurpose space where "imperfect people" (per the church's slogan, "No Perfect People Allowed") could gather. In 2023, TikTokers like Mrs. Dow Jones rediscovered and recycled this vintage Kardashian "tea," creating something of a micro-viral scandal cycle and raising awareness about the fact that religious institutions in America are exempt from federal, state, and local taxation. Users suggested that the Kardashian church was operating as a "tax haven" for the family, ensuring that the family's cash flow would stay within the system.

Christianity aesthetics have endured with the family's fame. Kris keeps "Lover of Christ" in the bio of her social media profiles. In 2018, Kim told *Vogue* that her family studied the Bible together every week. Her partner of nearly a decade, Kanye West, often declared himself a Christian man—loudest of all during his own public scandals—and, in early 2019, started his own fashion-forward "Sunday Services," which congregated in pastoral outdoor spaces and fused gospel and hip-hop. In 2015, Kim, Kanye, and Khloé went to Israel's oldest Armenian church to baptize North. Afterward, at their hotel, Kim and Khloé look out at Jerusalem from the balcony. "I just want to know where Jesus walked and take those paths," Kim says.

WRESTLING

However immersive *KUWTK* might have been, it was limited to two dimensions on-screen; few viewers would likely make it to California Community Church or the paths in Jerusalem that Jesus walked. It was only a matter of time—about one year into her reality show's run—before Kim Kardashian stepped into the real-life ring of one of the most profitable and well-known American storytelling institutions: World Wrestling Entertainment, which, according to its corporate website, partners with top media networks, from NBC Universal to Fox Sports, to reach more than one billion homes across twenty-five languages and 165 countries. Of course, the WWE comes with plenty of its own connections to Christianity. In 2006, WWE's chairman, Vince McMahon, faced off with "God": Addressing a

beam of light hovering over the ring's arrival path, he booms, "This is not your house, this is mine!" The WWE megastar Shawn Michaels publicly became a born-again evangelical Christian, and, in 2017, WWE Studios (and Blumhouse Tilt) released a film based on his journey, which was, as Dan Mathewson writes in *Sacred Matters* magazine, only emblematic of the countless wrestling stars who contribute to "the booming industry of professional wrestler autobiographies, an informal sub-genre of Christian autobiographies…recount[ing] their journeys from wrestling stardom to salvation."

Scholars have applied the literary theorist Joseph Campbell's "monomyth," or the theory of the "hero's journey," as detailed in his tome *The Hero with a Thousand Faces,* to most forms of popular media, from biblical myths to autobiographies to professional wrestling itself. Campbell writes that the hero's journey is the narrative structure fundamental to most great stories because it reflects "the unconscious desires, fears and tensions that underlie the conscious patterns of human behavior." (The neuropsychology of storytelling has since been studied, revealing that well-told story arcs can induce dopamine, cortisol, and oxytocin responses in us.) Campbell's idea of narrative generally sees a main character being "called to adventure," facing obstacles, and then returning home transformed for the better—a sequence recycled and reused by the Kar-Jenners anytime they undergo plastic surgery, enduring physical suffering for a guaranteed transformation or "rebirth." The same arc appears in every episode of their TV show: Kim is invited to dance onstage with the Pussycat Dolls! But her bad eyesight makes it hard to learn the steps! So, with her family's help, she undergoes a medical procedure to improve her vision! Finally, Kim masters the steps and takes to the stage with confidence, as her family cheers her on!

In the big picture, too, the Kar-Jenners abide by this structure: Kim wants to be famous! But compared with Paris Hilton, she's a lowly wannabe! Yet with enough grit and enterprise she—along with her family—fulfills her American dream of becoming a cultural icon!

The simple, linear narrative structure of WWE conversion memoirs and the Kardashian narrative—tales of struggle and triumph—is common to both

media enterprises.

In March 2008, Kim, wearing a blue dress and her pre-Instagram face, hosted WrestleMania XXIV, which was the twenty-fourth annual pay-per-view event, to be purchased by more than a million people, grossing nearly $24 million in revenue, according to a press release (only a touch less than the previous year's, which had been headlined by the future president Donald Trump as he slammed around the ring with Vince McMahon in a "battle of the billionaires" that ended with a victorious Trump shaving McMahon's head). While explaining the structure for an upcoming WWE championship, Kim is interrupted by the tattooed and bleached-blond Mr. Kennedy, a popular "heel" (bad guy) played by Kenneth Anderson, who leans into her mic to announce his intentions to win. The most replayed part of the YouTube clip from this moment is at the end, when the scene physically escalates like in any good WWE match, with Mr. Kennedy lunging toward Kim to holler his name into her face.

The French literary theorist Roland Barthes explored the spectacle and narrative inherent to wrestling in his 1957 essay collection, *Mythologies,* which argues that pop culture semiotics can both create and reflect larger cultural myths, ranging over the 1953 film *Julius Caesar,* soap commercials, striptease, astrology, and Greta Garbo's face. This text laid the groundwork for the kind of cultural critique we seem to know and love in the social media age (analyses that my friend, the artist Pia Marchetti, has described as "smart about dumb, dumb about smart"). Barthes makes explicit an unspoken truth about wrestling matches: that their conflicts are both real and unreal, a matter of suspension of disbelief, also known in the American wrestling world as a rather postmodern phenomenon called kayfabe. Barthes, writing of French wrestling (which he says is more focused on moral quandaries than on the politicized identities of American wrestling), doesn't use that term—the origins of which are unknown—but he defines it just as well: "It no longer matters whether the passion is genuine or not. What the public wants is the image of passion, not passion itself." They want to see what Campbell would call the "ordeal," and Barthes, "the ancient myths of public Suffering and Humiliation: the cross and the pillory. It is as if the wrestler is crucified in

broad daylight and in the sight of all. I have heard it said of a wrestler stretched on the ground: 'He is dead, little Jesus, there, on the cross,' and these ironic words revealed the hidden roots of a spectacle which enacts the exact gestures of the most ancient purifications."

In other words, this high drama of winners and losers follows a very, very old human narrative tradition rooted in our craving for catharsis. But here's the important part: "A wrestler…never disappoints, for he always accomplishes completely, by a progressive solidification of signs, what the public expects of him." The "heels" (bad guys) and "faces" (good guys), the image of a prim and polite Kim Kardashian giggling while being screamed at by a big, muscled man, or Donald Trump lurching around in his signature suit, throwing Vince McMahon over a conference table—all of these performances *play out* everything that each person involved is supposed to represent in the service of our own gratification, and using spectacle and exaggeration to ensure "intelligibility," the resulting fantasies are almost like a cartoon come to life. If wrestling is so watchable thanks to its intelligibility—every appearance, utterance, and movement is so extreme that the point of the story cannot be misinterpreted—then the same can be said of many scenarios in *KUWTK*. When Kim's new boyfriend, Kris Humphries, tosses her into the ocean in Bora Bora, and then she realizes her diamond earring is gone, she is hysterical with grief. "Kim, there's people that are dying," her sister Kourtney drones as the camera zooms in on Kim's crying face. Kim's Crying Face would become another meme both within the show and across social media, and with every sob Kim conjures the sensibility of a wrestler, who, Barthes writes, "as on the stage in antiquity…is not ashamed of [his] suffering" and "has a liking for tears." Tears, a visual representation of something internal, transform the scenario into a far more intelligible meme, or drama, or myth.

As the family's fame grew, the more WWE-like their storylines became. Other critics have applied professional wrestling to pop culture by comparing Kanye and Kim's feud with Taylor Swift to superhyped kayfabe wrestling rivalries, but I find the intra-family Kar-Jenner conflicts to be the most demonstrative of the concept, because they happen within the safe "ring" of

the family name. In season 18 of *KUWTK,* Kourtney and Kim, while lounging around at Khloé's house, get into a tiff over work ethic that somehow turns into hand-to-hand struggling. "Don't ever come at me like that," Kim warns Kourtney. "I swear to God I'll punch you in the face." When Kourtney goads her to "do it already," it becomes a full-blown fistfight, forcing Khloé to referee and, later, clean their makeup off her walls. Kourtney and Kim's rivalry had long functioned as one of the series' primary storylines, but this incident was extra memorable because it had gotten physical. In 2015, Kim and Kourtney fought because Kourtney was reluctant to share her likeness for a character in Kim's video game, *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood,* and almost every year that followed, they engaged in some new arbitrary but vicious battle.

The fact that in some shots during the 2020 fight scene it looked as though the women were giggling as they grappled only added a layer of "real or staged?" uncanniness to the spectacle, hardly the first time such an effect had been elicited by a Kim and Kourtney conflict. In 2018, after they had clashed over logistics for a Christmas card photo shoot, Kim declared Kourtney to be the family's "least exciting to look at." In anticipation of that episode's debut, the sisters brought their fight over to Twitter. "We all have different priorities. Mine is being a mother," Kourtney tweeted, earning fifty-four thousand "likes"—but not without using the hashtag KUWTK to promote the show. Kim responded, "And mine is not? The shoot was with our kids!!!!! My #1 priority is being a mother as well and I can work too, so can you!" As fans began chiming in with their takes on the complexities of sister relationships, coworking dynamics, which sister was coming off as more spoiled, and what they would do in the situation—and the sisters responded to or retweeted them—*Glamour* reported on the uncanny interaction with the headline "The Kardashian Sisters Are Fighting on Twitter, and People Think Kris Staged It." The mystery of what living in a perpetual state of kayfabe must *feel* like is much of what compels me to keep up with the family's content. The TV show "is our therapy," Kim has claimed more than once. It's true that they get to surveil their most performative and authentic moments at a scope the rest of us have no access to, and perhaps they find catharsis in replaying conflicts and

staging resolutions. Once, for fifteen minutes, I experienced a version of this process. During my early twenties, when my sister and I were moving out of our shared Brooklyn apartment, we hired a mover to help—some NYU kid making extra money over the summer. After he caught sight of our bong, we allowed friendly jokes about weed to grow too familiar, and when the packing job was done, he plopped on our couch and lit a joint, expecting that we'd all hang out. We felt too guilty about having led him on with our friendliness to ask him to leave. In the back of every woman's mind is safety—*he knows where I live*—but maybe most of all looms the great female fear of seeming rude. After shuffling into the hallway for a stolen moment of privacy, we decided to stage a spat to tell him without telling him that it was time to go. I forget what we fought about; all I remember is that we started off stifling laughs, and then halfway through, our performances began to feel more real. We paused and held eye contact, searching for confirmation that the other wasn't really mad. It took the kid a while to get the hint, and the longer he gawked at us, the harder we felt obligated to fight, and the more unclear our reality became. Finally, he stood up and said, "I was hoping to hang out with you girls, but I'll let you sort your issues out." Freed from our problem, we were exhausted, forced to process how much of that had been a matter of problem solving, and how much had brought up our real baggage. It was intense, and it must require a kind of Olympian emotional athleticism to do it all the time. But the fact that any onlooker of the Kardashian spectacle can tell it entails some mix of the real and the staged contributes to the family's stigma for being duplicitous—an extension of a skill set that has cartoonishly characterized women throughout time: "feminine wiles," or a woman's use of charisma and truth stretching for manipulative purposes, which are arguably honed through a woman's awareness of her own perpetual objectification and physical vulnerability. My point is that criticism of Kardashian kayfabe might be a bit gendered, while when it comes to wrestling, many fans are grateful to be entertained.

One of the WWE's greatest memes comes from a fan named David Wills who, during a 2005 wrestling event's Q&A, stood up to tearfully tell his wrestling heroes, "I just want to thank each and every one of y'all for all

you've done to your bodies—it's still real to me, dammit!" He understood, like Barthes, that wrestling was both fake and real, and the performer's body served as a medium between the two poles. In a paper titled after Wills's quotation, the humanities scholar Brian Jansen explores the ways the WWE "benefits financially from the genuine violence its performers enact on their bodies in the act of performing 'fake' violence while disavowing responsibility for long-term health consequences of that violence." He highlights the fact that WWE performers, responsible for their own training and costumes, are independent contractors, which relieves the conglomerate of liability for anything that may go wrong, and a quick visit to the Wikipedia entry for "botch," the wrestling term for "to fail in attempting a scripted move or spoken line by mistake, miscalculation, or an error in judgment," reveals some jarring injuries. We may never know whether Kar-Jenner conflicts, however trumped up for the camera, have caused any kind of actual emotional injury between the women. All we know for sure is that reality TV, professional wrestling, and Kar-Jenner industries have billions of dollars running through them because humans crave to watch heroes and villains fight it out. And that displays of such stories have made certain personalities, whether interpreted as heroic or villainous, so viral that they could eventually become president. (Jansen also points out that the WWE was "reported in 2017 to be the single largest donor to the Trump Foundation.") As for the Kar-Jenner clan, they have yet to botch their own kayfabe. To conclude the sisters' messy and uncanny Twitter matchup, Kim made sure to tweet, "Dont ever get it twisted, me, Kourtney and Khloé are GOOD! ALWAYS!!!! Never question that!"

LAS VEGAS

Continuing to walk their successful televisual brand out into the real world, the Kardashians opened their first retail store, Kardashian Khaos, at the Mirage Hotel and Casino in Las Vegas in November 2011. Vegas had already played a cameo role in multiple Kardashian moments within their short years of newfound fame. In 2008, Kim performed with the Pussycat Dolls cabaret

at PURE nightclub in Caesars Palace; in 2010, a high-drama *KUWTK* episode showed Scott Disick, Kourtney's loose-cannon boyfriend, getting too drunk at a steak house and stuffing a $100 bill into a waiter's mouth. (Most early *KUWTK* episodes that take place in Sin City feature Scott, who jokingly branded himself "Lord Disick" and whose substance abuse issues had a way of shattering the matriarchy's meticulously produced kayfabe.)

Kardashian Khaos sold all the trinkets you'd find at any Vegas souvenir shop—shot glasses, card decks, key chains, and T-shirts—all stamped with photos of the family's faces or the name "Kardashian." The family would, within a decade, become known for their e-commerce beauty and clothing brands, which they used their reality show and social media pages to promote, but in these years it was reasonable to experiment with brick-and-mortar stores as well. Even Amazon opened a physical bookstore in Seattle in 2015. Studies proved that during this era, consumers were content to move between online and in-person shopping, many of them even preferring to touch items to make their decisions. Ultimately, though, price was the deciding factor, and this period could be seen as the final porous stage between the analog and the digital eras for retail. Kim was striking her best balance between hyper-visibility in older popular forms like celebrity news, magazine covers, reality TV, and, for the previous two years, on Twitter, while also stepping out into the "real world" for club appearances and product events—including the debut of her first wax figure for Madame Tussauds in 2010.

Out of thirty-two Yelp reviews, Kardashian Khaos earned an average of only two stars. One critic, disappointed at the hefty fee to enter while Khloé was inside, wrote, "Now I can see how they got the huge family empire. I guess I'll just stick to seeing them on TV where it's free." Despite this sour reception, Kardashian Khaos survived for three years—a not-terrible tenure given Las Vegas's typically brisk business turnover thanks to the unending arms race there between real estate developers, a race that had evolved Vegas from a one-stop Wild West watering hole in the 1930s into an iconic neon simulacrum worth billions of dollars.

The word "simulacrum" emerged from the Latin word *simulare,* which means "to make like," and was popularized when the philosopher Jean

Baudrillard published his dense classic, *Simulacra and Simulation,* in 1981. Building upon Guy Debord's notions of "spectacle" as a stand-in for real life, he also incorporates a Jorge Luis Borges thought experiment that depicts a drawing of a map that becomes so massive it becomes a territory unto itself. The term "simulacrum" had another resurgence in popularity in 1999, when the Wachowski sisters cited Baudrillard's book as their inspiration for their blockbuster hit *The Matrix* (even showing one of the film's heroes, Neo, using a hollowed-out copy of the book as a hiding place for computer files). Baudrillard felt *The Matrix* was too literal an interpretation of his argument, and instead praised *The Truman Show,* a 1998 film that explored the "growing indistinction between the real and the virtual" by introducing an Everyman character who discovers that he is being constantly surveilled without consent for a nonstop, globally broadcast reality TV show. Truman's reality was a world-within-a-world with performances by covert actors, planned storylines, and the subtle branded advertising of every item he used (in other words, all representations that had come in from the world outside his own). That, Baudrillard explained, is a simulacrum: "no longer a question of imitation, nor duplication, nor even parody. It is a question of substituting the signs of the real for the real." Kim perfectly defined the notion of simulacrum when asked, in a 2019 home tour video for *Vogue,* how she "keep[s] it real for the family, in sometimes unreal surroundings": "We always keep it real, and there's really no real situations."

Simulations, according to Baudrillard, occur when all the elements of something we can collectively recognize are used to manifest a reality that is not "real," but hyperreal (like, say, Kim Kardashian as a wax figure, complete with butt and phone). He uses the example of a "fake holdup" to describe the way an accumulation of "signs" can create a liminal reality. If you go to a bank with a fake gun and a "trustworthy hostage," you may think you're merely acting, but that "network of artificial signs will become inextricably mixed up with real elements (a policeman will really fire on sight; a client of the bank will faint and die of a heart attack; one will actually pay you the phony ransom)." In other words, shit could get very (hyper)real, very fast. (Another example of the simulation's marriage of fake and real? The option

to take a real selfie with the phone held by Madame Tussauds's second, 2015, wax figure of Kim.)

Both simulation and simulacrum are, Baudrillard argues, conditions of the postmodern era. Of what he saw as America's exemplary simulacrum, Disneyland, he famously wrote that the Anaheim theme park "is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest is real, whereas all of Los Angeles and the America that surrounds it are no longer real, but belong to the hyperreal order and to the order of simulation. It is no longer a question of a false representation of reality (ideology) but of concealing the fact that the real is no longer real." Disneyland is a fantastical world-within-a-world that exists for escapism, but it counts as a reality in its own right because, well, it is a *real* place to be—or at least hyperreal, because its construction was based on Disney's caricatured and exaggerated interpretations of reality. And so it is with Vegas—a city that fully owns its own consumer culture by referencing the rest of the world with super-visual signs that come together as a cartoon city built in three dimensions.

Stefan Al, architect and author of *The Strip: Las Vegas and the Architecture of the American Dream,* once posed it to me this way: "You have, more or less, twenty different resorts, right? And they are all competing. They are offering, fundamentally, the same thing: rooms, swimming pools, gambling, and now, increasingly, other things too—celebrity chefs, Broadway shows. So how can they compete when they are all offering the same things?" The answer is architecture. "It's the image [Vegas casinos] are creating—being the newest with the mostest. It was a unique condition that really led to this rapid turnover of imagery and styles."

And this is why Las Vegas is a great synonym for the colorful Kardashian simulacrum.

Just as the Venetian offers a fine romantic experience with its gondolas and gold-flecked ceiling murals; the Luxor, a sense of the ancient with its huge black pyramid and massive entrance sphinx; Circus Circus, raucous fun within a big tent; and the Wynn, upscale pastel impressionism, the Kardashians project their own brand archetypes: Kim is the girlboss with a caricatured hourglass figure; Kourtney, the organic queen, both in brand and

in the cosmetic curation of her body (in other words, her plastic surgery appears most "natural"); Kendall, the tomboy turned runway model, and so on. (Not to mention all that we've already learned from the art critic John Berger and his belief that glamour has much to do with "vague historical or poetic or moral references" from "cultural lessons half-learnt," which we can see in the array of referential casino concepts across the Strip, as well as most Kardashian advertising.) This archetypal assortment—both on the Strip and in Kar-Jenner content—provides the illusion of options. Are you more of an au naturel Kourt or a princessy Kim? Do you seek a (simulation of) refined European experience on your Vegas getaway, or to clown around?

Just as the Strip's colorful and diverse casinos are its main draw, it's also a given that, as in wrestling, the Kardashians' bodies are the power sources of their brand. They expose their bodies, update them, dress them, always in new and novel ways—a spectacle that kicks off public conversations. We pick the themed casino atmospheres in which we want to drink and gamble; we scrutinize the Kardashian body narratives that affirm or offend our own principles: *As purveyors of curves in an anorexic early '00s media landscape, should the Kardashians be credited with ushering in a new era of body diversity? Are Kim, Khloé, and Kylie's presumed Brazilian butt lifts acts of cultural appropriation?* (Another connection to the Vegas ethos: Casino concepts, in their efforts to democratize travel for the working and middle classes by centralizing caricatures of global nations onto the same strip, have never shied from commodifying culture.) *Do their suddenly shrunken behinds mean that a "skinny era" is nigh? Did Kim promote body toxicity by crash dieting to fit into the Marilyn dress for the 2022 Met Gala?* By "scraping" Kim's social media analytics, the Kardashian Data Koalition was even able to prove that Kim's body grabs engagement: Year after year, her most liked Instagram photos were all bikini shots.

And even this—our urge to tap that virtual heart button on one of Kim's photos (or comment something negative), or any of the buttons on the colorful interface of *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood,* or to refresh our own feeds as we await "likes" on *our* photos—is Vegas-like, ensuring our immersion within the simulacrum. The cultural anthropologist Natasha Dow Schüll,

author of *Addiction by Design: Machine Gambling in Las Vegas,* explains the psychology of slot machines this way: "In jargon, it's called intermittent variable ratio…. If pigeons knew that they were going to get water every ten pulls [of a lever], they'd pull ten times, drink the water, leave, and put it out of their minds. But when you don't know when the water or the treat or the jackpot is coming down out of the hopper, it's much more compelling—and it actually blocks out everything else around us and you just stay there pulling the lever." Similarly, Schüll points out, when caught up in a cycle of "doomscrolling," we lose our sense of space and time and are sucked into the screen.

"You can say the same thing about social media and especially these kinds of 'Kardashian-like' accounts," she continued, speaking to the notorious "influencer" culture that proliferated throughout the 2010s. "Famous people are on an 'intermittent variable ratio' schedule, plopping out into the world updates about themselves—you don't know what's gonna hit and what's gonna land and what's gonna produce that jackpot excitement in you."

A Kardashian "jackpot" comes in the form of their unpredictable but always extreme narrative cycles; they often make viral impact, even though we tend to forget about that part as soon as the media coverage has passed. There were the headlines throughout the 2010s about how Kim was earning six figures for her club appearances at Vegas clubs like Tao; her oiled-up, nude "Break the Internet" *PAPER* magazine cover, which really did nearly crash the fashion rag's website in 2014; her viral Marilyn Monroe cosplay at the 2022 Met Gala; the time when the sad-girl pop star Lana Del Rey was unexpectedly featured in the 2024 SKIMS Valentine's Day campaign, earning the brand $13.7 million in impact revenue in four days.

Because there are *so many* Kar-Jenners, and because of the scale of their privilege and access, and the uncanny intensity of their appearances, and the wide range of mediums on which their narratives are broadcast, and the scope of their social networks, their updates always seem so *big* in proportion to our own daily dramas. Just like Las Vegas. The Strip's casinos are massive, mimicking the larger simulacrum that is Vegas by being veritable "mini cities" that you never need to leave if you don't want to. As Lawrence E.

Mintz put it in an essay for *American Icons,* "Bulk adds to the spectacle, a reason to visit and talk about the trip. Size also adds to the sense of the space as special, as extraordinary."

In its size, in its tangible exaggerations, Las Vegas is indeed "hyperreal." Of the casino New York–New York, Stefan Al writes, "It was based on the image of the city as it existed in the popular imagination…. All of the city's iconic buildings were pasted together in a pastiche scene that could never actually be photographed in New York. However, the resort's skyline looked more impressive and 'real' than the Manhattan skyline." The real city had been "Disneyfied…into a cartoon-character, or rather, a caricature of itself—like drawing a Mickey from a mouse."

Al argues that drawing the mouse from Mickey began with Steve Wynn, when, in 1989, allegedly inspired by a "vision," he built the Mirage, future home to Kardashian Khaos and "the first themed megaresort on the Strip, breaking a silence of 17 years of new resort construction," featuring a tropical aquarium, an indoor rainforest, a dolphin habitat, and a live erupting volcano.

Wynn often cited Walt Disney as a personal hero throughout his years of ushering in what Stefan Al has coined the "Disneyfication of Las Vegas," exemplified most of all by the 1993 construction of Treasure Island, which was "in direct competition with Disney," and by the appropriation of the last ride Walt Disney himself had ever designed, Pirates of the Caribbean—complete with a big ship built out front and an interior filled with workers dressed as pirates.

"What is specific about this design method," Al explains, "is that it is centered around 'storytelling'—a disciplinary crossover from Disney's movies. All elements of the resort were subjected to a single defining narrative, the central theme, and needed to communicate part of the story." The story had two functions: to directly dictate the story of the resort to the public, no guesswork required, and to function as "the 'mission statement' that mediated all aspects and phases of the design process, from space planning to exterior and interior decorations."

No wonder the Kar-Jenners love to visit Las Vegas. Whenever they go there—to get married, or meet Cher, or sell their latest retail goods from a

pop-up shop, or be serenaded by a roller-skating Usher—stepping into the "real world" beyond their self-made TV universe, they're really walking into yet another story.

THE TRUMAN SHOW

In February 2010, the *KUWTK* episode "Delivering Baby Mason" aired on E! It followed Kourtney's uncertainty about whether to allow her on-and-off-again boyfriend, Scott, into the delivery room after some recent crazy antics in Las Vegas. Eventually, she relented, and he joined her along with the rest of her family, passing around a camcorder to watch the first birth of their dynasty's next generation.

Any personal milestone aired on TV must be novel to ensure its memorability. *I Love Lucy* is credited with featuring the first televised pregnancy on a major network, though Lucy and Desi couldn't call it that due to the Code of Practices for Television Broadcasters. Pregnancy was, apparently, "sexually suggestive." Instead, the episode wherein Lucy tells Ricky her news is titled "Lucy Is Enceinte," the French word for pregnant, and in all following episodes she was referred to as "expecting." Perhaps as interesting as the feminist-coded refusal to hide Lucille Ball's pregnancy is Desilu's refusal to break their sitcom family's kayfabe. Ball even scheduled her C-section to occur on the same day her delivery episode aired (and was watched by forty-four million people).

In *KUWTK,* Kourtney pulled Mason out of herself with her bare hands. That was enough to make headlines, with CNN pundits debating whether it was "great TV, or too much for me," and Redditors continuing to discuss the scene years later: "She did not make a sound and literally pulled him out of her own vagina like it was nothing," a user named altitudious wrote admiringly.

Kourtney had pulled Mason out of her body and into her family's simulacrum—and, though he didn't know it yet, into a panopticon, where every action they took and product they sold was self-reflexive, and even the most intimate acts were subject to global broadcast. The "panopticon," its

name derived from the Greek word *panoptes,* or "all-seeing," was a theoretical prison design created by the eighteenth-century English utilitarian philosopher Jeremy Bentham, who believed that a circular structure enabling one guard to oversee all the inmates from a central tower would create a "sentiment of invisible omnipresence," because no inmate would know at any given time whether they were being watched. In 1975, writing *Discipline and Punish,* Michel Foucault argued that such a design could be viewed as a metaphor for larger power dynamics in a society that was moving from less overt (public executions) to more covert (surveillance) methods of, well, discipline and punishment. He called the panopticon a "machine for dissociating the see/being seen dyad," and added that its surveillance was "permanent in its effects, even if it is discontinuous in its action." In other words? The prisoners become their own guards. Over time, media theorists began applying the panopticon to reality TV and social media, suggesting that we are all bound to internalize the cameras and data tracking and public callouts that life online entails, which only begs the question of what kind of self-surveillant consciousness the Kar-Jenners have developed over the years. Marshall McLuhan has written of the way media envelops all our lives: "One thing about which fish know exactly nothing is water, since they have no anti-environment which would enable them to perceive the element they live in." From birth, the Kar-Jenner kids were fish that did not know they were in water.

A year later, Scott and Kourtney announced that baby Mason would not be featured in the family's spin-off show, *Kourtney and Kim Take New York*. In truth, the Disick children's absence from the public eye would be inconsistent; Mason appeared on the show again, and his younger sister Penelope's birth would also be featured on *KUWTK* in 2012 (a delivery that Kourtney again manually assisted).

Mason, and all the Kar-Jenner kids who followed, were not the first children to enter a self-contained yet hyper-public existence from birth (though they did set a precedent for the multibillion-dollar "momfluencer" industry growing on Instagram alongside their early childhood years). They had a fictional precedent in *The Truman Show,* the 1998 blockbuster that

earned Jean Baudrillard's approval. Jim Carrey stars as Truman Burbank—modeled by Carrey after his own father—a chipper Everyman who lives with his nurse wife on a picture-perfect island, Seahaven ("Voted Planet's Best Town," reads a front-page headline in the local paper). After losing his dad to a sailing accident in childhood, Truman is afflicted by an abiding water phobia that confines him to the island, safe from the revelation that the town really exists within a massive dome nested above the Hollywood sign: Since birth, he's been under twenty-four-hour surveillance, his life and all its milestones broadcast across the world as a TV show that teems with product placement, and all the people he knows are really actors trained to provoke from him optimal content for the consumption of the masses. Sound familiar?

It's tempting to compare Seahaven to Calabasas, the pristine and insular California valley where the Kardashian compounds are located. It's as tempting to talk about how Truman's hyper-mediated and commercialized life—his wife interrupts a disagreement to hold up some cocoa mix and sing its praises to an unseen camera—predicted influencer culture. "It's ironic that Truman was running from cameras," the film's writer, Andrew Niccol, told *Vanity Fair* in 2018, "and our society is running toward them." Christof, the control-freak showrunner played by Ed Harris, obviously *is* the Kardashians. Like any good evil genius, Christof was seemingly shaped by something dark that went down in his past. He tells a "Free Truman" protester, "The world, the place you live in, is the sick place. Seahaven is the way the world should be." Perhaps an event from the Kardashians' pre-fame past—their father's early death; the violence and unprecedented publicity storm around the O.J. trial—convinced the family that their kids would be just fine living under incessant surveillance.

Around the time of Mason's birth, moving into the 2010s, public discourse about government surveillance was intensifying. Ever since the 9/11-catalyzed introduction of the USA Patriot Act, the Bush administration worked to normalize wiretapping and other forms of surveillance, presented as a form of protection from foreign attack. In 2006, *USA Today* revealed that three major phone companies—AT&T, Verizon, and BellSouth—had been collecting the data of "tens of millions of Americans." The Patriot Act was

expanded throughout Obama's administration. It was in this climate that reality TV and social media began to boom, and as Big Tech continuously developed the imperatives to translate the "human experience…into behavioral data," as Shoshana Zuboff explained to *New York* in 2019, the industry was "creating predictive knowledge out of that and they're selling that predictive knowledge." The idea was that data collection could make our online experiences more customized. "But they're selling it to others, not to us," she added. "So it's knowledge about us but not for us." The essential question of the postmodern world: When does surveillance cease to keep us safe and instead strip away our defenses?

In *The Truman Show,* Christof casts a tender gaze upon his Truman, even as Truman becomes more and more enraged by the conditions of his life. Truman, like the Kar-Jenner matriarchy—forever grieving Robert Kardashian Sr.—is fatherless, having watched his dad "die" in a sailing accident. Once he begins to question his reality, Christof brings his father back to try to keep Truman on the island (resulting in a heartwarming reunion narrative that delights the viewers). And while Christof clearly cares for Truman in his own way, he keeps the fans of his show top of mind, almost as though they were extensions of Truman's family, and he, theirs. During an interview about his project, Christof notes proudly, "We find many viewers leave him on all night for comfort."

Sometimes it seems as though cameras serve as a supplement to the absence of Robert Sr., whose memory is at times invoked as an all-seeing eye (when Kim becomes too much of a diva, her brother, Robert Jr., reminds her that their dad wouldn't approve).

Maybe the family finds some comfort in the sense of ceaseless visibility to an unseen viewer. For a People.com "guest blogger" post after Mason's birth, Kourtney wrote, "I do wish that my father and Mason had gotten to meet each other, but I know my dad is looking down on us and really does know Mason well." Even if he's not, the rest of us are.

During the last season of *KUWTK,* in an episode called "Keeping Up with the Kids," Kim Kardashian and Scott Disick sit outside together, watching their scampering offspring. By this point, Scott has largely cleaned up his act

and proven himself to be a stable and loving father figure to the three children that he and Kourtney co-parent. Shaking his head, he at last puts into words the most distressing subtext of the family's relentless self-documentation project: that the existence of the dynasty's progeny is "basically *The Truman Show*. They were born in front of cameras." The rest of the episode is spent allowing the kids to take the cameras into their own hands, filming from the inside of their fishbowl.

RITUAL

Today, when you stream the "Kim's Fairytale Wedding" episode, it opens with a disclaimer: "On October 31, 2011, Kim Kardashian filed for divorce from Kris Humphries." The two-part wedding special, which aired on October 9 and 10, became the Kardashians' biggest scandal since Kim and Ray J's leaked sex tape in 2007 (and Kim's filing on a holiday, a typical strategy for her family, cannily connected a life milestone to a memorable date).

Following a brief courtship with the New Jersey Nets forward Kris Humphries, Kim began planning a wedding that was reportedly worth $10 million. Setting a precedent for the "influencer economy" only a few years away from booming on Instagram, the couple "struck deals with several companies and media outlets that offset the costs," including selling exclusive wedding photos to *People* for $1.5 million, and in the end "everything from Kardashian's 20.5 carat wedding ring (worth $2 million), day-of hair ($150,000) and Lehr & Black crystal-embellished invitations ($10,000)" was "received via discount (or just for free)." By this point, Kim was no stranger to big paydays. She'd become known for making six figures for a Las Vegas club cameo, and in 2010 a *New York Times* feature titled "Kim Kardashian Inc." reported on the mayhem that ensued in New York City's SoHo neighborhood when she arrived to sign autographs in honor of her jewelry line with the brand Bebe (some residents, annoyed by the "mob of fans," called 911). "Ms. Kardashian herself has represented many other products in advertisements," the article points out, "including some that a reasonable

person might consider to be sending mixed messages. In one ad she promotes QuickTrim weight-loss products; in another, Carl's Jr." When fans in line were asked what she represented to them, one young woman answered, "the average girl." Another said they appreciated her "ethnic sex appeal"; another, that she was "natural and curvaceous," a paragon of approachable beauty in contrast to the "thin celebrities out there who make women feel they are overweight." With Kim as a certified Everywoman, her participation in a fairy tale would be even more irresistible.

In the aftermath of both episodes—in which Khloé encouraged Kim to emulate Disney iconography for her wedding theme, Kris Jenner underwent a facelift, and Kim and her husband-to-be endlessly bickered—news outlets like *Deadline* reported that the episodes combined "drew 10.5 million viewers, ranking as the network's most-watched event to date." The fact that so many people tuned in to this television event was not, as *The Hollywood Reporter* put it, "unusual for the Kardashians," whose fifth-season premiere was viewed by nearly five million people, but it did have special resonance because it was a ceremony: a wedding, something "every little girl dreams of," as Kim and Kris Humphries and Kris Jenner routinely claim in the episode—and such rituals come with their own media legacy of capturing collective attention. As Marshall McLuhan wrote of John F. Kennedy's funeral, which was covered live by all major news stations and seen by almost every television owner in the country, it "proved the power of television to… involve an entire population in a ritual process." (And just think of the staggering viewership rates of any given royal wedding. As Chris Rojek wrote in *Celebrity,* "Research into collective memory and the British royal family has found that royal events like births, marriages and deaths provided frames for the recollection of personal experience…. People may be openly cynical about the royal family…. None the less, it remains culturally significant that collective memory is influenced by celebrity history, so that *temps perdu* in personal biography are recalled by reference to external events in celebrity history.")

An *SNL* sketch called "Kim's Fairy-Tale Divorce" aired the week following Kim's announcement, featuring punch lines about Kris Jenner's

obsession with youth, the Kardashian sisters' vocal fry, Kim's preference for dating Black men, the family's countless spin-off shows, and the smartphones that seem attached to their hands. The arc of the sketch, though, was about the family's relationship with publicity. "I know a lot of people think Kim got married to earn over $17 million from the wedding," says Kristen Wiig's Kris. "But that's not true—she also got married for attention."

FAMOUS FOR BEING FAMOUS

The high drama of it all surely satiated a public appetite that the media theorist Daniel J. Boorstin alluded to in his JFK-inspired indictment of modern media, *The Image: A Guide to Pseudo-Events in America.* Writing in 1962, Boorstin saw America in the throes of a cultural decline due to the graphic revolution—a transition from print to images, brought about in the late nineteenth century by the efficiency of the telegraph and printing press, which encouraged newspapers to seek more and more news to report on—and the improved technology of printing, which allowed photos to replace long-form text over time.

Image-driven news sensationalism led to what Boorstin has called "extravagant expectations" in American media consumers—both "of what the world holds" ("of how much news there is, how many heroes there are, how often masterpieces are made, how exotic the nearby can be, how familiar the exotic can become") and "of our power to shape the world" ("of our ability to create events where there are none, to make heroes where they don't exist, to be somewhere else when we haven't left home").

It wasn't only the content of Kim's seventy-two-day marriage that soaked up attention—the opulence of the ritual and its subsequent failure, which satisfied the ideas both that "fairy tales" can be made real and that everything seen in the media is a full-on conspiracy—but the numbers surrounding it.

When, in the months following the airing of "Kim's Fairytale Wedding," the family's spin-off show *Kourtney and Kim Take New York*—which documented the brief marriage—debuted, "preliminary ratings show[ed] that the series topped all previous openers, attracting just shy of 3.2 million total

viewers during its broadcast," proving, according to *The Hollywood Reporter,* viewers' interest in the "on-air dissolution" of the marriage. Boorstin might say that Kim's seventy-two-day marriage is famous at least in part due to the massive numbers associated with it. We associate the now-colloquial term "famous for being famous" with socialites like Paris Hilton, and accept that the rationale behind their renown is somewhat circular in nature. But a longer look at what Boorstin called "*a person who is known for his well-knownness*" shows us that it's the hype of someone's, well, hype that can cultivate such an ouroboros. (The other benefit of drawing such attention to numbers and records is posterity: Loud headlines about the family's hype make it much easier for people like me to track the family's growth and relevance, which is often contested by Kardashian skeptics, and to confirm the family's in-progress cultural dominance.)

John F. Kennedy's father, Joe, often boasted of his son's ability to sell papers and sell out events. Explaining how Kennedy's reputation for *possessing* media savvy seemed to precede and benefit him, David Lubin invokes another quotation from *The Image* about Charles Lindbergh, the first man to fly alone across the Atlantic Ocean, whose achievement became a media sensation: "Of course it was remarkable to fly the ocean by oneself, but far more remarkable thus to dominate the news."

As the family's brand expanded, the Kar-Jenners relied more and more on publicity as its own publicity strategy. One of the first memes of Kim sprang from a moment on *KUWTK* when she gloated to her family about being the top-searched name on Google (Khloé laughed that it was because she was "googling herself"). When, in 2016, demand for Kylie Jenner's latest line of lip-centric makeup crashed her sales website, she documented the traffic surge on Snapchat and posted a selfie video saying, "I broke Google?" When Kim Kardashian released SKIMS in 2019, headlines proliferated about how it had sold out in its first day. When, in 2020, the family took their TV show over to Hulu, most media coverage of the move emphasized that this had occurred due to a nine-figure contract, and once it premiered, Disney announced to *Variety* that the show's debut was its most watched in America. The truth, though, is that the family was wise to this circular concept early. In

Kardashian Konfidential, writing of their use of their reality TV show as an advertising medium, they said, “We’re paving our way to a future of lasting success. That’s what smart businesswomen do. Even if they’re just in the business of pursuing their dreams.”

MUG SHOTS

In early seasons of *KUWTK,* keen eyes will catch the framed photos of Khloé’s grinning 2007 mug shot in both Kim’s and Kris’s homes (Kim’s is in her living room, Kris’s in her office). The first season episode on Khloé’s DUI arrest features the oft-memed scene of Kim taking selfies en route to deliver Khloé to her scheduled jail stint, prompting Kris to tell her, “Kim, would you stop taking pictures of yourself? Your sister is going to jail.” Though the mug shot (and selfie) were taken at a time when social media as we know it was still nascent—before the time of the now-ubiquitous square meme template and the Instagram self-portrait—the photo seemed to serve as its own intra-family meme, one that viewers could delight in noticing for years to come. Users on *KUWTK* Reddit boards still post screenshots of Khloé’s background cameos and praise the family for their ability to make fun of themselves.

As the art critic Jerry Saltz wrote of Donald Trump’s instantly iconic 2023 mug shot, “The mug shot does not reveal a person’s essence; rather, it makes them seem criminal.” Celebrity glitz framed within a grim, streamlined square box creates a spectacle of contrast, and many American pop icons have starred in their own: Michael Jackson; Marilyn Monroe, though no one can confirm that hers is real; O.J.; Justin Bieber; Justin Timberlake; and, of course, Trump. Every time Paris or Lindsay ended up in yet another drug- or drinking-related arrest, the tabloids and news media exploited the fact that mug shots are public domain by announcing the images as breaking news, likely encouraging the eventual trend of posing or smiling for the shot, or even, as in Khloé’s case, prepping hair and makeup. (It only makes sense, the mug shot being some sort of campy badge of early ’00s tabloid relevance, that a Kardashian needed one of her own.)

A decade or so later, as nostalgia culture swept social media feeds, internet commenters would recirculate these images, calling Paris "iconic" for the way she'd utilized the clichés of her own brand during these incidents—telling the cops that there was no way the purse containing cocaine had been hers, for instance, because it was "too cheap." This was strange considering that by the 2020s, in a movement that the sociologist Musa al-Gharbi has termed the "Great Awokening," the American public had expanded its collective consciousness to subjects like the inequities of systemic incarceration, an issue Kim had happened to begin championing. Perhaps it was amusing for certain pop culture fans to see rich white girls smirking at the cops in 2010. In 2020, this blasé reaction is more surprising, especially considering mug shots come with so much stigma for everyone else—especially Black and brown people—that entire businesses have arisen around posting mug shots online and then soliciting payment for removal.

Various cultural, social, and legal events contributed to this climate of increased social justice awareness, one of which was the 2013 debut of *Orange Is the New Black*. A Netflix original series based on a memoir by Piper Kerman, it follows a well-to-do white woman who spends a year in federal prison for drug trafficking and money laundering and makes a diverse group of friends as she learns about the for-profit prison system and numerous precarities facing marginalized women. A review by Jessica Grose for *Slate* notes that the structure of the memoir followed a certain tradition: "*Orange Is the New Black* belongs in a different category, the middle-class-transgression genre. This genre also includes books from 'good girls' who become strippers, alcoholics, and dominatrixes. The tales of these well-educated women follow essentially the same narrative arc: Girl is bored, girl seeks titillating transgression, girl regrets, girl renounces prior misdeeds, girl lives happily ever after." Many critics agreed that the TV show "did better," while also ushering in a powerful new approach to TV.

As *The New York Times* put it in 2019, the show was "big in its reach (presumably, though actual viewing figures for Netflix series are still an occult mystery). Big in its influence, as one of the first genuinely original programs in the new medium of streaming. Big in its ambitions to represent faces and

situations that had been left off TV screens." (It also happened to star the bisexual actress Jackie Cruz, who'd made a 2009 appearance on the spin-off series *Kourtney & Kim Take Miami* as Kourtney's lesbian crush, costarring in a close-up make-out scene with Kourt.) *OITNB*—"a vast ensemble, composed of subgroups that break down into sub-subgroups—was a metaphor for Netflix, and the ways in which it was and wasn't like mass-media TV of the past. Like the old broadcast networks, it aimed to make TV for everyone. But like the niche cable channels, it didn't try to make each individual show appeal to everyone. It was macro and micro, a confederation rather than a monoculture."

This multiplicity inspired discourse from every imaginable angle: Why do people enjoy watching "caged women," as one 2018 anthology about the show asks? (The Kardashians, though, were nothing if not uncaged; Khloé's time in lockup, intended to be thirty days, lasted only three hours due to overcrowding.) Were the representations of marginalized groups exploitative or progressive, and did this mark the beginning of a new, bingeable method of watching TV? I never got into *House of Cards* or *Orange Is the New Black* or any of those early Netflix originals, but I can recall the zeal with which everyone I knew binged them the second they dropped, reemerging from weekends spent inside to tell others to check the show out, that all the episodes were "up." To be able to watch a whole new show in one go was a real novelty in 2013, perhaps our generation's gluttonous version of the paradigm-shifting experience of seeing a train in motion on-screen and thinking it would chug into the audience. *OITNB*'s opening credits also showed zoomed-in cuts of the cast's faces in an artsy and more dignifying take on the mug shot, which Jerry Saltz describes as "an unlovely subgenre of portraiture photography. It is the opposite of a self-portrait, which offers the maximum amount of agency."

The pre-operation cosmetic surgery photo is another unlovely subgenre, a kind of sister to the mug shot. You can't get plastic surgery without taking them—the "before" photos that will provide evidence of a glamorous transformation—and the process follows the same objectifying conventions of any mug shot: a snap from the front and two from the side, with the bonus of

two additional quarter turns for some cosmetic procedures. The family's appearances started to change in the 2010s—Kim's and Khloé's noses got smaller, jaws sharper, butts bigger—and, consequentially, rumors about their uses of plastic surgery were beginning to define the brand. After all, Kris documented her facelift journey in the "fairy-tale wedding" *KUWTK* episodes, even bringing cameras into the operating room, and another episode saw Kim visiting the family doctor for an X-ray of her butt to "prove" its authenticity. This straddling of the line between their right to patient privacy and their willingness to overshare teased the public's growing curiosity about —and sense of entitlement to—their bodies.

Through the years, Khloé's extra-plastic face would become one of the prevailing focuses of public fascination with the family's surgeries, and her criminal past also set her apart from her sisters. In fact, her stint in jail is why, in 2009, Donald Trump fired her from *The Apprentice,* telling her, "When you told me that [you had a DUI], I actually lost a little respect for you." In 2016, though, when Trump was running for president, several former show staffers leaked that his real issue had been Khloé's appearance: "Why don't we fire Khloe? She is a fat piglet. Why did we get the ugly Kardashian?"

Within ten years, the Kardashians' mysterious yet undeniable history with plastic surgery would become grist for a booming discourse, with YouTube essays watched by millions describing the harmful messages about body image the family has dealt to a generation of young women, demanding that the Kardashians be transparent about whatever they're doing to themselves. It's true that between the years 2000 and 2020 there was a 131 percent increase in plastic surgery procedures in the United States alone. But it is this kind of "accountability" the family can't turn into high camp. The fact is, the most photographed family in the world—willing to use their mug shots as home decor and, a year after *OITNB* came out, for throwback Instagram posts —has most certainly taken countless pre-op photos that we will never see.

Trump has also reappropriated the mug shot for his own purposes. After being arrested for racketeering and conspiracy in Atlanta, Georgia, amid his bid for the Republican ticket in the 2024 presidential election, Trump tweeted out his snarling 2023 mug shot and then began selling underdog-themed

merch (with “NEVER SURRENDER” emblazoned beneath the image on mugs, T-shirts, and posters). In one day of sales, his campaign made more than $4 million, and once he made his return to the White House in 2025, he took a cue from Kris Jenner’s office decor by hanging his own mug shot—framed in gold—just outside the Oval Office.

MEMES

It wasn’t long after the demise of Kim’s seventy-two-day marriage that she began stepping out with the megastar Kanye West, inspiring tons of tweets about how she was bound to become his “Yoko Ono,” a parasitic feminine counterpart sure to bring down his controversial but illustrious career. In 2008, Kanye brought Kim on to cameo as Princess Leia for a *Star Wars*–themed bit in his puppet-filled Comedy Central sketch show (which was ultimately scrapped), and he’d visited her at the New York location of her family’s clothing store, Dash, in a 2010 episode of *KUWTK*. As the couple’s self-spun mythology goes, upon hearing that his longtime pal—and crush—was finally single, Kanye invited her to his Paris fashion show. “He jokes that he put on this whole fashion show just to get a date with me. So I went there and I stayed with him, and that’s where we started dating. I swear from the moment I landed, I fell madly in love with him,” she said, meticulously minding the timeline of their courtship in another episode of *KUWTK*. It was inconvenient enough that her recent ex-husband was balking at signing the divorce papers, imposing a muddled start to the blossoming Kimye love story. Thus, the new couple “controlled the narrative” by producing a series of scenes that conveyed rebirth.

A 2012 *KUWTK* episode shows Kanye trashing all the tawdry, early ’00s contents of Kim’s closet so that he could begin styling her in his own, high-fashion-inspired image. “I think my style is just evolving and changing,” Kim explained, “and I think it should because that is what life is about.” Though obviously staged—Kim revealed about a decade later that every look she’d worn over the course of her public life had been not trashed but cataloged and stored in a massive closet archive—this episode functioned as it had likely

been intended: as a "turning point" marker in the larger "hero's journey" of the Kim K myth. When she interviewed me for NPR's *It's Been a Minute,* the cultural critic Brittany Luse cited the closet-clearing episode as Kim's most formative fame moment. It communicated the message clearly: Kim had upgraded her reality TV princess archetype to assume a new role as Kanye's muse and mannequin. It situated Kanye, too, as a legitimate enough visionary to take on a fashion muse. He'd been a self-described underdog in the fashion world, only recently making his way into the industry after years of voicing frustration about being pigeonholed solely as a rapper. The couple was engaged in October 2013, when Kanye took Kim to the center of San Francisco's baseball stadium and projected "Pleeease Marry Meee!!!" on the jumbotron. The irreverence of the scene (broadcast, of course, on *KUWTK*) is exemplary of their overall tone during this time: Kanye was well known for his absurd sense of humor, and Kim was tweeting stuff like "Thanks guys! I had no idea a pickle was really a cucumber! U guys totally confirmed it!" and "I like the feeling of having buttons to press, not just a touch screen."

Earlier, in May 2013: A very pregnant Kim Kardashian had turned up at the punk-themed Met Gala as Kanye's plus-one, wearing a floral Givenchy dress that became the subject of countless memes across Instagram, which had launched in 2010 and was acquired by Facebook in 2012. Kim joined in 2012, and the platform had reached 100 million monthly users by the spring of 2013. "It was a big night for Kim," ABC News reported the next day. "And she let us know that through Instagram. The girl uploaded a new picture every 15 minutes…. [W]e're glad she had a good time, even if she looked like a thrift shop sofa."

Know Your Meme, an online user-edited encyclopedia that identifies the origins of memes, claims that the "couch" joke began on Reddit, where the user curiouslizzie posted a photo of Met Gala Kim next to one of her boyfriend sleeping on a thrifted-looking sofa with the caption "caught my boyfriend sleeping with Kim Kardashian." The joke began circulating across Twitter and Instagram and, if ABC is any indication, news media as well.

The year of Kim's couch dress, Limor Shifman published *Memes in Digital Culture,* defining memes—as many theorists do—in terms of the

biologist Richard Dawkins's assertion that they are "small cultural units of transmission, analogous to genes, that spread from person to person by copying or imitation," situating viral YouTube dance trends like "Gangnam Style" as examples and arguing that these silly little cultural transmitters can be "agents of globalization." Still, because most memes, especially during their cultural emergence, are made by unpaid social media users and internet artists, "adjusting memes is part of their pleasure," as the meme researcher Anastasia Denisova has said, empowering members of the masses to flex their creativity. The free exchange of memes is unregulated—inspiring endless discourses about whether the form is subversive and, more important, if memes can be copyrighted—so it's challenging to accurately track their official origins and routes of distribution. Suffice it to say, though, that the couch dress meme was everywhere.

As the meme made its algorithmic rounds, even Robin Williams jumped in, tweeting, "I think I wore it better!" and sharing a side-by-side comparison of Met Gala Kim and himself as the title character in *Mrs. Doubtfire,* clad in a stuffy floral suit dress. In 2019, Kim told *Vogue* that the tight dress intended for her pregnant body had "made her so insecure," especially because she knew "nobody wanted [her]" at the Met Gala. "I was crying, like, the whole way home because I just couldn't believe it," she said. "There were all these memes about me and this couch."

But Kim needn't be sad. Sure, some meme researchers have considered the possibility that the popularity of memes made to poke fun at someone is attributable to "superiority theory, endorsed by Descartes, where 'our laughter expresses feelings of superiority over other people or over a former state of ourselves.'" But being mocked by as top-tier a celebrity as Robin Williams was a good thing. As Daniel J. Boorstin once wrote, "Celebrities intensify their celebrity images simply by becoming widely known for relations among themselves. By a kind of symbiosis, celebrities live off one another." Williams gave Kim a chance to live a little off his iconic character. Plus, most important, the memes offered free marketing, plastering Kim's face across everyone's feeds, a shorter, faster, and tamer iteration of the career-making sex tape that had leaked nearly seven years before. If memes are "agents of

globalization," then Kim was covering vast ground overnight. This would become one of the main causes of public fascination with memes as their cultural relevance became undeniable: that they compressed information, tone, ideology, and more within a four-cornered, shareable template, and then could spread infinitely far, for theoretically infinite amounts of time. Future studies would also prove that however lame corporatized memes might seem, they still make for more effective advertising than straightforward ads, and even possess the power to inflame full-on political movements: The alt-right has embraced memes, and Donald Trump's meme-ability has proven to be a prime political asset. Perhaps most of all, they indicate our unstoppable shift from a text-based culture toward a visual one.

In Lauren Michele Jackson's meditation on "meme death" for *The Atlantic,* she reflects on the 2012 ROFLCon, where 4chan's founder, Christopher "moot" Poole, worried about memes, once belonging to the domain of internet message boards, "going mainstream," especially as social media platforms continued to multiply and accelerate. "While internet memes…remain alive and well, individual memes do seem to die off faster than in Poole's 'good ol' days,' " she writes. "But if overexposure is partially to blame for their demise, it certainly doesn't tell the whole story." She considers the requisite Dawkins theory of memes as iterative cultural genes, which the communications scholar Alice Marwick called the "blur[ring] of lines between metaphor and biology," and weighs instead the function of memes as the internet's inside jokes.

The thing about jokes—the ones that spread across culture and endure, at least—is that they usually do reflect some sort of larger cultural anxiety or social context. Jackson points out the history of the "lightbulb joke," which spread through the 1960s and 1970s and was "one means to thinly veil prejudices, using the joke as an outlet for anxieties about the civil-rights legislation achieved in the '60s, and carried out in the '70s and beyond. Hence most lightbulb jokes, even when they don't cross ethnic or racial lines, tend to be a comment on some social, cultural, or economic position—'How many sorority girls does it take to change a lightbulb?' et al." The same goes for memes, she writes. (And, she wisely adds, just like explaining a joke,

"naming the meme" often kills it.) She cites the alt-right's reappropriation of the Pepe the Frog meme during the 2016 election because its users seemed to like its "male millennial grotesquerie" aesthetic, and the endurance of the "expanding brain" meme, "which mocks the infinite levels of intellectual one-upmanship common to any and all online discussions…exactly what's called for in this post-truth moment where everyone is a pundit."

Kim's most popular memes have followed an arc reflective of her career and, therefore, can also probably tell us something about culture at that time. In 2007, Kris Jenner told Kim, "You're doing amazing, sweetie!" and "Stop taking pictures of yourself, your sister's going to jail," moments that spotlighted female vanity at the helm of a new new media age. These scenes went viral in the form of screenshots circulated on Tumblr, Facebook, and message boards. The couch dress phenomenon is an example of a classic meme that mocked Kim, as the public attempted to preserve powerful institutions (as the Kardashian Kolloquium reader @chloedarling put it on Instagram, "policing who gets to be at the met ball by people who are also not at the met ball"). Skipping ahead exactly a decade, when post-pandemic America was churning with class rage, a series of ridiculous but true news stories about the billionaire Kim's opulent pop-culture-themed auction purchases (a necklace worn by Princess Diana; Michael Jackson's "Smooth Criminal" fedora) resulted in a phony news-report meme format—for example, the Twitter user @portsidesully's "Kim Kardashian has reportedly purchased Osama Bin Laden's AK and iconic green camo jacket for 22.5 million." Over the course of a decade, the evolution of these memes—from TV show screenshots to the tabloid-esque "compare and contrast" panels to a semi-believable and therefore hyperreal Twitter announcement—follows the evolution of what Jackson and other critics have termed the "post-truth" era of the 2020s.

In the years between, though—when Instagram was perpetuating a culture of self-documentation, self-curation, self-commodification, and self-promotion—Kim memes utilized her face or body as the context for some relatable personal disclosure. Kim's Crying Face, Kim eagerly peeking out from behind bushes, Kim looking bored in bed—these images said something

about despair, desire, or malaise ("When you've just eaten lunch and you're already hungry again," "When you overhear your friends talking shit about the girl you always hated," "When you double texted and now waiting to hear back"). Just as catchphrases catch on due to the "universality" of their syntax, the universality of Kim's face made for its own utility. In fact, because memes are the digital art form of the citizens of the "global village," the Kim meme might have even been a way for social media users to reclaim her image—which had been famously, confusingly, annoyingly ubiquitous on E! and tabloid news media—for their own purposes, kind of in the way Guy Debord's 1950s crew of avant-garde artists, the Situationists, employed a method of resistance called *détournement* to reappropriate or recontextualize corporate slogans and images, whether through collages distributed as zines or real-life defacement of public ads.

Whether this reclamation of Kim's image was successfully subversive or not, Kim memes became an unacknowledged internet tradition (even people I know who identify as Kim haters have used a Kim meme at some time or another) that did scaffold the family's success. In 2018, for example, Kim posted a shot of herself splayed in a funny way while wearing Yeezy, Kanye's sneaker and fashion brand, setting off a firestorm of memes that photoshopped her pose into other funny scenarios (amid, for example, all the toys facing "the claw" in *Toy Story*) and providing organic advertising for the brand.

As Jackson writes, "Memes catch on when we need them most and retreat when they are no longer attuned to public sentiment." It may seem silly now to imagine applying your personal feelings to a photoshopped image of Kim with massive biceps, but the Kim meme, which encouraged the sharing of the self, brought us closer to the format of today: the self-meme. Video content is increasingly eclipsing photos and text; the distance between social media users and their preferred platforms continues to diminish. On TikTok, users film themselves lip-synching to viral sounds and using grabby editing techniques while overlaying the video with relatable text. We have ourselves become the willing memes, something Kim celebrates, too, in a 2022 episode

of *The Kardashians* when she revisits the site of her "peeking from bushes" meme.

Yes, as feared, memes, as we once knew them, have gone corporate. The Kar-Jenners were bound to realize how big a role they played in the image economy, and they increasingly seemed to construct situations to prompt the public. Kim might post a series of photos of herself, famous ass exposed in a tiny bikini bottom, doing cartwheels on the beach; Kylie might conclude an office tour with her daughter's playroom, flicking on the lights and singing "Rise and Shine" to Stormi in a silly way. The best example of this, though, was in another 2022 episode of *The Kardashians,* when Kendall Jenner clumsily attempted to cut a cucumber. It was an obvious bid for ridicule, and the public took the bait. I received many TikTok requests to "talk about" the moment, though there was not much to say besides the fact that Kendall was not in the habit of making her own sandwiches, which the family was willing to broadcast. Somehow the image went viral enough to earn its own entry in Know Your Meme. It even played a role in the family's partnership with Uber the following year: In a commercial for the rideshare brand, Kendall struggles to cut a cucumber, and Kris extols the fact that you can get "anything" on Uber Eats, telling her daughter, "Let's just get you a salad—and maybe put the knife down." The family's canny *use* of the moment for an Uber deal would have made a better meme—a meme about their now notorious ability to manufacture on-brand spectacles and monetize them.

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EVERYWOMAN (2013–2020)

Kim demonstrates—and monetizes—her Mickey Mouse–like pliability throughout the Instagram era.

Power Couples

About a month or so after Kimye's Met Gala meme, Kim Kardashian gave birth to their first child, North. Three days later, Kanye released his sixth studio album, *Yeezus,* to critical acclaim. Several months after the album's release, West debuted the music video for its finale, "Bound 2," which costarred Kim and was an instant joke online. According to some reports, "By the time that it had reached seven million views on YouTube, the music video's 13,000 likes were outbalanced by the 50,000 dislikes." The video showed Kanye on a motorbike traversing a hyperreal depiction of Monument Valley. In many shots, a topless, blond (and, like any good mannequin, nipple-less) Kim is straddling Kanye as the motorbike bumps along in an obvious simulation of sex as he pronounces that "one good girl is worth a thousand bitches." While the art critic Jerry Saltz remarked on the numerous influences identifiable in the "Bound 2" video—"Richard Prince's *Cowboy* photographs, American Romanticism, Celestial Seasonings packages, shampoo commercials, Iranian music videos, Thomas Kinkaid, beer ads, Jeff Koons, *The Onion,* Lars von Trier, the House of Fendi, and Jeffrey Deitch"—and decided that the video was ushering in "the New Uncanny," others found it "whack" (Charlamagne tha God) or used it as fodder for a viral parody (Seth Rogen and James Franco).

This odd couple certainly provided quality content in a meme-crazed social media landscape that felt new and fun, and they appeared to be aiming, together as artist and muse, to straddle the highbrow and the lowbrow with their "New Uncanny" approach. But Kim didn't really believe she'd be returning to the Met Gala, did she? By now an infamous producer of

Instagram selfies, she had been a mere plus-one to an *actual* twenty-one-time Grammy Award–winning *artist*. Plus, as an anonymous source assured Radar Online in 2012, "Anna hates Kim. Why would she be invited to the event?"

Then, like a sucker punch, in late March 2014, the Annie Leibovitz–shot April *Vogue* cover was announced online—headlined "Kim and Kanye: Their Fashionable Life and Surreal Times #worldsmosttalkedaboutcouple"—showing Kanye standing behind his fiancée, clutching her Lanvin wedding-gown-clad waist. "Well…I guess I'm cancelling my Vogue subscription. Who is with me???" tweeted *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* star Sarah Michelle Gellar, speaking for the hordes who lamented the cover and inspiring an Amy Larocca–penned op-ed for *The Cut* headlined "Why Are People Being Snobs About Kim Kardashian on the Cover of *Vogue*?"

"I see the role of *Vogue* to reflect what's going on in the culture," Wintour later explained, noting that the first non-model celebrity she put on the cover of *Vogue* had been Madonna in 1989. "It's such a long time ago probably no one remembers, but she was a very controversial figure. Now she's part of the establishment. I think if we just remain deeply tasteful and just put deeply tasteful people on the cover, it would be a rather boring magazine. Nobody would talk about us. It's very important that people do talk about us."

Not only did people talk—snickering on message boards about what had sounded like a backhanded compliment from Anna—but they also bought. The issue sold 500,000 copies in the month of its release, outselling the then–First Lady Michelle Obama's cover issue, which had moved 300,000. Did this prove Kanye's inflammatory point when, the previous year, he took a few jabs at the ultimate power couple—America's First Family? He'd told Angie Martinez in a radio interview that President Obama was "just trying to be cool" anytime he criticized Kim and Kanye as representations of misplaced American materialism—"the reason why Obama mention our names is because we're the most relevant"—and Ryan Seacrest that "Michelle Obama cannot Instagram a pic like what my girl Instagrammed the other day." As Larocca noted, this is perhaps why people were angry about seeing the viral couple on the cover of *Vogue,* which had been "historically…more about social class than about celebrity." "The thing that seems to arouse this streak

of puritanical self-righteousness," she added, "is the nakedness of the celebrity play. Whereas everyone else pretends that fame is a consequence of talent and style and beauty, Kardashian doesn't pretend. She has mastered the thing we have all been complicit in creating—she has mastered popular culture." It was a pop culture capable of eclipsing politics, even though control of the country rested with the coolest couple the White House had seen since the Kennedys. Worse, the Kimye *Vogue* cover was only the beginning of a decade-plus relationship with the publication—a downright Kennedy-esque setup, when you consider Jackie and John's reliance on *Life* magazine to maintain relevance.

John's first *Life* cover, as a Massachusetts senator in 1953, featured his future bride. The sun-kissed couple is shown laughing on a boat in Cape Cod, Jackie leaning slightly onto John, conveying, according to David Lubin, the "semiotics of female dependence and male independence." *Life* was one of the most popular magazines in the country, read by nearly fourteen million Americans, and would cover the Kennedy family at least twenty times from the 1950s into the 1970s. Jackie drew particular interest: In another cover with John in 1959, she was foregrounded, wearing a pink boat-necked sheath with her signature pearls and given the headline "A Front Runner's Appealing Wife."

The article celebrated Jackie's highbrow acculturation as a complement to John's Americana Everyman shtick, noting her preference for privacy, her formative study-abroad year at the Sorbonne in Paris, and the time she helped him after he lost his notes for an upcoming speech by reciting, from memory, a Tennyson poem he'd planned to quote. Put simply? The pair had the makings of a power couple. They balanced each other and made for captivating cover stars. "The founder and director of *Life* and *Time* was Henry Luce, who was very conservative," Lubin told me. John's father, Joe, who nurtured many of his media relationships, was a Democrat. But "they were both hugely ambitious men who saw they would both benefit. Luce would benefit by promoting JFK, and Joe Kennedy would benefit by having JFK in *Life*. It was sort of a hand-in-glove relationship, crossing over what would have been an ideological divide."

In this sense, *Life,* which stopped short of endorsing JFK outright during his presidential campaign, was the semi-reluctant yet crucial medium for Kennedy self-promotion that *Vogue* became for Kim Kardashian, whose entire family would, collectively, grace its covers more than thirty times from 2014 through 2024. Inside the article, Kanye's knack for mythologizing every aspect of Kimye was on full display. In fact, if they were at all a power couple like the Kennedys, then in some ways *he* was "the Jackie." He talked about the possibility of using the Hall of Mirrors at Versailles as a wedding venue and listed the latest auteurs influencing his view of Kim as a muse: Walt Disney, Tim Burton, Hayao Miyazaki. He explained the remix of identities upon cultural references upon mediums that made Kimye work so well as a power couple: "You've got the interracial thing. You have mega-media and mega-art crash. You have, you know, the Vogue and reality show combination. There's a lot of new frontiers being broken in 2014." He declared that Kim was a "fantasy" who ought to "live in a dream world."

Power couples *are* captivating; history proves they always have been, and they're ensured posterity when they are skillfully mythologized. It's cool that Cleopatra, the ancient queen of Egypt, engaged in a series of love affairs with Roman leaders from Julius Caesar to Mark Antony that changed the course of history. As the Egyptian queen's biographer Stacy Schiff wrote, "The personal inevitably trumps the political, and the erotic trumps all: We will remember that Cleopatra slept with Julius Caesar and Mark Antony long after we have forgotten what she accomplished in doing so, that she sustained a vast, rich, densely populated empire in its troubled twilight in the name of a proud and cultivated dynasty." Power couples like Mary Pickford and Douglas Fairbanks shaped Old Hollywood, paving the way for the "New Hollywood" power couple Elizabeth Taylor and Richard Burton to extend the sexiness of Cleopatra's legacy with Joseph L. Mankiewicz's four-hour, bank-breaking 1963 film depicting the ancient queen's reign and romances. In real life, of course, Taylor and Burton were scandalous because both were married when their on-set affair began; they married and divorced twice, later teasing the public by starring in a play, *Private Lives,* about a divorced couple that gets back together. (The poet Clementine Von Radics once told me that

they believe Kim and Kanye, who divorced in 2022, may one day marry again just as Richard and Liz did.)

Perhaps the most verifiable proof that people love power couples, though, comes from Britain, where the data on viewership of royal weddings is always staggering (nearly two billion people tuned in to Harry and Meghan's wedding in 2018). Or consider the Spice Girls: The members who led the group into success during its ascent—Ginger and Scary Spice—have faded into relative obscurity compared with Posh. Victoria, on the other hand, started dating the football star David Beckham in 1997, and the two became instant tabloid and fashion icons (as well as underdogs for a few years after David was red carded at the 1998 FIFA World Cup and shouldered the blame for his team's loss). Because of her proximity to a sports icon, the Spice Girl who had once been among the more passive members of the group is today the most famous, launching fashion lines at Paris Fashion Week, with Kim Kardashian sitting next to her husband in the front row, a few weeks before a Netflix documentary about the couple was released. Again Daniel J. Boorstin gets it right: Icons are stronger in relation to one another. The same could be said for Beyoncé and Jay-Z, referred to often as pop culture royalty. To be sure, Beyoncé was the most ambitious and talented member of her early '00s girl group, Destiny's Child, bound to become a singular pop icon in her own right. But when, in 2002, she collaborated with Jay-Z, the business-savvy, self-described "best rapper alive," on a duet called "'03 Bonnie & Clyde"—the two even dressing up for the single's music video as the iconic Depression-era outlaw couple, who had been further mythologized by an Academy Award–winning 1967 film starring Faye Dunaway and Warren Beatty—the world began to contextualize the two music stars as an iconic duo, who would soon enough become inseparable combined billionaires.

Kanye touted these principles during his testy 2013 interview with *The Breakfast Club,* boasting that he'd partnered with an equal who "will actually buy me something for my birthday," rather than "dating me for my money." It's true that even without West, Kim was a millionaire due to her TV show, fragrance lines, and retail partnerships with brands like Bebe.

West made it clear that the beginning of Kimye marked the beginning not only of a great love story but of an enterprise. News reports from 2012 announced that he'd been shopping an ambiguous concept called Donda meant to "galvanize amazing creative thinkers" around Silicon Valley, to no avail (one gossip rag suggested he'd proposed to Kim in San Francisco so that potential investors could attend). He'd also started working with Nike on a sneaker line called Yeezy and was fed up with the company's refusal to offer him royalties, let alone transparency about his contracts or the scalability of his vision. Venting about this to *The Breakfast Club,* he was convinced that his and Kim's fame had exceeded their fortune, and the only way to ensure proportionate security was to become, well, billionaires.

"People say you can do it on your own," he said, "but it's the industries—the coal industry, the music industry, the newspaper industry, clothing, manufacturing, electricity. There's something different to the way these billionaires run the world. And we're not a part of that. We've only been let in on a communication level. It's a new form of cotton that we're all picking." This notion of unrealized sovereignty is what West was concerned with when he infamously compared North to royalty. "I've been working for two years trying to make Nike still hot and I still don't have the backing to really support and protect her…. Me and Kim, we on our grind—we have to do what we have to do to support our family. But we ain't there yet—we ain't financially there to the point to make sure that our North is safe at all times—and that's the reason I'm turning up."

Kim would soon become the most famous woman in the world—if she wasn't already—and was three years away from being violently robbed in Paris, turning Kanye's hyperbole into a headline that was at once a chilling prophecy and proof that overexposure indeed comes with great risk. Kanye was also correct that society deals in "iconography," which is why he illustrated his visions for his family's future by using cultural references that people could recognize—Walt Disney, Marilyn Monroe, the royal children. Radio pundits like Charlamagne, meanwhile, however wealthy and influential, were empowered only at the level of "communication," and *ultimate* power

would come from owning the means of production, as was possible for only a few—almost entirely white, and always male—moguls in the world.

But it's also true that the kind of wealth Kanye envisioned for his family was exactly what the Oxfam charity had calculated, the previous year, as the sum that would suffice to solve the world's poverty four times over. His yearning was a high-scale metaphor for the class hierarchies clinched by assortative mating across major cities and elite institutions. His goal was clear: He and Kim intended to "turn up" until they had as much generational "heritage" as any major political family or dynastic business. This meant accumulating cash and crafting themselves according to useful cultural symbols. Just as Jackie did.

Famously, in the days following John's assassination, anticipating a special issue on the ordeal from *Life,* Jackie fashioned her husband's life and presidential administration into a dream called Camelot. She offered an exclusive interview to a trusted journalist, Theodore White, whose past work on Kennedy had been flattering. She told White that her husband's favorite tales had been the ones about King Arthur—a visionary, courageous leader whose approval rating would have surely outstripped even the 70 percent Kennedy had earned by the year of his death—and Arthur's jovial court of knights, who hung out at a fictitious castle called Camelot. ("Camelot, located nowhere in particular, 'can be anywhere,' " wrote one scholar.) "There will be great presidents again," Jackie said. "But there will never be another Camelot." It's true that there will never be another media moment quite like the one that made the idyllic, photogenic Kennedys. In case there was any doubt of Jackie's intentionality in comparing John to the mythic king, it's worth noting, as the historian James Piereson did, that *Life* editors "initially rejected the inclusion of the Camelot reference as excessively maudlin and sentimental," and Jackie countered that they'd lose the whole thing if they didn't keep it in. "I was her instrument in labeling the myth," White later mused.

Did the piece really impact the way the Kennedys are remembered today? Well, the 2016 Jackie O biopic starring Natalie Portman centers on the White-Kennedy interview. When I asked my grandma what she thinks of

when she thinks of Jack and Jackie, she answered "Camelot." (As well as, as we discussed in the Kennedys chapter, "Jackie's pink pillbox hat," reminding me of what Kimye always knew: Successful fashion statements can comprise the fabric of cultural histories.) As Piereson puts it, "One has to give her credit for her quick and imaginative thinking in the midst of the most profound tragedy and grief; and also for her keen understanding that symbols and images often trump substance in shaping public memory."

Did the *Vogue* debut really shape public perception of Kimye? Odds are that in the modern, far noisier media landscape, their image as an eccentric, enterprising artist-muse union was the outcome of a combination of that initial *Vogue* cover, the many campaigns Kim would star in for Yeezy, and the countless vivid descriptors and anecdotes they shared about each other in print, TV, and social media interviews to come. (And they would, to the chagrin of their critics, return to walk the Met Gala red carpet together one month after their cover came out.)

SELFIES

In May 2015, two years after the Oxford Dictionaries announced "selfie" as its "word of the year," Kim published *Selfish* with the art book publisher Rizzoli. A colorful dispatch by Molly Mulshine for *Business Insider* illustrates the chaotic scene at one of Kim's New York City signings, with a line down Fifth Avenue that formed at dawn, fan disputes ("Yeah, you think you're better-looking than us?" someone shouted during "a fight over line-cutting"), and an unnerving disruption by animal rights activists that prompted an even larger police presence. Mulshine also spoke to one fan, the designer Shaobo Han, who called Kim the "Marilyn Monroe of our time" and "took issue with the classification of selfies as inherently narcissistic," explaining that "people are really loving themselves, especially women…. [Kardashian] is a strong woman who people should look up to."

Selfish was a coffee-table compilation of Kim's best selfies, taken between the years 2007 and 2014 and inspired, she said, by her wish to make a sexy private photo album for her husband, Kanye West. This reasoning for the

book's creation was a recycled narrative that maintained Kim's meticulous Madonna-Whore paradigm: A season 1 *KUWTK* episode followed her predicament when an R-rated calendar meant for her then-boyfriend, the football star Reggie Bush, accidentally went public. *Selfish* also followed a clear visual Campbellian narrative: Kim was a child (the first image was a selfie she took as a tot with her younger sister Khloé); then she was an Everywoman wannabe climbing the Hollywood ladder (the year-by-year chapters track her evolution from proximity to tabloid-era socialites like Paris Hilton to industry titans like Beyoncé and Karl Lagerfeld); then she was a thot (nudes are grouped in a blacked-out cluster of pages in the middle of the book); and finally she became a wife (the penultimate photo is a grand mirror selfie of Kim trying on her custom Givenchy wedding dress, and the last one is of her hands and Kanye's, beringed and stacked at their Florence wedding). The book proved that this second effort at a fairy-tale ending did not even require a whole TV show, cluttered with scenes, confessionals, and storylines: It could be told through photos alone.

A year had passed between the controversial Kimye *Vogue* feature (which included a shot of Kanye taking an iPad photo of Kim taking a selfie of herself with North) and the release of *Selfish*. In May, she and Kanye had married; in June, she'd released her phone-based app, *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood,* which brought in nearly $50 million within its first quarter by gamifying the Kardashian simulacrum; in November, she'd "broken the internet" with the now-infamous nude *PAPER* cover; and through it all, she'd posted selfie after selfie to her Instagram feed, accumulating about thirty-two million followers on the platform and amplifying the convention among social media users. (Google estimated that twenty-four billion selfies had been uploaded to Google Photos in 2015.) *Selfish* was Kim's way of ensuring her legacy as an early adopter of the world-changing photographic phenomenon, following several years of making a gimmick of her narcissism: taking selfies with stuffy news anchors after interviews, offering deadpan tutorials on the "perfect selfie" for pop culture news features, and even formulating an easy spectacle by letting Andy Cohen take a selfie with her ass. But she wasn't the concept's founding mother.

Citing the scholar Alison Hearn, the fashion scholar Elizabeth Wissinger has written about the Victorian "calling card" (known as a carte de visite), made possible by "technological innovations in photography" and the advent of mass production, which inspired "a wave of 'cartomania' " that "swept the United States." You've probably seen the cards before: sepia-toned portraits of grim-looking Victorians staring ahead at the camera—but they were printed to be mounted to cardboard and distributed. "Some young ladies became the Insta-girls of their age, as people liked collecting these cards, and their popularity soon afforded some the opportunity to achieve a local modicum of fame, as people would buy the cards of pleasant-looking strangers to add to their collections." It was during this time that "fashion modeling, posing for money, became a legitimate job," suggesting that the phenomenon both democratized and legitimized developing constructs of celebrity.

On some level, holding your phone outward to snap a pic of yourself is no more than a practical and autonomous way to "get the shot," but the real question is why we need "the shot" at all. The French psychoanalyst Jacques Lacan might say it has something to do with the "mirror stage" of infancy, initiated when we first catch sight of our reflections and realize that we are embodied. (Thus, the significance of Kim's toddler-age selfie in *Selfish*.) According to Lacan, the mirror experience causes a jarring revelation of our separateness from the mother and commences our lifelong pursuit of connection, often mediated by the "Gaze," which turns our objects of desire into, well, objects. When we gaze, we do more than look, which is what the art critic John Berger is getting at in his 1972 classic, *Ways of Seeing,* when he attempts to de-pathologize what is often interpreted as women's narcissism. Perpetually gazed at by men, he writes, women have internalized their own objectification:

> A woman must continually watch herself. She is almost continually accompanied by her own image of herself. Whilst she is walking across a room or whilst she is weeping at the death of her father, she can scarcely avoid envisaging herself walking or weeping. From

> earliest childhood she has been taught and persuaded to survey herself continually.
>
> And so she comes to consider the *surveyor* and the *surveyed* within her as the two constituent yet always distinct elements of her identity as a woman.
>
> She has to survey everything she is and everything she does because how she appears to others, and ultimately how she appears to men, is of crucial importance for what is normally thought of as the success of her life. Her own sense of being in herself is supplanted by a sense of being appreciated as herself by another.

Though the Gaze is driven by desire (or, as Lacan would say, "demand"), it is not always sexual. We gaze at art to determine whether it speaks to us; we gaze at the products being marketed to us, Berger writes, and imagine ourselves improved by them. The Gaze is needy, driven by projections and our wish to become a fantasy version of ourselves. The self-directed yet exhibitionistic gaze of the selfie might offer a return to that infantile experience of realizing our own terrifying humanness—and therefore aloneness—and offer some comforting closure.

In the early 2010s, tabloid It Girls like Paris Hilton posed for selfies with fans clutching digital cameras—and then took their own with one another at parties, a process itself often captured by the paparazzi (prompting Hilton to tweet in 2017 that she "and Britney invented the selfie!"). The selfie marked a turn from women being hunted by photographers to an era when they could plan and produce their own self-portraits, post-able at their own whims.

In Instagram's early years, most of us were treating the platform like a shorter-form Facebook, posting mundane pictures of sunsets and salads. Kim's early 2010s feed reflects similar chaos: selfies with friends and fellow celebs, sure, but also off-kilter photos of her red-carpet fits and low-quality ads for products like waist trainers. But around 2015, the Kardashians became noticeably grid conscious, moving from a focus on individual one-off shots to curated sequences that pleased the eye when looking at the larger feed. By the time she published *Selfish,* she had shifted from promoting outside companies' products on her feed and TV show to making and selling

her own products via a mastery of her own image, thereby creating an ever more self-contained financial circuit (a model the family figured out early with their church). Her face—and often, of course, her ass—proved a relentless engine of the brand, driving first a cosmetics line and later SKIMS. In the caption for one ass-centric image in the book, Kim remarks that this snap, taken behind the scenes at a formal photo shoot, had become more well known than the official result. The selfie, a commercial for the self, paved the way for Kim's self-ownership.

It was only a matter of time before the focus of social media would shift to the face. Human interest had been a growing sector of media at large since the 1970s; as Susan J. Douglas and Andrea McDonnell write, "*Time* magazine's market research in the early 1970s revealed that the very first part most people turned to when they opened the magazine was its 'People' section featuring brief tidbits about recent celebrity marriages, divorces, scandals, or accomplishments. So in March 1974, Time Inc. launched *People* magazine, with an emphasis on human interest stories, large photos, short, easily digestible stories, and, of course, celebrities." Recent studies prove that we are drawn to lock with other humans' eyes, even when looking at photos, even when instructed to look at other facial features; one established that photos featuring "human faces [were] 38% more likely to receive likes than photos with no faces." Selfies offer a sense of human connection—even if they raise questions about whether they also foster narcissism and self-objectification.

The mixed public reception to Kim's book is telling enough about the question of whether selfies are good clean Lacanian fun or dangerous gateways into a transactional conception of the self. The sociologist Pepper Schwartz asked, in a column for CNN, "Wouldn't it be great if Kim K's selfie book sat moldering in book stores and on Amazon? That would reassure me about the soul of modern girls and young women…. Instead of sending Kim K to the bank, let's encourage her to go to a really good therapist." *Complex* magazine reveled in the high-low collision of it all by publishing a listicle titled "Kim Kardashian's Best Selfies (Reviewed by an Art Critic)." Megan Garber at *The Atlantic* wrote, "You win, Kim Kardashian," praising Kim for repeatedly crediting her glam team throughout the book and for "her candor

about who she is and what it takes to make her that way," deciding that "she might also, against all odds, move us forward."

In 2016, Kim posted another nude mirror selfie—captioned "when you're like I have nothing to wear LOL"—that inspired such divided outcry that *The New York Times* covered the discourse: "In a climate where the harassment and bullying of young women online has reached alarming levels, experts say the encouragement of freedom of healthy sexual expression among women is increasingly necessary. But, they say, so is discussion about what, exactly, constitutes empowerment, and why." Selfie culture has undoubtedly encouraged a commodified view of the self, inclined as Kim may be to see it as a simple matter of making pretty self-portraits. A UT Southwestern study in 2022 proved that selfies can distort features like the nose and chin, driving people, even more studies have found, to pursue plastic surgery in droves. As social media platforms and cosmetic surgery industries simultaneously evolved, adding filters to the feeds and injectables to the facial-enhancement menu, terms like "Snapchat dysphoria" and "Instagram face" began to enter the lexicon.

Whom was all this self-optimization and presentation *for*? In *Ways of Seeing,* John Berger wrote, "You painted a naked woman because you enjoyed looking at her, you put a mirror in her hand and you called the painting *Vanity,* thus morally condemning the woman whose nakedness you had depicted for your own pleasure." It was easy to deride the selfie as narcissistic while still tapping the save button. Kim defended herself by tweeting nude photos with the hashtag #liberated, but as Nancy Jo Sales told the *Times,* the masses of young women emulating Kim had more to lose than she did, because they opened themselves up to perils like cyberbullying and nonconsensual sharing of their nudes; meanwhile, Kim was tweeting that she "was busy cashing my 80 million video game check & transferring 53 million into our joint account."

That's right—*our joint account:* In Kim's case, at least (or so she claimed), all these selfies were a tribute to her new husband. The final shot in *Selfish,* after all, documented their happy ending. Together they were resisting Lacan's conviction that an individual will never be complete, no matter how

hard we try to bond with the object of our affection, that "at the heart of desire is a misrecognition of fullness where there is really nothing but a screen for our own narcissistic projections. It is that lack at the heart of desire that ensures we continue to desire." Given Kim's status as Kanye's muse, and his protégée in business and fashion, the question of narcissistic projection arguably remained open.

Kim was paying special attention to one young woman under her sway, meanwhile: her sister Kylie Jenner, seventeen years her junior. She professed in *Selfish* to prefer Kylie's bathroom lighting for her selfies and admitted to borrowing the teenager's bikinis for a few shots. Her adulation failed to mask who the true influencer was, at least at this stage: With the size of her lips and the depth of her tan intensifying, Kylie was looking more and more like her older sister by the day. If Kim was Kanye's protégée, then Kylie was Kim's.

KIM 2.0

On April 20, 2015, TMZ reported on the viral social media hashtag #kyliejennerlipchallenge, which saw young people sucking on shot glasses or biting their lips to cause swelling. Their selfies of the results proudly imitated the seventeen-year-old Kylie Jenner, whose inflated pout had been on display in her recent posts (followed by upwards of forty million Instagram users). For years, the Kar-Jenner family had been engaging the public with their spectacles, which often involved a combination of relatability and shock value; now, it seemed, at the helm of new social media platforms, they were inspiring mimesis. A few weeks later, in May, the *KUWTK* episode "Lip Service" addressed the overriding media buzz about her physical transformation—though, in yet another case of convenient Kardashian timing, it was almost certainly shot long before the appearance of the dangerous meme, foretelling the public's appetite to mimic Kylie at whatever cost.

While promoting her new hair extensions line ("My followers and stuff know that I'm just crazy and change my hair so much, so it'll be cool for them to change it with me," she explained), Kylie—who had been situated as

a tastemaker within her family as early as a 2013 episode of *KUWTK* that finds Kim "Tumblr-stalking" Kylie, fascinated by her Gen Z sister's approach to social media—fields questions from the media. One reporter at her event says, "You're branching out into the fashion, beauty world—a couple of weeks ago, people were talking a lot about your lips—so tell me about them." Later, an editor from *Remix Magazine* asked her for her lip "secret."

The youngest Kar-Jenner turns to her sisters for advice on how to deal with the public's probing—even though the interviewers' conveniently representational questions feel more than a little staged. Kim tells Kylie it's fine to use available technologies to address her "insecurities," admitting that she's been feeling bad about her post-pregnancy body. In a confessional, Khloé adds that living such hyper-mediated lives is bound to induce insecurity.

Both sisters emphasize, though, that Kylie shouldn't "go crazy" with the enhancements. Throughout the episode, the phenomenon of Kylie's "plumped" lips is, itself, labeled "an insecurity," one and the same as acting on the feeling, with the real concern being the determination of when one has "gone too far." In other words, the family that had already made a fortune by forcing America to confront its moral boundaries was now fretting about where the "line" was. As the writer Billy Lezra once told me, they are, at once, "architects, subjects, and objects of harmful standards."

Kim advises Kylie to "own up" to the public about what she'd done—and "bank some selfies" of her new look while she's at it. (Kendall draws a harder line, interrupting their dialogue to cluck, "Nobody needs anything, everybody's beautiful.") Kylie returns to her next interview prepared to admit that she had used injectables, but the question never comes. Still, Kylie tells the confessional, "If my sisters can own up to their insecurities, then so can I." The episode itself was that offering. In fact, only one week after "Lip Service" aired, *KUWTK* put out a two-part special called "About Bruce," following Caitlyn Jenner's process of coming out as transgender to her family. Almost exactly one month after that was her groundbreaking *Vanity Fair* cover, debuting her embodied womanhood and announcing, "Call me Cait." A new era of curated transparency had begun.

Injectable fillers had been in the making for years, starting with cow-derived collagen in the 1990s (which often resulted in a puffy appearance), followed by the long-awaited FDA approval of the non-animal filler Restylane in 2003, with the much-needed addition of the numbing agent lidocaine to most fillers in 2007. Along the way, aesthetic approaches to filling lips, cheeks, and other parts of the face improved, turning injectors into sculptors, and 2013 offered a leap forward when the FDA approved Juvéderm Voluma, a "lighter" filler that *Allure* magazine granted a "Best of Beauty Breakthrough" award. There was a democratic subtext to media's framing of fillers: Now you could change your face without all the traumas and costs associated with full-blown surgery. It's worth mentioning that all this occurred during the "tech boom," when venture capital firms were throwing millions—billions, even—into start-ups like Uber and Airbnb that promised to make the high life accessible to everyday people (forever altering the transportation and hospitality industries in the process). In 2014 and 2015, respectively, these apps received more than a billion dollars in funding each, encouraging more hopeful founders to think up problems that they might be able to "solve" using ever-advancing technology. The philosophy of the Kar-Jenners—we are Every Girls chasing an American dream—was apparent not only in influencer culture but in the overarching grind mentality that defined the 2010s, leading to what we now call a gig or sharing economy. The family even directly endorsed Silicon Valley's exports: In 2016, Kim shared an endorsement for Airbnb on her Instagram, claiming that it had gifted her and Kanye a "home away from home" penthouse in New York City, and a few years later the family would partner with Uber in official ad campaigns, one of which beat the dead horse of Kendall's cucumber meme. The new fillers were the beauty industry's start-up-y disrupters. As Scott comments to Kim at the start of "Lip Service," "You can go pimp your ride anywhere in town. Walk in, and ten minutes later you're prettier."

One study shows that after Kylie confirmed her use of fillers, there was a 30.31 percent rise in Google search interest in the option. The American Society of Plastic Surgeons found that between 2014 and 2015 there was a 6 percent uptick in the use of fillers, with an increase in each year to follow. All

this was right on time for Instagram, which drew focus closer and closer to the face as selfies propagated the feeds.

Laying the ground for future studies of fads and trends, the American sociologist Robert E. Park coined the term "collective behavior," defining it as "the behavior of individuals under the influence of an impulse that is common and collective, an impulse, in other words, that is the result of social interaction." Most studies of these phenomena cite the sudden rise and fall of Hula-Hoops in 1958 as the ultimate example of a fad. People get excited about a novel product quickly—generating $25 million in sales, in the case of Hula-Hoops—and then drop it just as fast. Trends, on the other hand, ascend more slowly, with what the branding expert Colleen Dilenschneider describes as "identifiable and explainable rises that are driven by audience needs. They help solve a problem for people." For example, a TikTok dance is a fad, but the use of short-form video as a medium is a trend, continuing to expand worldwide interconnectedness and communication. And what problem was lip enhancement solving? The Kar-Jenners had made it clear throughout "Lip Service": insecurity.

In a 2017 retrospective for *The New Yorker,* Jia Tolentino borrows a term used by the makeup artist Colby Smith to decree the 2010s the age of Instagram face: "the gradual emergence, among professionally beautiful women, of a single, cyborgian face. It's a young face, of course, with poreless skin and plump, high cheekbones. It has catlike eyes and long, cartoonish lashes; it has a small, neat nose and full, lush lips." Smith pinned the origins of the Face to "when the lip fillers started."

Instagram face, a combination of facial fillers and makeup techniques, did seem to synthesize global ethnic features (Smith remarks that it comprises "an overly tan skin tone, a South Asian influence with the brows and eye shape, an African-American influence with the lips, a Caucasian influence with the nose, a cheek structure that is predominantly Native American and Middle Eastern"), reflecting social media's continued globalization. In 2012, the McKinsey Global Institute found that there were "1.5 billion social networking users globally," and 80 percent of those users interacted with social networks "regularly." In other studies, the institute tracked ever-

intensifying "flows" of information and capital between nations thanks to the internet. It's not hard to imagine Instagram face at least partly as an outcome of cross-cultural flow.

The Face also unified the Kar-Jenner sisters, with some variation, of course, according to their archetypes (Kim was, Smith said, "patient zero" for the Face; Khloé's enhancements were obvious and campy; Kourtney's, supernatural; and so on). But there was always special emphasis on the way Kylie and Kim—whose social media followings at the time outstripped their sisters', and most other celebrities'—used the technologies. Though they had different fathers, from different ethnic backgrounds, the two resembled each other. The moment's optimized face, as the celebrity surgeon Jason Diamond told Tolentino, had some "constants" exemplified by certain A-listers: "When you look at Kim, Megan Fox, Lucy Liu, Halle Berry, you'll find elements in common: the high contoured cheekbones, the strong projected chin, the flat platform underneath the chin that makes a ninety-degree angle."

If Instagram face had turned one's visage into a programmable formula, then Kylie functioned as a sort of Kim 2.0—proof that Kim's prototypical look, with the help of fillers and the right makeup techniques, was indeed transmissible across the algorithm. Eric Hoffer has written about how mass movements throughout history have always formed at a cultural turn, always driven by individuals who want to become part of something bigger than themselves—a "uniformity" of factors, regardless of ideology. The 2010s marked a major technological turn, in both social media and cosmetic surgery, and young aspiring influencers were participating in a kind of aesthetic capitalist movement, self-branding for social capital, but also often in the hopes of accumulating enough followers to earn more from partnerships with companies that would want to use their page for the visual placement of their products, or, later—as Rebecca Jennings has explored in a *Vox* piece about "sexfluencers"—to promote their OnlyFans pages. I've joked before that this era heralded a kind of Kim Clone Army, and as Tolentino writes, "In a world where women are rewarded for youth and beauty in a way that they are rewarded for nothing else—and where a strain of mainstream feminism teaches women that self-objectification is progressive, because it's

profitable—cosmetic work might seem like one of the few guaranteed high-yield projects that a woman could undertake."

In August, a few months after "Lip Service" aired, teasers for Kylie Lip Kits began dropping from the company Lip Kit by Kylie (in partnership with momager Kris Jenner and Seed Beauty, and to be renamed Kylie Cosmetics the next year). If you'd gotten fillers, you could now further enhance the results with coordinated lipstick and liner; if your lips remained unfilled, you could try to simulate the effect with makeup. The kits offered the illusion of an even more accessible entry point into cosmetic enhancement, rather as injectables had been framed by the media. Here was the defining moment: Kylie's lips, or Instagram face, or the Kardashian Clone Army, would be a trend and not a fleeting fad, because, by hyping Kylie's lips *first,* the family had preemptively manufactured a market for their product. The Lip Kits could solve the problem not only of lip insecurity but of access to lip enhancement itself.

This inverted approach to publicity followed a legacy established by Edward Bernays, Sigmund Freud's nephew and the so-called father of public relations. In his seminal 1928 book, *Propaganda,* he wrote that "under the old salesmanship the manufacturer said to the prospective purchaser, 'Please buy a piano.' The new salesmanship has reversed the process and caused the prospective purchaser to say to the manufacturer, 'Please sell me a piano.' " In 1934, working to expand the female market for Lucky Strike cigarettes, he suggested changing the company's green color scheme to something more "fashionable to women," but the company had already invested millions in the color, so he determined that color trends would have to change. Observing the parties thrown by French couture houses, attended by fashion editors from *Harper's Bazaar* and *Vogue,* which, he realized, shaped "the fashion of the world," Bernays decided to throw a green-themed ball of his own at New York's Waldorf Astoria in partnership with an elite-run charity for a women's hospital. The "society women" who attended came dressed in green, and columnists covered the event. Anticipating success, he reached out in advance to a stockings manufacturer and advised them to begin stocking the color. It worked: "Green became a fashionable color" for women.

Bernays could surely have predicted the success of Kylie Lip Kits with similar confidence, but Kylie was working in a world even friendlier to influence and consumerism. As Laura Nelson, cofounder of Seed Beauty, told Shopify in 2017, Kylie Lip Kits represented "the democratization of beauty," which "has been driven by two main factors, the first being social media. Information is being directly provided to the consumers so there's less filtering, less editing happening, and that really empowers the consumer to make really great purchasing decisions and get different perspectives directly from the brand. The second factor is e-commerce—consumers are able to buy those products online and brands are able to launch products when it works for them and their consumers. Traditionally you had big retailers setting the pace." As Kylie tells a reporter in another *KUWTK* episode aired in anticipation of the release, she opted to sell the kits online rather than in stores in order to remain the sole owner of the product and to reach her fans faster. Nelson said, "Kylie came about it from the same way that I've learned that she comes about many other things, which is to find the most direct path."

In November, when the $29 kits finally launched—which had generated even more hype by not being available for preorder—they sold out in minutes, crashing the store's website. The following *KUWTK* season, in an episode that showed the expansion and release of more kits—which also sell out in minutes—Kris proclaims, "Kylie, I think you've started an empire." She was right: By 2016, the company had brought in more than $300 million, and even though these numbers would be called into question (Kylie was described by *Forbes* magazine in 2019 as the "world's youngest self-made billionaire," only to have the honor retracted when documentation from her later merger with the beauty company Coty contradicted the claim), it led the way in scaling the family's entrepreneurialism into what we understand today as influencer culture.

In 2017, Kylie Cosmetics announced a collaboration with Kim called Kylie x KKW. This was a way to test and prep the market for Kim's incoming KKW Beauty and Fragrance ventures, which focused especially on contouring makeup, and expanded consumers' ability to attain the shapes and

shading they were seeing on the top-followed Instagram accounts. Given how much hype Kimye was generating at the time—and how important it seemed for Kim to kick off her marriage rooted firmly in the role as Kanye's muse, wife, and mother of their children (a *KUWTK* episode from 2016 showed him overriding the on-set creative direction for Kim's cameo in Fergie's "M.I.L.F. $" music video, nixing the red lip and pinup look they'd fashioned in favor of a more neutral color scheme)—it makes sense that Kim couldn't lead the charge into business, instead letting her mini-me chart the path. With KKW's contour line, though, the Face was finally complete. Kim and Kylie became known for their beauty tutorials on YouTube at this time, showing users how to use their products to imitate their looks.

In Tolentino's piece, Colby Smith notes that "the world is so visual right now, and it's only getting more visual, and people want to upgrade the way they relate to it." Citing archival Instagram accounts like "Insta Repeat," which "illustrate the platform's monotony by posting grids of indistinguishable photos posted by different users—a person in a yellow raincoat standing at the base of a waterfall, or a hand holding up a bright fall leaf," Tolentino suggests that Instagram face is itself a grid-friendly aesthetic. "Some things just perform well." An interaction was at play between the formula of the face and the algorithmic feeds on which it appeared. "How had I been changed," she wonders, "by an era in which ordinary humans receive daily metrics that appear to quantify how our personalities and our physical selves are performing on the market? What was the logical end of this escalating back-and-forth between digital and physical improvement?"

This is the definition of "mediatization"—much more complex than mere mediation, because it refers to what the media theorists Nick Couldry and Andreas Hepp describe as "the long-term processes of institutionalization and materialization" of media itself. If media is ever evolving and culturally saturating—and if we are bound to follow its increasing acceleration, compression, and self-centeredness, moving from posting salads and sunsets to our own faces—then, inevitably, we will begin to adjust to the structures of the platforms themselves. It's like how news anchors have developed a specific way of enunciating that maintains a "professional" tone no matter where they

are reporting from, or how Netflix positions its content according to what kinds of images look best in thumbnail form (faces work best, to no one's surprise, and the fewer people in a square, the better. "While ensemble casts are fantastic for a huge billboard on the side of a highway," Netflix itself admitted, "they are too complex at small sizes and ultimately, not as effective at helping our members decide if the title is right for them on smaller screens"). Mediatization could also describe the way TikTok dance moves tend to be more simplistic and sweeping than traditional dance moves, or the way politicians adjust their messaging to suit Twitter character limits and diminishing attention spans, over time simplifying their voters' relationship to policy and political organization. One's appearance *on* a medium is to be mediated. Self-adjustment *for* the medium is mediatization.

The Kar-Jenners—curating their own public images through their pages, owning their own products, and cultivating a veritable Clone Army that saturated the feeds—were dominating social media to an unprecedented degree, playing out what Kanye had meant when he swore to Charlamagne tha God that true power today means owning a manufacturing center. The Kar-Jenners might not have owned the social media platforms on which they curated their images, but their traces were visible in the faces of the millions of young women who opted into fillers or the bold form of makeup contour they'd popularized, and their power over the mediums would be felt. In 2018, Kim would humblebrag about how Twitter's cofounder Jack Dorsey had attended Kanye's birthday party by tweeting, "I had a very good convo with @jack…and I think he heard me out on the edit button." (He replied, "Now I see why I was invited!") That same year, when Kylie tweeted that she didn't "open Snapchat anymore," the company's stock plunged, losing more than $1 billion in capital in one day.

EMOJIS

In 2015, about a month after the Oxford Dictionaries announced that an emoji was its "word of the year" (the "face with tears of joy"), Kim posted her own news to Twitter, using an emoji lineup featuring a Black man with a

beard (Kanye), a pale woman with black hair (Kim), a light-skinned girl with pigtails (North), and a little baby with the same skin tone. The message was clear: Kimye's son, Saint West, had been born.

According to the *Oxford English Dictionary,* an emoji is "a small digital image or icon used to express an idea, emotion, etc., in electronic communications." Its existence is determined by a nonprofit that "develop[s], maintain[s] and promot[es] software internationalization standards and data" called the Unicode Consortium. The consortium, the intellectual property lawyer Gabriella Ziccarelli tells me, "creates a black-and-white shape outline and a short description for each emoji that create a standard that can be recognized across platforms like Apple iOS and Android." She explains, "You may notice that the platforms take some creative liberty with the standard emoji and they will look different depending on your operating system—we call these 'house styles.'" These stylized emojis create a gray area about who really "owns" that version of the crying face emoji. The other category of emojis, Ziccarelli explains, is called a "proprietary emoji," which isn't based on the Unicode standards (for example, Meta's Facebook Messenger emoji). If sent outside the platform, they won't render, because they aren't unified. Ziccarelli adds, "Proprietary emoji are more likely to be considered protectable intellectual property."

Regardless of who can lay claim to these little images that live in our phones, we make the most of them every day, and around the world. In 2021, Unicode asserted that 92 percent of the world's online population uses emojis. After all, words—our reliance on which creates what many media theorists call written culture, oriented around the alphabet, books, and magazines—are more and more drowned out by what *BuzzFeed*'s cofounder and would-be neo-Marxist theorist Jonah Peretti has called the "visual cacophony" delivered to us by TV and social media. The pros and cons of written versus visual culture are a debate unto themselves. But if the rise of memes and selfies has taught us anything, it's that images deliver information faster than words, which is probably why our efficiency-obsessed brains are so addicted to them. The Italian semiotician Marcel Danesi, author of *The Semiotics of Emoji,* puts it this way: "Images are holistic signs; they compress unlimited meaning into

one visual form. Visual thinking is all around us—traffic signs, symbols, cartoons—constituting a powerful form of understanding." And any chance Kim gets to compress meaning in the service of efficient communication, she'll take.

The useful thing about emojis—and visual culture in general—is that almost anyone, anywhere, could look at Kim's baby news and gather that she and Kanye had welcomed a new addition to the family. Images transcend language divides, helping people—and companies—to not only package but scale their messaging. Given the fact that numerous studies have established that emojis are useful in bridging language divides, it's not crazy to wonder whether her use of emojis—compounded by her continuous cosplay of globally recognizable pop culture icons—has made it possible for Kim to resonate with hordes of social media users outside the United States. In fact, it was also in 2015 that *Time* magazine reported that Kim Kardashian had become the most searched person in twenty-six countries, tied with the Argentine soccer player Lionel Messi. As Danesi explains of emojis, they constitute history's "first practical attempt to bridge linguistic divisions…. In effect, they are based on a sense of mutual intelligibility, with some caveats." Ziccarelli points out just how reliant meaning can be on context, recalling the time "people were peppering the comments sections of Taylor Swift's online posts with the snake emoji," implying Swift's duplicity after Kim inserted herself in the long-standing feud between the pop star and her husband (note this emoji snake war was later directed toward Kim by Swift's fans at the release of the *Reputation* album). "When Beyoncé's *Lemonade* came out," Ziccarelli adds, referring to the frenzy the album stirred up over Jay-Z's alleged infidelity to Queen Bey, "the Beyhive [Beyoncé's fan base] had theories on who 'Becky with the Good Hair' [the alleged mistress] was and bombarded posts from those users' Instagram accounts with emojis—the bee or the crown and the bee combo. It was a way of showing people, 'I am aligned with Beyoncé.'" If Ziccarelli showed these posts to her parents, they would have been at a loss. She explains, "Context and the affiliations community members associate with certain emoji matters…. Having a shared understanding and meaning associated with emojis can unify and strengthen

communities…whether it be sports fans, pop star fan bases, or cultural communities." Within ten years, this phenomenon would transcend pop culture, as social media users began using emojis as code both for underground marketing purposes and for political mobilization. A study of eighty-five hundred Craigslist ads showed that human traffickers were using the "growing heart" emoji to target young girls. ("The growing heart shows that they are young now, going to grow," Murray Jennex, the lead researcher, explained to *Vice*.) In 2024, suspicious that social media platforms were censoring political content, activists would turn to emojis to signal their fidelities, populating comment sections with watermelons in support of Palestine.

At some point, Kim made the call to contribute Kardashian dialect to the growing universal language—and customizable contexts—of emojis. A few weeks following Saint's 2015 emoji birth announcement, she debuted her proprietary emoji, Kimoji, a $1.99 phone app with 250 Kim K–themed emojis to represent common motifs from her narratives, from her much-memed crying face to her iconic butt to her pregnant silhouette. Within the span of a decade, she'd tracked the acceleration of media, moving from video star to TV star, to cover girl, to social media presence, to meme and selfie queen, to video game avatar, and now to a tiny digital communications item. The app was reportedly downloaded nine thousand times a second, and later that winter Kanye rapped in "Facts" that it'd made "a million dollars a minute" and "shut down the App store." Other public figures followed suit with their own customized celebrity emojis, from Steph Curry to Amber Rose to Justin Bieber. StephMoji eventually scored the No. 1 place at the App Store, unseating Kimoji (perhaps inspiring the growing Kardashian enterprise's gradual encroachment upon the world of professional sports, with numerous athletes featured in SKIMS campaigns to come).

Kanye was probably Kimoji's most vocal fan and visible user. A few months later, while beefing on Twitter with the rapper Wiz Khalifa—Wiz threw shade at Kanye's working album title, *Waves,* and later tweeted, "Hit this KK and become yourself," which Kanye misunderstood to be a diss at Kim when really it was a reference to Wiz's weed brand, Khalifa Kush—

Kanye posted "Work Hard Play Hard," a reference to one of Wiz's early musical hits, and punctuated it with a Crying Kim Kimoji. The absurdist clapback made *Billboard, Pitchfork,* the *Los Angeles Times, Sports Illustrated,* and *Vox* headlines. Kanye knew the potential of a single image to be deployed like a game token in an online battle. His tweet also demonstrated the unique utility of a Kim Kardashian–themed emoji: It was unexpected. It packed the punch of a meme, only in smaller form. And, most of all, it was Kanye approved, which meant something in 2016.

In 2019, David Liebensohn, cofounder of the burgeoning company App Social, filed a lawsuit against Kim Kardashian, alleging that she'd stolen an idea he'd verbally pitched to her during a 2014 meeting at Kim's home in Calabasas: to add representations of her likeness to the quirky emoji sets his company was already making. (Officially, the lawsuit was for "claims of breach of a partnership agreement, breach of fiduciary duty, unjust enrichment, and fraud.") Then, one of his business partners broke an NDA from that meeting, and, according to his complaint, one day after filing her *own* trademark for Kimoji, Kim had her attorney Martin Singer send the App Social team a letter claiming emotional distress, and threatened to sue for $5 million unless they agreed to drop their plans for the app.

"The facts presented in the complaint are inconsistent," Ziccarelli says, of Liebensohn's narrative about how it all went down. Liebensohn didn't attach copies of evidence he refers to in the complaint (for example, "there were no exhibits attached to the complaint showing copies of 'the original Kimoji mockup emoji set' allegedly shared with Kardashian"). Liebensohn failed to show in his complaint that a Kimoji-specific pitch had occurred at all, let alone that a deal had been reached. Further, Liebensohn did not include a copy of the $5 million intimidation letter that he claimed to have received around the time that Kim filed the trademark. The bigger matter, though, had to do with Kim's face.

"From an intellectual property point of view, technically Liebensohn alleges that he created Kimoji as a derivative of the proprietary emoji he had already made." If the derivative images had been different, maybe the outcome would have been different. "Creators typically own…variations on

their original work that they make with their own original creative additions, but here Liebensohn's derivative was based exclusively on Kim's likeness—including moments from the show, like the ugly cry. Absent a license with a right to use her likeness for this purpose, it's unreasonable for him to make claim that he should be entitled to profit off of her likeness."

Though she'd benefited from the mass consumption of her selfies, nude magazine covers, free creation and exchange of memes featuring her face, and the famous algorithmic proliferation of Instagram face, Kim had set a precedent of refusing to allow other entities to profit from her likeness since at least 2012, when she sued the Gap for running an Old Navy commercial that featured one of her doppelgängers (even weirder: The model, Melissa Molinaro, was then dating Kim's ex-boyfriend Reggie Bush, who famously married another Kardashian look-alike several years later). That suit was settled behind closed doors, and the commercial vanished.

In a sense, the Kimoji case study captures and compiles the complex Kardashian principles of power. Again, Kim wins because she has money and lawyers, and because she rests comfortably in yet another liminal space—this time, the murky matters of IP in the new media age—but also because her face and body were—and are—*her own*. By 2019, with the advent of SKIMS, Kim's likeness would become inextricable from commodity, and she'd remain the majority owner.

It's unclear exactly how Liebensohn's arbitration ended. Throughout the years, the Kar-Jenners would be sued for many IP-related offenses (with a noticeable surge, for some reason, in 2017). Khloé was sued by Xposure Photos, a paparazzi agency, for posting to Instagram a photo of herself that had only been licensed for the *Daily Mail*. Xposure eventually agreed to drop the suit. That same year, the photographer Mike Miller sued the Jenner sisters for releasing fake vintage T-shirts overlaying their faces on photos of late icons like Tupac, the Notorious B.I.G., and Jim Morrison. Miller, who had taken Tupac's photo, filed a copyright suit that disappeared after the girls pulled the shirts and released public apologies. It was also in 2017 that Kylie was sued by the U.K.-based artist Sara Pope for using neon lips—strikingly similar to Pope's signature image—to promote her spin-off show *Life of*

Kylie, and Kim was sued by the Danish makeup artist Kirsten Kjaer Weis for calling her makeup line KKW when Weis's had been called KW since 2012. (Both lawsuits ended with private settlements.)

In 2023, Liebensohn took to the streets of L.A., holding up a sign that said, "Kim Kardashian Ruined My Life." The image might not have been as grabby if the nation hadn't seen multiple protests for urgent social issues over the years; the semiotics of a protest sign hit different in the 2020s. But he supported his messaging online, too, setting up a website from his phone that told his story and joining podcasts to say his piece. The TikTok generation—or at least the members who populated my audience, who had not witnessed Kim's underdog rise but come of age in the era of Kim's looming corporate power—was all ears, viewing the situation as a sort of David and Goliath tale. Maybe if he'd initiated a slingshot emoji as the symbol for his fight, he could have commanded the narrative himself.

DISGUISES

A May 2016 episode of *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* called "Fake It til' You Make It" shows eighteen-year-old Kylie confessing to her big sister Khloé that she longs to feel normal for a change. They're lounging on a couch and taking turns stroking a sweater-clad puppy. Even though, by this point, Kylie was considered by some "more" successful than her prototype, Kim, if only because of her popularity with the rising Generation Z, this would not be the only occasion when Kylie expressed ambivalence about fame. In a later episode that season, again sprawled among sisters, Kylie will say with a sigh, "Some people are born for this life, but I just know I'm not supposed to be famous. I feel it deep down inside." Kim will reply, "Really? That makes me so sad. *I* am," with a wink. The exchange will highlight the absurdity of Kylie's circumstances: Of course the teen member of an increasingly culturally entrenched media dynasty—who has never transgressed the borders of her simulacrum, has been framed by a hype machine as "self-made," and has become an ever more useful symbol in intensifying culture wars—would be ambivalent. Whether she really meant to disavow her lifestyle mattered

less than the impact of saying such a thing. Even today, in my TikTok comment sections, when young pop culture consumers discuss the youngest Kar-Jenner, the moment continues to come up as evidence of her coinciding glamour (maybe one day her fame will doom her, as it has so many other late lady icons) and relatability (like many pop culture consumers of her age, she finds herself trapped in circumstances she does not desire).

But today, the youngest Kar-Jenner is talking to the ideal sister, because campy Khloé happens to "know a guy" who does "dope ass prosthetics" for the movies. "You can be whoever you want to be," Khloé tells Kylie, as though a promise of instant self-actualization weren't the subtext of every *KUWTK* episode or Kylie Cosmetics makeup tutorial on YouTube. "Do you want a big ass, do you want to look pregnant, do you want to be a fat person?"

Kylie doesn't just want. "This is what I *need,*" she says. "We prosthetic it up and go out."

Remo Gramigna writes in "Faces in Disguise: Masks, Concealment, and Deceit," "Forms of disguise, concealment, and deceit occur in nature as well as socio-cultural domains…. Because deception is endemic to the human condition, evaluating what is true and what is false is something we all have to do." In the animal kingdom, *and* the history of man, predators and prey have always exercised deception in their ongoing dances with each other. And yet humans have always hungered for a stable truth: Plato and Socrates resisted relativism, looking to math to contemplate the possibility of some sort of universal truth, while Enlightenment-era philosophers like Immanuel Kant and John Stuart Mill believed reason and empiricism could bring them closer. "Keeping up with the Kardashians" has meant trying to discern what's "real," from the legacy of Kim's ill-fated seventy-two-day marriage (was the love legit, or only for publicity?), to her continual vows that her derriere has not been artificially inflated, to her televised tears during televised tough times, to the family's endless iterations of new faces.

Kylie's coming of age was occurring at a time when discourses about fame —and truth—in the new media era had become an unforeseen matter of urgency. The year before, the establishment Democrat Hillary Clinton—elevated to candidacy by the Democratic National Convention over the

socialist Vermont senator, Bernie Sanders—found herself taking on the Republican front-runner, Donald Trump, whose unhinged and therefore headline-grabbing Twitter persona had thoroughly disrupted politics. Trump's savvy for manipulating media by barraging the public with colorful and contradictory statements—and zeal for riling up a constituency that seemed to simmer with race, class, and partisan resentments—proved that fame was perhaps more transferable to power than ever before, and truth was harder for a nation to agree upon than it should be. (In 2016, "post-truth" was the Oxford Dictionaries' word of the year.) Philosophically minded cultural critics rushed to apply to the Trump phenomenon the work of one of postmodernism's "founding fathers," the German nihilist Friedrich Nietzsche, who famously declared that God was dead, and once wrote that "there are no facts, only interpretations."

The Kardashian era of controlled narratives evolved easily into Trump's "post-truth" era, famous for the mass confusion and partisan polarization it exacerbated. A month after "Fake It til' You Make It" aired, *The Guardian* launched a column called "Lyin' Trump," performing routine fact-checks of his most recent public statements. (Many other outlets did the same, including *The New York Times* and *The Washington Post*.) In June, he'd told a crowd at the Trump SoHo hotel in New York City (since renamed the Dominick) that he'd "started off in Brooklyn, New York, not long ago, with a small loan, and built a business which today is worth well over $10bn," and that America was the "highest-taxed nation in the world." (Both claims were debunked.) Trump's lies often contributed to his self-styled Everyman mythology—or, as we might call it, disguise—perhaps best illustrated by his iconic campaign attire, a suit and a red baseball cap: at once a mogul and a Man of the People. According to a dispatch in the *Las Vegas Review-Journal,* reporting on a campaign event held at the theater where Cirque du Soleil typically ran, his persona was "a winner with the end of the party that believes America's going to hell and in need of a strong father figure…. [H]is billionaire populist schtick is priceless—and can certainly pack a Vegas showroom."

Kylie has her own populist pitch for her prosthetics opportunity: for herself and her sisters to try to blend in with fans on a Hollywood bus tour. “I just wonder what they say about us,” she says, “how they make us all seem.” Khloé reminds her sister of her success and the context of the hyperreal media moment they live in: “You *are* the Hollywood tours.” But she agrees to lead the field trip, and they rope in the rising-star fashion model Kendall—whose splashy and relatively easy recent entrance onto the runways was not received without complaints from others grinding their way up from the bottom.

The transformation process that follows takes a grueling six hours. Two special effects artists mix the goopy molding used to construct fake facial features to stamp a witchy nose and a forearm tattoo onto Kylie and adorn Kendall with acne scars and a pregnant belly beneath an oversized floral shirt. Everyone is wearing bad wigs. If the Kardashians’ idea of “blending in” with the masses means looking like this, then they have a rather gnarly view of the masses. Most of the labor, though, is dedicated to Khloé, who is playing a grandmother and therefore requires a whole new face and neck. “Khloé’s look is so ridiculous,” Kendall says, laughing. “She looks so legit and real.”

In his paper, Gramigna uncovers different methods and motivations of obscuring oneself. He suggests a distinction, for example, between “concealment” and “deceit.” There’s going “incognito” for survival, like the ninth-century Chinese ninjas who cultivated the “art of invisibility” in order to navigate Shinto Japan, but there’s also the archetype of the “trickster,” like Odysseus in *The Odyssey,* whose character was one of “cunning, opportunistic dexterity.” There is, of course, espionage—hiding one’s identity to gather information. And we mustn’t forget *The Prince and the Pauper,* Mark Twain’s class satire about the son of a beggar and the Prince of Wales who scheme a brief switcheroo so that each can experience a different life. Finally, of course, there’s the quiet pleasure of shedding identity altogether—anonymity. Somehow, with this gimmick, the Kar-Jenners seem to be shooting for all of the above.

Upon the final makeup touches and concluding selfies, the time has come to assume character. The trio replaces their signature vocal fry with

exaggerated southern accents, which somehow indicate that they are quintessential Americans (maybe even would-be MAGA voters). They are Dottie, Sam, and Natalie. They drive a beat-up rental car to the tour—which is meeting in the parking lot of a convenience store—and they mutter about how "embarrassed" they are as they clamber into the roof seating of the minibus, where other everyday Americans climb in after them.

The driver-guide says into his mic, "I always feel it's good to start a glamorous Hollywood tour next to a 7-Eleven," before setting off for all the movie industry locations and celebrity gossip hot spots the group had come to see. Technically, bus tours like this one are considered "media-related" tourism—a way for fans to "put themselves in the physical place that has formed the backdrop" to stories and imagery that have moved them, and revel in what Dolores Hayden called the "power of place." If there's one reality that cannot be denied, it's what you can plainly see when it's right in front of you. But a Tudor-style, Old Hollywood casting office and the restaurant where Cindy Crawford met her husband aren't the only sights on today's ride. From the back of the bus, Dottie, Sam, and Natalie are making spectacles of themselves, snickering at high volume about the "Kar-trash-ians" (a term popularized on Twitter by Kanye West's ex Amber Rose the year before) while taking Snapchat selfies.

In 2016, the Kardashians were known for the countless crazes they'd kicked off across the country, from their uses of social media filters (one that endowed users' faces with cartoon puppy features was especially popular) to the perfect physical symmetry afforded by their facial injections and rumored body contouring as well as their Kanye West–influenced "luxury athleisure," which was obsessively reproduced by fast-fashion companies. It was clear that a cultural shift was in progress, and the Kardashians were the face of it all. As start-up culture promoted optimization and efficiency—fracturing legacy industries as we knew them and expanding across the world—standards of women's fashion and beauty were streamlining and globalizing.

This kind of social power, of course, brings backlash, and for the Kardashians that looked like tabloid headlines and Instagram "hate accounts" that fixated on zoomed-in shots of the family's skin flaws or unflattering

photos taken before their presumed plastic surgeries—and the spread of phrases like, well, "Kar-trash-ians." A push-pull dynamic had developed between the attention-dependent, business-savvy dynasty and a public torn between the impulse to imitate them and the temptation to make fun of them, coping by exposing the little bits of Truth that could be extracted.

Gramigna argues that concealment can be a way for "the weak to outmaneuver those in a position of power." It's true that had the Kardashians arrived at a Hollywood bus tour as themselves—camera-free and sans security—the power relations between public and stars could quickly become precarious, even if the stars in question are social media and reality TV bred, which is to say, so hyper-visible because of the force of their own will. At best, the public would pull out their phones and start filming; at worst, they'd physically mob the stars. In this sense, the need for celebrity self-concealment proves the public's power: They influence every consideration a Kardashian must make before venturing into the "real world." But at the same time, the Kardashians' need for self-concealment also proves the dominance of new media and the family's power as symbols of it: The revelation of a Kardashian being *in* the tour bus would eclipse all the legacy Hollywood sites outside it, no matter how much more beloved and legitimate the family's detractors may proclaim older eras of stardom.

That said, Dottie and her granddaughters decide that some trailing paparazzi have blown their cover anyway, so they drop the remaining semblance of their earnest approach to the experiment, and it instead becomes some sort of exercise in loudly expressing their mixed feelings about celebrity. Khloé cracks a cosmetic surgery joke while filming her sisters for Snapchat ("It's the Old Kylie!"), and when the tour guide cites a Kar-Jenner drama that apparently took place at 1Oak Nightclub, they all holler back, "That's not true!" The *actual* everyday Americans sitting nearby keep glancing back with knowing looks, but nobody mobs them. Khloé, Kylie, and Kendall are insulated by thick layers of fake skin and the common knowledge that cameras are running and therefore security is near. (Or maybe, just maybe, these normies had been informed from the start that they were

playing extras in a *KUWTK* scene, and we, the TV show viewers, are the real dupes.)

By dropping the farce, the trio resumes their familiar style of "reality TV" performativity, and there's nothing anybody there can do about it but watch. In this sense, it's a familiar dynamic for all: the giggly gaggle of famous women, flexing power they claim to be ambivalent about, and their reluctant but nevertheless captive audience, laughing along if only because laughter is contagious.

At the first sight of the Beverly Hills Hotel, Khloé, Kylie, and Kendall hop off the bus and run—screaming, laughing, conspicuous—toward the historic Hollywood site beloved by stars of previous Hollywood eras as one of the few from which paparazzi are banned. An irony: Paparazzi had been blamed for their aborted mission when this was the family that had disrupted culture with their glorification of the kind of self-surveillance that had replaced tabloids.

In the end, the Kar-Jenners *were* the Hollywood tour, because they'd decided they wanted to be after all, opting for a brasher method of catharsis, one that would make for better TV: displaying that they could easily reclaim —which, in this case, means mirror and mock—all the mirroring and mocking that the masses had performed to cope with their dominance.

Trump's critics often attempted to reclaim and subvert his media ubiquity, usually contributing to his notoriety in the process. A 2016 piece for *The Washington Post* by Maura Judkis acknowledged that "for a presidential candidate who's so effective at applying derisive nicknames to his opponents, Donald Trump has proven difficult to tar with a moniker of his own." Finally, after the ex-Republican writer and political consultant Rick Wilson dubbed him "Cheeto Jesus" on Twitter, "a good, old-fashioned meme was born." In hindsight, the meme was a corny cope that failed to undermine Trump's ascendancy; just a year later, *Vice* published a plea to retire the name and "make insults creative again." The Democrats, torn between "When they go low, we go high"—as Michelle Obama encouraged party members to do—and engaging in gloves-off showdowns to keep up with Trump's performance style, doubled down on pandering identity politics and manufactured memes instead.

In trying to make sense of the Trump phenomenon, his critics grappled with a phrase that the *New York Times* columnist Sheryl Gay Stolberg attributes to the philosopher Hannah Arendt: "the conflict between truth and politics." Politicians, Stolberg wrote in 2017, have always stretched the truth —Nixon and Watergate, Clinton's affair, Bush's war on terror. The Trump problem was that "over the past two decades, institutional changes in American politics have made it easier for politicians to lie…. With no widely acknowledged media gatekeeper, politicians have an easier time distorting the truth." Some of these institutional changes, write Nolan Higdon and Mickey Huff in *United States of Distraction: Media Manipulation in Post-Truth America,* include the 1996 amendment of the Communications Act of 1934, which had established the Federal Communications Commission in part to prevent corporate monopolies over media networks, and the 1949 Fairness Doctrine, meant to ensure that "both sides" of any issue always got airtime. The rise of the twenty-four-hour news cycle made notorious by the O. J. Simpson trial was of little help, and the growing dominance of reality TV and social media echo chambers surely played a part. By the time Trump began campaigning, Higdon and Huff write, citing a Stanford study from 2016, "less than 20 percent of middle school students [could] distinguish between a news report and a sponsored story. Less than one-third [could] identify the implicit bias in an article they [were] reading." Higdon and Huff add, "Youths' inability to determine fact from fiction is worsened by the online sharing culture that disseminates disinformation and false news stories through social media. In fact, a 2017 Common Sense study found that 31 percent of youths ages ten through eighteen admitted to sharing an article online in the previous six months that they later found out to be false."

The pursuit of Truth has always been a philosophical mission, and an evolutionary drive, but the Kar-Jenners were producing self-serving narratives and transforming their appearances at just the time when people sensed that the country was fracturing due to the decay of a common understanding of Truth.

DISCOURSE

Kim and Kanye kept up with the 2016 election's unforeseen and epic spectacle by producing more of their own dramas and debuts. The summer teemed with viral Taylor Swift moments as Trump barreled toward overtaking the Republican primary ticket. It was as though Kimye sought to provide pop culture consumers with their own partisan display so that they could mirror the polarized CNN and Fox programming saturating the air and trickling down to social media feeds, and take their sides about who had been aggressive, who had been duplicitous, and which was worse.

Kanye also leveled up his Yeezy brand—which was often underwritten by Adidas after his dramatic break with Nike in 2013—putting on impressive fashion showcases designed by auteur artists like Vanessa Beecroft that came off more like performance art and drew the fashion elite to its front rows, all while simultaneously promoting his new album, *The Life of Pablo*. (The shows were never without their own micro-scandals, attaching memorability to the news. Yeezy 4, shown at the Four Freedoms Park on Roosevelt Island, fell on such a hot day that *The New York Times,* in an otherwise glowing review of the looks and set design, reported on a model who nearly collapsed.) Kim—thriving as wife, mom, and muse—didn't make any new entrepreneurial releases during this time, riding on the success of her video game, emoji set, and reality show and probably behind the scenes plotting her beauty line, which would be soft launched the following year as a collaboration with Kylie Jenner's explosive cosmetics company. When she dropped KKW's first promotional photo on Twitter, featuring her contoured visage and yet another very dark tan, she would be accused of wearing blackface: A discourse about the family as the exemplars of cultural appropriation was starting to gain more and more traction.

But this was still to come. In early October, while Kanye was touring for his album and Kim was visiting Paris Fashion Week—live posting about the trip on her social media accounts—a group of men found her at her luxury rental, known as Hotel No Name, where they bound, gagged, and robbed her. When a tabloid called *MediaTakeOut* published articles suggesting that she'd staged the story, she sued for libel (making yet another citable

representational action out of the widespread doubt that circulated at the time). After this, she phased out of the spotlight just in time for political discourse to take center stage as Election Day drew nearer. It was a discourse focused mainly on Trump's racist rhetoric, which the sociologist Musa al-Gharbi, advocating for more thorough "Trump studies," unpacked in a paper called "Race and the Race for the White House: On Social Research in the Age of Trump." He found that some of the most popular articles and research studies of the mid-2010s purporting to explain the phenomenon and impact of Trump's rise were reliant on biased or sloppy research methods that limited a fuller understanding of how and why it had happened, instead institutionalizing groupthink. "It is absolutely critical," he wrote, "for the 'resistance' to have an accurate understanding of who voted for Trump and why: inaccurate research would likely generate ineffective electoral strategies. Indeed, motivated cognition and confirmation bias likely explain why most analysts couldn't see Trump's strength in the last cycle. If progressive scholars wish to avoid another humiliating and costly 'black swan' defeat for their party in 2020, then we'll need to begin with a sober reckoning of how he won in the first place—even if this means being more charitable towards Trump voters than we feel naturally inclined to be, or being skeptical of claims that would be very satisfying to accept." For example, Ta-Nehisi Coates suggested in *The Atlantic* that the white working class, Trump's most visible fans, could not solely be blamed for his success; all white people were responsible, as though "white Americans rose up in 2016 to dismantle the legacy of America's first black president." Al-Gharbi found that a decent amount of Trump voters had previously voted for Obama, in fact, and, anyway,

> Trump not only garnered stagnant turnout and a smaller vote-share among whites relative to Mitt Romney—he was nonetheless able to win because he also received a larger share among Asians and Hispanics (who *did* turn out in higher numbers), not to mention African Americans. Should we assume that Asians, Latinos and blacks were *also* motivated primarily by racism simply because they did not

find Trump's rhetoric (about China, Mexicans and Muslims) disqualifying?

Al-Gharbi also found that in an ethnography of "Trump's America" by Arlie Hochschild, *Strangers in Their Own Land: Anger and Mourning on the American Right,* respondents were asked leading and racially charged qualitative questions, noting that "the goal of *Strangers in Their Own Land* is not so much to understand these people on their own terms, for their own sake…. Instead, Hochschild's Tea Party supporting subjects and their stories are used as a means to political ends," which, if secured, "would benefit her subjects in the end—irrespective of their own preferences." The point is that Trump was understood through a singular lens, and soon Kardashian image production—and public consumption—would take on a distinctly, almost singularly, racial frame. November 8 arrived. Trump won, emerging in the early hours of the ninth at New York's Hilton Hotel to make his victory speech. A few weeks later, Kanye was hospitalized for exhaustion at the UCLA Medical Center, canceling the rest of the dates of his tour. This was a blue period for Kimye, but it was also a winning one. That summer, a Yeezy model—the Boost 750—was reported to have sold out in one second. That Kim had been robbed in Paris during Fashion Week certified, in a sense, her belonging there: The usual media drama about her unwelcome presence in such an elite environment had been demoted by a far more operatic incident. Kimye's status as one of the country's most newsworthy power couples had been normalized.

In the weeks that followed Trump's win, a lot of articles came out about how his victory should *not* be "normalized," from *The New York Times, The Washington Post, Slate, Vox, The Atlantic, Vulture, The Guardian*—many of the same outlets that had inadvertently promoted him during his campaign by running real-time updates of shock and outrage over his unrelenting antics. It was too late. For better or worse, in large part due to the media's focus and framing, the public had "accepted" both Trump and Kimye as forces that, at the very least, demanded to be contended with. As the political scientist Deva Woodly writes in *The Politics of Common Sense: How Social Movements Use Public Discourse to Change Politics and Win Acceptance,* "The acceptance I

refer to is not of a policy position but of the relevance of challenger issues… that the mainstream media covers, the public acknowledges as significant, and officials are compelled to address." Citing Diana C. Mutz and Joe Soss, she explains how "opinion environments" are formed: "Coverage…change[s] people's perceptions about whether an issue is salient as well as their perception of the dominance of certain opinion in their community as a whole."

Is it any coincidence that it was around this time—almost a decade into the family's scandalizing media tenure, and, more recently, alongside Trump's rise—that people began to make meaning of the family's media framing in a more formalized way?

The Kardashians inspired literature for every shelf in the bookstore. In 2017, the branding expert Jeetendr Sehdev published *The Kim Kardashian Principle: Why Shameless Sells (and How to Do It Right),* laying out what he saw as the "six principles of SELFIE" (Surprise, Expose, Lead, Flaws, Intimate, and Execute) observable in Kim Kardashian's enterprising, which "will maximize the effect of everything—your personal brand, product innovation, policy initiatives, and marketing campaigns." In 2015, the award-winning poet Sam Riviere published *Kim Kardashian's Marriage,* inspired by Kardashian's seventy-two-day fairy tale with Kris Humphries and structured according to her famous makeup tutorials—primer, contour, highlight, powder, blend, shadow, liner, and gloss. The urge seemed to be to find an order in the Kardashian content barrage, whether for the uses of business or personal expression. If the family was here to stay, and if the drive to Discourse was further saturating Trumpian culture, we might as well reclaim the family's utilities. A 2019 play by Jasmine Lee-Jones, *Seven Methods of Killing Kylie Jenner,* uses the Kar-Jenners as, by then, commonly understood symbols of cultural appropriation to express the pain of colorism, the complexities of friendship, and the mechanics of virality.

In 2015, the pop culture critic and self-identified "Kardashian truther" Mariah Smith launched her column, "Keeping Up with the Kontinuity Errors" on Tumblr, where she recapped *KUWTK* episodes by fact-checking the sequences of their scenes against paparazzi photos and social media posts,

figuring out the inconsistencies of their narratives. For example, the season 1 episode where Khloé is arrested for her DUI—the arrest scene, she found, was likely reenacted—or the fact that, as revealed by a 165-page divorce deposition, Kris Humphries's proposal to Kim had been subject to multiple cuts and reshoots, as well as a number of inconsistencies in the episode where Kylie owns up to her lip fillers: Those magazine interviews had not occurred in the sequence shown on the show.

Meanwhile, mainstream media sources gratified readers in much the same way by deconstructing Trump's every word. NPR provided play-by-play debate fact-checks, and *The New York Times* compiled "The Complete List of Trump's Twitter Insults" and, in 2020, an interactive article explaining his tax returns. "Keeping Up with the Kontinuity Errors" was soon syndicated by Gawker and then *New York* magazine, running until 2019. Smith's column doubled as education, helping viewers understand exactly how the show and others like it are built on narrative formulas. (She told BET in 2017 that when she met Khloé, she told her about her project and Khloé asked, "Oh, do we have a lot of errors?") In 2018, after watching the season 6 *KUWTK* episode where Kim and her brother, Rob, get into a gnarly fight with each other while on vacation in Bora Bora—feeling struck by how "real" it'd seemed amid so many other obviously staged scenarios in the episode—I began to document, on Instagram, my self-directed study of postmodernism, calling myself Kardashian Kolloquium and creating memes that applied Jean Baudrillard's and Michel Foucault's theories to the family. The idea was to understand how the family accumulated and hoarded social power by constructing multimedia narratives, and to apply "highbrow" concepts to accessible content—in a way, mirroring what the family had begun doing with their own productions. (Kanye's 2016 tableau music video for his single "Famous" was, itself, a contribution to—and instigator of—discourse, depicting himself and Kim as nude wax figures splayed out in a large bed with ten other pop culture icons—from Rihanna to Trump to Taylor Swift—an homage to the contemporary artist Vincent Desiderio's painting *Sleep,* itself a seeming reference to Leonardo's *Last Supper*. "It's a comment on Fame," West told *Vanity Fair*.)

While growing Kardashian Kolloquium, I discovered that in 2015 the Britain-based professor Meredith Jones had organized the world's first academic symposium on the Kardashian family, called Kimposium, held at Brunel University in London. A *Daily Mail* article announcing the news included the following bullet points as a subheading:

- Many men have spent a great deal of time studying Kim Kardashian's rear
- Now academics in Brunel University will sit down and consider her charms
- Meredith Jones has organised a conference to discuss the Kardashians
- Dr. Jones said: "They have gone beyond being reality TV stars"

One commenter wrote, "Dr. Meridith Jones really needs to keep her own fascination with this family to herself rather than trying to create an interest that actually is not as influential as she thinks. [A] few likes on instagram and 100s of articles on the DM does not constitute mass global interest whatever you might think Dr. Jones." Another said, "I will agree that Kim's body has helped to sexify short, curvy, brown girls. That's much appreciated. I also agree that many people are making $ with social media and selfies, which the Kardashians long ago perfected. And yes Kim cannot spell symposium." Many people seemed to take the intellectualization of the Kardashians as an offensive suggestion that the Kardashians themselves were intelligent enough to inspire fancy-sounding words and academic consideration—which would be intolerable, because intelligence is apparently synonymous with morality or likability.

The widespread wish to insult the intelligence of the bully ideologue Trump was also well documented during this time. In an essay in *Why Irrational Politics Appeals: Understanding the Allure of Trump,* Stephen Reicher and S. Alexander Haslam cite a *USA Today* poll that asked people to describe Trump in "their own terms," and the prevailing response was "idiot/jerk/stupid/dumb." A *New Republic* article exclaims that Trump is "even dumber than we thought." An analysis by Carnegie Mellon University's

Language Technologies Institute found that Trump speaks at a fourth-grade level—only slightly behind most presidents, who average a sixth-to-eighth-grade vocabulary. But that simplicity of speech is exactly how Trump managed to reach a vast number of people. As Meredith Jones says of the Kardashians, "They may be vacuous and bland when they open their mouths, but they are also very powerful. It is silly to think this subject is not worthy of academics' attention." It is as silly to believe the accessibility of their communication hasn't helped them in the same way it did Trump.

Kimposium 2015 (there would be another in 2021)—which, Jones told me later, inspired death threats—featured theorists like Elizabeth Wissinger speaking on "glamour labor," unpacking how the family had so effectively modeled a relationship to the self-as-commodity in an emerging gig economy; Lazlo Pearlman on Caitlyn Jenner's "celebrifying" of trans identity; and Katherine Appleford and Cecilia Cappel on the ways in which Kim's ass represented both cultural appropriation and assimilation. Defending the symposium, Jones wrote, "When energy is spent declaring that something is not worth serious consideration, I know it is important. Because when people devote time and space to condemnation, it immediately makes me wonder what social fears or cultural desires might lie beneath the aggression…. These sorts of comments make me more, not less, focused on studying the Kardashians. I am interested in what this family can teach us about ourselves, about our cultural concerns, about how our societies are changing, about our fears and horrors."

POLITICAL POSTMODERNISM

It was in the summer of 2017, months after Trump's winter inauguration into the White House, that Kim and four-year-old North graced the cover of *Interview* magazine. Dressed as Kennedys, photographed by Steven Klein, they were interviewed by the Black trans activist and writer Janet Mock, who asked questions about how production of *KUWTK* really worked and whether Kim raised her kids with race consciousness. Kim wore a bouffant, white gloves, and pearls—all Jackie signatures—and even, in some shots, a pillbox

hat. North, who drove even more hype by giving her own "first" interview to a panel of celebrity children, published alongside Kim's, wore a proper Peter Pan collar and her own tiny gloves. Their skin tones matched.

The dismay the images provoked made the by-now-to-be-expected headlines. For one, people always hated it when Kim dressed up as a beloved cultural icon. After her *Vogue Brasil* cover in 2015, for which she donned Marilyn blond locks, tweets called for her early death. According to one of my own TikTok commenters years later, Jackie, another bastion of old-school "elegance and class," would be "rolling in her grave" if she witnessed Kim's self-aggrandizing costuming. Plus, there was the cultural appropriation element, a discourse that was making its way from online social justice spaces into more mainstream news as the media attempted to resist Trump's racist rhetoric by leaning into identity politics. The Kar-Jenners had long represented the phenomenon with their enhanced lips, butts, and, as Lauren Michele Jackson writes, "leery proximity to blackness," due to their almost exclusive partnering with Black men. The backlash prompted Mock to apologize for her phrasing in the interview (she'd said that Kim had "challenged standards of beauty to make it a bit browner, a bit bronzer, a bit curvier") and promise that she'd had no influence over the artistic direction of the cover. Finally, there were the semiotics of it all. Kim as one of the most iconic First Ladies, lingering with her daughter in White House–looking halls, prompted a broader speculation: Were Kanye's occasional outbursts about his planned 2020 presidential run for real? Should we be bracing ourselves for Kimye in the White House?

Maybe ten or so years earlier, when Kanye went viral for saying that George Bush didn't care about Black people, and Kim for her sex tape, this would have been a laughable notion. In 2017, it still felt a little weird to wonder—yet far more possible, because Kimye had by now established themselves as household names in multiple industries, all the while aligning themselves with high art in a way that had made high art feel more relevant to everyday people. Now pop culture fans, piqued by Kanye West's frequent references to high art in much of his Kim-inspired productions, were reading up on Leonardo da Vinci and Picasso, parsing out their stances on the race

and gender politics symbolized by Kanye West versus Taylor Swift. Not to mention the fact that a former reality TV host and WWE cameo was sitting in the Oval Office. It was harder and harder to distinguish between politics and reality TV, which, in a sense, was making politics easier for Americans to engage with. Trump's communication style was accessible to his fans and odious to everyone else in a way that even the politically disengaged could confidently rally against, providing a personal angle that allowed "pundits and comics to talk endlessly about politics without being political," as Russell L. Peterson, author of *Strange Bedfellows: How Late-Night Comedy Turns Democracy into a Joke,* wrote.

When Trump was sworn in, aerial photographs showed a sparsely populated National Mall, especially compared with President Obama's first inauguration in 2009, which was attended by 1.8 million people. At a visit with the CIA a few days later, Trump complained about the visual, saying, "I looked out, the field was—it looked like a million, million and a half people." His press secretary, Sean Spicer, announced that Trump had enjoyed "the largest audience to ever witness an inauguration—period—both in person and around the globe," and cited Washington Metro ridership data to back up his claim that Trump's crowd was bigger than Obama's, though media outlets found that he'd referenced only the morning number of riders on Obama's 2013 Inauguration Day, compared with a rough estimate of all-day rides on Trump's. Kellyanne Conway described Spicer's statistics as "alternative facts," a phrase that became an iconic byword for the Trump administration and the culture wars it stoked.

How could these people frame Truth as something subjective? Some cultural analysts would frame the Trump ascent as a case study of "postmodernism," though the term, which gained staggered traction in the art, architecture, and literary worlds in the 1960s into the 1980s, was famously hard to define—and probably applicable to the overarching bipartisan political condition of a new-media-driven, late-stage-capitalist society. My favorite explainer of postmodernism comes from a Teach Yourself pamphlet by Glenn Ward, who defined it as knowingness ("since few people can trust their convictions…irony is the only option"), hybridization ("swap[ping]

purity for new combinations of genres, styles, and media"), intertextuality ("constantly alludes to, quotes and pays homage to other texts"), eclecticism ("bringing material together from disparate sources…what you listen to, watch, eat, wear and believe may be drawn from the myriad centers of global culture"), surface effects (when audiences engage with signs rather than material reality; Ward cites the Baudrillard quotation "the dissolution of TV into life, the dissolution of life into TV" as an example), and "identity as simulation" (when "personal identity" becomes a "loose assemblage of cultural bits and pieces"). We'd see all this in Kardashian programming, the Trump administration's antics, and the ways its opposing party reacted.

Studies would later find that a linguistic analysis program could predict the falsehood or accuracy of a Trump tweet with almost 75 percent accuracy, based on the phrasing—something Kar-Jenner detractors surely wished they could do anytime a Kar-Jenner put forth their latest claim or storyline.

Another slew of studies found that Trump utilized "repetition effect," which is, as one researcher defined it, when "repeated information is… perceived as more truthful," a finding "known as the illusory truth effect" that is "typically thought to occur because repetition increases processing fluency. Because fluency in this context and truth are frequently correlated in the real world, people learn to use processing fluency"—when ideas are simplified and therefore more efficient—"as a marker for truthfulness." The Kar-Jenners employed the same strategy: You could observe it in the simplistic way they spoke while working through their conflicts or explaining one of their latest products, the ways in which they recycled storylines, and even the repeated self-costuming with iconic imagery, from Marilyn to Jackie, as if to drill it home that Kim, herself, were an American icon. In fact, the family's proximity to the White House would only offer more repetitive visual statements over the following years. In 2018, Kourtney would head to Capitol Hill to speak in a closed briefing about the importance of clean beauty products (which would be well documented by *KUWTK*). It was also in 2018 that Kanye would wear his MAGA cap (putting this hat on "made me feel like Superman," he said) to visit Trump in the Oval Office alongside the civil rights activist Jim Brown. Kim would visit the following year to endorse a

more specified initiative: building upon criminal justice reform legislation recently signed by Trump to help formerly incarcerated people enter the workforce. Trump would announce her as a "friend," and she'd stand presidentially behind the East Room lectern to declare that "these people want to work," adding that the plan involved using rideshare gift cards to help candidates get to interviews and job shifts. In 2022, Kim would go head-to-head with Hillary Clinton (and win) on a legal trivia game moderated by Hillary's daughter, Chelsea, in an episode of the Clintons' documentary series, *Gutsy,* but also, on multiple other occasions, be pictured out and about with Ivanka Trump, whose brother-in-law, Joshua Kushner, was a key investor in her SKIMs retail venture. There would be visits to the White House Correspondents' Dinner, Caitlyn would endorse Trump in 2024, and Kim would visit with Kamala Harris to talk criminal justice reform that same year. It was enough that my own readers started asking me whether I thought we were intended to interpret any subtext from the persistent images—would *Kim,* rather than Kanye, one day run?

Within days of Conway's "alternative facts" gaffe, George Orwell's dystopian classic, *1984,* shot to the top of Amazon's bestseller list, prompting Penguin to order seventy-five thousand more copies of the book. Craig Burke, the publisher's publicity director, told *The New York Times* that he pinned the bump to the Conway interview. Dystopian novels in general were having a moment, with Sinclair Lewis's *It Can't Happen Here* and Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* also spiking in sales. Neil Postman, the media theorist and author of *Amusing Ourselves to Death,* might see Huxley's work as the most appropriate explanatory text of the moment. In the foreword to his own 1985 classic, he wrote, "What Orwell feared were those who would ban books. What Huxley feared was that there would be no reason to ban a book, for there would be no one who wanted to read one. Orwell feared those who would deprive us of information. Huxley feared those who would give us so much that we would be reduced to passivity and egoism. Orwell feared that the truth would be concealed from us. Huxley feared the truth would be drowned in a sea of irrelevance. Orwell feared we would become a captive culture. Huxley feared we would become a trivial culture." The inauguration

photos might have demonstrated a wimpy turnout, but the discourse about Trump's defensiveness only created yet another viral media cycle and did not change the fact that, upon his arrival on the political scene, the country exemplified the term "divided." A Pew survey showed that voter support had been split almost evenly between him and Hillary; the fact that Clinton won the popular vote (while Trump took the electoral) did not diminish his undeniable crowd-pleasing appeal.

Trump, an intuitive entertainer, tapped a deep vein of nostalgia with his "Make America Great Again" slogan, harking back to a golden era of American life (though the media-savvy Ronald Reagan, in fact, coined MAGA in the 1980s). In a 2016 interview with *The New York Times,* he said America was at its best during periods of military and industrial expansion. "The turn of the century…was a pretty wild time for this country and…in terms of building that machine, that machine was really based on entrepreneurship," and "the late '40s and '50s," when "we were respected by everybody, we had just won a war." The Kardashians also embedded nostalgia—personal, rather than political—in their own narratives; a YouTube compilation video called "The Kardashians Being Nostalgic for Nine Minutes Straight" has more than 200,000 views. Repetitive and recycled storylines show them visiting their grandparents' old home, telling the new residents, "We have so many amazing memories here," staging a surprise birthday party for Kris in their childhood kitchen, countless flashbacks to grainy home videos filmed by their father, Robert Kardashian Sr., poring over scrapbooks, and showing their own kids early season episodes of *KUWTK*. These were the years when the Kardashian machine itself was being built—by virtue of their development as human beings. In the Kardashian simulacrum, American dream success is when the "good life" of the past can be called upon in the present.

Though Trump's gaudy persona and abrasive politics had little clear resemblance to any notion of classic, wholesome family values, he, like the Kardashian family, did seek advantage for his extensive brood, deploying his sons Donald Trump Jr. and Eric to rep him at various rallies, Tiffany to do outreach with the LGBT community, Ivanka and his son-in-law Jared

Kushner to fill senior adviser positions in the White House. Headlines burbled over each Trump family member's gaffes, business endeavors, and political machinations, their multiplicity offering an array of storylines for the media machine at any given moment; meanwhile, images of Kim and Kanye in the White House sufficed as fodder for speculation about whether they would one day live there, and mere rejection of Trump—or Kim's self-styled proximity to Jackie Kennedy—approximated political consciousness. As Postman wrote, "When a population becomes distracted by trivia, when cultural life is redefined as a perpetual round of entertainments, when serious public conversation becomes a form of baby-talk, when, in short, a people become an audience…then a nation finds itself at risk; culture-death is a clear possibility."

And what symbolizes culture death more than this? On May 5, 2016, Donald Trump whipped up his latest spate of headlines with a tweeted image of himself hunched and grinning over a plate of food. "Happy Cinco de Mayo! The best taco bowls are made in Trump Tower Grill," he boasted. "I love Hispanics!"

CULTURAL APPROPRIATION

Today, nearly three thousand results surface when you search "Kardashian" with the term "cultural appropriation" in Google Scholar. Searching the terms together on Twitter renders countless results. Google searches for the more general term "cultural appropriation"—first cited by Arthur E. Christy in a 1945 piece about Orientalism—continued their gradual ascent from their 2011 debut on the internet toward a 2018 peak.

As one of my longtime readers, Victoria Shirley, wrote in a bell hooks–inspired 2021 paper titled "Keeping Up with the Kardashians and Cultural Commodification," the show "glorifies a lifestyle that reduces cultures to commodities through consumption. In turn, mainstream culture follows suit and mimics this imitation."

Of course, cultural appropriation as a pop-culture-inspired discourse did not begin with the Kardashians. It was notably during Kim's foundational

tabloid-era years that, as Lauren Michele Jackson points out, Eminem entered the 2000 VMA "theater in a white 'wifebeater'…and loose gray sweatpants, trailed by dozens of white close-cut bleached-blond lookalikes. At the time, Eminem appeared to be the portent of hip-hop's future—artists, critics and other protectors of the genre worried about the next coming of Elvis, worried that Eminem might catalyze a transformation of rap similar to what long ago happened to rock 'n' roll, and to jazz before that." This was the era of tabloid socialites throwing up gang signs for paparazzi photos, and of suburban midwestern high school dances soundtracked by rap. But in the later 2010s, Kim's ever-growing ass—ridiculed in the pilot episode of *KUWTK* ("I think she has a little junk in the trunk," Kris quips), the punch line of countless jokes, the subject of numerous rap odes through the years, the focal point of most of her fashion shots—became her personal logo, just as we can all identify a Coke by the shape of its bottle, or Disney by the Mickey Mouse ears, and the catalyst for conversations about the phenomenon of appropriation. In 2011, as a guest on the short-lived reality show *H8R,* Kim confronted a Black woman and self-described Kardashian "hater" who explained, "There's a few of us who feel like, come on, she's stealing our shine. The point is, when the black guys are like, oh this Kim Kardashian. Who's this Kim Kardashian? Wow, she's got a fat ass, whatever. It's like, but wait, wait a minute, I thought we had a corner on that. That's us, that's who we are." Kim told her, "I'm Armenian so that's a part of my culture. You look at my aunts, and my cousins, and my sisters and everyone. We have that curvy body too, it's not just an African American thing."

It's true that curves can also characterize SWANA women. It's also true that some scholars have expressed concern over cultural critics' essentializing "assert[ions] that the 'BBL body' is an essential approximation of a 'Black female body,'" as Jordan Taliha McDonald writes for *Lux.* But even if many SWANA girls do have hourglass figures—and even though not every Black woman does—it seems likely that the Kar-Jenners underwent Brazilian butt lifts, the most dangerous and fast-growing plastic surgery procedure of the 2010s, to further caricature their shapes. Not only that, but there were ways, even if unintentionally, Kim Kardashian's body, platformed by pop culture,

overshadowed other issues faced by Black women. *KUWTK* followed the dramas of Kim's complicated pregnancies (laying the groundwork for why she would one day bring on surrogates to carry her last two children). She experienced preeclampsia while pregnant with North, a dangerous condition of high blood pressure and organ damage. A 2021 study confirmed that "Black women have higher rates of preeclampsia and eclampsia than do White women and are more likely to die from this complication." Though many activists work to bring attention to this peril faced by Black moms, Kim's experience has associated her name with the condition.

Though appropriation discourse didn't begin in 2011, its place in the media and the academy had evolved. A 2023 University of Pennsylvania study looked at thousands of Upworthy headlines and found that those featuring "identity cues" earned more engagement; the sociologist Musa al-Gharbi found that there was an explosion of academic papers about identity politics after 2011, with a steady rise until 2022 or so. Kim's *PAPER* magazine cover had come out in 2015, the same year that Rachel Dolezal, an NAACP chapter president, was exposed as a white woman posing as Black. Dolezal became the poster girl for a spate of academic and activist types exposed for pretending to be Black or brown, including Jessica Krug and CV Vitolo-Haddad. As al-Gharbi put it in a talk for Ohio University, this reflected the growing value placed by privileged people in the symbolic capital of oppression. Something about the direction society—which increasingly dealt in "symbols, rhetoric, data, analysis, and ideas"—was going was inspiring people to self-brand according to identity. "So, if it's a genuine disadvantage to be a woman, to be a minority, to be LGBTQ, to be disabled—and…that seems to be the case—then why is it that elites are so eager to identify themselves as these very things?" Kim never claimed systemic oppression for her Armenian-ness, nor even her bids for Black credibility—in a sense, she lived as an already-unmasked Dolezal—but her global presence and all the discourses her likeness provoked loomed over these anxieties. In fact, if the Trump era had inspired a media incentive to promote identity-driven discourses, then the Kardashians seemed more than happy to supply provocations to that demand.

As time went on, the Kardashians expanded their cultural oeuvres. In 2019, not long after the release of a multipart series of *KUWTK* episodes filmed in Japan, Kim announced her new shapewear brand, Kimono—a word she attempted to trademark. After a good deal of viral Twitter backlash (#kimohno) and a chiding from the mayor of Kyoto, she renamed the brand SKIMS.

The discourse, though, tends to remain focused on the Black-white binary so essential to American identity. In 2022, when paparazzi photos seemed to indicate that Khloé and Kim had shrunken the size of their butts, a tide of TikTok videos, Instagram infographics, and think pieces theorized about the peril that this (as McDonald puts it) "depreciation of assets" could impose upon Black and brown women. Heralds of the "end of the BBL" era ended up being somewhat of a false alarm, however. The Kar-Jenners' butts remained sizable, though their indisputable weight loss did inspire new conversations about the ceaseless cycles of body trends women are forced to contend with (and that their power to begin and end "eras" at all was confirmation of their role in culture).

After Eminem's 2000 debut, the VMAs as a site for pop culture's consumption of Blackness came full circle in 2013 when, as Jackson writes, "the VMA for Best Hip-Hop Video was awarded to a white anti-hip-hop rap duo from Seattle named Macklemore and Ryan Lewis. Those same 2013 VMAs invited Robin Thicke and Miley Cyrus to jerk and jive to the riff of a song that would later incur payment of court-ordered royalties to Marvin Gaye's estate for borrowing without permission." (She was referring to Cyrus and Thicke's infamous "Blurred Lines" performance, in which Miley twerked onstage.) The word "twerk" was one of the top searched on Google that year, outmatched slightly by "selfie," but, *Time* pointed out, "comparison of Google search volume for the two words reveals that…twerk saw both greater average search volume and a higher search peak than selfie did."

"The idea that any artistic or cultural practice is closed off to outsiders at any point in time is ridiculous, especially in the age of the internet," Jackson went on. "Most everyday acts of appropriation, done unconsciously, escape our notice: the word that works itself into your speech because your best

friend sprinkles every other phrase with it and where they got it from they don't even know; the yoga pose you sink into after a workout; the way you shimmy when your favorite song comes on."

Kim's ass, however Armenian it had started off, seemed to expand in tandem with all the growing interest in her body and in the concept of appropriation. The question remained: Could the butt alone be a symbol of cultural appropriation? As Jackson puts it, "Appropriation is everywhere, and is also inevitable. So long as peoples interact with other peoples, by choice or by force, cultures will intersect and mingle and graft onto each other." But in the case of the Kardashians, their butts were not the only grafted references. Per the nature of postmodernism, the Kardashians' entire ecosystem was built of borrowed aesthetics from a variety of sources. They even exposed some of their own thefts early, revealing, in the process, one of their most consistent reference points: In a dictionary cut-in for *Kardashian Konfidential,* the sisters cite one of their own common phrases—"shady"—and say they don't know the source. "Probably it was in a rap song and we stole it."

BRAIDS

In June 2018, only a few weeks after successfully visiting the White House to appeal to President Donald Trump to commute the life sentence of Alice Marie Johnson, a grandmother (and future SKIMS model) who'd committed a nonviolent drug offense in 1996—commencing the gradual breadcrumbing of her newfound interest in criminal justice reform activism and the study of law—Kim Kardashian wore Fulani braids to the VMAs.

These red-carpet images of Kim were far from the first nor the last time she wore Black women's hairstyles; she'd kicked off the new year by sharing a Snapchat video of herself in beaded blond braids and big glasses, announcing that she "did Bo Derek braids, and I'm really into it," and posting to Instagram a Polaroid of herself in the braids with the caption "BO WEST." She was referencing the white 1980s movie star Bo Derek, who had worn similar braids in an iconic swimsuit scene in the 1979 film *10,* rather than the history of the style, which had originated in West Africa and indicated

marital status, tribe, and social position. As Emma Dabiri writes in *Don't Touch My Hair,* braiding "is a process that brings people together and facilitates intergenerational bonding and knowledge transmission…. The social meaning encoded into braids' multiple layers brings with it centuries of accumulated information, beliefs, and practices."

In 2020, Kim would sport thick braids for her husband's Yeezy 8 campaign, and countless other examples exist of hair-based cultural costuming performed by all the other Kar-Jenner sisters throughout their rise and reign. In 2015, Kylie posted a photo of herself to Instagram wearing cornrows with the caption "I woke up like diss," prompting the *Hunger Games* actress Amandla Stenberg to comment, "When u appropriate black features and culture but fail to use ur position of power to help black Americans by directing attention towards ur wigs instead of police brutality or racism #whitegirlsdoitbetter." It bears consideration that all these images of the Kar-Jenners in Black hair are consumed by the public in the form of pictures. As Susan Sontag wrote in her seminal work *On Photography,* the act of snapping a photo is a sort of exploitation of reality itself, a "turn[ing]" of "people into objects that can be symbolically possessed." Through this lens, commodified Kar-Jenner images of cultural appropriation are really spectacles of appropriation *of* appropriation. "Despite the illusion of giving understanding," Sontag writes, "what seeing through photographs really invites is an acquisitive relation to the world that nourishes aesthetic awareness and promotes emotional detachment."

In 2018, after ignoring January's backlash and wearing braids again, this time to the VMAs, Kim faced another round of criticism. She told *Bustle* a few weeks later, "In no way am I ever trying to disrespect anyone's culture by wearing braids. If anything, my daughter was so excited to see me get matching braids with her. [When] we did her hair in these braids, she was so excited." When asked about her butt, Kim invokes her Armenian curves. When asked about her braids, Kim invokes her biracial daughter (and, in a 2019 interview with the playwright Jeremy O. Harris, she would do it again, also reminding him that Armenians have a braiding tradition as well). Then, in August, she was pictured for CR Fashion Book in an Americana shoot,

wearing prairie dresses and harmless plaits, as though to remind the public that there are many different ways to wear a braid, as though Bo Derek's 2015 dismissive remark to *The Cut* about Kar-Jenner hair controversies—"It's a hairdo! That's all it is"—had been the right answer. In high school, Kim was voted "Most Likely to Lie About Her Ethnicity." Whether she was trying to dodge her own SWANA identity in a super-white, rich Bel Air environment, or trying to align with the "ghetto fabulous" MTV aesthetic of the times, is an open question.

In any event, Kim's ethnic ambiguity allowed her to function in pop culture as a sort of post-racial simulacrum of female beauty. But the thing about simulacra—as we learned in the *Truman Show* section of the previous chapter—is that they replace reality with representations until the original is no longer relevant or even considered.

While the Kar-Jenners are able to don these hairstyles at will, discrimination against Black hair is written into history and law. As the researchers Saran Donahoo and Asia D. Smith wrote in 2022, "Black hair has been a contested issue since Europeans encountered Africans…. Slaveowners required Black women to cover their hair or adopt grooming practices that emulated White beauty," practices that often damaged their hair and skin, not to mention their self-image. The stigmatizing of Black hair, they point out, has fed a profitable beauty industry, adding that "Black Americans spend more than 9 times as much on their hair as individuals of other races." It has also endangered the employment of Black women who want to wear traditional styles or their natural textures, because some companies impose policies of "professionalism" regarding self-presentation.

As always, the courts have documented this American legacy. In 1970, Beverly Jenkins, a Blue Cross Blue Shield employee of almost three years, started wearing an Afro to work and was denied promotion; her supervisor told her she could "never represent Blue Cross" with this hairstyle. The court ruled in her favor, but "did not offer any directions about discrimination against Black hair." Donahoo and Smith cite six more cases that involved a Black woman defending her hair autonomy, some won and others lost, which

eventually led to the overdue establishment of anti-hair-discrimination laws in New York and California in 2019.

Al-Gharbi describes "moral credentialing," an unconscious process of self-justification he observes often in liberal circles. He cites studies that show that when people proclaim their commitment to feminism, they tend to become "more likely to favor men when making decisions about hiring and promotion." We're especially likely, he adds, "to seek out and brandish moral credentials in the face of some kind of actual or anticipated questioning of our behavior…so if we've done something or are about to do something that we think might be controversial…we often remind ourselves or other people about what good people we are by affirming these narratives about anti-racism or feminism."

Whether it was a matter of causality or correlation, Kim's cultural appropriation became a wider spectacle around the same time that she began to study law with a focus on criminal justice. Perhaps in her studies she came across what has come to be called the Bo Derek defense. In 1981, Renee Rogers, an eleven-year employee of American Airlines, sued her employer for sex and race discrimination over its "grooming policy," which prohibited women from wearing their hair in braids. Rogers lost the case. The judge decided that hairstyles were not "immutable," because they could be put on and taken off, and that braids were not culturally significant specifically to Black women because they "had been popularized by a white actress in the film '10.'"

TEQUILA

Kendall Jenner arguably eluded racial controversies nearly as adeptly as her sister Kourtney—except for her infamous Pepsi commercial in 2017, which showed the model bringing peace to a protest suggestive of Black Lives Matter by offering a Pepsi to a cop, inspiring an outpouring of memes, headlines, and tweets. But she did have a braid moment of her own: A 2021 commercial for her tequila brand, 818, showed her riding a horse through agave fields with two loose braids falling over either shoulder, raising her glass

in a toast with the field's harvesters (an ad that bears astonishing resemblance to the opening sequence of the classic telenovela *Destilando Amor*). When 818 was announced, the internet exploded with outrage. In a post that now has more than 100,000 "likes," the popular pop culture and fashion news Instagram account @diet_prada reported that "the Mexican and Latinx community aren't so keen on the launch," citing social media comments like "Tequila production is traditionally a family business in Mexico. I think it's disgusting that another rich white celeb is appropriating Mexican culture with the audacity to think you're making it better than Mexicans," and "yeah no, I'd rather be supporting an authentic Mexican brand than a white girl's."

When Kendall announced 818 on Instagram, she wrote that she had been "on a journey to create the best tasting tequila" and that "I think we've done it!" A 2023 study called "Culture for Sale" by Jason D. Lin and colleagues found that consumers respond poorly to companies' assertions that they have somehow "improved" upon the cultural products of less powerful groups. Still, few tequila brands had faced scrutiny like this. In the '00s, Patrón became a household name by being featured in rap songs by Lil Jon, Rihanna, Drake, and the Weeknd; P. Diddy popularized DeLeón in the later 2010s. The same study did find that consumers tended to care less when an identity group considered disadvantaged appropriated from another also considered disadvantaged. But that can't explain the lack of outcry in 2013, when the white A-list actor George Clooney and his friend Rande Gerber (Cindy Crawford's husband) debuted Casamigos, which became a household name and was sold four years later for $1 billion (a stroke of success that might well have inspired Kendall's venture).

Chantal Martineau, author of *How the Gringos Stole Tequila,* tells me that celebrity interest in tequila can be traced back to Old Hollywood, due to Mexico's proximity to Los Angeles. During Prohibition in the 1920s and 1930s, it was smuggled into California from Mexico as whiskey was to the northern United States through Canada. In 1955, Bing Crosby and his bandleader buddy, Phil Harris, discovered the blue-agave brand Herradura, which had been founded in 1870 by Félix López, and brought it to the States. Before then, any tequila brought in was *mixto,* or made with a compilation of

sugars rather than pure agave. Fast-forward to the 1950s again, when the Champs' song "Tequila!" further popularized the spirit, and again to the 1980s, when the singer Jimmy Buffett built a hospitality franchise around an (arguably) American-invented tequila cocktail: the margarita. "Way before Kendall Jenner came along," Martineau tells me, "you had an industry dominated by non-Mexican interests…. Other than Cuervo, there are no major tequila brands that are Mexican owned. It's been appropriated for four decades. If you've ever wondered why it's harder for Americans to do this with Champagne, it's because it's not available for American celebrities to buy—but tequila is." Besides, thanks to lax regulations on production and import of the spirit, tequila can be produced by any method, while Champagne (if it is to be labeled as such) must be made a certain way.

The point is that the history of tequila is one of appropriation, which is why Martineau found it "a little funny" that people were so mad at Kendall. In her book, she tells a story about "this guy who went to this distant corner of tequila country and asked the elderly patriarch if he could sell the tequila in the US." The patriarch refused the man's repeated requests, but after his death the American tried his son, offering him "more money than the kid had ever thought of or dreamt or seen. And that's how DeLeón started." Diddy wasn't involved at the time, she adds, but she finds that story "a lot more heartbreaking" than the rather straightforward way that 818 came about.

Such targeting of family brands happens less often now that there are established distilleries in the region, often producing multiple labels at once. There are only about 180 distilleries in Mexico, but they contribute to thousands of different brands. 818 is made by a Jalisco distillery that produces more than five others, using traditional agave crushing methods that Martineau approves of. "The master distiller can make something specifically to certain specifications," says Martineau, but the main distinguishing factor between brands is mostly down to the packaging. The splash made by 818 might reveal one unspoken cultural contribution made by the Kar-Jenners, and it's not the commodities they shill: People hate *their* family business so much that they tend to start overdue conversations.

There are “a lot of uncomfortable conversations to be had,” says Martineau, over what might seem “an obscene amount of money to a poor farmer in rural Mexico” in comparison to what a company makes off a $100 bottle in the United States, a fraction of which will go to the farmer. Did Kendall have some insensitive marketing? “Probably. Is she the first person to appropriate tequila from Mexico? No. Of course not. The whole story of tequila is a story of appropriation. So, everyone’s just arriving at the table for that.”

DISRUPTERS

For the first ten or so years of their fame—from the gaudy years of their arrival as stars to Kim’s Everywoman power-couple era—the Kardashians entertained what the *Vox* reporter Chavie Lieber calls a “symbiosis” with fast-fashion companies like Missguided, PrettyLittleThing, and Fashion Nova. Because “in the US, clothing designs are legally allowed to be duplicated, even without permission from the original creator,” Kylie would wear, say, a glittery tube top romper to her twenty-first birthday party, and within days Fashion Nova would promote its offering of a copy, invariably worn by a model who looked like a member of the Kardashian Clone Army. Tweets would circulate—“the devil works hard, but Fashion Nova works harder,” one person wrote, referencing an adage about the Kardashian family—but the Kar-Jenners said nothing. After all, “the constant attention from fast-fashion brands that regurgitate their fashion choices to the masses helps the Kardashian family because they stay at the top of the public’s mind.” For the masses to run around in affordable replicas of looks we’d first seen on the Kar-Jenners was basically on-the-ground (or, more aptly, on-the-body) marketing for the family’s brand (contributing to that resounding complaint: “They’re everywhere!”).

But on February 17, 2019, Kim Kardashian wore a black vintage Mugler dress with an avant-garde cleavage cutout to the Hollywood Beauty Awards in L.A. On February 18, Fashion Nova released a waiting list for fast-fashion fans to buy their own knockoffs of the dress (driving home the company’s

head-spinning manufacturing turnaround times). This time, suddenly, Kim did not consider the unofficial mass marketing so helpful. On February 19, she tweeted, “It’s devastating to see these fashion companies rip off designs that have taken the blood, sweat and tears of true designers who have put their all into their own original ideas.” She even brought Kanye into it, reminding us that for the past few years she had been a well-behaved, supportive wife, mom, and muse—her kid sister, Kylie, was the girlboss—and those traditional values were in no risk of phaseout. “I’ve watched these companies profit off my husband’s work for years and now that it’s also affecting designers who have been so generous to give me access to their beautiful works, I can no longer sit silent.” Fast fashion was also known for being, according to earthday.org, “one of the most polluting of all industries,” given that most garments end up in landfill incinerators and fabrics are often made with toxic dyes and heavy metals that end up in our water supply, not to mention their exploitation of factory garment workers in the global south, but for Kim the problem was a symbolic matter. On February 20, she filed a $10 million lawsuit *not* against Fashion Nova (due to the family’s history of partnerships with the brand, surmises Lieber) but against a different fast-fashion shop, the U.K.-based Missguided, citing the company’s use of the family’s photos to market its own products (Missguided had, for example, an entire page on its website dedicated to a scrapbook-style compilation of Kim’s outfits; she would win $2.8 million later that summer).

The crusade didn’t end there: On May 6, 2019, Kim wore another Mugler piece—the now-iconic compressive “wet look”—to the Met Gala, using the mediums of both the red carpet and her own body to show just how dramatically she could shape her silhouette. One month after that, she announced her new shapewear company, Kimono (which would be renamed SKIMS in August). Spinning a narrative with tweets, scandals, and lawsuits, Kim sent a new message to the world: If we wanted to reproduce her aesthetics, then *she* would be the manufacturer. SKIMS was cofounded with Jens Grede as CEO and Emma Grede as chief product officer (she had also co-founded Khloé’s denim brand, Good American). The company was

framed as start-ups often are: a “disruption” to the industry, a “solution” to a “problem.”

In his book *Thank You for Disrupting,* Jean-Marie Dru (who claims to be “the first one to ever use the word ‘disrupting’ in a positive way”) identifies the common traits of twenty-five moguls, from Apple’s co-founder Steve Jobs, “the first corporate leader who embodied, in an unprecedented way, the concept of ‘design thinking,’ ” to Arianna Huffington, who “disrupted the conventional news delivery and made digital news reporting respectable.” Their common trait, Dru romantically surmised, was “a real desire to transform things. This change can be accomplished by inventing as-yet-unheard-of solutions.” Common to many of these disrupters’ founding myths was an idea that they were destined for entrepreneurial greatness. In *The Art of the Deal,* Trump shares a childhood memory about playing with his younger brother. “I ended up using all of my blocks, and then all of his, and when I was done, I’d created a beautiful building.” In a *Kardashian Konfidential* sidebar titled “Buy and Sell,” Kim speaks of being eighteen and says that after realizing eBay was a way to resell unwanted goods for herself *and* her friends (after “cleaning out their closets”), “I had a rule: If I want to buy something I have to sell something first.”

The myth of the founder was a looming force in millennial culture in tandem with the most viral years of Kardashian (and MAGA) American dream chasing. One individual in particular shed light on the semiotics associated with the quintessential founder: the Stanford University dropout Elizabeth Holmes, whose fraudulent blood-testing company, Theranos (a portmanteau, Wikipedia notes, of “therapy” and “diagnosis”), scaled to a $4 billion valuation by 2014, the same year she was featured on the cover of *Forbes* as the “world’s youngest self-made woman billionaire.” Holmes was known for mimicking Steve Jobs’s iconic black turtleneck in her own self-costuming and speaking in a deep baritone voice that associates later claimed was not her natural tone. (Funnily enough, Kim Kardashian has also been observed to have undergone a sort of “voice evolution,” gradually abandoning her early-career L.A.-coded vocal fry by the 2020s for a deeper, clearer tone.) In 2015, the lies scaffolding Theranos were exposed, but Holmes’s

persona, now an infamous mockery, shed light on the trappings of the iconic archetype she'd been trying to actualize—not only a matter of turtlenecks, but of perpetuating a slick, problem-solver model that was popularized, in one way or another, by all the founders who came before. Throughout the 2010s, after all, billions upon billions of dollars had been poured into companies that made promises of industry disruption, like Uber, which freed users from having to wait on the curb; Airbnb, which made travel lodging more affordable; Netflix, which saved users a trip to the local Blockbuster, and more.

Right after SKIMS dropped in September, Kim told *W Magazine* that she was constantly reworking her shapewear. "I'd always be cutting them up and figuring something out, like the one-legged solution short that we have, because I'd be wearing a dress with a slit and still needing that support everywhere else, but wanting my leg out." She had solutions from shape, to seams ("Another problem that I had is I would put on something really tight over my shapewear and you'd see the seam going down the front—that kind of defeats the purpose when people know that you are wearing something"), to shades ("Usually if I had time, I would dye [shapewear] in the sink with teabags myself"). Kim summed her newfound identity up this way: "When I feel like I have a solution to something, it makes me really excited."

Focused on a range of skin-toned compressive fabrics, SKIMS offered an even blanker canvas than Yeezy athleisure suits did—onto which fans could layer an ever-accelerating rotation of trends. Proof already existed that shapewear was a winning concept: The underwear and hosier company Spanx, now a household name, had started out of the living room of the Disney World Resort employee Sara Blakely and was, by 2018, worth $400 million. (The story of the company's christening confirms that, from a business perspective too, SKIMS was always the better name for Kim's brand: In 2012, Blakely told Inc.com that she was first inspired by Kodak and Coca-Cola, both of which "had a strong 'k' sound in them…. I also have friends that are stand-up comedians and it's this weird trade secret that the 'k' sound will make your audience laugh. So…almost spontaneously, I'm sitting in traffic in Atlanta, the word 'spanks' came to me across my dashboard in

traffic…. I thought, 'That's it.'…I made a decision to change the 'ks' to an 'x' because I had done some research prior that made-up words do better for products than real words do and they're also easier to trademark.")

Kim's body-oriented enterprise reflected the fundamental formula of her fame—her physicality—and it also spared her the task of reproducing (and, therefore, risking alienating) her own quickening rotation of elevated high-fashion partnerships. This way, fans could have a piece of Kim that would never go out of style (and literally cling as close as possible), no matter how much faster information moved. As a song by Drake and 21 Savage would one day proclaim, "Put her SKIMS on, now she acting like she Kim."

The debut SKIMS collection dropped on September 10, 2019, with no item costing more than $100. *WWD* reported that the brand's first social media campaign, for what SKIMS called Solutionwear, featured an arrangement of "models of all shapes and sizes—and ages" in addition to Kim herself. Many of the models were "real women," working as writers, actresses, or entrepreneurs. The diversity echoed Rihanna's successful Savage x Fenty lingerie brand, which had launched in 2018 as an extension of her winning beauty line.

In fact, Fenty would compete directly with the Kar-Jenner beauty and shapewear enterprises—though neither empire would ever make a big thing of it. Though the 2010s Instagram era opened an onslaught of celebrity beauty and fashion brands—Jessica Alba, Ariana Grande, and Eva Mendes launched beauty brands the same year that Kylie Cosmetics hit the social media feeds and changed the industry—the Kardashians would avoid public rivalry with any of the celebrity brands they were really competing with, probably because, in a market where the brand was the same as the person, the narratives could become harder to control and actually harm business. Instead, Kim tweeted flattery to Rihanna for her showstopping maternity fashions while poaching former Victoria's Secret models for campaigns that inspired think pieces about how SKIMS was the new household-name lingerie chain, placing focus on expiring companies rather than beloved individuals. When personal drama was needed, she drummed up conflicts

with her own sisters, and a star whose Americana pop music brand had little to do with hers: Taylor Swift.

Only a month after launch, Kim was already featured on the cover of *New York* magazine wearing the quintessential, entrepreneurial black turtleneck—only it was a dress emphasizing the hourglass shape that had brought her to this point. “My Decade,” read the headline.

RECYCLING

The headliner of the debut SKIMS web campaign was Alice Marie Johnson, the grandmother on whose behalf Kim had pleaded for clemency to Donald Trump the previous year, lending a layered backstory to the ad. By featuring Johnson (who declared that her SKIMS made her “feel free”), Kim had recycled one iconic politically themed White House photo op for the purposes of a new, retail-focused one. Even if you were cynical about Kim’s intentions in helping Johnson, her story—one of adversity and redemption—had undeniable emotional appeal. In a study that deconstructs branding “repackaging” processes, Dr. Alfred Edema writes that “decisions…are made by the consumers according to what they feel; in fact the consumer visualizes and imagines the product…and estimates and assesses the feeling gained from it.” In his book *Postemotional Society,* Stjepan Meštrović agreed that “contemporary advertisements sell feelings, moods, and emotions that are synthetically attached to a given product.” The emotional summons turned out well for SKIMS: Headlines and tweets about Alice Marie Johnson populated media, the “famous for being famous” strategy working once again, selling out instantly, with TMZ reporting that “first-day sales numbers are unprecedented for shapewear and undergarment brands.” Spanx earned $4 million in its first year; SKIMS, meanwhile, “made half that amount in only a couple hundred seconds.”

From there, SKIMS campaigns began to unroll, seemingly at random, in contrast to the seasonal drops employed by most other brands. For many of them, Kim maximized her and her sisters’ cachet. *KUWTK* and *Kardashians* episodes documented the behind-the-scenes of photo shoots. In 2020, while

the pandemic lockdown was in full swing, she posted videos of herself and Khloé for the Cozy Collection: Seemingly filmed on grainy camcorders, the sisters wore face masks and neutral-toned fleece sets, chatting on dated-looking landlines. SKIMS campaigns became known for their cool aesthetics and for alluding to whatever the zeitgeist might be—often staged by the same auteur photographers and creative directors who styled Kanye West music videos or Yeezy showcases. (Kim called Kanye a "ghost creative director" of the brand.)

Whenever a campaign featured a Kardashian, its tone was distinctly nostalgic. A Kardashian Data Koalition survey of Kardashian Kolloquium readers tested brand perceptions of SKIMS campaigns, and found that the more "nostalgic" the coding of a campaign—Kim with Paris Hilton, clad in a velour jumpsuit and holding a flip phone; Kim pairing her metallic swimwear line with teased waves and blue eyeshadow, posing poolside surrounded by poodles at a mid-century ranch—the more respondents liked it. Even the notion of SKIMS itself was nostalgic. The Victorians had their corsets, and as Sam Sanders said to me in a conversation for *The Cut,* our moms had their "girdles." As Derek Thompson wrote of the power of nostalgia in *Hit Makers,* "Familiar ideas are processed faster, and the sensation of quick and easy thinking—also known as fluency—is strong yet sneaky, so that people attribute the pleasure of the thought to the quality of the idea."

Over time, though, as SKIMS' staying power became more and more self-evident—Nordstrom became the first brick-and-mortar retailer to stock the brand in 2020, and the following year pop-ups began appearing in L.A. and Paris—the "headliner" approach exhibited by the original Alice Marie Johnson campaign would come to define the brand. In July 2021, SKIMS announced that it would outfit the Team USA Women's teams during the 2021 Summer Olympics. In an Instagram post about the drop, Kim said, "Ever since I was 10 years old, I've heard every single detail about the Olympics from my stepdad. As I would watch the athletes compete, I would grow to understand the dedication and honor being a part of the Olympics embodied." A skim of comments on the post, or of Twitter responses to the post, surfaces the kinds of positive responses atypical for Kim content. "What

a brilliant way to get your designs on athletic toned people and seen by the world. Congratulations, Kim," wrote @lorraine_grant. (It also gave Kim a chance to get her designs on diverse bodies, because the campaign featured Paralympic athletes.) The public was picking up that SKIMS ads were practically coded to prompt discourse. In September, Kourtney Kardashian and Megan Fox—It Girls of the moment due to their similarly viral, PDA-heavy relationships with the tattooed celebrity musicians Travis Barker and Machine Gun Kelly—were featured in a sexy shoot by Donna Trope that called to mind classic grainy photos of Megan taken by Terry Richardson for *GQ* in 2008, twinning like any pair of Kardashian sisters. I was active on TikTok during this time and received a barrage of demands from followers to "talk about it." A pattern was forming: Kim seemed to be able to grab people at the height of their relevance and capture them for campaigns. What was so special about SKIMS? Now that Kim, nearing forty, owned a brand with infinite potential as a medium, the Everywoman was stepping back—part of the time at least—to let others represent her instead. In 2021, SKIMS announced a collaboration with Fendi. In 2022, after a power move of a collab with four of the most recognizable Victoria's Secret Angels, headlines asked, "Is Skims the new Victoria's Secret?" In 2023, as the country digested the conclusion of *The White Lotus,* which had been watched by 4.1 million people only a month earlier, a Valentine's campaign featured two beloved breakout stars of the TV murder mystery. Later that year, at the height of her TikTok virality, Ice Spice costarred in a few videos with North West, and then appeared in a Vanessa Beecroft SKIMS campaign with other Gen Z rising stars. Young pop culture fans, developing their own distinct flavor of Kar-Jenner disdain, were dismayed by this one. I received floods of comments expressing shock that Ice Spice, whose aesthetics reflected and inspired their own, had deigned to collude with Kim, and others angry that Kim had snagged their faves for a feature. "Ugh. Kim just HAS to steal the limelight from genuine upcoming talent," one comment read. I even received a call from a young music journalist who seemed to believe that Ice Spice had been an unknowing victim of the Kardashian-industrial complex. Finally, in 2024, after a series of *Kardashians* episodes showed Kim taking her kids to

soccer games in the U.K. and Paris, and after Kim was photographed at Fashion Week supporting Victoria Beckham's debut collection, she announced that SKIMS was expanding its offerings to men and dropped a campaign featuring some of the world's most elite and respected athletes, from the Brazilian soccer player Neymar to the Canadian basketball player Shai Gilgeous-Alexander. Not long after came an announcement that SKIMS was the official partner of the NBA, and a campaign featuring WNBA stars soon followed. SKIMS watching became a media pastime. Who would be next? Every drop was a statement of Kim's relentlessly expanding cultural dominance: If pop culture was a spectacle of interconnection and images, then she was shaping SKIMS into a cultural aggregator, or anthology, or archive, of key moments and figures. The SKIMS ad was the new *Rolling Stone* cover or *SNL* hosting gig or Got Milk? ad of the digital age: a showcase for *the* star of *right now*.

In this sense, then, SKIMS begs a question: Is the brand an agent of the "culture industry"? Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer coined the term in 1947 to describe "the automatic self-reproduction of the status quo in its established forms…an expression of domination." Adorno's concern was that streamlined culture created streamlined audiences. Was SKIMS in fact deciding who would be remembered as relevant?

By this point, we were living in what the media theorists Nick Couldry and Andreas Hepp called an era of "datafication," which is, they propose, the "fourth wave of mediatization," following the previous centuries' "mechanization," "electrification," and "digitalization." If reality as we know it is an ongoing process of interaction and integration of ever-evolving media, then we must realize that " 'data' and 'information' generated by systems of computers are today a precondition for everyday life." In other words, due to advancements in digital surveillance, Big Tech—of which Kim, whose narratives were presented and consumed using technology, and who had begun name-dropping Jeff Bezos as a newfound peer on her show around this time, was surely an agent—was able to see which celebrities were trending and what kind of content got consistent clicks and shape its productions accordingly. So, maybe the stars featured in SKIMS ads really just mirrored

our own interests. But all this goes one step beyond a brand spitting back our favorite images at us.

Stjepan Meštrović wrote in *Postemotional Society* of his belief that postmodern analyses of contemporary culture focused too much on the recycling of imagery alone—which the Kardashians indeed utilized, from Kim's recent Jackie O cosplay for *Interview* to the use of grainy camcorders in the cozy 2020 SKIMS campaign—but also the recycling of "dead emotions from the past into the living present," which he calls "more than nostalgia." Meštrović cites situations like the O.J. trial in America, where "emotional anger at the history of racism in the USA" was recycled by attorneys to get Simpson acquitted, or the way people in the West are now able to celebrate milestones, like parents for their kids' birthdays, using party experience packages from the likes of McDonald's (all of which "really constitutes the institutionalization of postemotionalism, the standardized, factory-like packaging of emotions pertaining to traditional events such as birthdays, weddings, anniversaries, and births, among others, which used to be more idiosyncratic, private, and personal"). When we see nostalgic images that resurrect our "dead emotions," we are not reacting to material reality but engaging in institutionalized ritual. After all, we are often told what to think about the images we consume by commentators on television. Meštrović's theory is inspired in part by his mentor David Riesman, author of *The Lonely Crowd,* whose ideas around "other-directed" personalities we explored in the Kennedys chapter. Meštrović believes that the cultural rise of "other-directedness" has made way for the packaging and recycling of emotions. "The other-directed type thereby lives his or her own emotions vicariously, in the present, through other opinion-makers, and nearly everyone is an opinion-maker in some capacity or other."

When the triumph of Johnson's release from incarceration (or doubts about Kim's motives in spending so much time with marginalized people) is recycled, or two Italian ingenues reignite the thrill of the *White Lotus* ending, or sports fans experience whatever they feel when their favorite athletes score big goals, we participate in this melodrama. So, Meštrović asks, "WHO is responsible for the recycling? In other words, is the recycling random or is it

committed by the 'culture industry,' as Theodor Adorno argued? And if the culture industry is involved, the same question must be repeated: Is the process in the vast culture industry random and spontaneous, as argued by Baudrillard, or does it have a mechanized logic of its own?"

That's where data can help us. The revelation that the Kardashians likely use data to monitor their audience's clicks, and therefore produce content most likely to engage them again in the future, is what inspired me to organize the Kardashian Data Koalition in 2022. During one of our meetings, after conducting an audit of the SKIMS Instagram page, the data expert Mia Parenteau announced her discovery that SKIMS had made nearly three times as many posts as Savage x Fenty, which had launched a year earlier. This was consistent with a claim I often made on Kardashian Kolloquium—that the Kardashians (like Trump) strategically overwhelmed the public with content so that there was a higher chance of at least one message sticking, and to keep people disoriented whenever a faux pas was committed. But for all this image production, Parenteau realized, SKIMS didn't often invent new product prototypes; it relied on a rapid turnover of images that represented the same basic products. For example, the Fits Everybody Collection was shown on the Victoria's Secret "icons" in 2022, and SZA in 2023. The Cozy Collection featured in Kim and Khloé's 2020 pandemic phone calls was worn by Snoop Dogg and his family in 2022. Packaging a product at all, Dr. Alfred Edema writes, is essential to any brand: "Packaging is not only a communication vehicle for transmitting symbolism, but it is also important for its own symbolic contribution to the total understanding of the brand." Products, he argues, have their own "life cycle symbiotically describ[ing] the human life cycle." In his view, repackaging is necessary mostly when the product gets "sick," or is facing "weak or dull appearance, loss of public confidence and investment trust, problematic or difficult vocalization, competitive inferiority," or "obsolescence." But Kim didn't wait for SKIMS to get sick; she kept changeover as rapid as media images moved in the larger picture.

This isn't the first time a corporation figured out the sustainability of doling out the same products using new campaigns. Douglas Gomery has written of how, after Walt Disney started his own distribution arm, Buena

Vista, in 1953, he and his brother Roy began to "re-release its backlog of animated features—their costs now fully paid for—in seven-year intervals to new generations of children."

Of course, whether SKIMS was sustainable in a meaningful way, amid growing discourses about the brutal working conditions and egregious environmental damage promoted by fast fashion, remained an open question. SKIMS orders are delivered in a bag stamped with the text "I am not plastic." As earthday.org reports, "SKIMS currently has 9 fabrics available in their line. Four of these are made mainly from cotton, but the remaining fabrics contain materials like spandex and nylon." These synthetic materials are "responsible for releasing tons of microfibers—which are known to have adverse environmental and human health impacts—throughout their lifecycle." When Earth Day reached the company, "SKIMS stated that their products were sourced in Thailand, China, and Turkey, and produced in Thailand and China." These are all countries where, of course, worker exploitation has been reported to occur, though "SKIMS' website states that their workers are 'ensured fair wages, safe environments and healthy working conditions.'" This is the most that the organization could surmise about SKIMS' production practices—likely because, as the nonprofit watchdog Remake found after auditing the company in 2023 and giving it a score of 0 out of 150, SKIMS offered "no transparency" about its actual practices. "They don't disclose anything," Alexa Roccanova, senior advocacy manager at Remake and a coauthor of the report, told Sourcing Journal. In 2023, one TikTok user, @heyalexfriedman, went viral for announcing that she believed she found SKIMS' Turkey manufacturer—Eurotex Tekstil Ticaret, which also manufactured Spanx. *BuzzFeed* reported on the discourse catalyzed by this discovery, because, in a now-deleted post, another Instagram user known as @justinp shared the outcome of his deep dive of Eurotex: The company used "3-D knitting technology" to manufacture some of its items. Though this might be a good look in terms of concerns around garment worker exploitation, "some people expressed their frustration at his revelation…given the steep prices of its products." All this focus on a Turkish manufacturer also drove home an inconsistency across the different arms of Kim's overall

brand. A proud Armenian, in 2011 she publicly chastised *Cosmopolitan* for using a photo of her for the cover of their Turkish edition on the same month—April—as the Armenian genocide's anniversary. Facing criticism in 2019, she tweeted, "We consulted with experts and searched globally for the best in class options, some [of] which was found in Turkey." A month later, in a video interview with Reuters, she said she was "really excited…to have a meeting to talk about" opening a factory in Armenia. (This has yet to materialize.)

All in all, Kim has been dodgy about the details of SKIMS manufacturing, so Kourtney offered a peripheral narrative about sustainability transparency on *The Kardashians* by documenting her journey as "sustainability ambassador" for the fast-fashion brand Boohoo, with the subtext of the episode revealing the family's knowledge of their own utility as symbols of the evils of fast fashion. In a meeting with brand executives, her assistant explained, "When Kourtney is the head of this collection, people know exactly who to find to say things to." The concept of corporations, for many consumers, is somewhat abstract, but the headlining of the Kardashians, whose jobs are to humanize the brands, makes it easier to direct our anger. "Whereas when Boohoo gets backlash, it's not to you and you," she added, pointing to each executive at the table. "It's to this, like, brand." Thus, the hazard of reveling in the individualizing myth of the founder.

Still, people love SKIMS, even if they hate Kim (and even though, as KDK found, Kim's image has become inextricable from her corporation—by 2022, Google searches for SKIMS had begun to converge with those of her name). One critic, Tahirah Hairston, wrote a column for *The Cut* headlined "I Hate How Much I Love My Skims," explaining that "Kim Kardashian West offends me to my core. She also makes maddeningly good shapewear." One woman she interviewed explained that "whenever she gets a compliment on a Skims look, she tells everyone she's wearing Fashion Nova."

Borrowing Kanye's strategy, as he put it to Charlamagne tha God in 2013, of offering quality products at accessible prices, and of helping consumers contextualize the brand by citing iconic names, Kim has been clear about her vision for SKIMS. In a 2022 episode of *The Kardashians,* describing positive

interactions with investors, she said, “Apple, Nike, SKIMS—we’re in that conversation.” People scoffed (one Reddit user asked, “I love you Kim, but are you delusional?”), and it’s true that Nike’s value in 2024 was more than $100 billion, and Apple’s, in the trillions, but SKIMS’ valuation continues to climb. In 2021, SKIMS was valued at $1.6 billion. In 2022, it was worth $3.2 billion. In 2024, it was worth $4 billion.

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THE DONDA ERA (2020–2024)

Kim de-power couples from Kanye and steps out on her own—just in time for the TikTok-ification of media.

Scale

"My great-grandparents had a string-cheese factory in a small town called Gyumri. They didn't have cars back then. So, they had two horse and carriages. And back in the day, they said that was equal to two private jets. And so, Kardashians were, like, the celebs of Gyumri. They were the…us."

That's Kim Kardashian telling her nephew Mason and niece Penelope about their ancestry on her second trip to Armenia, accompanied by their mother, Kourtney. It was October 2019, and the sisters were in "the motherland" to meet with the president of Armenia and to baptize the youngest Disick and West kids (in 2018, a daughter, Chicago West, had been born, and, right before Kim announced SKIMS, a son, Psalm, was born—both by surrogate). Tension between Kim and Kourtney was high. The episode opened with what remains one of their most "iconic" *KUWTK* moments: a sisterly fistfight. Their grappling—before Khloé's large photograph of an exasperated-looking Marilyn Monroe—was over what Kim saw as Kourtney's diminishing work ethic, and Kourtney saw as a toxic dynamic in which she was baited and bullied for the sake of the cameras. As the family's brand continued to elevate—Kim was now a founder, after all—such raw-seeming conflicts with Kourtney would prove useful to the family's increasingly slick TV show and would be recycled season after season. Now, in Armenia, Kourtney—flopped on the floor of the Armenian genocide memorial—complained to her kids about her jet lag, and, later in the car, to a cringing Kim about the malaise induced in her by the pressures of celebrity.

"This is a trip to be seen, to be heard, to be loud," Kim vents in a confessional. "We are trying to get the president of the United States to

recognize the Armenian genocide." The last time Kim had been in Armenia was in 2015, with her sister Khloé, when she was plenty famous but by no means in a position to meet with the president regarding a humanitarian cause. That earlier episode was oriented around her disclosure to Khloé that she was pregnant with Saint, and how many fans she had in the small country. "They're all chanting her name," Khloé said then. "If Kim ever loses a little bit of fame, she should just move to Armenia; she'll be golden for the rest of her life…. It's like I'm with the Princess of Armenia." As Kim looked out the window of her hotel to take in the throngs of fans, fantasizing about having a balcony so that she could wave at them "like Eva Perón," it became clear that this 2015 episode was using real people to demonstrate the material translation of Kim's digitalized rise. If it was hard to grasp what "breaking the internet" meant in terms of web impressions, you could see the mobs of people surrounding Kim in Armenia and understand.

Visiting with President Armen Sarkissian in 2019, Kim makes small talk about biblical references to Armenia, and nods as he explains his mission to honor the millions of lives lost during the genocide. In *The Politics of Naming the Armenian Genocide,* Vartan Matiossian writes that "the annihilation of the Armenians in the Ottoman Empire, mostly carried out in 1915–1917, was a searing open wound"; a word was needed to define "the dastardly crime" that had nearly wiped Armenians from the map.

These efforts to define the atrocity speak to the power of language and archive, two things the Kardashians, self-appointed authors of their own histories in a postmodern media landscape, understand well. "The repetition of unproven claims drives the facts," writes Matiossian, "which are shaped into an alternative reality, giving further voice to a trend as old as the crime itself to rationalize, refuse, and rewrite what happened more than a century ago."

But here Kim was, at the height of her fame, to change that, to platform the small country of Armenia and its diminished but resilient population on the world stage. The Armenia-set *KUWTK* episode aired in 2020, when the United States had seen several years of the first Trump presidency and was in the middle of the COVID-19 lockdown and widespread consciousness shifts

about race following the murder of George Floyd. As Arjen Mulder writes in *Understanding Media Theory,* the scale of visibility to global issues made possible by media progress can lead to social upheavals. Of the cultural transition from film to TV, he writes, "TV provoked deep involvement. Because of this involvement, the first generation of American children to grow up with television…became the 'protest generation,' which felt personally responsible for all the suffering in the world. The United States lost the Vietnam War because of the introduction of color television, which showed the American public in a luridly realistic manner what 'our boys' were doing and experiencing over there." Kim's cultivation of an activist arm of her enterprise—generating discourses among skeptical social media users about whether "impact" or "intent" (a dialectic commonly explored in social-justice-oriented Instagram infographics, which Kim seemed to troublesomely subvert) mattered more—was right on time. The image of her in another president's house was by now no great shock, and the episode took viewers, stuck in their homes, across the world. No matter what was happening in real life, the Kardashians kept up with the maintenance of their simulacrum, offering a portal of elite experiences to jump into if we wanted. Especially in contrast to Kourtney, who said she wanted a smaller life, it was clear that Kim was scaling.

Scale, as Nick Couldry and Anna McCarthy put it in the introduction to their anthology, *MediaSpace,* is a "difficult concept to define," but most important, it "expresses a number of different kinds of proportional relations, from the comparative size of physical phenomena to the mathematically calculable relationship between an object and its representation." Marshall McLuhan, with his notion of the internet as a "global village," had a fascination with the word, which David Bobbitt wrote "suggests that electronic media collapse the world into a village where we are aware of what is going on all over the world, all the time." Technology increases and decreases scale at the same time so that "large scales of experience (i.e., worldwide events such as revolutions, wars, or terrorist attacks) are collapsed into a small space for consumption via a connected technology such as a television, a computer, or a cell phone."

The Kardashians ruled this "village," which we, their viewers, began to explore in an entirely new way once the pandemic hit. A Pew Research survey found that 90 percent of Americans said the internet was useful to them during lockdown. Most of them reported using video calls to connect to others. And "for 40% of Americans, digital tools have taken on new relevance: They report they used technology or the internet in ways that were new or different to them."

"The Internet," Bobbitt adds in his analysis of McLuhan, "enhances the scale and democratization of the production and distribution of media content, increases the amount of information available to people, and extends social connectivity across a greater distance." The internet has exploded over the last thirty years, with the number of users growing from "16 million (less than 1 percent of the world population) in 1995 to over 2.1 billion (over 30 percent of the world population) in 2011. The Internet is a kind of super-medium because it subsumes all previous media, providing a world-wide distribution and presentation platform for texts, images, graphics, sound, and video," produced at a scale never seen before and for a marginal cost. (By 2024, those figures had more than doubled, with 5.5 billion people online—about 68 percent of the world population.)

The year the pandemic struck was also the year that TikTok, a short-form video platform owned by the Chinese internet company ByteDance, blew up in popularity, especially among Gen Z. If the internet was a super-medium, then TikTok aspired to be the super-medium of the super-medium; it offered the possibility of faster virality to anyone who joined, with an innovative For You page that delivered videos you'd like based on past engagement habits (and a not-yet-uncovered tactic of "heating," or, boosting on the algorithm, the videos that TikTok wanted to promote). This created a genre-driven universe, containing "booktok," "fashiontok," "foodietok," "sportstok," and anything else you could think of. A twenty-two-year-old in my life encouraged me to give the app a try, so I logged in and began to translate my Instagram memes into talking videos for "pop culture–tok."

My partner and I were staying at my mom's place in Arizona during lockdown, so I hung bright purple streamers in her carport to make a campier

backdrop and recorded from there. For me, none of this was fun: staring at my own face on the app's camera, writing lines for myself, redoing takes. But if I'd learned anything from the Kardashians, it was that diversifying mediums is a wise move, and I wanted to keep pushing my work out there. Right away, my TikTok videos earned hundreds of thousands of views. Natalie Franklin, author of Nori's Black Book on Instagram, had once told me that the Kardashians were a "cheat code" for social media virality; it had been true for Instagram, where I'd built a following of about fifteen thousand followers, and held true on TikTok too. The first videos to go viral were adaptations of memes I'd made about "all the women Kim Kardashian has been," starting with Jackie O. Before I knew it, I had followers in the six figures on TikTok, and my following on Instagram had more than doubled with the crossover arrival of fans. The "likes" delivered a gratifying high. (In fact, a high more powerful than anything I'd ever felt on Instagram.) Kardashian Kolloquium was scaling, all from my mom's cramped carport.

In the fall of 2020, the family released a joint statement that *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* was "coming to an end" after fourteen years and twenty seasons, and then, a month later, for her fortieth birthday, Kim posted a bunch of luxe tropical party photos of her friends and family to Instagram with the caption "After 2 weeks of multiple health screens and asking everyone to quarantine, I surprised my closest inner circle with a trip to a private island where we could pretend things were normal just for a brief moment in time." This would kick off a multiyear-long trend of creators on the platform declaring that unrelatable spectacles like these heralded the "end" of the Kardashians as we knew them; the frequent virality of such videos, over time, triggered a reversal in the media cycle: Think-piece writers began to cover the discourses that were going viral on TikTok. My own audience prodded me to declare it too. *TikTok is a place of authenticity,* many on pop culture–tok declared. *The Kardashians are still stuck in the mindset of curating for Instagram feeds.* There seemed to be some kind of pride in the idea that TikTok—a space for all those who couldn't afford the surgeries, or didn't want to use the photo editing apps, to make perfect posts for a homogeneous grid—was the new and more democratic zeitgeist and that the

Kardashians could not figure out how to "be relevant" in a space that encouraged even more closeness to the objects of their consumption. ("The influencer is dead. Long live the Genuinfluencers," declared Priya Elan for *The Guardian* in 2021, arguing that openly consumerist figures like the Kardashians would be deplatformed by more "genuine" producers of content.)

The thing is, Kim's insensitive caption had become a meme—people posted her caption with GIFs of slapstick moments from *Gilligan's Island,* or screenshots of their favorite video game islands—which we know by now only elevates her social relevance. And even though the family had again fallen in public favor—and it seemed as though *all* institutions as we knew them were weakening—they were, in many other ways, bigger than ever. Their businesses—which they had been carefully scaling from the beginning—were thriving, and that had been the real goal all along. It would only be a few years before Kim announced another arm of her enterprise—SKKY Partners, a private equity firm cofounded with the industry veteran Jay Sammons. The duo's stated goal was to invest in "growth-oriented, market-leading consumer and media companies." In other words, even as culture continued to fracture, undermining the once monocultural effect of the Kar-Jenner reign, their influence would live on behind the scenes in any media or product they put wealth into.

If Armenia, their homeland, was a representation of the "family" (and activist) aspect of their brand, then Vegas, where Kim went to do early-career club appearances, was their representation of self-commodification. (It bears mentioning that like the internet, which, McLuhan believed, collapsed "large scales of experience" into "a small space," Vegas collapsed images representing the whole world into its singular strip.) Their Las Vegas souvenir shop, Kardashian Khaos, was opened at the Mirage in 2011; Wendy's used Las Vegas as a test market for a new burger line a year earlier. The city had served as a test market plenty of times before that—for a new network system for Motorola in 1990, or Hallmark greeting cards in the mid-1990s, and for CBS Studios audience-tested TV pilots. Thanks to its distance from other major markets, "Las Vegas is a great sociological lab to test things," the

UNLV sociologist Simon Gottschalk told the *Las Vegas Sun*. "It is constantly reinventing itself, and corporate America sees that as being important when it tests its products and services. Las Vegas serves to forewarn America of what is to come, and many American cities have and will continue to follow suit." Kardashian Khaos was likely a way of testing whether Kardashian-themed retail would move.

The success of Kylie Cosmetics, SKIMS, and even Good American and 818 proves that it does. The effective SKIMS marketing campaigns—an ever-updating carousel of images featuring the Moment's big stars—even come off as a scale of Kim's hyper-relevant Instagram feed. SKIMS makes itself a pop cultural aggregator, and this, Douglas Rushkoff writes, can be its own method of scaling: "On the net, everything is occurring on the same abstracted and universal level. Survival in a purely digital realm—particularly in business—means being able to scale, and winning means being able to move up one level of abstraction beyond everyone else…. The net has turned scalability from a business option into what appears to be a business requirement." Because of the internet's flat playing field, "success has less to do with finding a niche than establishing a 'vertical' or a 'horizontal.' Going vertical means establishing oneself as the place to do everything in a particular industry: the one-stop place for hardware, or cycling needs, or home electronics. Going horizontal means to offer a service that applies to every category's transactions, like making the credit card transaction software for everyone else's websites. In either case, 'scaling up' means cutting through the entire cloud in one direction or another—becoming all things to some people, or some things to all people." The Kardashian family, offering a range of personality archetypes, cross-industry commodities, and multimedia narratives, were, themselves, both vertical and horizontal.

Starting with a scale model was essential for the kinds of moguls the Kardashians aspired to be. Walt Disney himself used the tactic. In 1953, Leonard Goldenson, founder of ABC, "was desperate to get Hollywood involved in television. A television station, he believed, was like a theatre with audiences multiplied by several thousand…. So when Walt Disney told him he had hocked his life insurance to pay for a scale model of a pipe dream

called Disneyland—both a TV show and a theme park—Goldenson was intrigued."

Walt's famous risk was a success; we all know what Disneyland became, collapsing the world of his animations into the contained chunk of land in Anaheim, California, while simultaneously expanding the family business into a conglomerate with infinite potential and seemingly eternal legacy. And in December 2020, just a few months after announcing the end of *KUWTK* and letting discourses about their "over-ness" linger, the Kardashians announced that they had just inked a deal to "create global content" with Hulu, the streamer owned in majority shares by Disney. (And a few months after that, President Biden formally acknowledged the Armenian genocide, though in most accounts of what led to this milestone, Kim's big 2019 meeting goes unmentioned.)

KARDASHIFICATION

Kardashification: "Using one's name and parental influence to fool the world that you are an important and integral member of society despite your lack of talent."

> *The kardashification of American culture has led to celebretizing people with menial intelligence. The subjects of kardashification use their name and social media to continue to grow their wealth without doing anything but having insta followers and headlines. This phenomenon has led to additional useless celebretizing of other stupid people.*

This was submitted to Urban Dictionary in 2019 by a user named jdspeakstruth, and though, in the larger scheme of media history, the "celebretizing of stupid people" did not begin with the Kardashians, the coinage did certify a blended word that had been growing in popularity online. Based on tweet threads and TikTok videos showing before-and-afters of celebrities whose once-familiar faces now looked suspiciously contoured, symmetrical, and lifted, all captioned "The Kardashification of [Jennifer

Aniston, Lady Gaga, Tori Spelling, Gypsy-Rose Blanchard],” the social phenomenon was most visible in people’s faces and bodies.

The word itself is a neologism (a made-up, newly coined word) that refers to systemization. Such neologisms were reclaimed by young people on TikTok as a standardizing lexicon for the chaotic plethora of micro-trends manufactured by the platform’s users. The term “yassification” has nearly 110 million posts on the app, inspiring *The New York Times* to investigate the word in 2021, finding that “to ‘yassify’ something…is to apply several beauty filters to a picture using FaceApp, an A.I. photo-editing application, until its subject—be that a celebrity, a historical figure, a fictional character or a work of fine art—becomes almost unrecognizably made up.” Then there’s “bimbofication”: In 2022, *Vice* asked, “Bimbofication is taking over. What does that mean for you?” and examined a few of the notorious “bimbology” scholars of the moment. One named Fiona Fairbairn posted the “Bimbo Manifesto,” a screenshotted list from her notes app that she presented in a video, listing ten principles including “stop fact-checking, show up everywhere hot all the time, purposely do things wrong so that u don’t have to do them (even simple tasks).” The *Vice* piece suggests that this emphasis on aesthetics, play, and passivity is a response to the oppressive “girlboss” feminism of the Instagram era. Whatever the cause, “yassification,” “bimbofication,” and “Kardashification” all describe processes of systemizing one’s appearance or lifestyle—processes that had been at play throughout the 2010s with the photo-enhancing app Facetune and other social media filters that optimized the appearance of their users, and were now being either deconstructed or reappropriated on TikTok.

Neologisms referring to systemization describe social phenomena that exist in our subconscious perhaps because they’ve been floating around for years: “Disneyfication,” coined in 1959 by Lawrence Lipton, and popularized as “Disneyization” in 2004 by Alan Bryman, described “the process by which the principles of the Disney theme parks are coming to dominate more and more sectors of American society as well as the rest of the world,” by way of “theming, hybrid consumption, merchandizing, and performative labour.” “McDonaldization,” coined by George Ritzer in 1983, is “the process by

which the principles of the fast-food restaurant are coming to dominate more and more sectors of American society as well as the rest of the world," by way of "efficiency, calculability, predictability, and control," and "Coca-Colonization," popularized in 1994 by Reinhold Wagnleitner, situated the iconic soft drink as an agent of "a process of change that happens everywhere where the culture of capitalism takes root. The secret of its success is the promise that we have all waited for this change because we have seemingly had enough of the same old thing for much too long."

These various "-izations" can be further traced to the early twentieth-century German sociologist Max Weber's idea of "rationalization"—a concept that Ritzer, who studied Weber's work, admits is "very difficult to analyze," but is, in so many words, inspired by the progression of capitalist bureaucratic culture, which has systemized the way we go through life. "Weber saw the 19th- and early 20th-century bureaucracy as a highly efficient organizational structure," writes Ritzer, "and in the realm of production it was soon joined by the assembly line, which greatly increased the efficiency of the production process." Weber argues that in societies where rationalization prevails, when a leader dies, the system persists—because it's been organized for perpetual propagation. (A little bit like the sizable, multigenerational Kardashian dynasty itself.) In other words, rationality is at play when "the best means to an end is chosen on the basis of universally agreed-upon rules, regulations, and laws."

Was the global spread of the ideologies of brands like Coca-Cola and McDonald's a distinctly American thing—a phenomenon that some theorists have quite literally called Americanism? Wagnleitner writes about how "only a few commentators…acknowledged that Americanism did not necessarily have its roots in the United States, but instead in capitalism as such. Siegfried Kracauer correctly commented that the performed precision of the Tiller Girls, one of the most-admired" U.K.-founded, U.S.-based girl revue groups of the 1890s (known by some as the original Rockettes), "represented neither the 'girlization' of U.S. civilization nor cultural feminist tendencies of women stepping over men," but "corresponded to the reflex of the aspired rationality of the ruling economic system."

Even if rationalization is a nation-blind capitalist phenomenon, it's still undeniable that these modern American semiotic machines—Disney, McDonald's—are some of the most visible agents of globalization. Part of how they're able to do this, Ritzer writes, is through a process of hybridization, which some theorists call "glocalization," or "the interpenetration of the global and the local, resulting in unique outcomes in different geographic areas." After all, standardization can also highlight difference. So, when Kim Kardashian the Everywoman is making her White House cameo in a suit one moment, and appearing at Paris Fashion Week in supertight couture the next, or when SKIMS features a pop star one month, followed by a famous athlete, the Kardashian image is indeed spreading far and wide, but also adapting to the uniqueness of its different chosen domains. To better understand glocalization as a subset within the larger phenomenon of McDonaldization, Ritzer points out the way traditional cuisine becomes McDonaldized once one of its franchises has opened in a new global location: "McSpaghetti in the Philippines, McHuevo in Uruguay, McFalafel in Egypt, and Teriyaki Burger in Japan."

You can also see Disneyization at play clearly in Las Vegas, where, Alan Bryman points out, "virtually every new hotel on the 'strip' is heavily themed. The famous strip now contains such themes as ancient Rome (Caesar's Palace), ancient Egypt (Luxor), ye olde England (Excalibur), the movies (MGM Grand), city life (New York New York), turn-of-the-century high life on the Mediterranean (Monte Carlo), the sea (Treasure Island)…and so on." The Kardashians similarly Disneyize their lives every time they throw their kids a birthday party, and, typically with the help of the Gatsby-esque event planner Mindy Weiss, transform their backyards into full-blown theme parks. One year, for North and Penelope's joint party, Kim's backyard was turned into a tropical paradise for a *Moana*-themed birthday, complete with visits from actors dressed as the movie's main characters. (And, lest we forget, in 2021, North was given a poop-emoji-themed party, allegedly at her request.) Another year, Dream Kardashian enjoyed a Barbie-themed party, complete with an oversized Barbie box the kids could take photos in.

It's exactly the packaging and commodifying of family experiences like these—a bastardization of nostalgia—that proves, Stjepan Meštrović writes, that emotions themselves have become McDonaldized. Though Kardashification is most apparent on the face and body, it is more pervasive than that.

We pick up on Kardashification when we hear vocal fry; when people speak of their experiences in bored yet histrionic ways, as though they were in a video confessional; when we see people taking selfies in public. (*Saturday Night Live,* which has steadily harpooned the Kardashians since they hit the scene, offers a useful case study in Kardashification, and how easy the girls make it for comedians. In *Strange Bedfellows,* Russell Peterson writes about how impersonation "reduc[es] a living, three-dimensional person to a collection of infinitely repeatable phrases and gestures…turn[ing] his target into" a mechanical product, a "man-machine who repeats these words and motions with clockwork predictability.") When we bridle at these reality television and social media outgrowths, maybe it's less about the Kardashians as people than the discomfort of watching any powerful systemization take hold. More than one study has proved that reality TV culture influences our social media behaviors—whether encouraging "self-disclosive" efforts like blogging or making TMI posts, or bad faith conflicts between individuals. (Ironically, I'd say that the Kardashians do a better job at modeling positive resolutions to their ceaseless cycles of conflicts than most other TV shows out there.) The point is, though, if the world has fallen victim to Kardashification —a hybridized word that has begun to proliferate across a social media landscape that loves hybridization of the highbrow and the accessible—then it only proves that the Kardashians have, in some way, joined the ranks of McDonald's, Coke, and Disney.

MARIE ANTOINETTE

Revolution and representational figures

On the cusp of the pandemic lockdown and some months before the spectacle of Kim's private island fortieth birthday, twenty-two-year-old Kylie Jenner

posed as Marie Antoinette for the March 2020 cover of *Harper's Bazaar*. The feature was replete with the requisite powdered and feathered wig, corseted couture gowns, and a two-year-old proverbial princess, Stormi, both of them surrounded by pastel-pink cakes and petits fours while sitting in a corporate office (the Kylie Cosmetics headquarters). Kylie and Stormi's feature wasn't the first time a Kar-Jenner compared herself, consciously or unconsciously, to the eighteenth-century queen known during the French Revolution—a response to a stratified class system (known as the ancien régime), government debts caused in part by aiding the American Revolution, and widespread waves of famine due to poor harvest seasons—as Madame Deficit. In 2015, Kim Kardashian powdered her face and posed on a velvet chaise as the ill-fated queen in Polaroid-shot ads for Hype energy drinks. In a 2018 conversation for *The Hollywood Reporter,* Kanye West told the interior designer Axel Vervoordt he saw his wife as "a representation, a Marie Antoinette of our time."

That's the thing about Marie: Even for the people of France in 1793, *she* was a representation. It wasn't common back then to kill queens during social uprisings; usually, the king alone sufficed. But her execution after a conviction on trumped-up treason charges reflected the fervent (and gendered) rage manifested during the revolution. Though the killing of King Louis XVI represented the official end of the monarchy, according to Caroline Weber, historian and author of *Queen of Fashion: What Marie Antoinette Wore to the Revolution* ("The king must die so that the revolution can live," as Maximilien Robespierre famously proclaimed), Marie Antoinette's death ushered in the Reign of Terror, when revolutionaries, facing a power vacuum, began to turn on one another, finding "counterrevolutionaries" everywhere, putting them on sham trials, and sending nearly twenty thousand people to the guillotine—all within one year. (Misogyny was a part of this time. "The Reign of Terror," says Weber, "became focused on sexual virtue in its women. Women have to stay home and be virtuous housewives and have more sons who can fight in the armies of the revolution and the republic." They began to execute "women who [were] perceived to have too much influence in politics. Women who fought for the revolution from the very beginning like Olympe de

Gouges, who wrote *The Declaration of the Rights of Women,*" lost their heads en masse.)

Marie Antoinette is a cultural "representation," or icon, because, after the fourteen-year-old Austrian archduchess was sent to France to marry the teenage Louis XVI to strengthen relations between the countries, she figured out how to maximize her fashion sensibilities and a media moment in transition to become an aspirational yet relatable It Girl, became the quintessential "woman behind the man" of her husband's reign, and ended up losing her head amid a deprived nation's revolution. It was "sort of a Cinderella story in reverse," says Weber. "Part of our fascination with her is because there's no other figure in history that has had that trajectory on such a grand scale."

A century-long norm, by the time Marie joined the royal family, was that the monarchy remained ensconced in Versailles, the palace about twelve miles west of Paris. (One could compare such grand confinement to the Kar-Jenners' depiction of their Calabasas compounds on their TV show.) Marie's young new husband feared her at first—"he had been told by tutors who raised him that both of his parents, who actually died of disease, had been poisoned by Austrian spies"—and so, famously, it took several years for Marie to produce an heir to the throne. As in the Kar-Jenner matriarchy, the authority typical of a husband was diminished in Marie's life, and she "effectively had nobody controlling what she chose to do." She began visiting Paris with "her entourage"—her husband's brothers, and other princesses and duchesses—where they gambled, shopped, and danced, flourishing in the kind of fun imagined by Sofia Coppola in her classic 2006 candy-colored biopic (itself the outcome of a lineage of early Hollywood films about the queen). The same year that Louis XV passed away and Marie and Louis XVI inherited the throne—while still teenagers with little understanding of their responsibilities—she also fell in with a visionary fashion merchant named Rose Bertin, who collaborated with her to constantly change her image, from a "crazy new hairdo one day or a crazy new apron on her skirt or shawl around her neck." One frequent hairdo, designed by Léonard Autié—known as the pouf—was "basically a billboard for personal style. It was this three-

foot-high scaffolding of hair that you could put a basket of fruit in, flowers," feathers, and so on. All this image crafting—the consequence of youth, boredom, and resources—occurred alongside a revolution in printing. "The first versions of what would later become fashion magazines are being published," Weber explains—fashion engravings and almanacs. And Marie, with her ever-changing style—itself a spectacle—was a regular cover girl for these publications, inspiring emulation of her hairstyles and fits across France. Even better? Marie altered the norms of the fashion industry itself, making emulation even easier to do. Previously, seamstresses and tailors for the French royal family were barred from "provid[ing] services [for] anybody else without royal permission." But "Marie Antoinette gave Rose Bertin permission to copy the fashions she made for [her] for other people—always with a delay" of a few weeks. "So, she would always be the first, but then there could be a million copycats."

The Kardashians similarly democratized aspirational luxury through their uses of social media, making fashion and beauty the main methods of self-Kardashification. Like Antoinette, the family even—as Via Bleidner points out in *If You Lived Here You'd Be Famous by Now*—converts their experience of admiration from peasant followers into an idealization of the mundane, and flourishes in creating worlds-within-worlds. In the spin-off show *Life of Kylie,* Kylie confesses that what she wants is "to live on a farm and have chickens and raise animals," and tours a "106-acre, sixteen stable, guard-gated farm…. The producers edit in upbeat music while she oohs and ahhs over the cows and goats." Marie Antoinette, Bleidner explains, "notoriously ordered a 'little farm' to be built on the Versailles property ('little' being a mere eighty-six acres, complete with three separate mansions, twelve cottages, and orange groves) because she wanted to play dress-up and play pretend peasant every once in a while." On one level, Kylie's hyperreal existence might explain the hold she has over Gen Z. A massive 2023 study by the marketing company Sooth found that Gen Z media consumers tend to take financial advice from influencers and celebrities over "people who purport to be leaders in financial services," with Kendall and Kylie Jenner at the top of the list. I've personally observed that this generation has an

ambivalent relationship with Kylie: Any video I post about Kylie rather than Kim or the other sisters to TikTok goes viral; anytime a Gen Z journalist has interviewed me, they are teeming with mystified questions about the mimesis she's inspired across feeds, what she might do next. I've always chalked this fascination up to a sort of identification with the simulacrum in which she'd been reared. After all, like Kylie, Gen Z has not known a world outside the fishbowl.

When people are starving, though—or stuck in their homes as the world outside seems to have entered an accelerating state of decay—such performances of peasant cosplay are only so sustainable, and any remaining tatters of relatability are remade into uniform rage. As Weber put it, "Marie Antoinette—even if she understood the power of image making…didn't understand the danger of [it]. In making herself available to people, she made herself attainable to them in a way that…they could tear her down." She had graduated from cover girl to girlboss, advising her timid husband on political matters (specifically, to be staunch in refusing proposals made by moderate constitutionalists that could square power relations between the monarchy and the people), but she remained primarily a symbol. Her big hair, once an object of #inspo for women across the country, came to represent the people's resentments, which proliferated in the form of rumors. "Flour was one of the ingredients in the hair pomade—the hair powder that was used to hold all her big hairstyles together." And after the fall of the Bastille, the idea spread that all the flour was going to the queen while the people starved, which "had kind of a trigger in the form of these pouf hairdos that she had been famous for more than ten years before." When, inspired by calls to arms by the radical journalist Jean-Paul Marat, "the people marched on Versailles in October of 1789, they said, 'We want to take away the baker, the baker's wife, and the little baker boy.'" The one about flour was not the only rumor to add fire to the flames of revolution. Most of us now know that Marie did not actually utter her supposed catchphrase, "Let them eat cake," in response to being told that the French people were experiencing a bread famine; Rousseau wrote the line when Marie was nine, at least two decades before the revolution even began. But the "affair of the necklace," chronicled in several Old Hollywood

films, genuinely harmed Marie's image. It was another case of fashion influencing public perceptions of power: A grifter named Jeanne de La Motte tricked a cardinal into purchasing an expensive diamond necklace under the belief that it was for the queen, only to defraud him. Though Marie had nothing to do with it and was found blameless in the ensuing trial, her reputation was further damaged, with the scandal only underscoring her reputation as a frivolous, manipulative spendthrift.

And so when Marie Antoinette and her family were captured by a mob at Versailles and brought to a Paris prison, where some of her children died of illness, Louis was the first to lose his head, and she followed soon enough, wearing a white dress she'd hidden in the wall of her prison "for her final fashion statement." The lesson of Antoinette is not only about the surprising interplay between fashion and politics; it is also, at least in part, about how much easier it is to grapple with complex problems through individualistic lenses, especially in an ever-enclosing media landscape that encourages personal identification with public figures.

"Marie Antoinette would likely have been perfectly happy to have played only a ceremonial part as queen," Richard Covington writes for *Smithsonian* magazine. "But Louis' weakness forced her to take a more dominant role—for which the French people could not forgive her…. Ultimately, she was condemned simply for being Louis' wife and a symbol of tyranny. Thomas Jefferson, minister to France under Louis XVI, famously asserted that if Marie Antoinette had been cloistered in a convent, the French Revolution would never have taken place. Perhaps Jefferson goes too far. Certainly she became a scapegoat for nearly everything that was wrong with France's absolutist, dynastic system. But it's also clear that in their refusal to compromise, Louis and Marie Antoinette lost everything."

It was during the unsettled 2020s that people began to situate the Kardashians as a court of modern-day Maries. Studies now tell us that the rich became richer during the pandemic, while the poor became, you guessed it, poorer (and were disproportionately killed by the disease). Gen Z missed out on formative real-life milestones, like school dances and graduations. Life online more and more reflected a prevailing sense of doom. A study of

Twitter during the lockdown period found that "according to [the] psychological theory of the finite pool of worry, people avoid dealing with multiple negative events at the same time," hyper-focusing on one crisis instead. Thus, the looming threat of climate change, at one time the issue du jour on social media, was dethroned by fretful tweets about the pandemic, and all its public health and labor implications—not to mention all the things people couldn't do because they were stuck inside, a misery mocked by the Kardashians, among other celebrities, every time their social media flaunted the mansions in which they quarantined or the exotic travel they'd somehow managed to pull off (often by way of private planes).

Kim's function as the face of social tensions was only emphasized when, in 2022, at the height of her success while promoting her new reality TV show with Hulu—and against the backdrop of a record-breaking slew of nearly fifty million voluntary resignations within the past year, dubbed by the media the Great Resignation—Kim sniped to *Variety* that she had "great advice for women in business. Get up off your fucking ass and work. It seems like nobody wants to work anymore." Because this advice was delivered in video form, direct to the viewer, it felt extra personal.

Kim has always branded herself with a non-regal and quintessentially American value: what Elizabeth Wissinger, in her writings about Kim's "glamour labour," compares to the cliché of the "Protestant work ethic." In Kim's iconic 2017 Jackie O–themed interview for *Interview,* she told Janet Mock, "You can say a lot of things about me, but you cannot say I don't work hard. I don't sing. I don't dance. I don't act. But I am not lazy." Through the years, this repetitive self-identification was accepted without much outcry (at least compared with other Kardashian offenses), besides the occasional scoff of "you call what you do *work*?"

Wissinger would say it was, for better or worse; so would I. Wissinger cites the sociologist Kathleen Barry's notion of the "wages of glamour," the idea of "crafting bodies and personalities to meet corporate and culturally approved expectations of femininity," while her own conception of the new phenomenon of "glamour labour describes the speculative labour of crafting a body and personality to optimize and enhance its impact, in hopes of a

possible future reward." In other words, glamour labor is a matter of facing the fact that beauty is pain and crafting one's real-life body and face to appear Facetuned or filtered—consciously mediatizing oneself, as we discussed in the "Kim 2.0" section of the previous chapter—within the larger context of an intensifying gig economy, all in a bid to "make it."

But does this sort of labor even demand glamour or self-Kardashification to be endured? Wissinger often cites the media theorist Mark Andrejevic, who conceptualized the notion of "the work of being watched": "a form of production wherein consumers are invited to sell access to their personal lives in a way not dissimilar to that in which they sell their labor power." He argues that the American dream notions of digital-age success promoted by reality TV and social media—all within a surveillant corporate culture—turn us into workers for the larger machine, as we share our takes and selfies and engage in comment section brawls that feed the, well, feeds.

But in the 2020s, unemployment was spiking, a general cultural disillusionment was rising, and even though more than half of young people had confessed their aspiration to "make it" as influencers, and even though race and class activism proclaimed the potential to change the world if only we posted more, my guess is that many people realized that a Kardashified approach to "the work of being watched" might not deliver them to aesthetic comforts. Conspicuous consumption became, if anything, kind of corny. Think pieces declared the "end of the influencer," and it became less cool to post posed selfies than to jump into dance trends on TikTok or share political or cultural hot takes or Storytimes about scandalous or bizarre experiences (and then call one another out for having "bad" or "good" takes by using the app's "stitching" feature, stoking the kinds of interactive dramas that felt more immediate and authentic than what reality TV could offer).

So, Kim's chiding comment about how we *weren't* working hard enough hit different; like Marie Antoinette's apocryphal "let them eat cake," it seemed to suggest that *we* were failing to uphold the economy crumbling around us. If we were no longer working at the level of grit displayed by Kim, then maybe we were failing at the new media American dream by phasing out of Instagram culture; that same year, she and Kylie Jenner reposted a meme

that pleaded, “MAKE INSTAGRAM INSTAGRAM AGAIN (stop trying to be tiktok I just want to see cute photos of my friends) SINCERELY, EVERYONE.” Her latest catchphrase would also inspire one of the biggest meme cycles of the Kar-Jenners’ media tenure (as well as a deep dive from the University of Calgary researcher Paul Fairie, who posted a thread to Twitter of the sentiment’s documented history, which had been uttered at least ten times by op-ed writers and critics of strikes, dating back to 1894).

Plus, Kim’s chastisement came not long after a media cycle when pop culture consumers felt more exploited than ever by her family’s side of the celebrity pantheon. On November 5, 2021, Kylie’s on-again-off-again partner Travis Scott staged the first post-COVID run of Astroworld, his Houston-based music festival. A crowd crush began during his performance, resulting in the deaths of ten fans (including a nine-year-old) and injuries to hundreds of others. Overcrowding and a lack of adequate crowd control measures contributed to the mayhem, with attendees becoming overpowered by the crowd and unable to escape—and all the while Travis Scott didn’t stop the show.

In the days that followed, the theory of the finite pool of worry seemed to flood TikTok—along with the productive sense of duty associated with Andrejevic’s “work of being watched.” Countless videos, many of which earned views in the millions, were posted by kids who had been there, showing their sections of the crowd, where people tried to scream in unison at Scott to stop the show, but he either didn’t hear them or ignored them. (He later told Charlamagne tha God, “I just really go off the fans’ energy as a collective, you know? Call and response. I just didn’t, I just didn’t hear that.”) Some offered their grim first-person accounts of the carnage they witnessed or experienced. Others took a deconstructive approach, taking screenshots of the stage design and pointing out how Scott’s edgy imagery—the mountains of fire and upside-down crosses for which he’d become famous—indicated that this performance was really a satanic ritual calling for human sacrifice. On the one hand, social media can be credited with the rise of citizen journalism: Media theorists will always point to the Arab Spring of 2011, when use of social media was at a high in the Arab world, and young people

from Tunisia to Syria began to resist the authoritarian regimes of their countries, documenting police brutality and coordinating protests; more recently, there was the example of BLM and documentation of its marches.

On the other hand, misinformation can catch flame, and in keeping with how fast you can swipe through content on TikTok's endlessly refreshable and hyper-customized For You page, it's been proven that false news travels faster than truth. ("The degree of novelty and the emotional reactions of recipients may be responsible," surmise the study's researchers.) As Joseph Russo, an anthropologist and expert in conspiracy theories, told *The Guardian,* the satanic panic that followed the Astroworld disaster called to mind the right-wing boomer fascination with QAnon, a notorious emblem of the Trump era. QAnon "is mutating and taking different forms," Russo told *The Guardian*. "But it goes back to the idea there is a shadowy group of people in control behind it all…. It is super seductive, and always comes back—but it is surprising young people are following this script more and more."

But *is* it so surprising? TikTok, like any other social media app, is addictive. In 2020, the UC Berkeley researcher Kyle Giffin published his argument that TikTok had been designed according to principles of "imitation and repetition" (quoting Nietzsche as an epigraph: "In individuals, insanity is rare; but in groups, parties, nations, and epochs, it is the rule"). Citing a well-known study conducted in the early '00s that established the concept of "mirror neurons," which are activated "both when an animal acts and when the animal observes the same action performed by another," revolutionizing the field of neuroscience, he concluded that "it is highly likely that mirror neurons are activated in Tik-Tok users during the viewing and subsequent imitation of whatever dance challenge is trending." And this can surely apply to whatever trending topic is spreading across the app more generally—whether opinions or conspiracy theories (which have their own neuropsychological ties to "apophenia," or the dopamine kick one gets from "perceiv[ing] a connection or meaningful pattern between unrelated or random things").

In 2024, an unsealed lawsuit filed against TikTok by the State of Utah argued that the app weaponized a "slot-machine effect," arguing that "the user

is excited for each new video by the possibility that it might be incredibly rewarding. This pattern keeps users engaged, constantly anticipating that dopamine rush." I would add that as someone who posts to the platform, the lever of potential virality is even more thrilling than the one that may or may not bring you a rewarding video to watch. Sometimes, as a content creator, you post a video that sets the algorithm ablaze, and other times the video "flops." I never found myself fiending for "views" more than when I was on TikTok. For many, surely, chiming in on Astroworld was a way to get in on the numbers. (The hashtag for the incident has more than 5.4 billion views.) After I brought Kardashian Kolloquium to TikTok, it took me too long to realize that part of why I went so viral was that my attempts at Roland Barthes–esque cultural deconstructions of the family were perceived by my audience as actual exposés. In one of my early viral videos, I speculated that the TikTok dancer Addison Rae had paid for her own placement as a guest star on an episode during the twentieth season of *KUWTK*. It seemed clear to me that this was a mutually beneficial partnership, an outcome of the Kardashians' probable realization that TikTokers represented the latest iteration of social media and their need for a Gen Z link to the platform. But speculating about whether a person could pay their way to a TV presence seemed like a way to get people to consider the role embedded advertising plays on-screen, the way fame itself is a transferable form of capital, and the mutuality that existed between influencers and reality stars—all in all, a way to encourage consuming content actively rather than passively. Instead, it was received as a hot take, with several viewers commenting that they would never see Rae the same again.

Gen Z "faces a number of risk factors for misinformation," the *Guardian* article continues. "It has far higher rates of mistrust in traditional institutions such as the news media and the government compared with past generations and uses social media to get its news coverage at much higher rates than its counterparts." We on TikTok watched the Astroworld tragedy unfold—and weighed in—as if it were our job. A certain convention had formed to inform our duty: spreading the most "seductive" stories, that is, those of individual victims and a sole villain (Scott). As a sourceless quotation (commonly

attributed to the dictator Joseph Stalin) goes, “One man’s death is a tragedy; a million deaths is a statistic.” The more personal a spectacle can be crafted, the more powerful its effect.

According to *BuzzFeed News,* in the aftermath of Astroworld, one seventeen-year-old found her photos being used for TikTok videos and Twitter posts, claiming that she was one of “the first to be announced dead.” “I was honestly very confused and was wondering how people found my pictures,” she told *BuzzFeed*. (But she did appreciate the virality; her “I’m not dead” clarification video on TikTok received millions of views. “That made me feel so much better about the whole false death accusations, I told my close mutuals and we all had a good laugh.”) My own commenters requested that I adjust my language and refer to the event as a “massacre” rather than a tragedy. Everyone was so mad at Travis Scott for not stopping the show, and so convinced that he had let these kids die on purpose because of his incendiary imagery and history of rabble-rousing, that I was hesitant to make any videos suggesting they’d all taken his image as an edgelord far too much at face value. Scott, who had, early on, followed the common pop star strategy of naming one’s fan base (his were “ragers”), brought a corporate gleam to his wild onstage performances; he had completed a massive partnership with McDonald’s the year before. This disaster was more likely a systemic failing not unlike what happened at Woodstock in 1999, when budget cuts to food supply, sloppy security, and an asphalt setting seared by the sun led to mass sexual assaults, three deaths, thousands of injuries, and, eventually, a riot. Chuck D of Public Enemy came onto Instagram to argue that corporate greed played an unacknowledged part in the disaster, and that people should consider the larger systemic failings surely at fault in such a major tragedy. “I’m not buying the Young Black Man Did It…. Live Nation controlled this show. They control almost all of the concert venues. Artists ain’t speaking out because these same cats are already bought by these corporations. No one can say a word against them unless they want to be Blacklisted and hurt their careers.” He addressed Live Nation directly, pleading with them to “stop letting one Young Black Man take the blame, the hate, the fall. We don’t know everything that happened or exactly what failed.

But concert promoters have all the power to make the changes to keep everyone safe and alive."

He had a point: That year, NPR found that Live Nation has a history of safety incidents—"a 2011 stage collapse in Indiana in which seven people were killed and 61 injured…a 2013 incident, [in which] a concert staffer in Long Island, N.Y., suffered brain damage after a forklift tipped over the booth he had been working in." But all that is less captivating than the experience of feeling personally victimized by your former idol. My TikTok comments were flooded by people making calls to boycott Scott's music. It didn't help optics that the Kar-Jenners took two days to post statements about the tragedy to their Instagram accounts, even though Kendall, a pregnant Kylie, and an earmuff-clad Stormi had all been present at the show. "Travis and I are broken and devastated. My thoughts and prayers are with all who lost their lives, were injured or affected in any way by yesterday's events," Kylie finally said in an Instagram Story. (The Kardashians usually make their serious statements as temporal Instagram Stories rather than permanent posts to the grid.) "I am sending my deepest condolences to all the families during this difficult time and will be praying for the healing of everyone who has been impacted." Nonetheless, calls to cancel the Kar-Jenners for their association with Astroworld spread unabated.

I admit that though I purported to use my social media presence as a space to "educate people about media literacy," I could have done more to argue that these kinds of things happen because of systems much greater, richer, and more complex than any one representational individual. I tried my best to embed that lesson as subtext without losing followers, but I also posted videos echoing social media's overarching sentiment—that the Kardashians had been "disrespectful" to victims by not engaging with the tragedy sooner. Maybe this was true, but because I have no personal stake in the moral performances of the family, I know I did it for the "likes."

If the micro dramas that cycled during my initiation to the app were any indication, I provided welcome perspective until I didn't. And every time some new drama cycle was initiated, I felt panicky and violated, distracted from my real-life duties by the nagging knowledge that I was being perceived

in bad faith by an ambiguous mass (and, of course, that sinking feeling of seeing the following count drop). Even worse was that on Instagram cancellation efforts usually took place in the "stories." People would post their evidence and screenshots exposing someone's offenses, sending their audience to flood the accused's comment sections. The schadenfreude ritual could remain somewhat self-contained, at least for transgressions that were ultimately unprovable or unserious. On TikTok, though, people recorded their testimonies—telling their chosen nemesis off as though it were a real-life interaction, even though they were gazing, through their phone cameras, upon their own faces—a TikTokified take on Robert De Niro's famous "you talkin' to me?" mirror performance from *Taxi Driver*. I wasn't the only one who felt stressed by the looming threat that one person's personal beef with your persona could inspire such a video, often kicking off the production of more by other users due to the algorithm's mimetic effect. Everyone I know who uses social media to chase their dreams has caught flak for "bad takes" that resulted in being flooded by videos and comments branding them with simplistic but stigmatized labels. When one acquaintance said that she didn't believe people should have kids until they were financially stable, she was labeled a eugenicist; when another, new to New York, complained about choosing an apartment that was far away from the subway station, she was labeled a gentrifier. These were not the revelations of the #metoo era, challenging the previously unquestioned authority of abusive men (who, as painful as it may be to admit, were nevertheless entitled to due process). These were moral panics that reaped even greater gratification because they were happening to smaller public figures, in part because to have a double- or triple-digit following was viewed as an achievement to vie for, a position of power.

In *Celebrity,* Chris Rojek argues, "The emergence of celebrity as a public preoccupation is the result of three major interrelated historical processes. First, the democratization of society; second, the decline in organized religion; third, the commodification of everyday life…. It is sufficient to say at this point that the decline of Court society in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries involved the transference of cultural capital to self-made men and

women." We see this with the once unknown movie actors and actresses like Marilyn Monroe who were "discovered" by photographers while working in factories, and an even closer version of it anytime a reality TV star or social media influencer earns enough data-proven virality to be viewed as democratically deigned for fame. That on-ramp to fame became more accessible than ever with the advent of social media, and particularly TikTok—with its slot-machine algorithm and predilection for confessional-style videos of faces—but this also left individual content creators uniquely exposed to the resentments that used to dog royalty, then celebrities, and then reality stars: facing all the stressors and pressures associated with fame, minus, in most cases, the epic compensation. It wasn't only the "bigger" creators who were vulnerable to online mobs. If we want hard proof that "smaller" creators (note, by the way, the shift from referring to content producers as "influencers" to "creators") were becoming more novel to consume, we can look to a 2019 study by Samantha Kay, Rory Mulcahy, and Joy Parkinson, which found that audiences were more likely to buy products being openly endorsed by "micro" influencers—who felt like peers—than by "macro" influencers who had not disclosed sponsorship. We can consider the media theorist Kevin Munger's reminder that "the number of people empowered to produce media has exploded…. More hours of video media are recorded and uploaded to YouTube and TikTok in a day than were created in the world in a decade during the heyday of the postwar broadcast media." Through the years, a trend emerged on the app of using quintessential surveillance tactics to "expose" the moral missteps of everyday people. As Bianca Borissova writes for Screenshot, in May 2021, a user named @drewbdoobdoo posted a video announcing, "I hate to be the one to stick my nose where it doesn't belong, but if your name is Marissa, please listen up. I just walked by your friends, and I need to tell you that the weekend you are away is not the only time that they could do their birthday party…. They are choosing to do it the weekend you're away and you need to know. TikTok, help me find Marissa." His video earned fifteen million views. Marissa was found, and after publicly processing her sense of betrayal with her own posts, she was inspired to make "an Instagram page called

@nomorelonelyfriends…where she creates meetups in New York for other people who are in need of friends." This story had a happy ending, but as TikTok more and more became a medium for exposing friendship beefs, bad breakups, and the misbehavior of strangers—often using people's real names or displaying their faces—it could function as not only an ongoing reality TV show but a vicious tabloid where non-consenting, uncompensated everyday people could earn their fifteen seconds of fame.

Numerous studies from the 2020s have established that online harassment has as much of a toxic impact on people's well-being as real-life harassment; the psychologist John G. Cottone even declared that "when one's words or actions are deliberately taken out of context, it can understandably lead to anxiety, depression, PTSD, and even suicidal ideation." Discourse around "cancel culture" itself seemed to be split. A 2020 Pew survey found that 44 percent of Americans had heard of the phrase, while the rest had not. And partisans were as torn on its function. People on the right tended to believe that calling people out on the internet was a matter of "punishing people who didn't deserve it," while the left saw it as "holding people accountable to their actions." (The survey offered no option to answer that it functioned to keep people engaging with the platforms for as long as possible.)

I just wanted to post my wannabe-Barthes takes in peace—envious of how, back in the 1950s, the French critic got to write essays about Greta Garbo's face being a cultural metaphor without accusations of being a "psy-op," or being expected to expose more about his personal value system to justify his interests.

Then, in November 2022, Kim's epic, postmarital separation product placement campaign with the luxury fashion house Balenciaga came to a crash landing now known as Balenciaga-gate. Internet sleuths discovered that the brand had released a holiday campaign called Balenciaga Gift Shop featuring children holding what appeared to be teddy bears in bondage gear. Another campaign, released five days later, featured the French actress Isabelle Huppert posing in an office with prop books in the background that, as *The New York Times* reported, "included…'The Cremaster Cycle' by Matthew Barney, which appeared in conjunction with an exhibit of the artist's

at the Guggenheim Museum, and 'As Sweet as It Gets' by the Belgian painter Michaël Borremans, whose work has been shown at the David Zwirner gallery. The gallery has described Mr. Borremans's paintings as 'toddlers engaged in playful but mysterious acts with sinister overtones and insinuations of violence.'" Another photo featured a handbag on a desk with "printed copies of the Supreme Court's 2008 decision in U.S. v. Williams. The case examined whether laws banning the 'pandering'—promoting—of child pornography curtailed First Amendment freedom of speech rights."

These discoveries were disturbing, and had surfaced at a time when the culture wars were focused on the safety of children; queer activists more and more deconstructed traditional views of "family values" in their discourses: Could trans children consent to medical interventions? Are "drag queen story hours" acceptable? Do kids belong at Pride if kink is present? Plus, the idea of kids being platformed in adult media contexts had become a wider question; the Kardashians and their perpetual maternalistic self-branding had set the tone for family-focused influencers, who were increasingly being exposed for exploiting their kids: In 2021, the vlogger Jordan Cheyenne was caught coaching her son on how to cry for a video post when she didn't realize the camera was still running. The right had claimed most of these issues of child safety—at their most extreme, becoming moral panics in the form of conspiratorial 4chan communities like QAnon, where a sizable network of users strategized how to expose the cabal of elites engaging in political string pulling and pedophilia—leaving little room for the left to take on the important nuances about how kids can be best supported and protected. Studies show that political polarization in the new media age has become so severe that people will align with "their side's" political stance on an issue simply because it's the stance of their side, but the unique thing about Balenciaga-gate was that it seemed (at least in its initial virality) to capture people regardless of political affiliation. The reality star Bethenny Frankel made a video arguing that celebrities were afraid of losing their profitable relationships with the brand, writing in the caption that "people kept messaging me and asking why nobody was speaking up," and the NFL player Cooper Kupp made a post on Twitter about how the ad was an "attack

against our young ones." Eventually, Kanye and Kim made statements condemning Balenciaga. Kim reminded people that she had not been featured in the offending ads, but added that "as a mother of four" she was "disgusted." Kanye declared that most others were not speaking out because "all celebrities are controlled." It was as though fashion as a prompt for cultural discourse offered a less threatening way to "find the line" when it came to kids than online partisan political battles could, and on social media, where performance of one's principles was essential to the chain of content supply and demand, to "remain silent" was cause for suspicion.

I was asked again and again by my own commenters why the celebrities were "staying silent." They seemed hungry for confirmation that Balenciaga was aligned with some kind of menacing and mysterious elite power. Other TikTokers flourished (and grew followings) by zooming in on the documents in the background of the ads and clucking that Balenciaga had put its pedophiliac agenda on full display. Rather than revealing that there existed a secret, organized concentration of evil among our most elite entertainers, Balenciaga's icky campaigns were a likely case of high fashion's ceaseless efforts to push the envelope (a routine satirized back in 2001 in the comedy film *Zoolander,* in which Donald Trump and Paris Hilton made cameos, and its sequel, in which Kimye were credited as cameos despite not being seen in its final cut) and a regrettable error at the props department—Balenciaga was quick to sue the production company responsible for the campaign for $25 million—but it's a net positive that the brand learned its lesson to leave kids out of business. On Thanksgiving Day, pushed by commenters to "spread awareness" about the issue, I said as much and then announced that I'd be celebrating the holiday with my family.

This did not go over well: It was my job, as a volunteer cultural critic, to deconstruct and then moralize about such a revelation, as everyone else on the platform was doing. As we learned from Stje–pan Meštrović in the "Recycling" section of the previous chapter, in a society that has managed to even transform emotional experiences into cyclical postmodern commodities, pundits work to package an "event for us, emotionally, live, as it happens"; my refusal to participate in the chorus coming from other commentators was

jarring. “You brushing over these extremely disgusting topics that are much more important to our children’s futures than the kardashians will ever be is concerning. You’ll deep dive into product placement and brush over Kardashians supporting pedo and satanic brands,” wrote one commenter. “Paid,” accused another. One user, who would proceed to post a series of “you talkin’ to me?” type videos about my work, with the camera close-up on her face as she snarled, said that nobody cared what I thought of the scandal. “We want to know the thing you’re famous for—tell us why they’re being quiet.” She suggested that I was part of the Kardashians’ cabal. “We see you.” (I may as well remind you here that I made my living not through my social media presence but from a day job in an unrelated field.)

The viral visual deconstructions that ensued throughout Balenciaga-gate, though, called to mind QAnon, which the researcher Matthew N. Hannah writes is an example of “a confluence between extremely online, crowd-sourced conspiracies, whose adherents possess a high capacity for online information gathering, and visualization, meant to communicate data about our world effectively and accurately through optical means which has been co-opted for information warfare.” The notion of visualization itself comes with its own cultural credibility—which is part of what makes the meme of Charlie from *It’s Always Sunny in Philadelphia* looking crazy and pointing at a bunch of official-looking documents on a bulletin board so resonant—the taking seriously of something that might be coincidental, a hallmark of our times. “When combined with the sheer amount of data now available online,” writes Hannah, “visualizations produce a sense of authenticity and have become prominent (with some strange aesthetics) in the world of online conspiracy theorizing.” As with TikTok discourse in general, declarations of outrage, and guiding others through visual deconstructions they’d already seen in countless other viral videos to further revel in the pleasures of apophenia, are a way to prove that you “care” and are deserving of the capital you’ve commanded (even if it is only capital in the form of attention). The angriest critic of my “silence” began sending her fans to my page to try to goad response videos out of me, focused on the idea that my midsized audience meant I was in possession of some sort of power and access to the very elites

they hungered to hear more scary theories about. “By researching the breadcrumbs and building the map, anons weave themselves into the conspiracy theory, becoming ‘digital soldiers’ and keyboard warriors in a battle with the Deep State for the soul of America,” Hannah writes. Ever since Balenciaga-gate, I have managed to evade scandals by refusing to engage with provocations, no matter how tempting—though, years later, fans of that user still sometimes appear in my comments to spit poison (sometimes even utilizing that classic social media warhead: the Death Threat). But because social media has served to democratize information in such an overwhelming way that the organization of data into visualization grants its organizer almost automatic authority, self-appointed “digital soldiers” have taken on the labor of maintaining “lists” of celebrities and influencers whose online behavior—whether posting about the wrong thing or not posting enough—has branded them as bad. In 2023, when the Writers Guild of America went on strike over a labor dispute with the Alliance of Motion Picture and Television Producers, Redditors compiled lists of influencers who had either intentionally or unintentionally “scabbed”: in some cases, attending red-carpet events of struck productions; in other cases, unclear on the rules put out by the unions, tweeting about a show they’d enjoyed. In 2024, amid the brutal Israel–Hamas war, databases began appearing as Instagram accounts, flagging as “Zionist” both actual celebrity warmongers and behind-the-scenes people who had posted sympathies for victims after the October 7 attack but whose politics were otherwise unknown, and even people who just hadn’t made any statements at all. (The same proclivity for auditing, of course, can be said of the other side, which, after the 2025 assassination of the right-wing pundit—and, rather ironically, self-proclaimed free speech activist—Charlie Kirk became overrun with volunteer feed inspectors who circulated a massive online “database” of social media users who had posted statements about his death ranging from celebratory to dismissive, and then lobbying their workplaces to get them fired. It’s worth noting, of course, that the right tends to foster less infighting.)

It’s true that no one likes a scab, and criticism of war machines in the Middle East had been long overdue, but a cautionary tale for what we see

today in left-wing online cannibalism can be found in the fable that sprang from Marie Antoinette's revolutionary demise. As the historian Nicole Bauer wrote, "The fiery journalist Jean-Paul Marat, who advocated total transparency, often published, in his newspaper *The Friend of the People,* the home addresses of those he deemed secretly counterrevolutionary or unpatriotic, and his devoted readers would sometimes violently harass his targeted victims. Marat believed that 'tyranny sharpens its sword in darkness' and that a free press helped prevent secret government abuses, keeping the state accountable to its citizens. He also, however, made baseless claims and accusations at times, usually of conspiracies and plots against the revolution. Once, Marat wrote to the famous Jacobin Maximilien Robespierre, declaring that they needed five or six hundred beheadings of false patriots to ensure the continued success of the revolution. Robespierre, a radical himself, was bewildered and asked how he had come by that number. Marat could not give a satisfactory answer." (Marat himself ended up being assassinated in his bathtub by a royalist, who said, during her own trial, that she "killed one man to save 100,000"; as most of us know, Robespierre would face his own turn at the guillotine, which symbolized, for many historians, the end of the Reign of Terror.)

Travis Scott himself, if not solely to blame for the Astroworld tragedy, was undeniably no stranger to fanning the flames of chaos as a way of connecting to his audience—an audience largely bored by anodyne, openly corporate pop stars who belatedly realized that they wanted their favorite "rager" to be a little tamer after all. After the disaster, TMZ reported on past Instagram posts where he shared photos of knocked-out fans with captions like "TO THE KID THAT DIDN'T SURVIVE THE RODEO. UR A HERO IN MU BOOK." In 2017, Scott had pleaded guilty to disorderly conduct after being accused by Arkansas police of inciting a riot. The public was wondering what kind of accountability he'd face; Scott hired Donald Trump's former lawyer Daniel Petrocelli as the lawsuits stacked up into the hundreds. ("Everything that Travis Scott has done or said since 10 people died and hundreds of others were injured at his concert has been lawyer-driven and calculated to shift blame from him to someone else," said the attorney Tony

Buzbee.) Scott lost a hotly anticipated campaign deal with Dior and partnered with the phone therapy app BetterHelp to offer traumatized Astroworld attendees one month of free therapy. It's a little like what Caroline Weber told me of Marie Antoinette during the revolution: that her fall was unjust did not mean that she was an innocent party. "She was committing all kinds of political crimes that the revolutionaries were unaware of—trying to plot to escape from prison to help the Austrian army," for one. But "she was accused of moral crimes" rooted in misogynistic conspiracy theories, "like sleeping with her son, wanting to drink the blood of the French people…and all these charges…. leveled against her in libelous pamphlets for more than a decade." Like Scott, convicted in the public imagination of devil worship and intentional sacrifice of his fans rather than a more mundane (and more likely) obliviousness and inattention to safety standards, she was a useful symbol of perverse decadence.

That winter, at a National Mall rally, denying his presidential election loss to Joe Biden, Donald Trump told his followers, "You don't concede when there's theft involved. Our country has had enough. We will not take it anymore." He encouraged them to march to the Capitol and "cheer on our brave senators and congressmen and women, and we're probably not going to be cheering so much for some of them." What happened next, almost as soon as his raucous applause died, was that thousands of people made their way there, broke into the building, and vandalized congressional offices. A Reuters photographer later tweeted that he overheard three different rioters say that "they hoped to find Vice President Mike Pence and execute him" for not doing his part to overturn the election results. A gallows was erected outside the Capitol. In total, nearly $3 million of damage was done, five people died, and four cops killed themselves in its aftermath. A case proceeded to the Supreme Court to judge whether Trump would be deemed legally responsible for the "insurrection," a word later explored in a 2024 *Washington Post* inquiry. One legal scholar "said he opposes Trump and believes he's a danger to democracy. But, he added, 'I think there's another danger to democracy, which is the exclusion of candidates who the people want to vote for.' "

I wondered whether whatever was decided of Trump's responsibility would set a legal precedent for Travis Scott. Sure enough, a week after the insurrection, Trump was impeached, though the Senate would later acquit him, and his various legal troubles would drag on for years without resolution, further animating his underdog image with his followers. A Pew Research study found that U.S. adults were starkly split on whether Trump bore responsibility for the insurrection. (As time went on, another survey reported, fewer people believed he was responsible.)

That summer, a Texas grand jury decided against indicting Travis Scott, though he, too, faced countless civil cases to be settled privately.

As for Marie, the question of whether she and the king deserved their deaths when they could have just been banished continues to inspire debate. A 1988 article for *The New York Times*—"The French Revolution: Right or Wrong?"—surveyed the way French perspectives on the republic, which emerged out of the Revolution, shifted based on the state of French politics. Apparently, more than two hundred books on the Revolution were due for publication that year, all with different partisan takes on the "elements of the struggle for interpretation over what the event represented for France and the world": "The revolution is generally perceived to have created a nation 'coupe en deux,' cut into two irreconcilable parts, thereby giving French history its special whiff of the unreasonable, its taste of conflict, insurrection, class antagonism. It took most of these two centuries for the French to heal the wounds. And so it is odd that just now, when the country is more united than at any time since 1789, more governed from the political center, it has fallen into a political and scholarly quarrelsomeness over the revolution." Leftists defended the Revolution's contributions to developing the concept of human rights; counterrevolutionaries lamented its bloody excesses. "The point is," concluded the *Times,* "can there be revolution without derapage, without the guillotine or the gulag? It is a measure of its gravity and difficulty that 200 years later, that question is among the few remaining things that still cut the French in two."

A few things are for sure: Donald Trump won the 2024 presidential election, and the virtual uprising against Astroworld failed to deplatform

Scott, though it did manage to bring public awareness to TikTok's utility in spreading misinformation, and I'm sure plenty of young people got canceled within their networks for saying the Wrong Thing about the incident along the way. The claim that "cancel culture isn't real" is common today among those who flourish from participating in it, though anyone who toils online in the production of takes, facing takedowns from their peers, will dispute the statement. The mantra does appear to hold true when it comes to the rich and famous.

Not even a year later, Lauren Cochrane of *The Guardian* reported, "Travis Scott's two shows at London's O2 in August were a huge success, selling out in less than two hours—with tickets for the 20,000-capacity venue going for as much as £180. But when it came to profit margins, that was only part of the story. Scott also sold $1m (£900,000) of merchandise at these concerts—surpassing a record previously set by BTS in 2019." Another year after that, the "Stormiworld" birthday parties resumed in Kylie Jenner's backyard, inspiring a new cycle of social media outcry about the family's insensitivity. In fact, the 2020s marked the beginning of the family's homing in on wealth as their primary mode of spectacle, inspiring viral use of a hashtag—#cancelthekardashians—as, for example, Kim joined in on a trending TikTok formula to give a tour of the opulent SKKN offices, home to Kim Kardashian's latest endeavor, a skincare line: "I'm Kim Kardashian; of course I have a tanning bed." She posted to Instagram photos of herself posing with Tesla Cybertrucks, and even, in 2022, posted from her new shared TikTok account with North footage from the family's "royalty"-themed Thanksgiving holiday, where the dining room's walls were covered in grand portraits of all the dinner guests, imagined as European royalty from different eras (including Kim wearing a familiar white "pouf" hairdo). The family had always flexed conspicuous consumption as a signal that they'd fulfilled their American dream, but now, facing accusations of unrelatability, they seemed to be leaning all the way in, even as views for the #cancelthekardashians hashtag surpassed fifty million. In the end, the result of all the TikTok outcry, all the users tirelessly cranking out videos railing against a lone figurehead, might have been nothing more than another spate of

publicity for powerful individuals—produced for free by the very people Kim exhorted to get up and work.

MERCH

Travis Scott's ability not only to sell out shows but to sell millions of dollars' worth of merch is proof of the futility of cancel culture as it functioned in the 2020s; it is also proof that merch is an essential part of the relationship between the famous and their fans.

Merch is a method of flagging allegiance to your fave—be it a band or a sports team or a politician. (Much has been written about the "Feel the Bern" merch utilized by Bernie Sanders during his 2016 presidential campaign, which even included the manufacturing of "pocket-sized" Sanders dolls.) It often functions as a souvenir that proves You Were There at the Big Event. It brings in a significant share of profits for artists and sports teams. It frequently has nostalgic resale value. As Lauren Cochrane of *The Guardian* wrote in 2022, for instance, "The streetwear resale site StockX reports that a sweatshirt from the merch run of Kids See Ghosts, the 2018 project by Kanye West and Kid Cudi, typically sells for 533% higher than it retailed for—even after West wore a White Lives Matter T-shirt for his Yeezy show earlier this month."

In the years between 2020 and 2022, while the Kardashians prepared for and then unrolled a hiatus from their reality TV show, and Kimye's marriage began to fall apart, an unofficial form of merch became the thread that kept their mosaic of media content together. At the time, the luxury fashion industry—once considered "resilient" ("Rich people, the most obvious consumers for luxury goods, don't balk at price tags," so the luxury industry is less affected by economic downturns, Whizy Kim explains in a *Vox* article)—was experiencing pandemic-catalyzed instability, including widespread layoffs and diminished sales.

Kimye scholars may disagree on when the power couple's end began. We may as well acknowledge that, in 2020, Kanye embarked on a short-lived presidential run (which was later exposed to have been funded by Republican

operatives across five states). At his first rally, in South Carolina, strapped in a bulletproof vest while talking about abortion, he shared an anecdote about being trepidatious about Kim's first pregnancy with North, and Kim's refusal to take the termination pills. "I almost killed my daughter," he cried. He also said that "Harriet Tubman didn't actually free the slaves, she just had the slaves go work for other white people." (This scene was representative of numerous headline-grabbing antics enacted by Kanye over the years, which Kim acknowledged, in an Instagram Story post, were symptomatic of his mental health issues.) After years of rumors that had been brewing since Kanye first donned the MAGA cap, Kim Kardashian filed for divorce on February 19, 2021.

And then something curious began to happen.

While Kimye took time away from the spotlight, *Keeping Up with the Kardashians* fulfilled its final season on E! featuring episodes that teased the possibility of a romantic reunion between Kourtney and her ex-partner Scott, showed the Kar-Jenners in a family meeting deciding to end their show, introduced the kids as more significant players in the dynasty's brands in a *Truman Show*–themed episode, and homed in on the drama of Kim failing the "baby bar." *KUWTK,* it was clear, was airing its episodes out of tune with the family's faster-moving news media and social media shenanigans. And so, it was during this time of relative Kimye quiet that Kourtney, the eldest Kardashian, enjoyed a brief "main character moment" of her own, using news and social media to soft drop a new relationship with the pop punk band Blink-182's drummer, Travis Barker, iconic for his technical talent, bald head, tattoos, and veganism. Had a new music icon arrived to influence the family's aesthetic? It was two days before the news about Kimye's divorce dropped that Kourtney posted a photo of their hands interlocked—meticulous red manicure contrasted with tattooed skin—to formally announce the relationship, officially kicking off a higher-volume influx of media content that would carry them to a luxe Catholic wedding in Italy "hosted" by Dolce & Gabbana and featured on the family's TV show a year later. The couple posted to social media photos from extravagant vacations spanning from Utah to Italy, always appearing professionally styled in aesthetics that ranged from

kitschy *True Romance*–inspired retro to jewel-toned luxury. They stepped out around L.A. for paparazzi shots, which was almost a nostalgic nod to the long-passed tabloid era. Their "thing"—their semiotic, some might say—became PDA. Most photo ops involved them kissing—sometimes in exaggerated ways. (The Kar-Jenners would build a storyline for their new Hulu show around how hilariously annoying Kourtney and Travis were, always distracted by their infatuation with each other.)

This approach to media storytelling—the reliance on images alone, even without a TV show, across different mediums, to sustain a narrative (in this case, a love story)—laid a blueprint for how Kimye would construct their own divorce lore over the next year, competing with each other like campaigning politicians, creating hype for the new Hulu show, music album, and clothing lines along the way.

Musa al-Gharbi might call this mode of hyperactive image and narrative production an example of "symbolic capitalism," an extension of Debord's notion of the spectacle, where representations interact with one another to captivate consumers, and of Bourdieu's capital theory, which maps out the various performative ways that elites can maintain their dominion over the status quo. "Although most employees continue to work in the productive economy (at a ratio of nearly 2:1)," al-Gharbi wrote in 2024, "symbolic industries are approaching the lion's share of GDP." He cited U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics research that shows how much more "value is added" to the economy from the FIRE industry (finance, insurance, and real estate), "professional business and services," "information," education services, and art, even though a larger percentage of Americans works in manufacturing and labor jobs—the jobs that require interaction with the material world. In other words, the economy is driven, more and more, by everything we've gone over in this book—data, engagement, identity discourses, the myths of our public figures, and our own self-branding—even though the country continues to rely on real-life laborers.

The gap between real and digital worlds was never felt more than during the pandemic, and in 2020, in collaboration with McKinsey & Company, the trade publication *Business of Fashion* released a video alerting the fashion

industry that growth was down 3 to 4 percent, and that, "as traditional engagement models struggle on established social media platforms, fashion players will need to rethink their strategy and find ways to maximise their return on marketing spend. Attention-grabbing content will be key, deployed on the right platform for each market, using persuasive calls-to-action."

The timing was seamless. Once people had their fill of the springtime Kravis media cycle, and as online commentators began to wonder how Kim, famously Kanye's fashion muse, would manage as a glamour laborer without him, Kanye hosted the first "Donda" listening event at the Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta on July 19, 2021. *Donda,* an in-progress album, was named for his late mother and muse, Donda West, chair of Chicago State University's Department of English, Communications, Media, and Theater. Of the larger media project he'd named after her, he tweeted, "DONDA is a design company which will galvanize amazing thinkers and put them in a creative space to bounce there [*sic*] dreams and ideas." In other words, it was a multimedia, multi-genre manufacturing center of symbolic goods, though it had never been executed. (Soon enough, it would become fair to say that Kim's multimedia, multi-genre career reflected its blueprint.)

Kim and the kids were present at the first sold-out *Donda* album listening party, Kim wearing a red Rick Owens bodysuit that matched Kanye's red puffer jacket from his recent Gap x Yeezy collection. The event was all about the pain of loss—loss of mother, loss of marriage—which made Kim's physical presence even more intriguing for fans. A small red dot at the center of the whitewashed stadium, Kanye dropped to his knees to cry, "I'm losing my family" (from the song "Never Abandon Your Family"). This broke Apple Music records, with 3.3 million people tuning in to the live stream of the event.

The second event at the same stadium, a few weeks later, also sold out, continued the experience, with Kim and the kids again in tow, and Kim, again, matching what Kanye wore—this time, in head-to-toe Balenciaga black, with faces covered by masks. In the weeks between shows, Kanye had tweeted a photo of the dank back room he'd been staying in while honing the songs based on social media feedback from fans; the image became a meme.

During the show itself, he set up a stage that replicated the small memed room. This show was less a fist shake at the abyss, as the first had been, and more of an experimental theater performance as he paced the room while rapping his updated songs.

At the grand finale, another Apple Music record breaker, this time at Soldier Field in Chicago, Kanye set up a replica over a large mound of dirt of the modest childhood home where he'd lived with Donda. He invited famously "canceled" musicians like DaBaby and Marilyn Manson to stand with him on its front porch; he set himself on fire at another point; and in a dramatic final scene, a veiled Kim Kardashian emerged in a Balenciaga wedding gown and they appeared to have a wordless, baffling wedding ceremony, which seemed to reference the couple's 2013 engagement (Kanye had proposed to Kim at the center of a stadium). Khloé and Kylie posted videos of the moment to their social media stories, with Khloé also tweeting about how "sick" (in a flattering way) the scene had been to witness IRL.

And it was after this final ritual—the hyperreal wedding—that Kim was seen wearing Balenciaga at almost every major public appearance she made. Conspiracy theorists, obsessed with data visualization, speak often of color-oriented public rituals that "initiate" some new chapter of the public figure's life (some Illuminati theorists believe, for example, that Kanye's interruption of Taylor at the 2009 VMAs was a "humiliation ritual" for which she first wore white, setting up her later reemergence in red, having earned her initiation). This apophenia-inducing logic was plucked from the annals of online speculation and made real, in the interest of art, enterprise, and hype. Only a few weeks later, on September 13, was the Met Gala, typically held in the spring but pushed back due to lockdown, and Kim walked its carpet covered in head-to-toe black, a veritable silhouette of herself, accompanied by a matching, masked date that many assumed to be Kanye because the figure possessed his mannerisms—until it was revealed to be Demna Gvasalia, Balenciaga's creative director, who was teasing his own postmodern vision for post-lockdown fashion marketing.

That fall, Kim hosted *Saturday Night Live,* wearing a Barbie-pink Balenciaga bodysuit during her monologue and another version for the after-

party, and the "behind the scenes" of all this (including a storyline that situated Kanye as her continued friend, who helped her write her *SNL* monologue) would air on Hulu six months later. If all this production of image and narrative was symptomatic of "symbolic capitalism," then much capital was being invested in rather simplistic and uniform pieces of fabric. After all, as Edward Bernays writes in *Propaganda* of the onus on manufacturers to reverse engineer public desire for a product, "the logical way out of this dilemma is for the manufacturer…to give the product, in the public mind, some other attraction, some idea that will modify the product slightly, some element of originality that will distinguish it from products in the same line. Thus, a manufacturer of typewriters paints his machines in cheerful hues…. A minor element can be made to assume economic importance by being established in the public mind as a matter of style."

And so, the narratives began to layer. I can recall participating in the online anticipation of Kim's *SNL* performance by predicting that she would be making "some kind of announcement" in her monologue, as Kristen Stewart had used her monologue to come out as gay, and Keke Palmer would, a year later, use hers to announce her pregnancy. When Kim punctuated her monologue not with a revelation but with an O.J. joke, I stood corrected. But her appearance did entail a hidden announcement of sorts: Soon thereafter, a photo "leaked" to *People* showed Kim and the *Saturday Night Live* comedian Pete Davidson—whom she'd smooched on a "magic carpet ride" during the *Aladdin*-themed sketch—riding a roller coaster together. Soon branded "Skete" by a scorned Kanye, the Kim and Pete pairing was highly novel thanks to its cougar subtext, since Kim was forty and Pete was twenty-seven; its disfluency, since Kim was becoming more and more associated with luxury and Pete was a Staten Island–reared bad boy covered in tattoos; and, maybe most of all, since Pete was white. The algorithms and headlines had been set ablaze. Especially after Kanye, wearing Balenciaga, dropped onto a *Drink Champs* podcast to complain about the whole thing: "SNL making my wife say, 'I divorced him,' on TV because they just wanted to get that bar off, and I ain't see the papers. We're not even divorced…. They ain't no joke to me. My kids want they parents to stay together. I want us to be together." The

prevailing narrative for this latest cycle became one of "are they or aren't they?" (Divorced, in the case of Kimye; dating, in the case of Skete.)

If you want proof that this felt like a cultural moment at a Trump-weary time when it was harder and harder to capture collective public attention—one that was already becoming inextricable from a brand—consider that the social media company Meta, faced with its own project of promoting Mark Zuckerberg's pet project, "the metaverse," an "immersive, interconnected virtual environment," tweeted at the brand, "Hey @Balenciaga, what's the dress code in the metaverse?"

I'll admit it: Before this media cycle, I, a fashion world layman, knew little about Balenciaga. The Spanish luxury brand, founded in 1919 by Cristóbal Balenciaga, had belonged since 2001 to the French corporation Kering, which also owned brands like Gucci, Alexander McQueen, and Yves Saint Laurent. When, in the new year, Kanye responded to Kim's viral rebound by stepping out with his own downtown It Girl, Julia Fox, previously known for her role in the hit Safdie brothers film *Uncut Gems,* both wore Balenciaga for most resulting paparazzi shots as they flounced from Carbone to the theater. The cultural critic Patrik Sandberg tweeted, "I find it rather unprecedented that Kim and Kanye are exclusively wearing Balenciaga. To sponsor and dress a celebrity divorce feels like a cynical yet brilliant new breed of endorsement."

Kim's and Kanye's tandem romances were as visual and contextless as Kravis's had been—spurring viewers to fill in the blanks with discourse about whether the advent of Pete and the diminishment of their BBLs and assumption of blond hairdos meant the Kar-Jenners were staging a return to cultural "whiteness"—but the common denominator, Balenciaga, was a brand appropriate for the family's positionality in pop culture; after all, SKIMS' low-key competitor, the Fenty founder Rihanna, had claimed LVMH, and Balenciaga's name and fragrances were licensed with Coty, the beauty company that owned majority shares of Kylie Cosmetics. Plus, as KDK would later find out, the Kardashians have a pattern of partnering with fledgling institutions, bringing their classic Kardashian controversy-virality to revive the brand and associate themselves with a heritage-tied name—generating hype for both parties (when Kim joined *American Horror Story* in

2024, viewership of the show had fallen; when Kylie partnered with Bratz, the brand was at a lower point). This *did* seem to be a high-scale approach to product placement, even in the absence of a TV show. (If TikTok was teaching us anything, it was that reality TV mattered less and less anyway.)

Even weirder was when *PAPER* magazine pointed out that Julia Fox and Pete Davidson had been featured together in a 2019 issue of the magazine, dressed like Barbie dolls ("these images tell a story," read the caption). And fans found images of Julia Fox modeling for SKIMS in 2020, while other photos emerged of Pete and Kanye hanging out in the past. Meanwhile, my own notoriety was on the rise. My own apophenia-inducing takes on the influx of all these images were going more and more viral: I argued that Kimye's proliferation of Balenciaga looks called to mind costumes worn by a cartoon superhero family in the Pixar classic *The Incredibles,* to which Kanye had compared his family in a 2019 episode of *KUWTK;* was the fracturing family on some kind of cultural ascent, "finally fly[ing]," as he had put it? Kimye had been such a fashion-forward couple it only made sense that their ending would be a drawn-out story told through clothes. For *PAPER,* I pointed out that if Balenciaga really were somehow sponsoring this divorce, it was a new take on an old relationship between fashion and media: "It's an artful approach to product placement that simultaneously elevates the films and further mythologizes the brands. In 1967, Yves Saint Laurent tailored Catherine Deneuve's suits for her 'fragile and seductive' depiction of Severine in cult-classic *Belle de Jour*…. There's something about being dressed by a great designer that graduates a story's more basic characters into influential 'icons.' Legend has it, after all, that trench coat sales went up following *Belle de Jour*'s release."

While I was writing the piece, Kanye announced that his Yeezy x Gap line was partnering with Balenciaga for a special collection; so, we cultural critics, pushed to the lines of conspiracy, weren't so crazy after all.

With Kim clad always in Balenciaga or SKIMS—and looking good in it—the issue of whether she would flounder without Kanye there to dress her seemed to be quickly nipped in the bud. In January 2022, Kim stepped out as a Balenciaga partner, starring in traditional ads for the brand. Kanye began

going on Instagram tirades, making multiple posts in a matter of minutes with wild captions ("ALL OF YOU HATE ME AND DEMNA'S RELATIONSHIP DEMNA IS THE MOST RELEVANT FASHION DESIGNER SO IT MAKES SENSE HE USES KIMYE THE MOST RELEVANT PERFORMANCE ARTIST ON THE PLANET AND YOU FASHION AND ART BITCHES HAAAATE IT KIM IS A HYBRID OF MARINA ABROMAVIC MARILYN MONROE AND HILLARY CLINTON I AM JOSEPH BEUYS ANDY KAUFMAN AND DAVID HAMMONS I AM EVERY ARTISTS FAVORITE ARTIST"), often in all caps and promptly deleted. Some of his captions expressed rage toward "Skete," and in March his music video for the *Donda* single "Eazy" was released, showing him as a *Celebrity Deathmatch*–style Claymation character kidnapping and decapitating Davidson, which inspired discourse about domestic violence during breakups that flooded my own comment sections and was even weighed in on by public figures like Trevor Noah and Azealia Banks (both of them "Team Kim"). At this stage, audiences were choosing their "sides" between Kanye and Kim as though they were sports teams or politicians, or some new hybrid of both—calling to mind what Jason Turcotte has written about the "framing of politics as sport."

According to Turcotte, political candidates more and more speak of their work using sports terms—referring to gaffes as "fumbles" and successes as "touchdowns"—making it easier for "low information voters" to engage in "policy understanding," and news media channels focus "on the competitive aspects of politics" like polling results and races for votes with "less news attention to policy," leading to a gamified approach to partisanship wherein people buy merchandise—hats, T-shirts, and dolls—to identify themselves with their favorite "teams." So, it was fitting that, in January, Kim and Kanye had also been seen spending time with their own partisan associates—Kim with the establishment Democratic Party, out to lunch with Hillary and Chelsea Clinton, Kanye in Miami with Jared Kushner—again unified by fashion, both wearing the same shade of Balenciaga's neon green. (*What did it mean?* my audience asked. Probably nothing besides the apophenia it provoked; as Matthew Hannah quoted of Baudrillard in his study of

conspiratorial uses of data visualization, “We live in a world where there is more and more information, and less and less meaning.”) A few weeks later, Kanye tweeted a meme that rendered his competition with Kim and Pete as a Marvel movie poster, titled “Kanye West Civil War.” Whether the decoupled icons formerly known as Kimye were superheroes, politicians, or sportsmen, one thing was certain: They were now competitors in a game that had turned the immaterial realm of digital media into a full-blown stadium show.

Kim and Pete attended the Met Gala in May, in looks that, benefiting Kanye’s previous Instagram comments, referenced Marilyn Monroe and JFK. In October of that year, after Kanye and Candace Owens wore those “White Lives Matter” T-shirts to his showing at Paris Fashion Week, and Kanye posted to his Instagram that he was going to go “death con 3 on JEWISH PEOPLE,” Balenciaga formally severed ties with Kanye, who began stepping out with his new wife, an Australian architect of Italian descent named Bianca Censori. Censori physically resembled Kim, but her marital role appeared to differ in its defiance of fashion. Kanye had famously *dressed* Kim in a way that helped to elevate her into a full-blown phenomenon, while his project with Censori was one of undressing. Together they made spectacle-inducing public appearances from Vegas to Venice, with Censori standing, wordless and nearly nude, at his side.

The controversy surrounding Kanye would only be the preview for the way Balenciaga’s proximity to drama would eventually exceed control. But at the height of the *Donda Era,* Balenciaga, SKIMS, and Yeezy x Gap products offered souvenirs from the Kimye divorce media experience. All that symbolic capital had to manifest itself into *something* material, after all. Kim’s neon-colored dresses and bodysuits, representing a transitional time in her larger myth, established a blueprint of using strife to attach meaning to fabric and hype a brand.

And whatever dips the luxury fashion industry suffered in 2020 had quickly flattened and bulged. I’m not saying that the Balenciaga-sponsored divorce single-handedly revived interest in luxury, but Kering’s stock value was never so high as during the 2021 *Donda Era,* and the overall fashion industry saw some of its best years in 2021 and 2022.

CONSPIRACY THEORY

That Balenciaga actually sponsored a high-profile divorce is unproven. So, is the resulting discourse about it an example of conspiratorial thinking ("an attempt to explain harmful or tragic events as the result of the actions of a small powerful group," according to *Britannica*) or critical thinking (a "mode of cognition using deliberative reasoning and impartial scrutiny of information to arrive at a possible solution to a problem")? When everyone knows that advertising and media content have become more and more embedded, is it so crazy to suspect that Kimye's relationship with Demna was a bold, creative take on the well-documented advertising strategy of "product placement"? Influencer culture is all about the infusion of commodity into real life. *The Truman Show* was ahead of its time, satirizing this. One interactive *New York Times* article from 2022, featuring a photo of the comedian Larry David clutching a bottle of Perrier in an episode of *Curb Your Enthusiasm,* traces the legacy of product placement in media and its "explosion" in the streaming era: "Product placement is now a $23 billion industry, up by an estimated 14 percent since 2020."

Growing mistrust in media is surely what led to Balenciaga-gate, convincing people that the luxury fashion brand had, through a disturbing ad campaign, revealed the pedophiliac proclivities of its stakeholders. "Extraordinary expectations," embedded into the dopamine-spiking algorithm, have encouraged the belief that evil is not "banal," in Hannah Arendt's phrase—something any ordinary person could be capable of when placed in the right context—but the outcome of something secret, bigger, and more sinister than all of us. But even if we understand that a cabal of satanists is probably not running the world, it's indisputable that Amazon, and Apple, and Meta, and Disney, and all the other American conglomerates that the Kardashians have made it their business to fly high enough to rub shoulders with *do* represent smaller groups of elite individuals whose decisions about their businesses impact our culture and economy in ways that trickle down to our day-to-day lives. The appeal of conspiracy theories is perhaps self-evident: They "provide people with simplified answers, specifically to

questions of how a certain crisis situation emerged, and which societal actors can and cannot be trusted."

If you look at the history of celebrity, every icon's myth is inextricable from at least one conspiracy, with themes that usually have to do with sex or death: The CIA killed JFK; JFK killed Marilyn; Elvis still lives; Walt Disney is frozen in a vat somewhere; any men associated with the Kardashians are followed by a "curse" (just as the Kennedys have a "curse" of their own). Do such narratives grow and spread because we are troubled by the power wielded by our icons? After all, history shows that conspiracy theories tend to appear during times of unrest. The researchers Jan-Willem van Prooijen and Karen M. Douglas cite a study of more than 100,000 letters to *The New York Times* and the *Chicago Tribune* between 1890 and 2010. They expose not a linear rise of conspiratorial content but instead "fluctuations" that spiked twice. "The first spike occurred shortly before the year 1900, at the height of the second industrial revolution—a period that was characterized by the rise of major companies, quick technological progress, and rapidly changing power structures. Such major societal change is a recipe for feelings of insecurity among citizens, particularly those who feel powerless or voiceless. The second spike occurred during the late 1940s and the early 1950s—a period that marked the beginning of the Cold War. Many of the conspiracy theories that were ventilated during that period assumed an association between groups or institutions with communism." I wish this study had lasted into the 2020s and that we could map it alongside the rise and fall of public interest in the "Kardashian curse," which may be, itself, a response to the entrance of a massive, matriarchal capitalist enterprise on the world stage, disrupting gendered media representations and therefore power relations.

In 2015, *Star* magazine published an issue with a cover that proclaimed, "Black Widows: How the Kardashians Destroyed Their Men," subtitled with, *Lamar: Attempted Suicide; Scott: Does Drugs for Breakfast; Kanye: Career in Tatters; Caitlyn: 23 Years of Mental Torture,* and featuring photos of the Kardashian sisters and Kris as they navigated a handful of scandals that seemed to converge at once. The cover represented a rumor that had been floating around the internet—that the Kardashian women carried a curse that

condemned the men in their sphere. The origins of this legend are unknowable, but considering the long-studied (and proven) relationship between sports and superstition and the fact that Khloé and Kim both dated professional athletes early in their careers—who later suffered embarrassing blows on the court or field—we can guess it began circulating early (yet again reminding us of the ever-present flirtation between the "girlie" domain of reality TV and the "macho" realm of professional sports).

It didn't help that in the aftermath of his unwanted split from Kim, Kanye began spouting off complaints about feeling manipulated by the family. In the beginning of January 2022, while driving, Kanye posted a video venting about how the address of the princess-doll-themed birthday party of his four-year-old daughter, Chicago, was withheld from him. "I'm taking control of my narrative this year…. I'm just putting this online because I need ya'll's support…they take so many fathers through America, they been taking fathers out the homes…so I'm using my voice to say this aint going to keep happening…there's a lot of people that's in a position where they ain't got no voice when people be playing games like this. Baby mama's be playing games, the grandma playing games." (Eventually, after Travis Scott texted him the information, he was granted entry.)

The Kimye divorce inspired discourse around the gender wars—which, in the 2020s, only seemed to be worsening on social media in general, with public figures like Andrew Tate and Jordan Peterson rousing the rage of "red-pilled" young men en masse, and raking in millions—in a louder and more glaring way than any previous Kardashian media provocations had. It was happening at a time when the Kardashians were bigger than ever—with automatic invitations to the Met Gala, living as official billionaires, signed on with one of the most iconic and resilient brands (Disney) in the world.

The Kardashians seemed to understand that they were in possession of power and responsibility in the depiction of men on their show—from removing their long-suffering little brother, Rob, from the public eye to the apologist framing of their former partners, even compulsive cheaters like Khloé's ever-present ex, Tristan (whose antics had offered prime, multi-season drama for the family's most loyal fans). In season 1 of *The*

Kardashians—and throughout its promotion—Kim spoke of her ex-husband in flattering terms. "Kanye will always be family," she told Andy Cohen in an interview. Episodes showed Kanye helping her retrieve the remnants of her sex tape from Ray J and spinning hyper-visual family-focused spectacles, like picking up their kids for school in a fire truck. Such an idyllic take on their conscious uncoupling seemed intended to cushion the true agenda of the season: to demonstrate Kim's careful detachment from Kanye in a way that could not be called a disposal of him. In one scene, she considers the idea of having him be the musical guest for her *SNL* episode. "That would be epic… but then, do I want my own moment?" she asks her family. Of *course* she did, but to drop him too fast would contradict the family sitcom sensibilities that had carried the dynasty this far, and prove right the countless critics who preferred to view the women as witches. In the season that followed, after Kanye's Instagram spirals and podcast appearances, the family began to include scenes that reframed Kanye in the context of his newfound self-styled villainy. "Even through all of the craziness—of everything that Kanye says about us—I never comment. I never post," Kim cried. This is the point: The Kardashians had the power to "control the narrative" of the impulsive men in their lives—whether by framing or by omission—because it was all going down on *their* TV show.

One thing is certain: No collective of women had ever accumulated so much power within a single decade; history knows no matriarchal dynasties that have managed such global media impact, so it's understandable that discourse about the Kardashians often leads to feminist infighting. (Kim has opted to elude the label: In a 2016 essay for her website called "Why I Don't Call Myself a Feminist," she wrote, "I support women to the fullest. But, at the end of the day, no one should feel pressured to be labeled as anything just because they believe in certain things and support certain values or ideals.")

"I will never forgive millennial girlboss feminism for trying to make us think that the Kardashian Jenner empire is a win for feminism," says one TikToker in a viral video. "If they were a bunch of dudes hanging out, would we hate on them so much?" asks a man in one of Kareem Rahma's viral "Subway Takes." Sharon Osbourne declared, "I don't think because she takes

her clothes off and is confident with that, that makes you a feminist," while Joey Soloway, creator of the *Transparent* TV show, told NBC that they consider the Kardashians "feminist heroes." "It's a matriarchy…. In the world of feminism, they call this femmephobia…. When people are saying, 'are these the women we don't stand for?' They're always…women who use their femininity and beauty to make money." The discourses that unroll in most of my comment sections echo these disputing sentiments. (I've always said, when pressed, that the Kardashians are examples of what optimal woman empowerment could look like in our system as it works today; their wins, however, will never lead to our liberation from domestic, street, and sexual violence, oppressive beauty standards, reproductive injustice, nor any of the ways that racial and class divides exacerbate these concerns.)

One thing, though, is certain: They are powerful. Studies have found that men working under female bosses are more likely to sexually objectify women as a way of reclaiming their sense of dominance, which makes a mindfuck out of Kim's self-professed willingness to post bikini and pantsuit shots on the same Instagram feed. In 2024, Daniel Jolley, Silvia Mari, Tanya Schrader, and Darel Cookson published a paper tracing the history of studies of conspiracy theories that have led to the outgrowth of "feminist conspiracy theories" targeting women as an out-group, ranging from the belief that "gender studies were introduced secretly against the Catholic Church to harm traditional values and social arrangements," to the proliferation of "rape myths," the likes of which we've all heard before: that "women enjoy being raped," that a woman's manner of dress rationalizes violence. Indeed, after studying more than five hundred people (about half women and half men), these researchers found "evidence that a belief in, and exposure to feminist conspiracy theories, where feminists are depicted as aiming at destabilizing the power hierarchy based on gender purposely at the expense of men (which goes beyond a simple feminist stereotype), could increase rape myths acceptance." Perhaps it's sensing what is at stake for women that inspires some Kardashian apologists to draw their lines.

In any case, the most consistent critique of the family concerns their mastery of "controlling the narrative," an echo of a stereotype about women

that has persisted throughout time, taking shape, at times, in the form of the archetypical femme fatale—or "lethal woman." Femmes fatales use their charisma to glean power, ostensibly because traditional methods of doing so—for example, the masculinized notion of brute force—aren't available options. One might even say that Eve was the first femme fatale, masking her weak will with manipulation and deceit and seducing Adam into his downfall at her side. As Jordan Peterson told Nellie Bowles of *The New York Times* in 2018, "You know you can say, 'Well isn't it unfortunate that chaos is represented by the feminine'—well, it might be unfortunate, but it doesn't matter…. [T]here are reasons for it…. This is underneath everything. If you change those basic categories [of masculinity and femininity], people wouldn't be human anymore."

The idea of women bringing men down is biblical; Khloé even took a page from Kim's Everywoman book and dressed up as Adam's self-indulgent wife in 2024 for the cover of *TMRW* magazine, holding an apple before her left breast. The literary scholar Joseph Campbell tells the story this way: "The serpent…saw Eve and thought she must be bored, as most wives are when their husbands are working all the time…. The serpent said: 'Look there's an interesting thing about this tree. Don't mind that old buzzard—have a taste and you will really know something.'" We know the rest: Eve persuaded Adam to try the apple too. The duo, ashamed by their transgression, "told God what happened, and that ran the usual way: the man blamed the woman, and the woman blamed the snake. God then cursed the lot of them in increasing degrees. Man got it fairly easy: all he had to do was to work and sweat. The woman had to bring forth children in pain." And, of course, the couple was kicked out of the Garden of Eden, yearning to return for the rest of human history.

A year or so after the "Black Widows" *Star* cover came out, *KUWTK* devoted a whole episode to the Kardashian curse—conveniently bumping the family's reality show to the top of the phrase's Google results (talk about reclaiming the narrative). In the episode, Kris and Kourtney take a bummed-out Khloé on a wine-tasting trip to Napa, where she bemoans the stress of her divorce from Lamar, whose bad choices somehow reflected worse on her;

meanwhile, Scott wonders aloud to Kendall and Kylie about whether the Kardashian curse is real, then visits a series of psychics to get to the bottom of it and even stops by a farm to rent a rooster for use in a ritual to relieve himself of it. By the end of his odyssey, he reassures the offended Kardashian sisters, "Maybe there's not a curse; maybe I should stop with the excuses," revealing the episode's entire passive-aggressive point, which would be stated explicitly by Khloé almost a decade later, in an episode of *The Kardashians,* when she, Kim, and Scott watch a new viral TikTok video about how their family's ancestors allegedly struck a deal with four Armenian witches to guarantee their fame at the cost of the men in their lives. "It's so sexist—why can society blame us girls but they can never blame men?"

Perhaps some of the appeal of the idea that supernatural darkness can explain the Kardashians' successes is that it undermines the American dream grit narratives the family always espouses. In his book *Celebrity,* Chris Rojek cites Max Weber, who "devised the concept of charisma to apply to special or unique qualities attributed to the individual. He argued that charismatic authority…depends on apparently miraculous or semi-miraculous occurrences, such as prophecies that come true, battles that are always won, powers of healing that never falter, artistic performances that succeed time and again." That's the thing about the Kardashians; they never seemed to fail, exemplars of the 2020 meme archived by Know Your Meme: "They hate to see a girlboss winning." By the 2020s, it was no longer possible to deny the fact that the Kardashians were winners in business. Their series showed them reveling in what William James called, in a letter to H. G. Wells, the classically American "worship" of that "bitch-goddess success." But, as some online detractors vented, their success was attributable to little more than the cynical selling of their silly personalities and their sexualized bodies. By this logic, their "charisma" and the supernatural privileges it came with explained their extraordinary station in society; no superior stratagem, nor skill, had aided their domination of a male-dominated domain.

In 2023 and 2024, the metaphysics that maintained the Kardashian media machine became an open question on the family's TV show (in a manner that, yet again, seemed to meld product placement with reality-based narrative).

Not long after Kourtney and Travis were married at Dolce & Gabbana's Portofino property, Villa Olivetta, in a decadent, Catholic-themed wedding, Kim accepted the brand's offer to "creative direct" an archive-sourced collection for its spring/summer season. Seasons 3 and 4 of *The Kardashians* followed the sisters' ensuing battles over Italian luxury aesthetics. It was tempting to write the whole drama off as staged, inspired by the Balenciaga Divorce blueprint, to generate brand hype for Dolce & Gabbana. Still, Kourtney's tears of frustration as she called Kim a "fucking witch," amid one conflict, were consistent with complaints she'd made throughout the years about feeling baited into fights by her sisters to produce organic dramas for the sake of the show ("Fights are our thing," Kim said, shrugging, in a season 20 episode of *KUWTK*).

As episodes followed Kim's dinners with Domenico Dolce and Stefano Gabbana and visits to Italy to plan the collection, Kourtney questioned what was "driving" her relentless sister. "What is it about yourself…that you have to have everything?" she asked Kim when they met up to talk it out. "People are driven by certain reasons, and they make you great. But there's also something about being able to be content and happy with what you have and not feel like you need more."

Later in 2024, Kourtney would costar with Kim in a Sophia Loren–inspired ad campaign for the inevitable SKIMS x Dolce & Gabbana collab, but in this moment, she was touching on the greatest spectacle—and mystery—of Kim Kardashian at this stage of her career: the unforeseen level of power she had achieved, and her compulsion to pursue more of it. Every time it seemed as though she'd reached the finish line—"breaking the internet," making *Vogue* covers, and marrying Kanye West in the mid-2010s, bringing SKIMS to a multibillion-dollar valuation, and walking couture fashion weeks in the early 2020s—she'd raise the stakes beyond previous imagination: announcing a debut to some new industry, like her SKKY Partners private equity firm and foray into TV acting for *American Horror Story,* or some major partnership, like outfitting Team USA and the NBA in SKIMS, or some other unpredictable yet, more and more, totally unsurprising event, like

jet skiing in Greece with Jeff Bezos or donning a sari in Mumbai to attend the opulent "mega-wedding" of the son of Asia's richest man.

During these years, I was often asked by my own audience about *why* she kept going, *when* she would stop, *what more,* really, was there left to do. These were, really, questions about capitalism itself: What were its limits? Did it *have* limits? And how is it that a select few people, whose names we all know, figured out how to hack it? Obama used the family as an example of this dilemma as early as 2013, when he lamented that kids were "monitoring every day what Kim Kardashian was wearing, or where Kanye West was going on vacation, and thinking that somehow that was the mark of success." Kris Jenner clapped back on her short-lived talk show: "I wasn't aware that you could only set the bar so high…. I was taught: Dream big, work hard and you could have whatever you wanted." She then pointed out the president's own access to power: "I bet the President has some friends with 10,000 square foot houses and that he wouldn't mind going over there…when [he was] asking them to have a party for [him] while [he was] campaigning for dollars to run for president."

Conspiracy theories exist in part because of a mystification with the notion of power, often in contrast to one's own feeling of powerlessness. In 2013, *Scientific American* wrote about how "a large 2008 study by Jennifer Whitson of the University of Texas at Austin and Adam Galinsky of Northwestern University showed that participants who lacked control were more likely to perceive illusory patterns, including conspiracies…. In other words, adopting conspiracy beliefs recasts the world as a more predictable place. A tangible enemy absorbs the blame for problems that otherwise may seem too abstract." Distressed and calling Kim a "witch" and a "narcissist," the sorts of labels the family's widespread critics also liked to throw around, Kourtney articulated the question the rest of the world seemed to share, forced by media inundation to gaze upon the spectacle of Kim's ceaseless pursuit of more power. As Kim's forsaken ex-husband prophetically rapped back in 2010, "No one man should have all that power." Only, fifteen years later, it applied best to a woman.

BARBIE

Collective memory—and its fracture

In April 2022, just as *The Kardashians* was set to make its streaming debut on Hulu, the marketing for Greta Gerwig's *Barbie* movie began: first, with an announcement of its 2023 release date at Las Vegas CinemaCon, including a photo reveal of the movie's star Margot Robbie as Barbie beaming big in her iconic pink Corvette. A month later, Robbie and her costar Ryan Gosling, who played Ken, shot the film's Rollerblading scene in plain view on a busy Santa Monica beach, resulting in the proliferation of behind-the-scenes paparazzi and social media photos that presented the stars on set, dressed up in doll-like neon clothing. From there, marketing for the film exploded (later estimates suggested that the marketing budget surpassed the movie's $145 million production budget). News that the future blockbuster was slated to share an opening weekend, the following year, with Christopher Nolan's nihilistic A-bomb biopic, *Oppenheimer,* provided a novel tonal dialectic that inspired a portmanteau, Barbenheimer, which, itself, set off a series of social media memes. TikTok trends spread as creators danced to remixed takes on the 1997 earworm "Barbie Girl," by Aqua; a *2001: A Space Odyssey*–inspired commercial merged "highbrow" culture with the accessible, showing a giant old-school Barbie in place of Kubrick's famous monolith to a soundtrack of *Also sprach Zarathustra,* communicating that Gerwig intended to feed us some sort of elevated take on Mattel's infamous hot-pink hegemony. There was a partnership with Airbnb where fans could spend a night in Barbie's Dreamhouse, and high-end fashion designers like Balmain released pink-heavy collections in collaboration with Mattel (it's a surprise that the plugged-in fashion house Balenciaga, which had been dressing Kim in unofficial Barbie pink the previous year, did not snag this one; nor, of course, did Kim's newfound pop culture aggregator SKIMS). There was even the bold use of the phrase "If you love Barbie, if you hate Barbie, this movie is for you" in some poster taglines for the film, a method of monetizing one's own divisiveness that was famously used by Elvis's manager with "I Hate Elvis" merch. The president of Warner Bros. marketing, Josh Goldstine, told *Variety,* "The word 'hate' is a tricky word for marketing and we don't usually

use it…. We wanted to recognize there were legions of Barbie fans, but that Barbie had quite a history and there are people who felt like Barbie wasn't for them. This was a movie that understood that and was acknowledging it." Which brings us to the final, simple fact that the movie was about Barbie, a household name, and there would be something captivating about seeing the ubiquitous, miniaturized, commodified female form scaled and brought to life.

Barbie was invented by Ruth Handler (and her husband, Elliot) in the late 1950s after watching their daughter, Barbara, play with paper dolls, along with a fateful visit to Germany, where Handler encountered the curvaceous, cat-eyed Bild Lilli doll (a sexy gag gift for men). Back then, baby dolls, child dolls, and paper dolls were the main toy options for American kids who wanted little human replicas to play with. These consumers were deserving of some variety. As the poet Otamere Guobadia put it in a piece for *AnOther* magazine, "Dolls offer…a transcendence of simple realities; the construction of a world within and around themselves." Why not enjoy many worlds, wherein one could work out various concerns? (Kate McKinnon's long-suffering Weird Barbie is a good representation of the sometimes-sadistic catharsis that kids find in their dolls.) Plus, dolls long predate the modern toy box. Guobadia writes of ancient Egyptian children with dolls, and an Armenian tradition of sewing handmade dolls with intentional imperfections out of a fear that the doll might otherwise come to life. You could interpret Adam and Eve as dolls, carved by God out of clay. Kim Kardashian is a doll, too, played with by her plastic surgeons and fashion designers, sculpted and dressed according to some ever-evolving combination of the vision of elite creatives and the will of the masses—just as loved and hated as Barbie, and as aware of it as her marketers.

Barbie, a grown-woman doll with cartoonish proportions, was first announced at the North American International Toy Fair in New York City (where she was met with skepticism); she came with movable limbs (designed by a former military engineer, Jack Ryan), the option of either blond or brunette hair, and a zebra-striped swimsuit. Handler's savvy marketing sensibilities put Barbie on track to success; Mattel even sponsored the

successful Disney television show *The Mickey Mouse Club,* enabling Barbie to reach millions of young media consumers. In her first year, Barbie sold around 300,000 dolls. (Today, Mattel reports, 100 Barbies are sold every minute across the world.) As Dawn Heinecken put it, "Handler deliberately made Barbie's face…as blank and bland as possible…to encourage children to 'fill in' the blank with their own imagination and thus to open up a wide range of potential imagery identities for the doll." Meanwhile, "Barbie's numerous careers over the years, ranging from a model to an astronaut… make her a sort of 'Everywoman.'" Existing as a cultural medium in this manner has plagued and benefited both Kim Kardashian and Barbie. As Heinecken writes of Barbie, she "provides an embodied site where we can express our relationship to dominant culture through the doll and engage with, comment upon, or resist normative notions."

Barbie apologists often claim that she was "ahead of her time." We've never had a female president, but Barbie has already been leader of the free Barbie World—as a special collection release in 1999, and again in Gerwig's movie, played by Issa Rae. It is true that—especially in her earliest incarnations—Barbie showed girls what could be possible even before certain milestones had been achieved. (Mattel itself proclaims its stake in the "dream gap," referring to an NYU study that found that by the age of six girls tended to begin giving up on the idea that their gender is capable of brilliance.) For example, Barbie bought her Dreamhouse in 1962, before real women were allowed to open their own bank accounts; she was sent to the moon in 1965, four years before the United States touched down on its craters (to this day, no woman has been to the moon). As time went on, Barbie began reflecting in addition to predicting cultural changes: Amid the fight for civil rights, the first Black Barbie—Christie—was announced in 1968; in 2016, as pushes for body diversity strengthened, a range of Barbies with different body types from skinny to tall were released. "They kept her in tune with the times," Carol Spencer, one of Barbie's first designers, told Today.com in 2023. "They kept her appealing. She changed as we changed."

Heinecken adds, "Although Barbie has been criticized by many feminists for representing unrealistic standards of passive femininity, she has

simultaneously been seen as promoting a message of empowerment for girls…. In the context in which she appeared, Barbie signified freedom."

As there has, at some point in time, been a Barbie made of most of the women Kim has also "been," from Jackie O to Cleopatra to Marie Antoinette to the Spice Girls, it should also go without saying that every compliment or critique anyone could level at Barbie—a wide span of race, class, and gender discourses Gerwig attempted to capture in her film—could be leveled at Kim Kardashian. In September 2022, she was featured on the cover of *Interview* magazine's invented-for-the-occasion "American Dream" issue wearing blond hair and a jockstrap over her bare ass, in front of an American flag—shot by Nadia Lee Cohen in images derivative of a photo shoot Kim had done with Terry Richardson for *Rolling Stone* in 2015, for which she wore a red, white, and blue bikini while sucking on an American flag Popsicle. The Richardson shoot was encoded with irony—a grim, still-fresh hypothesis that the phenomenon of Kim Kardashian was telling us something about America. This time, though, almost a decade later, the American flag shoot stimulated ever-enlarging conversations about whether Kim was heralding a new cultural moment by engaging in racial identity play yet again. "Is she auditioning for something?" asked the Twitter user @atima_omera. "For whiteness, I think," replied @naima. The timing seemed right for Kim to alter her appearance and elicit cultural change; she had terminated her partnership with Kanye, who had shaped her image, dressing her in his designs and regularly singing the praises of her large butt; she was entering a new chapter with the advent of the family's Hulu show and the debut of a younger, white boyfriend; and, maybe most of all, criticisms of the political implications of her body contours had reached the mainstream, with YouTube video essays about the family's toxic influence exceeding views in the millions, and outlets like *Time* publishing features centered on her "legacy of Blackfishing and appropriation." Ask, and audiences at last received (though it seemed apparent to me that the BBLs and brunette hair had disappeared so that they could, at the right time, make a spectacle-generating comeback). Other viewers of the *Interview* cover, by now accustomed to Kardashian narrative breadcrumbing, speculated that this was a clue—especially following the

post-Kimye publicity spins that contrasted her CNN-approximate politics with Kanye's MAGA mindset—that she might really one day run for president.

Questions about whether Barbie has been more helpful or harmful have been asked since the doll's debut; there are nearly 200,000 results for the search term "Barbie" on Google Scholar. But the early 2020s—filled with Barbenheimer hype and therefore renewed urgency about the doll in think pieces, tweets, and TikTok takes (which offered free promo for the film itself)—cast cultural studies, at least for a time, in a pink hue. After all, race, class, and gender issues can be examined with appealing ease when observed from a bird's-eye view above a Dreamhouse-themed simulacrum. But the question of how Barbie—as well as the Kardashians—continues to be such a cultural coup, a ceaseless presence in girl-world, a global conglomerate despite all the flak to flay her with, can perhaps be understood better if we view the cultural phenomenon as an apparatus, as the media theorist Kevin Munger does in his examinations of YouTube, one of the most successful but understudied social media platforms.

Citing Vilém Flusser, Munger explains that an apparatus "reduces humans to mere operators, taking inputs from and supplying outputs to a system they cannot comprehend." Much of our discourse about social media, he writes—especially in this era of verifiable and worsening political polarization—has been focused on the question of whether media outlets really encode their content with ideology, as well as whether algorithms create online "echo chambers" powerful enough to radicalize social media users. But is that flow of production—and influence—so one-sided? He echoes the question: "Who decides what the system talks about or considers important? Does the media still tell the public what to think about, or does the public now tell the media what to talk about?" He concludes that "any serious analysis of the system must conclude that it's both," and traces the history of American media through the lens of incentive for "profit maximization": "The birth of the United States as an independent nation was intimately tied up with the circulation of news…. The role of pamphlets, mail, and newspapers in the success of the Revolution led the Founding Fathers to give them special

protections in the Constitution." Thus, the "freedom of press" we hear about so often today. "The second constitutive moment came with the emergence of the second party system, when Democrats responded to Andrew Jackson's defeat in 1824 by investing in a national network of newspapers." Other parties followed suit, and a "vertical integration," not unlike the kind in the Old Hollywood studio system, emerged "between parties and newspapers." The "best model for the media in this era," Munger writes, "is that of party loyalists," where ideology was delivered from the top down. When technological advancements encouraged the faster and wider production of papers, advertisers began to sponsor papers, which meant papers were motivated less by the ideology of their owners than by the will to titillate the masses. The same happened with broadcast media: Initially, at the advent of the medium, there were only three channels on TV. Due to legislation throughout the 1950s until the Reagan era journalistic standards were high, and approaches to divisive social issues aimed to offer balance. But as cable came up and channel options expanded, networks became motivated, as the newspapers had become, by advertisers; to hold attention to earn the most competitive viewership numbers became the goal (leading to the kind of sensationalism we explored in the O.J. chapter). This structure, writes Munger, best predicted the operations of digital media today. Finally, with the rise of social media, media became "individualized," leading to the arrival of independent creators who were motivated to "emphasize their originality, uniqueness, and social identities" to claim enough eyeballs to impress their sponsors—data that was more public than ever in the form of visible "likes" and "views."

Munger questions whether YouTube recommendation algorithms alone suck their recipients deeper and deeper into radicalization, arguing that on social media "demand creates its own supply," whereby YouTube creators become the "*creations*" of their own audiences. He brings up several studies that found that audiences can "radicalize influencers by 'enforc[ing] a type of accountability on [them],'" which can in turn encourage influencers to espouse more extremist viewpoints, creating what Munger calls a "whirlpool" of production and consumption. By this logic, we are recommended what we

are likeliest to click, and because, as he cites of the political scientist Alexander Coppock, "people adopt new beliefs about the world by combining their prior beliefs with new information," we are more likely to click on suggested content that illuminates our own journeys. Munger supports this with his own fifteen-year study of YouTube trends, where he found that there was an explosion of political content after Trump's first presidential campaign, seemingly in response to the major change to the establishment. After classifying channels as either "affiliate" (channels connected to more traditional media outlets, like the Young Turks) or "non-affiliate" (creators whose content came off as more personal and original for fans), according to classifications of left-wing, centrist, and right-wing, he found that as far as "intensive" measures of engagement (the ratio of "likes" to views) go, "each of the Unaffiliated channels outperforms its Affiliated ideological partner throughout the time series." In other words, even though other studies prove that legacy media continues to hold the greatest amount of social power, on social media people prefer to consume people over organizations (which, we might argue, is why it is so pertinent for Kim to continue to spin personal stories of trials and triumphs around her company SKIMS). Munger also found that the like/view ratio of these non-affiliate channels exploded after 2016, suggesting "audiences' growing awareness of their control over creators," as they more strategically hit the "like" button on content they approved of.

"It requires incredible willpower," Munger writes, "to ignore the reverberations of the ever-present audience on social media to maintain an independent artistic vision or coherent ideological position. And for YouTubers attempting to make a living, the vast and intense competition makes it impossible to do so. The audience can simply click away if the YouTuber displeases them. The pressure of having a million bosses issuing conflicting demands can produce 'Creator burnout' or worse." I sure experienced this anytime I was tasked with covering controversial Kardashian news—from Astroworld to Balenciaga-gate—and was then punished by my fans for refusing to sell more of myself to the algorithms by embedding moral perspectives into my analyses.

But conglomerates like Barbie and the Kardashians do not face the perils of smaller creators, and rather thrive when they perpetuate the cycles of supply and demand, adjusting their supply according to the preferences of the market. We can't know for sure, but can guess that some hybrid of sales data and cultural analysis has influenced the increasingly progressive production of Barbies like Christie and the body-positive crew from 2016. Josh Goldstine admitted that Gerwig—aware that the film would face pushback—had "thought" to use the "love it or hate it" tagline. The resulting film seemed to be the outcome of a predetermined endgame to appease both camps. On November 24, 2022, Kim tweeted, "What do you guys wanna see for season 3 of The Kardashians? Do you guys like family stuff? Work stuff? Kids stuff? BTS of shoots? Family pranks?" The tweet enjoyed its own micro meme cycle as viewers mocked the "desperation" of the question and used it as a prompt to lament how "boring" the show had become. In actuality, the family's TV show was likely to be shaped, as we assume of Barbie, according to a mix of data-driven social listening and cultural analysis. They began to shape storylines for their TV show that displayed their interest in viewers' interests—for example, the hot-button issue of their influence on women's body image, a critique that trended often on social media.

In a 2023 episode of *The Kardashians,* Kylie Jenner finally acknowledged the long-standing cultural conversation by telling her sisters that the time had come to acknowledge their influence on beauty standards. "I just think we have huge influence. And what are we doing with our power?" she asked. The scene was short; as she and Khloé sit in glam chairs together, she asks this, and then confesses her regrets for ever getting breast implants, citing concern about her daughter Stormi's well-being. In January 2024, Kylie was photographed at Paris Fashion Week with deflated facial fillers that revealed prominent under-eye bags, inspiring a slew of X ridicule for "looking old." Later that year, she was in another *Kardashians* scene crying to her sisters over the online hate. "I hear nasty things about myself all the time. After ten-plus years of hearing about it, it just gets exhausting." The moment was reported on by Twitter tabloid pages like Pop Base, which is followed by just over a million people, but its posts show up as recommended based on

previous engagement interests. This post—quoting Kylie paired with screenshots of the scene—was viewed by more than forty million people within days of being posted. This alone may expose the function of the family's fan-panned reality show in an increasingly fractured digital landscape: to earn short-form headlines that can stimulate discourse across varied platforms, every scene a bite-sized Boorstin-esque pseudo-event crafted according to audience interest, which may or may not hit the virality jackpot when its headline hits the algorithm. That same season, following a trend of fan tweets calling for this to happen, Kim visited the true crime icon Gypsy-Rose Blanchard, who was recently freed from incarceration and had developed a cult following among Gen Z and millennials after several streamer documentaries covered the story of how she and a boyfriend murdered her mother, who had Munchausen's syndrome by proxy; this novel pairing made headlines that were possibly more popular than the episode itself.

One can assume that the Kardashians are okay with this. In season 1 of *The Kardashians,* Kim spoke about her then-boyfriend Pete Davidson's plans to fly to the moon in a commercial flight with Jeff Bezos. The flight never happened, but the news made headlines, inspiring TMZ podcasts and even making some morning news shows. When Kim recycled the news story in her TV show, even her discussions with friends about his plans made new headlines: "Kim Kardashian Says She Felt 'Bad' Pete Davidson Couldn't Go to Space," read one *People* magazine headline. The reading line declaring, " 'I'm sure there's nothing more Pete would love than to get off of this planet right now,' Kim Kardashian said in this week's episode of *The Kardashians,*" itself a wry comment about Kanye's public harassment of the couple. The flow does not stop there, though; the idea seems to be to make headlines on legacy news sources, which will then be tweeted or reposted to Instagram, to then be engaged with.

The point is, as the Kardashian family became more of a cultural given than a cultural shock, they made it their business to offer colorful, quotable tokens to the flows of discourse-driven digital platforms capable of sustaining their relevance. Plus, this flow of content—and the emotions it evokes in

audiences—seemed to cycle faster than ever before. One minute, people pitied Kim for her ex-husband's public harassment of her, using her as a case study to talk about the perils of post-divorce violence faced by many women; the next, they hated her for association with a fashion brand fallen from grace, Balenciaga. One minute, they felt bad for a crude sex joke made at her expense during Tom Brady's Netflix roast; the next, when faced by a pro-Palestine protester at a speaking event in Germany, she replied, "free everyone," and again fell from public favor. (At least, these were the cycles I observed within my social media sphere.) It's enough to make you realize that even though the Kardashian conglomerate, like Barbie, and like Munger's YouTube apparatus, used the "supply and demand" framework to engage its consumers, the family was unlikely to face the same kind of burnout described by Munger of social media creators (or, rather, creations). As much as audiences attempted to "control" the objects of their consumption by calling for their #cancellation, the Kardashian apparatus was designed to simultaneously pander and provoke—and, by this point, was far too big to fail.

Though odds are that content about women's bodies or outer space or anything violent will reach feeds far and wide, the reason I caught sight of the popular tweet about Kylie's quotation about feeling ugly is presumably that the algorithm knows I click on Kardashian content. Forty-three million people is a lot, but it's far from the whole world. We live in a time when recommendation-driven content cycles fracture media experiences into if not echo chambers, which Munger writes off as a reductive trope in modern efforts at media analysis, then certainly customized categories in which we are all granted our own experiences of consumption. This is what makes the mini media cycle induced by the Pete-Going-to-Space storyline so ironic: The race to space was one of the defining elements of the global icon John F. Kennedy's myth, and in 1969, when the moon landing was televised, it was the most watched TV event in history, with 125 million people tuning in. If Pete really did go, would that many people tune in? If the Kardashians were lucky, maybe about a quarter of that number would click on a tweet about it, which is at once massive and anticlimactic because it does not provide the

same kind of widespread shared experience as tuning in to the same live event on television.

Still, the Kardashians, themselves, offer audiences that increasingly rare experience of collectivism by virtue of the basic fact that everyone knows their name—just as the myths of Kennedy, O.J., Trump, and others unify the world for the same reason. Still, where previous Kardashian dramas once managed to reach TV viewers—Kim's ill-fated wedding to Kris Humphries drawing 10.5 million TV viewers, for instance—more and more, due to the rise of a far more fractured digital media, specific incidences of Kardashian content no longer grab the world at once. During the early 2020s, cultural commentators—from legacy media cultural critics to social media creators alike—wondered aloud about when the family would "stop," or "just give up," given the growing sense that reality TV was being eclipsed by social media. But they'll never stop, because the show now exists not to entertain but to sustain; to supply the new market demands for spectacle-inducing headlines and prompts for discussion on the very mediums that promise to one day, indeed, destroy reality TV as their own participants become the more interesting spectacle. (Meanwhile, the Kardashians have entrenched themselves enough in culture, using all the methods explored in this book, to endure, just as Barbie will whenever that collapse comes.)

Of course, amid all this post-modernization, nostalgia as a cultural value persists, which is what made the Barbenheimer hype so much fun. It managed to induce the kind of collective media experience that was more and more rare as the 2020s stretched on.

For *Vox,* Kyle Chayka writes about the dueling definitions of the word "monoculture," a word that was thrown around a lot as critics attempted to process what this giddy sense of box office anticipation meant. (Search trends of the term surged throughout the early 2020s.) "Within the monoculture obsession, there are two concerns. The first is that in the digital streaming era we have lost a perceived ability to connect over media products as reference points that everyone knows, the way that we used to discuss the weather or politics, at least in a bygone time before our realities were split by climate change and Fox News. The fear is that we exist in a fragmented realm of

impenetrable niches and subcultures enabled by streaming media. The second concern is that, because of the pressures of social media and the self-reinforcing biases of recommendation algorithms that drive streaming, culture is becoming more similar than different. We are worried that our digital niches cause a degree of homogenization, which the word monoculture is also used to describe." In other words, "These two concerns appear in some ways irreconcilable, and yet they coexist. Is there less monoculture today, or is culture more mass than ever?"

Thanks to the ubiquity of the Barbie movie's marketing—designed in both content (acknowledging the doll's divisive role in culture; fun songs and fashion aesthetics) and form (being disseminated across the fashion world to TikTok trends to experiential Airbnb opportunities, according to audience preferences)—and the satisfying counterbalance of its sibling movie, *Oppenheimer,* America was wrapped up in a collective cultural experience comparable to older eras of more centralized media. The numbers can back this up: *Barbie*'s opening weekend grossed the movie $356 million worldwide, and *Oppenheimer,* $180.4 million.

Why should we crave this? Dan Krier breaks down Émile Durkheim's theories of social integration by way of explanation: "According to Durkheim, the collective consciousness is formed through social interactions…. Yet all around him, Durkheim observed evidence of rapid social change and the withering away of these groups. He saw increasing population density and population growth as key factors in the evolution of society and the advent of modernity. As the number of people in a given area increase, he posited, so does the number of interactions, and the society becomes more complex. Population growth creates competition and incentives to trade and further the division of labor. But as people engage in more economic activity with neighbors or distant traders, they begin to loosen the traditional bonds of family, religion, and moral solidarity that had previously ensured social integration. Durkheim worried that modernity might herald the disintegration of society." Contemporary theorists can back this up using psychology studies around collective attention to prove how much comfort we find when we are connected. In 2024, the psychologist

Garriy Shteynberg wrote that "synchronous attention with others yields stronger memories, deeper emotions and firmer motivations. Studies show that seeing words together renders them more memorable, watching sad movies together makes them sadder, and focusing together on shared goals increases efforts toward their pursuit." He adds that other research "suggests that shared attention on a common subjective experience can build relationships across the political divide and strengthen cooperation among strangers. For instance, when people co-witness that they have the same gut reaction to an unfamiliar piece of music or a meaningless inkblot, they like each other more, even if they have opposing political leanings."

Even if you had a beef with *Barbie*—whether it was, as some men in my life complained, too radical, or, as many feminist friends decried, not radical enough—or felt that *Oppenheimer* had succeeded or failed at capturing the horrors of nuclear warfare, you were part of the Moment. Delight in this rare case of collectivism translated to delight in the theatergoing experience—itself an act of nostalgia in a post-pandemic era when movie theaters were shuttering en masse. As Chayka quotes of the director Martin Scorsese, "To be in a packed house in one of the old theaters watching *Rear Window* was an extraordinary experience: It was an event created by the chemistry between the audience and the picture itself, and it was electrifying." In the case of Barbenheimer, in the days preceding the opening weekend, AMC reported that it had sold twenty thousand double-feature tickets.

The Kardashians—unlikely (though never say never) to ever release a box office theater hit—are less capable of providing this level of hype, even if they have wisely devised their own methods of remaining relevant. Still, if anybody can rival that Barbenheimer opening weekend, they can. I'd argue that the frenzy of images amid the *Donda* era's Balenciaga-dressed divorce drama achieved a similar effect, though this is hard to prove now without hard data and is, more important, harder to viscerally recall. Even though we know that Barbenheimer had been exciting, can we really remember how it *felt;* the emotions of double-feature day, an IRL experience, are certainly easier to conjure than any given day online leading up to it, looking at the memes. Life online moves so fast that moments that would have once unified a stunned

nation are now a dime a dozen. We may remember how the first announcement of Trump's 2016 election triumph felt, sitting on our couches, maybe with loved ones, gaping at the TV. But do we remember how it felt when his mug shot dropped online in 2023? We might remember the sensation of being surrounded by girls with puffed-out lips and being unable to scroll the novel social media feeds without being forced to consume the image of yet another Kardashian clone. But we probably don't remember any long-lasting sensations upon hearing that Kim's new boy toy intended to shoot himself into space with Jeff Bezos.

This is because in the new media age, collective experience does not necessarily translate into collective cultural memory. In a study called "Collective Memory in the Digital Age," Taha Yasseri, Patrick Gildersleve, and Lea David write about how rituals of collective memory are rooted in tragedy. They are often expressed through concrete forms of memorialization such as statues and the establishment of sites of "moral remembrance." Kim seemed to recognize this when she visited the Armenian genocide memorial and pushed international political leaders to recognize the atrocity. In the decades following World Wars I and II, when "nationally bound narratives" of past events were proliferated by the state apparatus, the Universal Declaration of Human Rights expanded the discourses around human rights violations beyond what the states had deemed significant. This kicked off a "rapid growth of memorialization across the globe during the 1980s and 1990s, and [an] obsession that shifted from commemorating victories to commemorating massive past human rights abuses." This obsession is "grounded in the presumption that 'proper memorialization' is essential for 'healing' societies with a difficult past and moving beyond trauma and violence," an idea the studies attribute to Lea David. "Moral remembrance points to the current preference, worldwide, for memory standardization, institutional homogenization, and norm imitation. It provides a technocratic-like set of policies and a tool kit of practices that aims to advance a human rights vision of memorialization processes to promote democratic, human rights values across the globe." Yasseri, Gildersleve, and David suggest that Wikipedia may be a good example of a digital site of collective memory, because it was

intended to provide a "sum of all human knowledge." "The notion of globally shared knowledge," they write, "is adjacent to the notion of global collective memory." It's apparent that the Kardashians are trying to amass their own trove of cultural memory with their endless memorialization—a process that began early in their lives, when their father was part of one of the most documented media events in history.

ARCHIVES

Mark my words: Kim Kardashian will one day be known as the most archived woman in the world. Throughout the 2010s, she was notorious for her self-documentation compulsion: selfies on social media and TMI on reality TV. In the 2020s, Kim began shedding light on her archival endgame, revealing in season 1 of *The Kardashians* that all along she's maintained a massive closet containing thirty thousand pieces of her past decade's public looks; she also established a headline-grabbing presence at auctions by scooping up artifacts owned by icons like Princess Diana and even her ex-husband Kanye West. This accumulation of footage, documents, and relics is probably meant to, one day, be exhibited in some kind of curatorial space, but why? And *where*?

Jacques Derrida begins his 1995 essay "Archive Fever" by pointing out that the Greek root of the word "archive"—*arkhē*—means "the commencement" and "the commandment," two forces apparent in this passage from *Kardashian Konfidential:* "We have practically our entire childhoods on video. Hey, maybe that's why it's so natural for us to live so much of our lives on camera with our TV show! Dad was absolutely glued to his video camera. Everything we did, he documented."

Robert Kardashian Sr. commenced a family custom of memory capturing. Their long-running reality show—which Kris Jenner often calls "the best home movies ever"—sometimes features Robert Sr.'s grainy footage of the Kardashian girls, adding a dose of drug-like nostalgia to the show's tone.

As the family's experiences elevated over time, their "archive fever" apparently intensified. Kim's sisters surprised her for her fortieth by setting up a warehouse with reenactments of her first, fourth, tenth, sixteenth, and

thirtieth birthday parties, reuniting Kim, for example, with the white BMW she was gifted for her sweet sixteen and returning her to the Tao Nightclub red carpet on which she'd posed for so many photo ops in the early birthdays of her public life. Not only did this walk down memory lane double as grabby Instagram and reality show content (allowing fans to vicariously "relive" something they'd never been a part of the first time around), but it was also a power play, regaling us with the family's resources, vision, and resolve to reanimate lost time. "The archivization," Derrida writes, "produces as much as it records the event."

For Kris Jenner's sixty-fifth, Kim rented the family's childhood Beverly Hills home from its current occupants to stage a surprise lunch. She replaced the kitchen wallpaper with the fabric from their years there and set the table with their old china.

"All of our memories live here especially with our dad," Kim later captioned Instagram photos from the day, which had been filtered to appear retro. "It's where each Kardashian child was born and made us who we are." Again, Derrida would not be surprised. He described "archive fever" as "an irrepressible desire to return to the origin, a homesickness, a nostalgia for return to the most archaic place of absolute commencement."

Throughout his essay, Derrida professes the power of the archive by bringing in Freud. After all, Freud theorized that much of what we do is driven by sex urges and death anxieties and sex anxieties and death urges, and that that trauma often sticks within us and sometimes we repress it and other times we compulsively return to it, and about how the essential point of psychoanalysis is to make sense of our pasts so that we might finally make sense of ourselves.

In this sense human memory might *be* an archive—or at least it yearns to organize itself into a coherent structure, externalize all that inner storage, and actualize as one. "There is no archive without a place of consignation," writes Derrida, "without a technique of repetition, and without a certain exteriority. No archive without outside." Now is a good time to bring in good old Marshall McLuhan, whose claims that media is an "extension of man" we have revisited again and again. If electronic media mimics and extends upon

the functions of our nervous systems, then maybe Derrida's idea really does track: The archive is an extension of the human psyche.

But once we bring the inside outside, where do we keep it? Derrida and the Kardashian matriarchy would probably agree that the archive as a concept is tied closely to the domestic. The Kardashian archive, after all, will be mostly made up of family memories in various forms—lest we forget the time capsule they all buried in Kim's backyard during season 20 of *KUWTK,* filling it with, among other things, Kylie's career-making lip kits and Kim's first fragrance brand—as well as the countless expensive pop culture treasures Kim has been accumulating upon joining the ranks of the elite. Derrida reminds us that Freud's home was eventually turned into a museum, which makes me wonder whether one day some Kardashian estate will become a tourist destination akin to Southern California's other domiciles turned exhibits, the Getty Villa or Hearst Castle. (In fact, because recent decades have shown that celebrity spectacle captivates Americans far more than history education—consider the fact that more people visit Disneyland each year than the monuments at D.C.—the pop culture offerings of a Kardashian estate may prove more accessible to visitors than any of the ancient art at the Getty Villa.)

Derrida adds that the "*arkheion*" was the home of "*archons,*" which is to say, "superior magistrates," or "those who commanded." Basically? In ancient Greece, those with political power decided what was filed, and therefore remembered—filing that occurred in home spaces. In considering the archive as a fusion of home storage and systemic power, we might recall the famous quotation (of debated origin) "History is written by the victors."

This might be why a minor cycle of TikTok cancellation seemed nigh when I made a video talking about "Kim Kardashian's archival impulse." "A poor person would be called a hoarder," read one comment, representing many. It's true that the inevitable Kardashian exhibit to come will tell an implicit story about power, if only because the family could afford enough physical and digital space to hold and preserve all their relics, and that the existence of all these items indicates an inherent self-importance in assuming

that future societies would even care. (Perhaps in part for this reason, Kim often comments that her keepsakes are "for the kids.")

Would it be better to have none of it? After all, people persist in tweeting out fantasies of the Kardashians being wiped from the earth entirely. I can't help but think about the fact that few of Marie Antoinette's original costumes exist today; parts of her wardrobe were given away seasonally to her ladies-in-waiting, and the rest destroyed during the storming of Versailles. (Though Jackie O, who professed a personal identification with the icon, would one day manage to pick up a few of her leftover items, presumably from auctions; while giving friends a tour of her post–White House Martha's Vineyard home, she showed them a red leather box that was the jewel case where Marie stored her pearls.) While most of us might be either neutral or maybe a little bummed about that fact, it's difficult to imagine, with such distance from the past, that anybody alive today is clenching their fists and crying, "Good riddance!"

The Kardashians surpassed comprehensible visibility and cultural power in the 2020s, earning more comparisons to Marie Antoinette than ever before. This has seemed to prompt their online opponents to attempt a proverbial palace storming—which, in the new media age, looks like the cultivation of a critical mass pronouncing *denial* of the family's relevance. In fact, the Kardashians are still in the active process of accumulating assurance that their legacy will never really die.

Should the World Wide Web implode and every photo of Kim in the white BMW vanish, that white BMW and the little fable about the sweet sixteen it represents will remain. So will Kim's *Selfie* book, a hard-copy compilation of digital cultural documents, and *Kardashian Konfidential,* which was designed to simulate a scrapbook, and Kanye West's Pastelle jacket, which nine-year-old North was photographed wearing all over Paris during 2022 Couture Week, and the controversial Marilyn Monroe dress, on which Kim Kardashian has imprinted her own memory, and so much more.

Derrida does account for the profound absence of whatever isn't included in an archive, referring to the excluded as "the One," or, in Freudian terms, as "ghosts." In his own review of "Archive Fever," the archivist Walker

Sampson explains, “In the ceaseless work to maintain one memory at the expense of another the archive not only maintains and curates memory, but buries it as well.” (Or, as Rose Bertin, Marie Antoinette’s personal stylist, is alleged to have once said, “There is nothing new—only what’s been forgotten.”) This applies to the proof of the lives of the poor, who mattered and deserve remembrance and understanding, even while the Palace of Versailles receives ten million visitors a year, but perhaps the palace tells their story by displaying all that they sought to resist.

The future Kardashian archives will be haunted, too, by the ghosts of every common person who could never live as they did, despite the culture of aspiration that they famously inspired, but also one more: Robert Sr., an icon of the women’s “compulsive, repetitive, and nostalgic desire for the archive.”

“It’s fun,” they write, of their dad’s dedicated documentation of their lives. “But it’s kinda sad that we never get to see him. He was always holding the camera, filming.”

ROBERT KARDASHIAN SR.

“Look at you! You’re forty, and all grown up. You look beautiful, just like when you were a little girl. I watch over you, and your sisters and brother, and the kids, every day…. I am so proud of the woman that you’ve become…. And all that you’ve accomplished…. But most impressive is your commitment to become a lawyer and carry on my legacy…. I’m with you every step of the way. The way that you’re connecting to your roots and supporting Armenia means so much to me. You are a proud Armenian, and I am a proud Armenian father. The most beautiful thing I have witnessed is watching you grow your family. You married the most, most, most, most, most genius man in the whole world, Kanye West. And you are the most, most, most, most amazing mother to your four beautiful children…. Keep doing what you’re doing, Kimberly…know that I am with you. I have built a firewall around our family.”

That’s Kim’s dead father, Robert Kardashian Sr., resurrected as a hologram to give Kim a fortieth birthday speech that covers every aspect of

her enterprise—from her ageless beauty, to her Armenian identity, to her success in business, to her interest in law, to the influence of Kanye's creative vision, to her identity as a mother, to, in the appearance of a computing term like "firewall," her own proverbial existence as a bona fide cyborg. Then Robert vanishes in an implosion of the same kind of stardust that crests over the Disney castle logo. This was 2020, during Kim's private island pandemic party, a hyperreal Hallmark card from her soon-to-be-ex-husband Kanye—a full-sized, speaking, dancing virtual duplication of the most central character of the family's TV show, made by a "multimedia hologram" company called Kaleida whose higher-scale products, one of its directors and producers, Daniel Reynolds, told *Slate,* cost "hundreds of thousands." There's no way not to experience the uncanny valley when looking at this version of the Kardashians' onetime patriarch, grainy photographs and 1990s news clips of whom we'd been fed by the family for more than a decade by this point, but who was now brought to life by a multistep process of "visual effects, machine learning algorithms, but also physical choreography, and a bit of sound synthesis." (Though Reynolds is quick to emphasize that "the key element to the production is really the [physical] performance…. You can have the best hologram in the world, but if that performance is not right, it's just going to fall flat.") "Uncanny valley" is by now its own cultural colloquialism, as we grapple with all the virtuality and intensifying AI abilities that pervade our everyday lives, but the term was coined in 1970 by the Japanese roboticist Masahiro Mori and is formally defined by *Cambridge Dictionary* as "the unpleasant feeling that some people have when they see robots, or pictures of a human being created by a computer, that appear very similar to a living human." In some sense, every aspect of the Kardashian enterprise—as listed by Hologram Robert—evokes the uncanny valley. The modern world and the insistent acceleration of its technological progress has made it so that a glitchy gray area can exist between living and dead, real and staged, authentic and commodified. Living within, manipulating, and sustaining such a glitch is the Kardashians' creative calling and craft. When you consider the role grief plays in the Kardashian enterprise, Neal Gabler's comment on the work of the French film critic André Bazin feels relevant:

“One of the functions of art is to cheat death by creating immortality.” Michel Foucault cites the “Arabic stories, and *The Arabian Nights* in particular,” in which storytelling is a “strategy for defeating death. Storytellers continued their narratives late into the night to forestall death and to delay the inevitable moment when everyone must fall silent.” That’s one way to explain why so many seasons of the family’s ceaseless TV show exist.

Audiences first heard of Robert Sr. (if they’d forgotten about his role in the O. J. Simpson trial) during *KUWTK*’s first season, when Khloé gets a DUI and explains to her family that she had acted irresponsibly due to the pain of the approaching anniversary of his death. She visits and kneels before his grave on camera, mediating a clash of the sacred and the circus of reality TV cameras—as she and her family would continue to do in perpetuity.

Perhaps because the matriarchy has had intimate experiences with destruction and decay—Kris Jenner’s semi-estranged father died in a car crash before they could reconcile; Robert’s best friend, O. J. Simpson, was accused of a brutal mariticide, the details of which were deconstructed on the world stage; and, years later, Robert himself was given a sudden diagnosis of the throat cancer that killed him within months—they have a tendency to confront death on their TV show as though it were high camp. In 2012, although their dad is buried elsewhere, the gang visits Hollywood Forever to shop for graves—setting the stage for Kris to hop into caskets, comparing their stitching to “a Chanel purse,” and take jokey camera phone pictures of herself looking dead. A few years later, convinced she’s being haunted by a malevolent spirit in her mansion, Khloé invites a medium over who instead connects her to her dad. Years after, she and Kim, dressed in their baddie-wear, would tour underground bunkers, joshing around while also contemplating whether they’d prefer to be ensconced during the end of the world or perish along with the masses.

It is understandable, however appalling, that the Kardashians—the most prolific producers of story to ever live, if we include everything from macro-narratives of their TV show, to the countless micro ones posted to their literal social media “stories,” to the strange intertextual hybrids of narrative played out across mediums—depict death in their content almost as often as they

conjure their late father. Walter Benjamin, whose words on the concept of "aura" we went over in the Marilyn Monroe chapter, wrote about how death gives meaning not only to life but to story: "Death is the sanction of everything that the storyteller can tell. He has borrowed his authority from death." Interpreting this, the literary critic Peter Brooks writes, "Benjamin reaches back to this tradition that believes the moment of death to be a moment of truth-telling." As we are forced to wade through the barrages of dramas and constructions of artifice thrown our way by the family, it doesn't get much more real than death, than Robert Sr., famous now not only for aiding O.J. but for being dead, brought to life as a hyperreal entity. More generally, the Kardashians show us that death, too, can be packaged, not only as an opportunity for a grim punch line, but as a cynical process that Stjepan Meštrović addresses in *Postemotional Society:* "Baudrillard has already suggested that Western culture is dead and therefore fascinated by death. Pope John Paul II recently called Western culture a 'culture of death' because of its proclivity toward abortion, euthanasia, murder, and suicide. Hitler's death still continues to fascinate people. One should also take into account the existence and widespread viewing of films that show real executions and death for teenage entertainment…. Tourists flock to Jim Morrison's tomb in Paris, to the site of John F. Kennedy's assassination, to the site of Marilyn Monroe's death, to the site of the burned Branch Davidian compound in Waco, Texas, and so on. Or they take tours of barrios in San Antonio, Texas, or Harlem or other sites of widespread social suffering. One must keep in mind that the tourist industry is just that, an industry that has codified, rationalized, routinized and otherwise converted these experiences of death and suffering."

Robert Sr.'s ever-present ghost throughout the TV show's episodes has inspired equally crass fascination in its audience: Reddit deep dives about how Khloé looks nothing like him; TikTok conspiracy theories about how his tragic death was karma for getting O.J. out of jail; Twitter speculation about how the born-again Christian would be rolling in his grave over the lives his daughters have made for themselves in his absence.

Yet Robert Sr. is one of the figures that the Kardashians encode with zero ambiguity. Within their simulacrum, he is a saint, the one who taught them how to pray, love, and work, whose lessons they return to whenever faced with a new quandary. "When we were little," they write in *Kardashian Konfidential,* "we called him Dad…but whenever we were talking about him, we called him Daddy." He was fond of the adages "blood is thicker than water" and "money isn't happiness"; for Christmas he gave them handmade certificates for "one hour of conversation with your father to talk about life," and together they watched old Hollywood films.

If we've learned anything, it's that most icons have some tie to the spectacle-inducing phenomena of sex and death. As Jean Baudrillard explains of the "cult of the body," "It is the only object on which everyone is made to concentrate…as an object of frantic concern, in the obsessive fear of failure or substandard performance, a sign and an anticipation of death…. The body is cherished in the perverse certainty of its uselessness, in the total certainty of its non-resurrection." (That is, apparently, until Kanye West finds out about the capabilities of artificial intelligence technology.) But most icons also have a connection to a father who looms large, either lost or ever present. Cleopatra, close to her dad, was titled the "father-loving goddess." Much of the humanizing appeal of Marilyn Monroe's myth was due to her lifelong search for her real dad. Truman is fatherless in *The Truman Show;* Princess Jasmine is motherless, tending to her sultan father; Walt Disney, the loving parent of Mickey Mouse, was known to yearn for his own austere father's approval; John F. Kennedy would be nowhere without his determined "dad-ager"; the Spice Girls were put together by a father-and-son management team; Marie Antoinette's whole job was to make a father of the king; and, well, according to the religion claimed by the Kardashians, Jesus himself is the son of a distant Father.

Robert's hologram manages to generate the aura of nostalgia—transitioning his speech into an unnerving finger-snapping dance to a self-referential doo-wop song called "Who Took the Bomp," while describing a sweet scene of driving young Kim to school in a "little Mercedes." He concludes the monologue by suggesting that the Kardashians' massive

matriarchal media project has been about not only establishing *a* legacy but, through her interest in becoming an attorney, carrying on *his* legacy, a thesis further fleshed out in 2023 when *GQ* crowned Kim "Man of the Year," in a feature titled "What Kim Kardashian Learned from Her Father," and posed her on the cover in a suit and tie (one of the first incidences I've ever observed of Kim posing in clothing that was not hyperfeminine).

Kim might have learned from her father, but the point of seeing her in a suit is to show us that she is, today, capable of filling the suit herself, of embodying all the facets of his character, the same way the engineer at Kaleida had enough visual and auditory data on Robert Kardashian to be able to, as Umberto Eco might say, upload and preserve him through "full-scale authentic copy," achieving "immortality as duplication." But is this the mode of immortality Robert Sr., the celebrity attorney who made a midlife career shift into the business of media licensing, would have wanted? Is it something that Kim—whose career, when observed from a certain angle, tells a story about the pursuit of owning one's image entirely—would really find comforting? As the psychologist and theorist Lida Papakonstantinou points out, "One of the most difficult and crucial questions the law has to answer is whether this futuristic technology concerns artistic freedom of expression or an infringement of individual rights…. Why should one not argue that even stating, 'I love you, Kimberly,' as did Robert Kardashian's hologram, is not unlawful or unethical, when the living Robert Kardashian never consented to these words being spoken in this way?" The Robert Sr. hologram—perhaps the pinnacle of the Kardashians' hyperreal project—arrived at a time when artificial intelligence was becoming more and more indistinguishable from real images, when tech CEOs like Elon Musk and Sam Altman were warning the public that robots could one day take over the world, when it could no longer be denied that the Kardashians themselves were exemplars of the excesses of the postmodern world.

In her 1985 work "A Cyborg Manifesto," the feminist scholar Donna Haraway writes of her formulation of a postmodern feminist prototype, the cyborg, "a cybernetic organism, a hybrid of machine and organism"—which, in her view, has the potential to defy social binaries. "The cyborg…is

oppositional, Utopian, and completely without innocence. No longer structured by the polarity of public and private, the cyborg defines a technological polis based partly on a revolution of social relations in the *oikos,* the household." In other words, the cyborg bucks the boundaries between the domestic sphere and the rest of the world as we understand them, as well as the nuclear family system as we know it—sound familiar? The communal Kar-Jenner matriarchy, as we by now know well, catch flak for living like post-feminists: Through their wealth, they had achieved the kind of freedom Haraway wishes for us all; they are unburdened by their femaleness (besides the obligation to perform the kinds of gender roles the rest of the world still clings to). Haraway continues, invoking the biblical myth of the Fall, "The cyborg does not expect its father to save it through a restoration of the garden—that is, through the fabrication of a heterosexual mate, through its completion in a finished whole, a city and cosmos. The cyborg does not dream of community on the model of the organic family, this time without the oedipal project. The cyborg would not recognize the Garden of Eden; it is not made of mud and cannot dream of returning to dust." To be clear, to compare the Kardashians to Haraway's cyborg strips the manifesto of its politics, which encourages a resistance to essentialist identity categories and traditional power hierarchies and promotes coalition building between people (women, especially) of different backgrounds, but they are doubtless visually evoked by Haraway's breathless, hyper-visual sketches of this fatherless, shape-shifting cyborg, especially when, as in Halloween of 2021, Kim is dressed by Mugler as a self-described "CowBot" in an all-silver cowgirl getup suggestive that she is self-aware of her status as a hybrid of human and machine. Just as the cyborg refuses to become the fallen Eve—unable to recognize the capacity for decay within herself—the Kardashians won't be condemned to the physical agony of womanhood that God imposed on Eve after she persuaded Adam to take his damning bite. At least not when it comes to labor: Since 2018, when Kim's daughter Chicago was born via a gestational surrogate, the family has normalized the use of other wombs to produce their offspring. This is not to say that Kim and Khloé have not paid their pounds of flesh for the privilege: Episodes throughout early *KUWTK*

show Kim weeping in pain over complications she endured while carrying her first daughter, North (one scene shows Kris standing over Kim during her sonogram with an inscrutable expression that could be interpreted as a smirk; after all, she did it five times and then started an empire). Khloé claimed to suffer similar ailments while carrying her first child, True. So, from then on, the women hired unseen surrogates for most of the rest of their kids (Kourtney and Kylie continued carrying their own), building reality show storylines around the same moral questions that surrogacy has been provoking in feminists and religious essentialists for decades. Heather Jacobson, sociologist and author of *Labor of Love: Gestational Surrogacy and the Work of Making Babies,* tells me that the debate has been simmering since at least the 1980s, when, instigated by a landmark court case over a child known as Baby M, a surrogate kidnapped the baby she'd been contracted to carry and deliver, and a judge ruled in favor of the couple who hired her. Public concern over the transformation of women's wombs into commodities intersected with concerns over what was "natural," making "interesting bedfellows," says Jacobson, out of surrogacy's progressive *and* conservative critics. In one episode of *The Kardashians,* Khloé finds out that her surrogate has a right to terminate the pregnancy at any point and is stunned.

"One of the things that was hashed out…in the classroom, in the courtroom, but also in the media was this debate about what makes a good mother and who is a good mother," Jacobson explains. "So you could see how people's reactions to or feelings about the parties involved then shaped their interpretation of the correctness or soundness of surrogacy."

It's true that when it came to the Kardashians, surrogacy inspired hot debate. "Keeping up with the Kardashians means paying other women to have your babies," read one *Guardian* op-ed from 2019. "Watching the Kardashians actually educated me on surrogacy & delivery 😁," tweeted another. When I polled my Kardashian Kolloquium audience about whether surrogacy is (a) okay, (b) not okay, or (c) okay but not when the Kardashians do it, nearly two thousand people responded, landing at (a) 47 percent, (b) 21 percent, and (c) 32 percent.

One thing is true—whether (or not) we feel the Kardashians' rental of other women's wombs is legitimate, purportedly due to a history of high-risk pregnancies, doing so freed them to fully engage in their glamour labor without disruption, filming scenes of themselves complaining about bad Wi-Fi while doing squats together in their home workout rooms, glamming up for red carpets in looks that inspire love or hate from the rest of the masses who don't get to be there, and selling the commodities of their own beauty, bodies, and dramas without big belly stretch marks. The Kardashians have long ceased to suffer as Eve did—made from Adam out of clay and condemned to the pain of giving life, before again succumbing to dust—let alone most of all the other women of the world, but we also suspect they suffer in ways we'll never bear witness to, anytime they optimize their faces and bodies using ever-advancing enhancement technologies for the purpose of digital reproduction and resistance to the "decay" of aging. Recovery from cosmetic surgery is long, ugly, and brutal, and even though, early on, Kris Jenner took one for the team and allowed cameras to follow her into the operating room as she underwent a facelift that would prime her for her role as "mother of the bride" before Kim's fairy-tale wedding to Kris Humphries, and though the family has shown us their pursuits of inner perfection—stepping off set from photo shoots to accept needles in their arms so that genetic scientists could test their blood for faults—we have not been shown the probable and persistent behind-the-scenes agonies that render the Kardashian women at once all too human and human designed. Our collective understanding of this reality seems to be intuitive; one of my most popular memes on Kardashian Kolloquium is a screenshot of Kim holding a hand mirror and gazing at her original face over the fake caption, my application of a classic Haraway quotation: "I'd rather be a cyborg than a goddess."

Maybe a cyborg, built to live forever, can bear the sorts of things the Kardashian women have had to experience because the human condition requires it of all of us. In the glossy pages of *Kardashian Konfidential,* you'll find a recollection from Khloé about her dad: "When Kourtney and I were called to Dad's house to say goodbye, the priest was there. Dad looked so little. He had a toy monkey when he was a kid that he named Jocko and he

still had it in his bedroom closet. He asked for his Jocko, like he was a little boy. I went to get it and brought it to him." In the larger context of Kardashian oversharing, this is yet another little ditty, this time, a sad-themed one, written with the clarity and simplicity we have come to expect of any Kardashian copy. But imagine the visceral reality of being there. Seeing the adult who once made you feel safe in the world shrunken and suffering in bed, asking for his toy. All I can come up with is a kind of despair impossible to duplicate, describe, endure.

We can assume that one day Kim will be made into a hologram too, for the purposes of whatever museum or archive may contain both the family's physical artifacts and its new media canon. Reynolds even admitted it himself: "A lot of actors and musicians [are] wanting themselves documented as holograms before they actually die." By submitting themselves to the necessary full-body scan "before they're deceased, they'll have high-quality hologram data available should they need to use it in the future." And maybe then people can visit the Kardashian girls and their dad, reunited, in a remade Eden, together, forever, as data.

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PART I

CHAPTER 1. BLUEPRINTS

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